Name: _____

Batch: _____

ENGLISH

RC Compendium

2018

mbaguru
LEADER IN ADAPTIVE PREPARATION FOR CAT

Introduction

Welcome to the world of Reading and Reading Comprehension for CAT!

With almost the entire English Section (VRC: 34 Questions out of 100 at CAT-15/16/17) revolving around RC, the importance of getting comfortable with a very diverse range of content and genres cannot be overemphasized.

Reading Comprehension is a skill – and skills need regular work to develop. Long hours of sporadic effort may help you memorize things and do well in some knowledge-based exams, but it doesn't work like that when it comes to developing the craft of reading and being able to grasp what you read. Craft requires regular work; it's more like a habit you can't do without.

The purpose of this Compendium of articles is first and foremost to get you into a habit of reading, and making friends with the language, and various genres and styles that people adopt while writing in it.

The following articles have been selected from a vast variety of sources not only to give you a diverse reading experience but also to make you familiar with the most common sources of actual CAT/non-CAT passages.

Your English mentor will guide you in detail about what is expected from you before and in each RC session and how to make best use of this wonderful resource to crack the CAT!

mbaguru
LEADER IN ADAPTIVE PREPARATION FOR CAT

SET-1

Article 1

On the morning after Christmas 2004, the staggering death toll (eventually more than 230,000) from the tsunami was still unknown, when a call from Sri Lankan President Mahinda Rajapaksa to Indian envoy Nirupama Rao made it clear that island nation needed urgent humanitarian assistance. In Washington DC, Indian Ambassador Ronen Sen was also being asked by the U.S. government how much India could help further afield, as the tsunami had wreaked havoc across the area now called the Indo-Pacific. For India, said a senior official, it was time to show that the Indian Ocean was in fact India's domain, and India committed in an unprecedented manner to the effort. Within 12 hours, Indian naval helicopters were in Colombo with relief material. By the next day, two Indian naval ships were in Galle and Trincomalee, while three others were despatched to Male. Two more, INS Khukri and INS Nirupak, were converted into hospital ships and sent to the worst hit-country, Indonesia, within days as well. In all, about 32 Indian ships and 5,500 troops were involved in the international relief effort, not to mention the work the armed forces carried out in Tamil Nadu and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands.

"India's full capabilities came as a surprise to the world," recalls Shyam Saran, Foreign Secretary at the time, who received a call from U.S. Secretary of State Condoleezza Rice, saying the world couldn't wait, and it was up to the countries of the Indo-Pacific that had naval capabilities of scale to move in urgently. On December 29, U.S. President George W. Bush announced that India, the U.S., Japan and Australia would set up an international coalition to coordinate the massive effort required: to rescue those trapped in the waters, rush relief, and rehabilitate those made homeless, and to restore power, connectivity lines as well as infrastructure like ports and roads. By mid-January the coalition handed over charge to the UN, but while their immediate mission had ended, it led to the birth of a new framework: the Quadrilateral, or Quad. Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe was the first off the block, voicing his long-standing idea of an "arc of prosperity and freedom" that encompassed India, and brought it into a tighter maritime framework, with Japan, the U.S. and Australia, which were already close military allies. The plan for a meeting of the Quad was firmed up when Prime Minister Manmohan Singh visited Tokyo in December 2006.

Even as the idea grew, however, it encountered growing concerns in Beijing. But, the idea born of such intense urgency as the tsunami met a lack-lustre end after its meeting in May 2007. Contrary to public perception, Australia wasn't the first to demur. The U.S. felt that angering China with the Quadrilateral would hamper larger strategic efforts under way, including the move for sanctions against Iran in the UN Security Council, and the six-nation talks on North Korea.

A decade later, the question is: will the Quadrilateral melt away as before, or it an idea whose time has finally come?

Article 2

The resignation of Frances Fitzgerald, Ireland's Deputy Prime Minister, has averted the risk of an early election and saved the minority government of the Fine Gael party. Ms. Fitzgerald becomes the second political casualty in less than a year of a longstanding scandal, after former premier and highly regarded centre-right leader, Enda Kenny, was forced to step down as Prime Minister in May. The specific allegation against Ms. Fitzgerald was that as the Minister for Justice in the previous administration she did not take action despite having knowledge about an attempt by an ex-chief of police to discredit a whistleblower. She had claimed that she had no authority to intervene in the matter when a judicial inquiry was under way. But once Sinn Fein, the hardline party of the left, moved a vote of no-confidence this month, her exit was inevitable. While Prime Minister Leo Varadkar initially defended his deputy, the opposition FiannaFáil, on whose support the Fine Gael minority government depends, moved a motion against her. Ms. Fitzgerald's resignation has averted the collapse of the government for now. The reprieve Mr.Varadkar has earned has come at a critical stage in Ireland's negotiations in the European Union over the implications of Britain's exit from the bloc. At issue is the maintenance of the status quo of open borders with Northern Ireland, which underpins the landmark 1998 Good Friday agreement. Britain's withdrawal from the EU customs union could lead to the reintroduction of security checkpoints.

Agreement on the status of the Irish boundary is one of the three EU preconditions for Brexit negotiations to move to the next phase, to discussions on a free-trade agreement between London and Brussels. There has been greater progress on the other two elements of the terms of Britain's divorce — a financial settlement and the reciprocal rights of U.K. and EU citizens. The future of the Irish border is intertwined with the nature and shape of the U.K.'s relationship with the bloc, and clarity could take some time coming. Mr.Varadkar's insistence on obtaining written assurances on how London proposes to prevent a hard border and the threat to block Brexit talks are possibly aimed at domestic audiences. Dublin has even demanded that post-Brexit, Northern Ireland be integrated into an EU regulatory regime. London's conservative government, propped up by the Democratic Unionist Party, may view this as no more than political posturing by an equally weak government across the border. The broader reality is that Britain is Ireland's largest market, and the gateway for sizeable exports to Europe and the rest of the world. In the current state of Brexit negotiations, a spirit of reasonable accommodation could well define the future.

Article 3

Media coverage of peacekeeping operations is an area with many gaps. Consider for example, an incident last week, where at least 15 peacekeepers and five soldiers in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) were killed and numerous peacekeepers wounded by armed militants in one of the worst attacks on United Nations personnel. A local Islamist extremist group overran the remote base. Most of the dead and wounded are from Tanzania. Was there any media coverage in India? It would have been a different story had they been troops from the West. In the midst of this, one must focus on China as its grip on UN affairs tightens and it starts deciding policy, to the detriment of India.

China rising

Amid the buzz around Beijing taking centre stage in world affairs, the import of China's deployment of its first peacekeeping helicopter unit in the peacekeeping mission in Darfur has been lost sight of. Having

made a reluctant entry in peacekeeping, when it sent a small cadre of soldiers to Cambodia in 1992, Beijing has become the largest troop contributor among the permanent members of the UN Security Council (UNSC). More importantly, China is now the third-largest contributor to the UN's regular budget and the second-largest contributor to the peacekeeping budget. News of any country supporting peacekeeping is good, but what does this portend in Beijing's quest for great power status? In a September 2017 report, the Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS) says: "China's participation in UN operations offers... a low-cost means of demonstrating their commitment to global stability... and allay(s) fears about its military and economic strength." But is the picture that simple for India in geopolitical power play?

The UN, especially the UNSC, is a blue-blooded political body, notwithstanding its charter of considering all countries as equals. In practice, a nation's voice is in proportion to what it contributes towards the UN, especially funds — India's contribution is only 0.737% when compared to China's 7.92% and the U.S.'s 22%. Troop contributions to peacekeeping do not get their due in UN power politics. Having led a peacekeeping contingent, in 2005, I have seen first hand how pivotal posts in UN missions have always been with major fund contributors. China is indeed a part of the picture.

Veto power

The CSIS report states that China has used its veto only 12 times, but two were cast where its economic interests were involved, like in Myanmar and Zimbabwe despite these being low on human rights records. What is more worrisome, however, is that two vetoes were also cast "over concerns over territorial integrity pertaining to Taiwan". China was against sending UN peacekeepers to Guatemala and Macedonia because they had established diplomatic ties with Taiwan. When this self-serving act is linked with Beijing's other recent coercive actions such as against Mongolia due to a Dalai Lama visit, and against Japan when it is said to have halted exports of rare minerals following the arrest of a Chinese trawler captain, the increasing front-lining of China in international affairs via the UN has an ominous ring.

In 2015, China committed a standby force of 8,000 peacekeepers and a permanent police squad for UN operations. In addition, there is a 10-year $1 billion China-U.N. peace and development fund and $100 million in military assistance to the African Union. It is no coincidence that Africa is where China has large economic interests. Peacekeeping is said to be a cover for China to test its strengths in overseas deployments. The deployment of a People's Liberation Army Navy submarine off the Africa coast for anti-piracy patrolling is totrain its seamen in long-distance operations.

Impacting India

Chinese involvement in peacekeeping, along with its higher funding contributions will put Beijing in the driver's seat in formulating peacekeeping mandates, thereby affecting India in more ways than one.

Is India losing out despite having provided almost 200,000 troops in nearly 50 of the 71 UN peacekeeping missions over the past six decades? We have also sent scarce aviation assets including Canberra bombers to a UN Mission in Congo in the 1960s and helicopters to Somalia, Sierra Leone and Sudan. The truth is that though our troops have been on the front line of facing danger (168 soldiers lost in UN operations, till May 2017), the returns in UN power play have been low. It was perhaps not a troublesome issue until now considering India's good relations with the other four permanent UNSC members, but will this continue with China rise in the UN, especially with U.S. President Donald Trump's preoccupation elsewhere? Chinese opposition to India's candidature for a UNSC seat and its repeated vetos on the Masood Azhar issue are unwelcome indicators.

Peacekeeping missions are the raison d'etre of the UN and India's generous contributions as far as peacekeeping troops are concerned should be key in its argument to have a greater say in the affairs of the UN. India must demand its pound of flesh.

Article 4

English is one of the most common languages in the world, second only to Mandarin. However the term English has become an umbrella below which there are hundreds if not thousands of national and regional accents, as for example, Received British Pronunciation, American, Australian, Indian, South African, New Zealand, Manchester, Welsh, New york, South Carolina, and so many more. It is these accents which make the language richer and give it character, as they show the history, geography, ethnography and even politics of the area where they have developed. They also often give a sense of belonging

What is an accent?
An accent is the way in which a language is pronounced, and this will vary depending on nation, location, or even social class. There are two different accents. First is the "foreign accent" that occurs where an individual speaks a language using sounds and rules of another language which is not his/her mother tongue. The other kind of accent is associated with variations on a person's mother tongue. People who live together tend to share a way of speaking or have an accent, which differs from other groups. This can be true of villages which are only a few miles apart. The difference in accent may be subtle but to the trained ear it is there. However, the difference can also be so great as to be indecipherable to an "outsider". A week or so of listening to a different accent is usually enough to adapt and start understanding, it depends on the language level of the learner and the amount of exposure he or she is given.

Like languages, accents are also constantly evolving. For instance Cockney is no longer the prevailing accent in London. With the influx of Jamaican and with the influence of American on the language, there is a new accent in London termed Estuary English. This is is a variation of Cockney but spreading very quickly and tending to dominate, especially among the younger generation.

It has been suggested that students do not learn accent from their teacher. Instead they develop from exposure to the language in their environment which these days means social media, films, TV, pop songs books, comics etc. I am aware of one Swedish Lady who spoke with a perfect Manchester accent through being addicted to a Manchester soap opera. I am inclined to believe that the teacher is a role model and so has a duty to teach clear English probably with the help of the IPA as is taught in teacher training.

How to make students aware of the different accents throughout the world
While it is not the job of a teacher to instill a particular accent into a student, which could be a dangerous and stifling experience. We can expose our students to various accents and make them aware of them and prepare them for what sounds they might encounter outside of the classroom. These days that is particularly easy with social media and particularly YOUTUBE. In the past, when foreign students were taught BBC English, it often came as quite a shock to learn that the majority of British people did not actually speak that way. Most languages have a standardized form, normally the language spoken by newsreaders and the like but it is very important to make students aware of the variations that can also be used.

Accented Native or Non-native speakers Can a teacher who has an accent teach English?
Much has been said about the ability of non-native English teachers to teach EFL or ESL students and the debate rages on. In the past and as I am about to show, still in the present, there was and still remains concern about whether a teacher whose language is characterized by flaws in intonation, pronunciation, and grammar patterns can still teach and communicate effectively. In other words, can an accented English teacher be a good language teacher for his or her students? The answer is of course, yes, for so many reasons that we as teachers appreciate.

In his work published in 1999, Canagarajah[1] describes the native English speaking teacher and non-native English speaking as center speakers of English and periphery speakers of English. The first group refers to

those who use English as their first language including United States, Australia, Britain, and New Zealand. The second group, periphery are those from other countries outside of these four, this irrespective of whether they speak English as a first language or second language such as Canada, Germany, Ghana, and so on. These are referred to as the accented teachers.

Please look at the following example.
According to an article published on Wall Street Journal indicates that the Department of Education in Arizona decided that teachers whose English is deemed accented must be removed and restrained from teaching in a class of students still learning English. The author indicates that the move is to ensure that low-proficiency level students are taught by native English teachers. Also, she states that to ensure this happens, the Education Department started classroom observations in the entire state to evaluate the output of teachers in pronunciation, writing skills, and correct use of grammar.

Article 5

It's understood that the best entry into the business world, would be through a good MBA degree. Why so? Because getting an education is requisite to succeed in any kind of business, today. And possessing such a valued management degree can make all that difference to excel and succeed amidst all the cut-throat competition.

You should definitely think of an MBA, if you are looking to start your own Business or switch careers mid-way or want to progress in an established career, itself.

Now, when compared to other Masters programs that deal with specific specializations, an MBA degree acts more like an interdisciplinary program, focusing on essentials from relevant fields of Psychology, Sociology, Economics, Accounting and Finance.

And ofcourse, an MBA also immensely helps one to polish their skills and prepare for various managerial roles such as manufacturing, advertising and sale of products and services, managing the finances , keeping a positive image of company in the market, analyzing the industry and market data and trends, managing the best team to keep the company running etc.

You also learn to toe the line and make improvised decisions during tough times and major challenges. And, you get some of the best networking opportunities, as you make your way up, the managerial ladder.

Many of the current employees who hold a high-level management position, today possess a MBA degree. And the positions include senior managers and board directors. So, that means higher salary, bonuses but also greater responsibility.

Lastly, the people you meet and interact during your MBA college life, internships and fests; they become your valuable buddies in the management world later on. It's like a reliable partnership for life. Who knows, you might meet your future business partner or mentor.

Well, that's a great picture painted there on why an MBA should be pursued. But, we still have another important decision to make; MBA in India or MBA abroad? And, for that we shall be seeing in detail, for both cases.

Scope of MBA in India

Nowadays, pursuing your MBA in India isn't a wrong choice for those who don't have major financing for an education abroad. By now, you know there are number of reputed Management colleges and institutes in India that are recognized all over the world. For instance, the Indian Institute of Management, Ahmedabad, recently made it to top 50 of

QS World University Rankings: Global MBA Rankings 2018. Indian Institute of Management, Bangalore also featured at 58th rank and Indian School of Business, Hyderabad at 93rd rank.

So, what is needed, is a thorough self- evaluation and information about the course and university. It's also vital to understand the background of any MBA program or course objectives.

If it's the global exposure you want without having to do full-time MBA abroad, then are plenty of opportunities for that. Indian B-schools run in tie-ups with foreign universities and colleges for student exchange programs and internships, which can give you the global touch in your resume.

The demand for MBA graduates in India is up, because of managerial opportunities, in the fields of Banking, Finance, Investment and Corporate Banking, Information System Management, Healthcare management, Marketing and Sales, Entrepreneurship, Operations Management, Human Resources, Strategic Management, Organizational Communication and Corporate Social Responsibility. And these sectoral opportunities are just going to rise, with rise in businesses, Tech startups, MNCs, industries and companies in India.

With plenty of jobs available in banks, insurance companies, financial organizations, hospitals, educational institutions, the profile of a MBA graduate in India, is simply worthwhile. However, you got to work hard,prove your skills and expertise to climb up the ranks of top managerial circles.

In the recent placement season of 2017, many top B-schools in India recorded sharp increase in their average and highest salary packages. S.P. Jain Institute of Management and Research, Mumbai, Faculty of Management Studies, Delhi, Jamnalal Bajaj Institute of Management Studies, Mumbai, Management Development Institute, Gurgaon, XLRI Jamshedpur were some of the MBA colleges that recorded high average salary packages. The highest average salary package was INR 20.9 Lacs p.a. and maximum salary package was INR 54 Lacs p.a.

MBA in India doesn't sound so bad!

Scope of MBA Abroad

Next, moving on to a management education, abroad. And why should anyone pursue so? That's primarily because one can expect and gain new perspectives on managing business and experience global scenario while doing so, apart from the experience to live in a different country. So, it's kind of mixture of increase in the cultural and intellectual experience.

Next, it is important to evaluate the reputation of the business school, along with the state of the economy, job scenario and specific career prospects in the particular country. That'sbecause job and market trends vary tremendously from that of Indian market. Factors like economic recession have burdened too many

people during its last hit in global markets. Plan well in advance, about the type of job profile and industry type you want to get in and choose your B-school accordingly.

Insead Business School, France, HEC Paris, France, London Business School, UK, Harvard Business School, USA and Duke University, USA are some of the known faces among top business schools abroad.

Now, one of the best reasons to study MBA abroad is that you get a chance to work abroad. Also, it gives a hope to the start of an international career, if not long, at least for few years. That ultimately gives your resume an impressive touch. It shows that you have what it takes, to work in a global and multilingual setup. So, even if you come back to India, few years down the line, you would be a very potential candidate, back home.

Working in the exports, International marketing, Business Development profiles are quite promising and rewarding. Simply because you get to travel much in your initial work years and also because it adds value to your resume. Other good profiles are that of Banker, Insurance Broker, Financial Advisor, Investment Analyst and Project Manager, Business Head etc.

Some of the foreign companies that employ a large number of MBA graduates include Deloitte, Ernst & Young, McKinsey, Boston Consulting Group, Apple, IBM, Procter and Gamble, Amazon etc.

Those with one year of work experience can expect an average salary of $50,000 per year. One to four years of experience can lead to $60,000 and 10 to 19 years can further lead to salary of more than $95,000 per year.

Now, one of the popular job profiles after MBA is in the line of Strategic Management, which offers about $90,000 initially and increases to more than $140,000, annually. Human Resources is another preferred area, where the median pay can rise above $75,000, annually.

How to Decide Between MBA in India and MBA Abroad?
We are going to break it down, step by step, into the task of better possibilities and opportunities of doing MBA, both in India and abroad.

I. The cost of doing an MBA in India and abroad varies with the type of institution, funding and other factors. It can be about INR 10-15 Lacs in IIMs, whereas MBA degree from the top reputed institutions abroad, can cost about INR 30- 50 Lacs in total.

And that is why this point should be evaluated well. It is important to ask yourself whether spending huge amounts is actually worth for you. Now, there would be two scenarios here. Either you have your own means of funding or else a financial loan. If you have your own money, then you should go for it. Also, be aware of number of years needed to recover the total cost of investment. At the same time, you can also find out scholarship possibilities for abroad. For example, countries like Canada, Germany and Australia provide MBA education at low cost budgets.

II. For those taking the help of educational loans to study abroad, it is slightly easier to pay off the loan. That way, doing your MBA through financial aid is good, provided you have proper plan to manage your expenses and loan installments later on. What matters is a good job profile.

III. Understanding your aim and goal through a course in management education is also vital. Do you intend to work and settle in India? Do you intend to work abroad, a few years and then back to India? Or settle abroad in India?

Guess you can see how essential it is to answer these questions, by yourself.

IV. Internships are common in almost every management education. In India, you get placed through placements mode and not internships. The slightly higher edge is that, in abroad, students get job offers through their internships, as well. However, you need to be very good at what you do. Because the competition can be slightly high, with more diverse talent.

V. Now, sometimes there are good MBA programs that are only available abroad and not in India. Here also, your actual aim and goal plays important part in deciding whether to pursue MBA in India or abroad.

So, on the overall, the worth of a MBA from abroad, is more because of higher returns on investment, that too at a quicker pacethan the Indian job market for MBA graduates. On the other hand, studying in the top B-schools in India can guarantee those costs of investments.

But what makes the worth of foreign MBA higher than an MBA in India, is the combined form of more global exposure, diverse expertise and skills and higher pay, that one stands to gain, provided he/she has what it takes to be at the top.

So, there you go! Hope you are able to get a proper base, so as to figure out your aim and goal, and make the right choice for your management education in MBA. Whether it is India or abroad, you have to work hard and that is inevitable.

Article 6

The Centre's bid to dispel the pall of gloom over the economy has been helped in recent weeks by a sovereign rating upgrade from a global agency and a sharp improvement in India's rank on a World Bank index for ease of doing business. More significantly, the economy clocked a growth of 6.3% in the second quarter of this year, after slowing for at least four quarters. But official data for the third quarter (October to December) so far suggest that the economy is still not entirely out of the woods and fresh headwinds, such as rising oil prices, could upset the fragile recovery. Manufacturing growth, driven by restocking by producers after the rollout of the goods and services tax, was a major factor in the second quarter growth pick-up. After two months of robust 4%-plus growth, industrial activity however slipped in October, with the Index of Industrial Production reflecting just 2.2% growth. October was a festive month but consumer durables production contracted by nearly 7%, mining was virtually stagnant, and manufacturing growth moderated to 2.5% from 3.8% last year. This coincides with exporters seeing a 1.1% slump in shipments in October, after growing at an average of over 13% in the second quarter. It is also borne out by the nearly 10% drop in GST collections that month compared to September. The IIP has now grown just 2.5% in the first seven months of 2017-18, compared to 5.5% in the same period last fiscal.

If the spectre of slower growth with weak exports at a time when global trade is recovering is not worrying enough, with job creation still to pick up, the latest inflation data set too is cause for concern. Prices at the consumer level rose at the fastest pace in 15 months this November, with inflation touching 4.88%, up from 3.6% in October and just 1.5% in June. This reflects a broad-based price rise under way, although it is led by fuel inflation (at 7.2%, from 6.1% a month ago) and food inflation (4.4%, from 1.9% in October). Within food, rising onion and tomato prices pushed vegetable inflation to a 16-month high of 22.5%; inflation in

egg prices quickened from 0.8% in October to 8% in November. While some of this food inflation could wane in the coming months, there is greater concern about the rise in core inflation (excluding food and fuel) and inflation imported through high global prices. On Tuesday, oil prices breached the $65 a barrel mark for the first time in over two years. The government faces difficult choices. Slashing fuel taxes could calm inflation, but it would hit revenue collections that are already uncertain owing to GST deadline extensions. Not doing so would leave less room for the central bank to lower interest rates. As the Economic Survey said, oil at $60-65 could hit consumption and public investment and dent private investment further. That is not a path to a sustained revival.

Article 7

Judicial finality need not necessarily mean that India should hang Yakub Memon. Even in this situation, as his life thread of a fresh mercy plea to the President, is the irreversible and inhuman sentence of death the only recourse for a democratic government?

Carrying out the sentence will only have the appearance of a justice that is retributive and vengeful, not substantial or morally different from the very offence that gave rise to the proceedings. In recent times, we saw the horrific judicial murder of Afzal Guru, who was hanged in secret without a final opportunity for his family to meet him, marking an unprecedented abandonment of morality on the part of the state. It was only in apparent cognisance of this that the Supreme Court ruled early last year that a formal communication to the convict and his family, intimation to the local legal aid centre and a clear gap of 14 days between the communication and the execution were necessary. Further, there are bound to be questions each time someone is hanged or spared. Even in the Mumbai blasts case, the 10 men sentenced to death by the trial court for planting the explosives were given only life terms by the Supreme Court on appeal, while Yakub Memon alone was awarded the death penalty. Such distinctions may seem arbitrary to the layman. As also, the revelation that the Memon family may have been induced to return to India will cast a shadow on the legitimacy of hanging a man who cooperated with Indian agencies.

The debate on the need and desirability of retaining the death penalty has been overshadowed by much intellectual exertion on the nature of the crime involved, its gravity, its heinousness and the fatalities it caused. The time has come to end this debate once and for all by ascending to a moral position that there shall be no death penalty on the statute book, regardless of the heinousness of the offence, the circumstances or the number of fatalities involved. Anyone following closely the evolution of the law on death sentences and the clemency jurisdiction in India will understand that the Supreme Court is making it more and more difficult for the executive to carry out death sentences. It has evolved a jurisprudence that limits capital punishment to the 'rarest of rare cases', allowed a post-appeal review as well as a curative petition, and made decisions on appeals for mercy justiciable. It has laid down a cast-iron rule against undue delay in disposing of such mercy pleas, and it has humanised the process by repeatedly intervening in favour of condemned prisoners, often at the very last minute. A truly lasting solution to the moral dilemma that each instance of capital punishment poses will be to abolish it altogether and replace it with a sentence of imprisonment for the rest of the convict's life. The quality of mercy is not strained. The President, under Article 72 of the Constitution, has the power to grant pardon, and to suspend, remit or commute sentences. To not exercise this expansive power in the service of mercy would be inhuman and unconscionable.

Article 8

All money is a work of the imagination. Pound coins, dollar bills, and even the fragments of computer code known as bitcoins can do their work only because of a collective agreement that they will. That doesn't mean they are imaginary. Their power is real, but it arises from mass belief. When people lose faith in a currency it can lose all its purchase on the real world and be reduced to nothing more than squiggles on paper, tulip bulbs or figures in a spreadsheet cell. So, there is nothing unnatural in the efforts of libertarian computer programmers to invent their own money, and then to use these new currencies to buy things, among them old-fashioned currencies like dollars and euros. So long as enough people agree to believe in them, they exist like any other. Bitcoin, the oldest, best known and most valuable, has lasted for nine years now.

All these cryptocurrencies are made possible by an ingenious solution to a problem which would otherwise make purely digital currencies impossible. A digital currency is one which exists solely as a string of numbers inside a computer and copying numbers at lightning speed is the core competence of any computer. So there seemed to be no way to stop any given piece of digital currency from being copied and spent unlimited times. This ease of copying is what devastated the music industry and many others. It seemed to make digital money impossible even in theory. The solution turned out to be a programming device called the blockchain, which ensured that any transaction could be recorded in a way that was impossible for anyone ever to change. Applied to money, this means that the same bitcoin can't be spent twice without changing hands.

There remains the problem of what to spend it on; and the experience of the last nine years suggests that they are mostly spent when anonymity is an advantage to buyer, or seller or both: drugs and ransoms for malware are the ones for which bitcoin is chiefly known Although some businesses have accepted it in payment for legitimate goods, their number is shrinking as it soars against the dollar. Why spend it at all when you could hoard it?

Because cryptocurrencies can be anonymous, it's impossible to know how many people use them. Estimates from the Judge Business School in Cambridge suggest that there are between 5m and 10m active users in the world today. Very few are using it as currency, or as a medium of exchange. Instead it is being used as a means of speculation. The exchange rate between the bitcoin and the dollar has seen the price fluctuate crazily in the last three years, from $1,242 to $246 and back up above $2,800 again. Why not, when it is worth only whatever buyers and sellers agree at any one moment that it should be?

Another, rival, cryptocurrency, ethereum, has appreciated by more than 40 times against the dollar this year. At current prices, the two together are priced at a notional $66bn. There's still little sign of anything except imagination to justify this. Ethereum has technical advantages. It can itself contain computer programs which can then be run by other holders of ethereum. The hope is that contracts can be made and enforced without any human intervention, instantaneously and incorruptibly. That might save banks, for instance, an awful lot of money. The promoters of these technologies are filled with the mixture of exuberant greed and libertarian zeal that drove the earlier iterations of the internet such as the growth of the world wide web. That is a disconcerting precedent. There is a persistent belief among programmers that understanding how code works means that they also understand the world outside code. It is mistaken. The web has turned out to be something that nobody had imagined, whether they could build the underlying technology or not. It is both better and worse in many ways than we could then dream – and much more powerful. When all today's bubbles have burst the blockchain may prove the same.

Article 9

Given Nepal's mix of the first-past-the-post system and proportional representation, the final picture of its new Parliament may take some time to be clear. But it is already evident that the Left Alliance is on course to win more than 70% of the 165 parliamentary seats being decided by the FPTP system. In the 110 seats allocated based on proportional representation, the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist-Leninist) is leading, with its ally, the Communist Party of Nepal (Maoist-Centre), not far behind. This is a decisive victory for the Left Alliance, the first such win for the leftists since Nepal turned democratic in 1990. The UML had also emerged as the single largest party in the local elections held earlier this year; with the Maoists joining them in the run-up to the parliamentary polls, the resulting alliance has proved to be ideologically coherent. The UML expanded its support base beyond the hill-towns and the Terai into the far-west and the upper-hills, while the Maoists, who had floundered in elections since the formation of the Constituent Assembly in 2008, got second place and staved off decline. For the Nepali Congress, the third-place finish is a severe blow, limiting it to its weakest parliamentary presence. Others in the "democratic alliance" led by the NC, the plains-based Madhesi parties and the former royalist parties that tried using the Hindu card, have also received a setback.

It is quite clear that the Left Alliance's win draws from a yearning for a stable and lasting government after years of political instability. This is reflected in the fact that 13 leaders have held the post of Prime Minister since 1990. The Left Alliance has been seen as a natural coming together of like-minded forces which had both given up on radicalism and were willing to work within the parliamentary system. With such a big mandate, it is incumbent upon the alliance to finally focus on governance. Such transformative moments have been visible in the past too — during the initial sitting of the Constituent Assembly almost a decade ago when nearly the entire polity voted for Nepal to become a republic, or when the peace process between the Nepali state and the Maoists was completed, or after the earthquake in 2015 when political parties decided to quickly narrow down their differences on the Constitution in order to work together. But they all lapsed into more political wrangling. The Left Alliance now has both the opportunity and the strength to deliver on governance and development. As for the NC, the grand old party of Nepal has much to introspect on. It was blindsided by the formation of the Left Alliance and its own ragtag alliance was found to be wanting. It will now have to step up to play its role in opposition.

Article 10

India's admittance into the Wassenaar Arrangement, a multilateral export control regime, as its 42nd participating member is a big step forward in its quest for formal acceptance as a responsible nuclear power. This has come a year after India made the request for membership. As a non-signatory to the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT), New Delhi has been at pains to convey to the international community that it adheres to, and is invested in, a rules-based order. The Wassenaar Arrangement was founded in 1996, and is clubbed with mechanisms such as the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG), the Missile Technology Control Regime (MTCR) and the Australia Group. Its stated aim is "to contribute to regional and international security and stability, by promoting transparency and greater responsibility in transfers of conventional arms and dual-use goods and technologies, thus preventing destabilising accumulations." India's Wassenaar success at the Vienna plenary meeting last week presumes a broad acceptance among its members of the country's credentials as a fastidious adherent to export controls. It comes on the heels of membership last

year of the MTCR. Ever since India signed the 123 Agreement in 2005, the underlying assumption was that the United States would help chaperone New Delhi into global nuclear acceptability after it separated its civil and military nuclear programmes and plugged the loopholes to prevent diffusion of nuclear materials and technology in a way that is demonstrably in line with best practices followed by the members of the NSG.

However, over the past couple of years it has become evident that Delhi has to do most of the heavy lifting to gain a seat at various global high tables. The Wassenaar Arrangement membership is also a lesson on the need for quiet diplomacy in sensitive nuclear issues, compared to the botched attempt to gain entry to the NSG last year. While India's efforts at the NSG were stopped by China, which is not a member of the Wassenaar Arrangement, raising the pitch publicly at the time came with costs. It made the task of forging a consensus on membership to the NSG more difficult. And when that attempt failed, it gave the setback the appearance of being significantly more insurmountable. Nonetheless, now that more and more countries are signing on to India's steadily strengthening credentials in the nuclear area, there is hope that a fresh momentum will be imparted to a future bid for the NSG. It will not be easy. The Australia Group, which focusses on biological and chemical weapons, may be easier to crack given that China is not a member. But meanwhile, the Wassenaar Arrangement will embed India deeper in the global non-proliferation architecture and enable access to critical technologies in the defence and space sectors.

Article 11

It is an ongoing investigation and very little can be said with certainty about the back-story of the murder of a Bengali migrant worker in Rajasthan's Rajsamand district. But from videos shared on social media and initial information from the police, a few things are clear. Mohammed Afrazul Khan, aged 50 and a long-time resident of Rajasthan, was hacked to death and his body set on fire by a man identified by the police as Shambhu Lal Raigar, a former marble trader. The videos, uploaded by his 14-year-old nephew, record Raigar as saying he killed Afrazul to save a woman from "love jihad", and ranting against Muslims, his ramble ranging from films depicting inter-religious romance to the Babri Masjid. The police arrested Raigar and his nephew and declared they would seek the death penalty for the former. Director-General of Police O.P. Galhotra said that prima facie the murderer was of unsound mind, a theory his family seems to subscribe to. While Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje condemned the murder, saying the case should be prosecuted swiftly, the opposition has embedded the crime in the larger majoritarian rhetoric of the Sangh Parivar. But irrespective of whether the murder was the work of an isolated and unsound mind or a deliberate conspiracy, it is important that the political discourse around it be responsible, and responsive to the insecurity among migrant workers, especially those who are Muslims. It is imperative that this case comes to trial swiftly and the guilty are brought to book; this will be a test of the system's capacity and intent to deal firmly with hate crimes.

Hate crimes are particularly serious because of their potential to provoke panic. The speed with which the videos travelled on social media frames a difficult challenge for law enforcement authorities. A temporary Internet shutdown that was enforced in Rajsamand may appear unavoidable, but these are post-hoc measures and cannot prevent the problem of provocative, even grisly, content being made available and even spreading online. Rajasthan's elected leaders would do well to go beyond denouncing the murder and its heinousness. Given the sheer venality of the videos, their accompanying anti-Muslim rhetoric, and the likely sense of insecurity they have caused, it is important for them to declare that they stand firmly against

sectarian hate crimes. Such crimes pose a very stiff challenge in a democratic society. They may be isolated, they may be the handiwork of individuals acting on their own, but by positioning one group (religious, racial, ethnic, gender) against another, the impact of these crimes spills into the wider community. They heighten anxieties among the targeted groups, and in the age of a polarised social media, they risk giving the unacceptable a perverse acceptability. There is only one way to counter them: with a clear, unambiguous consensus against hate.

Article 12

The election of Justice Dalveer Bhandari to the International Court of Justice for a second term is a major diplomatic success for India. Five of the 15 judges of the ICJ are elected every three years. This year there were six candidates for five slots. The winning candidates required a majority in both the United Nations General Assembly and the Security Council in simultaneous voting through secret ballot. While four candidates were elected smoothly, Justice Bhandari and Christopher Greenwood of the United Kingdom ended in a dead heat as the former won the UNGA and the latter the UNSC in multiple rounds of voting. The U.K. wanted to end the voting and move to a conference mechanism, which involves selecting a panel of three UNGA members and three UNSC members, who would then elect the judge. This mechanism has never been used before. India opposed the move, and the U.K. could not gather adequate support for its demand in the UNSC. The U.K. then withdrew its candidate, paving the way for Justice Bhandari's re-election. India and the U.K. had staked considerable diplomatic goodwill in the election, and the outcome is significant politically for both.

For the first time, the U.K. will not have a judge on the ICJ. It is also the first time that a permanent member of the UNSC has lost at the ICJ on a vote. For British Prime Minister Theresa May the loss comes at a difficult time as she struggles with the process of leaving the European Union and with her own leadership coming under assault from Conservative MPs. In this context, the loss at the ICJ is being read as confirmation of the U.K.'s diminishing role in global affairs. As America's inseparable and unquestioning junior partner, the country had asserted its relevance in the post-War order even as its military and economic power eroded. With the U.S. under President Donald Trump less guided by the "special relationship" with the U.K., a post-Brexit U.K. will have to do much more heavy-lifting in multilateral forums. For India, soon after its failure to gain membership to the Nuclear Suppliers Group, the lobbying for the ICJ election has different lessons. With all five permanent members of the UNSC fiercely locking arms to protect their collective interest of dominating the world body, India's success was built primarily on the support of developing countries, among whom it has nurtured goodwill over the decades. Japan also appeared to align with the P-5. India's call for a more equitable world order has a better resonance among developing countries than the custodians of the current order. India's support in the UNGA was expanding with subsequent rounds of voting, a reality the U.K. and the U.S. could not brush aside. For India, the takeaway is clear: to find a louder global voice, it also needs to put more emphasis on ties with countries away from the high table.

Article 13

The disqualification of dissident Janata Dal (United) leaders Sharad Yadav and Ali Anwar as members of the Rajya Sabha was done in needless haste. Even if it did not violate the letter of the anti-defection legislation, the Chairman of the Rajya Sabha, Vice-President M. Venkaiah Naidu, could have considered whether it militated against its spirit. In his order, he cited the time-consuming procedural requirements as the justification for not referring the issue to the committee of privileges. Mr. Naidu took the view that all such cases should be disposed of within three months as any delay would be tantamount to subverting the anti-defection law. But neither Mr. Yadav nor Mr. Anwar posed a threat to any government to warrant such fast-tracking of the disqualification process. The decision under the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution was sought to be justified on the basis of the argument that the two members voluntarily gave up the membership of their party when they attended political rallies organised by rival parties. Mr. Naidu went by the fact that the faction led by Mr. Yadav did not command a majority within the JD(U) legislature party in the Rajya Sabha. Quite correctly, he did not accept the contention of the two members that it was the JD(U) leader Nitish Kumar who had given up membership of the party by quitting the Mahagathbandhan, the grand political alliance that had brought the party to power in Bihar. It is current political affiliation and not past electoral alliance that is relevant to the disqualification process. However, neither Mr. Yadav nor Mr. Anwar had disobeyed a whip or posed a danger to the stability of any government. Given this, the Rajya Sabha Chairman could have taken the assistance of the privileges committee before deciding the case. It is the fact that he did not exhaust all the procedural avenues before him that has left him open to charges that his ruling has a political hue.

The JD(U) order is the latest in a long list of contentious decisions on disqualification by presiding officers. In many State Assemblies, such disqualification proceedings have had an impact on the very survival of the government, most recently in Tamil Nadu and Uttarakhand. Invariably, presiding officers take a politically partisan view, necessitating judicial intervention. India's party-based parliamentary democracy requires MPs and MLAs to strike a fine balance between their roles as representatives of the people and of a political party. As members of the legislature are elected by votes sought in their own name and in the name of their party, the provisions of the Tenth Schedule should not be misused to stifle dissent, whether inside or outside the House. The anti-defection law works best as an insurance against violation of the people's mandate for a party, but it cannot be made a tool to stifle all dissent.

Article 14

If the EU referendum taught this country's pro-Europeans anything, it ought to be that they lacked the political focus and discipline of the leavers. Pro-EU campaign complacency proved no match for pro-Brexit fanaticism, with catastrophic results. Something similar is now in danger of happening again, as the Brexit process reaches a critical milestone: the end of phase one of the Brexit talks. If Britain is not to pitch out of the EU without a deal, it is vital that history does not repeat itself. But the danger of that is very great.

The trigger for the current crisis was the Democratic Unionists' derailing of the draft EU-UK phase one deal in Brussels on Monday. That happened because of an inexcusable political oversight. The UK government did not share the content in advance with its DUP backers, who pulled the plug, fearing that Northern Ireland would be put into a special status separate from the rest of the UK.

Since Monday, however, it has become much clearer that the UK government's failures and incompetence on Brexit go wider and deeper. Philip Hammond confirmed on Wednesday what this column had reported, that the cabinet has never at any time had a specific discussion about the kind of Brexit that it is aiming for. As Sir KeirStarmer said in a Guardian article, membership of the single market, the customs union and a role for the European court of justice were simply swept off the table as options by Theresa May's grossly irresponsible diktat of October 2016.

David Davis's revelations at the Brexit select committee on Wednesday compounded that lack of direction with further shocking admissions. Amid clouds of characteristic bluster and solipsistic swagger, it eventually became clear that Mr Davis has at no point set about an assessment of the consequences of Brexit for the British economy and for UK jobs and conditions. The "impact assessments" for 58 UK economic sectors that parliament had demanded in order to better understand the Brexit options turned out not to exist at all. The only rational explanation for this extraordinary neglect of public duty and misleading of MPs is that Mr Davis knows such impact assessments would paint a bleak picture wholly at odds with the vacuous optimism of the Brexiters.

The document that Mrs May had intended to sign on Monday before the DUP vetoed it is a practical one as far as it goes. The thread running through it is the UK government's quiet willingness to compromise on the key issues – rights, money and Ireland – set out in Michel Barnier's April 2017 brief, presumably in the over-optimistic hope that this will help secure a beneficial trade deal with the EU in phase two. Yet when Mrs May was challenged on her Brexit strategy at prime minister's questions on Wednesday, she gave none of the leadership that is now needed in defence of compromise, convergence, alignment and the economic security that she should have invoked. Instead she reiterated the deluded and contradictory mantra that has got Britain into this mess in the first place – leave the single market and customs union, no hard border and a close partnership.

This proved enough to see off a disappointingly ineffective, though welcome, set of criticisms of her Brexit handling by Jeremy Corbyn at PMQs. But it cut no ice at all with either the DUP, who are in their element as the tail wagging the Tory dog, or with the Tory party's Brexit obsessives. Following Iain Duncan Smith's lead on Tuesday night, in which, completely irrationally, the former party leader accused the EU not the UK of causing the talks breakdown, three hardlineBrexit MPs rattled their swords behind Mrs May with insistences that no red lines must be crossed. It is clear that the fanatics scent blood. They see an opening to ensure the talks collapse next week with the no-deal outcome that they crave as the prelude to their desired bonfire of the social regulations.

The crucial question in politics is therefore whether the pro-Europeans have the weapons and organisation to stop this. In an important intervention this week, Nick Clegg made clear that the leave fundamentalists are focused on reaching March 2019 with the minimum of pledges to regulation or convergence. Those who oppose this scorched-earth Brexit must now match them, steel for steel, working as one, as Mr Clegg argued. That approach requires significant amendments to the withdrawal bill and parliamentary votes that put the national interest ahead of party. As so often, for the bad people to triumph it requires merely that their opponents do nothing effective. That happened in the referendum campaign. It absolutely must not happen again now.

Article 15

An ex-company executive-cum-economist turns to the anchor during a discussion on the farmers' agitation. "Overpopulation is destroying the farming activity. There are simply too many mouths to feed and the farms are shrinking. We must look to the urban areas for creating new jobs," he says. The man at the local paan shop tells no one in particular: "Yaar, none of the farmers' children want to dirty their hands anymore. They wear jeans and own mobiles. They will sell the land as soon as they inherit". A respected Hindi anchor turns to a farmers' representative, "Kaka (uncle)", he says, "Our agriculture minister is out somewhere performing yoga asanas with some baba as our farmer brothers suffer. What do the farmers really want from the government?" Kaka thinks for a bit. "The farmer has traditionally never wanted anything from a government except a fair support price," he says.

What do these pictures and dialogues have in common? They have males talking to males about what is being seen as a totally male problem, to be tackled by males. By now one is used to such responses from people about the enormous churn going on in our farming communities. They are only reacting to and repeating messages such as the ones above. What can life as a woman farmer, daily-wage labourer mean if women were to start talking?

As women who came of age in the campuses of the Sixties, many of us avidly read the first ever (1974) national report on the state of India's women, Towards Equality, cover to cover. It revealed, in no uncertain terms, that the rural agricultural sector was the biggest employer in India. However, unlike male farmers and cultivators, their female counterparts remained doubly burdened during their peak productive period with their reproductive role seen as fundamental to their gender while the duties it entailed were socially created. So even as women laboured in fields, they continued to have and rear children almost single-handedly, the report showed.

Nearly two decades later, working with a group of women on Shram Shakti (the first government report on India's women workers in the unorganised sector), this fact was reconfirmed. The farm sector, even in 1989, employed the largest number of women workers both as cultivators and daily-wage labourers. But women remained outside the formal definition of "worker" in the census reports.

Cut to the the 21st century. The latest census figures list only 32.8 per cent women formally as primary workers in the agricultural sector, in contrast to 81.1 per cent men. But the undeniable fact remains that India's agricultural industry, which employs 80 to 100 million women, cannot survive without their labour. From preparing the land, selecting seeds, preparing and sowing to transplanting the seedlings, applying manure/fertilisers/pesticides and then harvesting, winnowing and threshing, women work harder and longer than male farmers.

Maintaining the ancillary branches in this sector, like animal husbandry, fisheries and vegetable cultivation, depends almost solely on women. So where are these women while the male farmers and their kakas furiously debate the future of farming, loans, subsidies and irrigation matters? Men get more than their share of visibility on TV, in governmental publicity material and within the banking sectors but millions of women farmers have no spokesperson from their ranks.

The primary reason for this is that they are usually not listed as primary earners and owners of land assets within their families. So getting loans, participating in mandipanchayats, assessing and deciding the crop patterns, liaising with the district officials, bank managers and political representatives and bargaining for MSPs (minimum support prices), loans and subsidies, remain male activities.

Over the last decade, as farming became less and less profitable and small and marginal farmers began migrating to cities, rural jobs for full-time women daily-wage labourers (those who do not own land but work at least 183 days in a year in someone's farm) in the agricultural sector have shrunk alarmingly. The Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employee Guarantee Act, that employed many of them in the interim period, has been curtailed sharply by the government that proclaims "sabkasaathsabkavikas" as its basic mantra. According to a recent study by the Evidence for Policy Design at Harvard University's Kennedy School, there has been a drop of almost 11 per cent in women's participation in the workforce.

When confronted with these facts, the usual laconic response has been: "Oh but why do you wish women to be stuck perennially in these low pay low visibility jobs as farm labourers? Most of our educated young women do not wish to work in farms. They can now be teachers, nurses, Ashadidis". If only it were so. The same study also reveals that with so many well-educated men also competing for these white collar jobs, rural girls in urban homes, armed with a mere school certificate cannot find jobs. They must also have a college degree. So the vast sea of farmers' faces on our TV sets shows no female leaders. If they appear, they do so as sobbing widows and mothers of farmers who killed themselves or were killed by police bullets.

At a time when fundamentalism and neo-fascism are on the rise and unfettered consumerism and trade treaties are eroding old communities and threatening the environment, when measures like the ban on animal slaughter are impacting the dairy industry and destroying jobs, diseases due to the contamination of earth and water are erupting everywhere can we afford to sustain gender barriers between human beings unquestioningly? When not just the politicians and media persons but also the farmers regard the impoverished sea of women farmers as a faceless void, they deny them their humanity while diminishing their own.

Article 16

I was in the room when President Bill Clinton decided to reappoint Alan Greenspan, a lifelong Republican originally appointed by Ronald Reagan, as chairman of the Federal Reserve Board. A political adviser urged Mr. Clinton to choose an administration ally, but that was never seriously considered. The president's choice was not determined by party, or politics or ideology.

That's how it has been for decades: Federal Reserve chairmen and governors have been selected based on their ability to serve the country. President Barack Obama reappointed George W. Bush's nominee, Ben Bernanke, as chairman. President Reagan reappointed Jimmy Carter's nominee, Paul Volcker.

The Federal Reserve System was created by statute in 1913, but the independence of its monetary policy from congressional or presidential influence is not codified by law — and it wasn't always inviolable. In recent years, so-called reforms have been proposed to subject Fed monetary policy to congressional review, but its independence has so far been preserved.

For good reason: An independent Federal Reserve led by governors who are committed to pursuing its dual mandate of price stability and full employment, as well as effective regulation — and who make decisions based on facts and analysis — is critically important to our economy, the well-being of the people and the market credibility of Fed policy making.

But that independence is about to be severely tested. Daniel K. Tarullo stepped down from the Federal Reserve Board last week, adding to the board's two existing vacancies. Instead of remaining as governors, Chairwoman Janet Yellen and Stanley Fischer, the vice chairman, could step down when their terms expire next year. President Trump has already said that he will not reappoint Ms.Yellen as chairwoman because she's not a Republican.

Mr. Trump could therefore fill as many as five of the board's seven seats within the next year. I fear that he may appoint governors who lack a commitment to the Fed's dual mandate and will instead seek to please the White House.

There could also be an effort to scapegoat the Fed if (or rather, when) the administration's unrealistic economic growth estimates fail to materialize. The recent rejection of Congressional Budget Office health care estimates is a troubling sign. The administration could use rigged economic projections to attack the Fed over its decisions, rather than respecting its integrity and independence.

The Fed is not always right — no one can be on these matters. But it is staffed by, and the board consists of, immensely capable professionals who work with absolute intellectual integrity. That's why the Fed's work is highly and widely respected in the United States and around the world. This credibility keeps market interest rates lower and liquidity greater. That, too, could change.

Efforts to denigrate the integrity of the Fed's work, and to inject groundless opinion, politics and ideology, must be rejected by the board — and that means governors and other members of the Federal Open Market Committee must be willing to withstand aggressive attacks.

In the short run, these attacks could occur if the Fed raises rates when the administration would prefer to avoid impediments to its wishful thinking on growth or to the continued run-up of the stock market. The Fed is expected to raise rates two or three times during the coming year, based on its widely shared view that unemployment is as low as it can be without triggering inflation. There is undoubtedly still some room to bring those who have dropped out of the labor market back in, but mainstream labor economists say not much, especially given the skills gap.

The path to greater growth over time is productivity-enhancing policy. While a small fiscal stimulus might increase real growth and wages, a highly expansive fiscal policy is very unlikely to meaningfully increase real growth, and the rest of the effect is likely to be inflationary, absent countervailing Federal Reserve action. Waiting until inflation gains momentum could force the Fed to take more dramatic action that could induce recession. With the administration's unwillingness to appreciate these realities, Fed rate hikes could provoke political backlash.

During my years as secretary of the Treasury, I had a weekly breakfast with Mr. Greenspan and Larry Summers, the deputy secretary. We discussed everything under the sun, from the outlook for the United States economy to the latest political gossip. But never once did Mr. Summers or I, even in the privacy of those meetings, raise monetary policy, nor did anyone in the Clinton administration comment on monetary policy.

As a result, the Fed chairman knew that the White House would not try to advance an agenda on that policy. And this trust enabled the Federal Reserve and the Treasury to engage fully with each other on other matters, such as the Mexican and Asian financial crises. Sooner or later, there will be other financial crises – in the United States and abroad – and maintaining a framework of trust for the Treasury and the Fed to work together is critical.

The administration's relationship to the Fed, and its appointment of governors, must be based not on politics but on the same question every president ought to ask: Who and what will best serve our country?

Article 17

The majority of successful senior managers do not closely follow the classical rational model of first clarifying goals, assessing the problem, formulating options, estimating likelihoods of success, making a decision, and only then taking action to implement the decision. Rather, in their day-by-day tactical maneuvers, these senior executives rely on what is vaguely termed "intuition" to manage a network of interrelated problems that require them to deal with ambiguity, inconsistency, novelty, and surprise; and to integrate action into the process to thinking.

Generations of writers on management have recognized that some practicing managers rely heavily on intuition. In general, however, such writers display a poor grasp of what intuition is. Some see it as the opposite of rationality: others view it as an excuse for capriciousness. Isenberg's recent research on the cognitive processes of senior managers reveals that managers' intuition is neither of these. Rather, senior managers use intuition in at least five distinct ways.

First, they intuitively sense when a problem exists. Second, managers rely on intuition to perform well-learned behavior patterns rapidly. This intuition is not arbitrary or irrational, but is based on years of painstaking practice and hands-on experience that build skills. A third function of intuition is to synthesize isolated bits of data and practice into an integrated picture, often in an "Aha!" experience. Fourth, some managers use intuition as a check on the results of more rational analysis. Most senior executives are familiar with the formal decision analysis models and tools, and those who use such systematic methods for reaching decisions are occasionally leery of solutions suggested by these methods which run counter to their sense of the correct course of action.

Finally, managers can use intuition to bypass in-depth analysis and move rapidly to engender a plausible solution. Used in this way, intuition is an almost instantaneous cognitive process in which a manager recognizes familiar patterns. One of the implications of the intuitive style of executive management is that "thinking" is inseparable from acting. Since managers often "know" what is right before they can analyze and explain it, they frequently act first and explain later. Analysis is inextricably tied to action in thinking/acting cycles, in which managers develop thoughts about their companies and organizations not by analyzing a problematic situation and then acting, but by acting and analyzing in close concert. Given the great uncertainty of many of the management issues that they face, senior managers often instigate a course of action simply to learn more about an issue. They then use the results of the action to develop a more complete understanding of the issue. One implication of thinking/acting cycles is that action is often part of defining the problem, not just of implementing the solution.

Article 18

Around the globe, many LGBT people are being persecuted. Many more are hiding in fear. They are being made homeless, losing their jobs and being tormented by their families. Some are detained; others beaten. This is the kind of demeaning and degrading treatment that is classed as persecution under the 1951 UN Refugee Convention. As such, states have a duty under international law to act.

Businesses have no such obligation. Companies should do what they can to end persecution of LGBT people—but it would be foolish to expect too much of them. A company's primary responsibility is to its shareholders. Even in the era of inclusive capitalism, a financial gain can trump a social consideration such as rights for LGBT people. Recently, when a court case in Singapore upheld discriminatory laws against gay people, there was not a squeak from a single business. They stood back while many of their employees remained criminalised by their own country.

This case goes to show that we cannot expect businesses to see their responsibilities towards LGBT people as anything other than limited. They should take all possible measures to mitigate the harm done to LGBT people, but how far should they go to fight LGBT persecution when it may harm their bottom line? For example, Virgin Atlantic flies to a number of jurisdictions which criminalise homosexuality. Should the company halt its flights to St Lucia in solidarity with the gay men and lesbians there?

Virgin Atlantic's customers themselves could, of course, refuse to take those flights. Boycotts have already been used in the fight to end LGBT persecution: in 2013 drinkers poured Stolichnaya vodka down the drain in protest at the Russian government's anti-gay laws. But the stunt had little impact on Vladimir Putin's policies. Or companies could stop trading with anti-gay countries, just as some withdrew from South Africa to protest against apartheid. But boycotts against apartheid in South Africa worked because the discriminatory laws subjugated the overwhelming majority of the population. LGBT people are everywhere, but in each place our numbers are small. Do companies calculate that enough people care? Is boycotting Russian vodka sustainable, let alone effective?

So companies' obligations are real but limited. Ultimately, the responsibility for ending the persecution of LGBT people lies with states and international organisations such as the UN. By suggesting too much responsibility for business, we let the state off the hook.

Although countries such as Britain and the United States may no longer criminalise homosexuality, they should feel an obligation to do all they can to end criminalisation elsewhere. Our human rights are not the gift of the state, but all states have a duty to recognise and protect them. LGBT-friendly states should pressure their neighbours and allies on LGBT equality. Strong countries such as Britain and the United States could do more to enforce the international human-rights laws and UN conventions that require states to strike out their anti-gay criminal laws. South Africa has a duty to lead the way in southern Africa and across the continent.

Similarly, criminalisation of homosexuality should be incompatible with membership of the Organisation of American States, the intergovernmental organisation for the Americas. If it were, Saint Lucia and the eight other Caribbean countries that criminalise gay people would have to change. The Council of Europe has already used a similar lever. Seventeen countries, including Russia, decriminalised gay people as a result.

Governments and intergovernmental bodies can use their power to pressure states in other ways. For example, the EU is currently negotiating a trade deal with Sri Lanka. Couldn't the EU make decriminalising homosexuality a condition? Doing that would, in fact, only be good for trade. A brilliant Sri Lankan lesbian

activist is doing all she can to request that the EU take ending LGBT persecution seriously in the talks. A push from the EU could transform the lives of LGBT people in Sri Lanka and boost the country's economy.

Some businesses have done huge amounts for LGBT people all over the world, and they are to be heartily thanked. But ending LGBT persecution is not their responsibility, nor will business activism be enough on its own. It is the role of governments to end LGBT persecution. We need pressure to come from all available sources, including business, but ultimately the buck stops with states.

Article 19

Until the 1960s, social scientists and journalists almost unanimously accepted the *secularization thesis* – broadly, that life under modern capitalism tends to erode the importance of religion (which for our purposes here means monotheistic religion, chiefly Christianity). Adherents of this thesis did not claim that there would be a growth of atheism; simply that religion would have less and less importance in people's lives.

Beginning in the 60s and becoming more audible in the 70s, a minority of social scientists and popular writers began to challenge the secularization thesis. Observers of American religion noted the curious fact that the churches known as 'Mainline Protestant' were dwindling as a proportion of the total population, while the 'Evangelical' churches were growing. Evangelicalism has an 'old-time' Biblical literalist perspective, whereas Mainline Protestantism appears to have accommodated itself to the scientific worldview, accepting evolution for instance, and also accepting that the Bible is not infallible in its historical claims. So the growth of Evangelicalism and the decline of Mainline Protestantism look like the *opposite* of secularization. It has indeed been hailed as an example of desecularization.

In 1972, Dean Kelley published an influential book, *Why Conservative Churches Are Growing*. He later pointed out that a more accurate title would have been *Why Strict Churches Are Strong*. Kelley argued that religion loses appeal if it becomes lax and accommodates to the secular world. Evangelical churches were growing at the expense of Mainline churches because they made fewer concessions to the secular world and more demands on their members.

This message was taken up the sociologist Rodney Stark, who argued in *The Churching of America* and numerous other writings that religious commitment has been growing in America since the early nineteenth century. As Stark sees it, when churches accommodate themselves to the non-religious world at the behest of well-educated and comfortably-off ministers, they lose members. New, enthusiastic, and more demanding sects spring up and attract worshippers away from the more complacent liberal congregations. While some secularization is always going on, it is always being made up for by energetic new sects. In Stark's view, desecularization has outweighed secularization over the past two hundred years in America.

Since 1939, the Gallup organization had been asking a random sample of Americans 'Have you been to church in the last week?' In 1939 the affirmative response was forty-one percent. In the 70s and 80s, affirmative responses still hovered around forty-one percent! This too didn't look like secularization. Other developments seemed to give credibility to the view that religion was on a roll. For instance, there was the activity of the Religious Right (later called the New Christian Right), associated with Jerry Falwell's Moral Majority and then with Ralph Reed's Christian Coalition.

The desecularization theory has attracted many active proponents, and is regularly repeated in a stream of popular books and articles. The writers usually agree that Christianity is in its death throes in Europe, but so much the worse for Europe! The desecularizers insist that what goes for Europe does not go for America – America is different. In America, as in the Third World, religion is alive and well, even expanding its influence.

A recent example of this type of writing is *God Is Back*. Yet if we look at the evidence its authors offer, we find it consists of a breathless recitation of disconnected factoids. Those from the industrialized world are seriously misrepresented, while those from the Third World are beside the point. There is no dispute that the sheer amount of religious activity going on in the world is growing, simply because religion is stronger in the poorer half of the world, where population growth is still rapid. (The richer half of the world would show declining populations if it were not for immigration from the poorer half.)

To gauge the global trend, what we need is not a rag-bag of anecdotes, but a systematic survey of religious commitment compared with economic development. The best thing we have along these lines is the study by Pippa Norris and Ronald Inglehart reported in their book *Sacred and Secular* (2004). They looked at seventy-four countries, classified as agrarian (poorest), industrial (richer), and post-industrial (richest). They found that religious belief and commitment is dramatically higher in agrarian than in industrial societies, and is higher in industrial than in post-industrial societies. So the facts indicate that secularization is a worldwide (post-industrial) reality. What we want to know next is whether the United States of America is an exception to this. Contrary to what is frequently asserted, we'll see that it is not.

Article 20

Despite initial doubts that the growing February protests would amount to much, many observers at the time—including Lenin's Bolsheviks, Russian liberals, and foreign diplomats—were nevertheless certain that a revolution was only a matter of time. The roots of Russia's turmoil ran deep. During a devastating famine in the early 1890s, the inability of the government to provide sufficient relief had fanned revolutionary fervor in the country. In the cities, the appalling exploitation and squalor suffered by the workers triggered waves of protests and strikes.

The pressures of industrialization were worsened by the actions of Tsar Nicholas II. Reigning from 1894, Nicholas had inherited Russia's colossal empire and the autocratic ideas of his family, the Romanov dynasty. In 1905 the tsar's popularity was ebbing due to continuing domestic problems as well as an unpopular war with Japan. During a peaceful demonstration in St. Petersburg in January 1905, protesters were fired on and killed, an event that triggered months of protests. The revolt continued throughout the year. In the fall of 1905 Tsar Nicholas finally compromised. He issued the October Manifesto, which laid the groundwork for the protection of civil rights, the creation of a constitution, and the establishment of a parliament called the Duma. These concessions appeased enough of the revolutionaries for Nicholas to stay in power.

Many others viewed the October Manifesto as too little, too late. Inspired by the writings of Karl Marx (1818-1883), who foresaw a revolt in which laborers would become the ruling class, revolutionary figures, such as Lenin, continued to agitate against the tsar. Just under a decade later, unresolved social and economic tensions were magnified by Russia's entry into World War I in 1914. Located near the

front line with Germany, Petrograd (the former St. Petersburg) swarmed with soldiers and hungry workers, who toiled in the shadow of the city's lavish palaces. Exhausted by the war and food shortages, by early 1917 Petrograd was a powder keg of despair and anger with those in power. What happened next was not just a revolution, but multiple revolutions; a rejection not just of the state, but of all figures of authority: judges, policemen, government officials, army and navy officers, priests, teachers, employers, landowners, village elders, and patriarchally minded fathers and husbands.

Contrary to Shlyapnikov's prediction that the protests would peter out, the unrest snowballed in the last days of February. Red flags and banners began to appear, calling for the downfall of the monarchy. Despite the turmoil, the authorities could have contained the situation if they had avoided open conflict with the crowds. But the forces of the tsar opened fire, killing protesters. The demonstrations began to turn into a full-scale revolution as angry protesters broke into the barracks of the city's Pavlovsky Regiment. Rather than attack them, the soldiers joined the protesters, some even firing on their own officers. The authorities were, by now, almost deprived of military power in the capital. The expansion of the revolt led some to assume that events were being orchestrated by socialist parties. In fact, they were driven by many individuals: soldiers, workers, and students, people whose names never made it into the history books.

Although the Provisional Government saw itself as an interim body to guide the country through the war and the ongoing political upheaval, it nevertheless enacted significant reforms. Led by Prime Minister Prince Georgy Lvov, a liberal reformer, and Minister of Justice Aleksandr Kerensky—the lone socialist and only government figure who was also a member of the soviet—it swept away the old laws of the tsarist regime against freedoms of speech and assembly. Russia was transformed into what Lenin called the "freest country in the world." From exile in Switzerland, the Bolshevik leader followed the rapid course of events in Petrograd with frustration. He finally returned to Russia on a sealed train provided by the Germans, who were hoping that his opposition to the war would undermine the Russian war effort. On April 3 Lenin arrived at Petrograd's Finland Station with a 10-point program—his April Theses (later published in *Pravda,* the Bolshevik newspaper)—for a second revolution based on "power to the soviets."

On February 27 a crowd came to the Tauride Palace—the seat of the Duma—looking for leaders. A workers' council, known as a soviet, was elected. The majority of the leaders of the Petrograd Soviet had no intention of taking power. Instead, they wanted the Duma leaders to form a government in line with the doctrine laid down by Karl Marx: That in a country such as Russia, the first step toward a socialist order would be taken by bourgeois democrats. On March 1, a provisional government was formed. The soviet pledged to support it as long as it adhered to a comprehensive list of democratic principles. Nothing less than Tsar Nicholas's abdication, meanwhile, could save the war campaign against Germany—all his senior generals told him so. The Duma also called on him to stand down. On March 2, 1917, Nicholas II gave up the throne. The end of the monarchy was marked by scenes of rejoicing throughout the Russian Empire. Symbols of monarchical power—emblems, coats of arms, double-headed eagles, and tsarist statues—were destroyed.

Lenin's writings ran counter to Marxist theory because they rejected the need for the first phase—the "bourgeois-democratic" revolution. Even so, Lenin managed to win the Bolshevik Party around to his theses. Mass enrollments of workers and soldiers drawn to his charisma aided his cause. These new members knew little about Marxist theory and valued his efficiency: Why wait to reach socialism in two stages when they could get there in one? Discontent continued to spread throughout Russia from the cities to the countryside. Workers' expectations soared: Strikers called for an eight-hour day and workers' control of the factories. As part of the wider crisis in authority, the Petrograd Soviet had limited control over revolts in the provinces and agrarian communities. Local towns and regions behaved as if they were independent of the nation. As in 1905, the village commune was the organizing kernel of the

revolution in the countryside, as land and livestock were seized. Soldiers had their own committees, which supervised relations with the officers. Some soldiers refused to fight for more than eight hours a day, claiming the same rights as the workers.

Article 21

The emergence of competition in the banking sector has pushed the public sector banks to adopt innovations in their business models. The rise of competition has come from the private sector banks, the foreign banks and the new kids on the block – viz the microfinance and non-banking finance companies. The innovations have been at three levels. At one level the banks have introduced changes in the way they source deposits from the public. Using those deposits to offer credit has also undergone changes. The third level of changes or innovation has come in the internal process of the banks. These innovations have become necessary, as we have said, for the public sector banks to retain their supremacy in the markets. These banks between themselves control 70% of the banking business in the country, which means, when they ring in innovations the entire banking sector undergoes changes. The first level of changes the public sector banks have made is in making it easy for the public to open an account.

To understand the level of innovation, one has to know the RBI rules that guide opening of accounts in banks. The RBI rules are encapsulated in the Know Your Customer guidelines or KYC for short. Banks have to obtain exhaustive list of information on their prospective customers, before they allow a new account. Since this involves providing a lot of documentation the process is almost closed for the relatively poor people including even those receiving salary in the 26rganized sector, who therefore cannot transact through a bank. But it is necessary that they are brought into the banking system to obtain cheap credit and take advantage of other benefits that a bank account provides. These banks have therefore started a no-frills account class. The accounts do not require a customer to maintain a minimum balance as that is too expensive for them. In return the banks do not provide them cheque books but they can use the account with debit cards to do business. This innovation has vastly expanded the reach of the banking sector and already India has the largest number of savings bank accounts in the world. The landless labourers working under the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act too have been able to obtain bank accounts thanks to the no-frills account. The banks have similarly introduced innovative practices in their credit practices.

Article 22

Drama, as we know, is quite different from a novel or a poem. We usually read a novel or a poem when we are alone. But drama is something more than words on the page – it is meant to be performed or enacted. The audience is an active participant in the theatrical presentation. So we respond to a play not alone but along with the other members of the audience. It is quite another matter that different people will respond differently. But then there are some plays which we do not see performed but read them as literature. How will we approach such plays? One must remember that playwrights usually expect their plays to be performed. It is for this reason that they present their themes through dialogue, action, music, song and dance so that the play is visually captivating. So when reading a play one should make full use of our imaginative powers. We must try to see the action -and scenes as well as hear the voices of the characters. It

is only then that one will be able to experience the play in its different dimensions: as 'literature' as well as 'theatre'.

Modern Indian drama is influenced not only by classical sanskrit drama or local folk forms but also by Western theatre following the establishment of British rule in India. Sanskrit drama flourished in ancient India and produced Bharata'sNatayshastra, the great treatise on all aspects of drama. It is comparable in range and scope to Aristotle's Poetics. In the Poetics, Aristotle prioritizes tragedy as a higher art form as opposed to comedy. But in classical Sanskrit drama there cannot be a tragic end. This is because of the Hindu worldview which considers the world a 'maya' or an 'illusion' and death not a final end, but a release of the soul into higher forms of being-an event to be celebrated rather than lamented. So there are no tragedies in Sanskrit drama.

People in the West first heard of Kalidasa'sShakuntala (circa 5th century) when Sir William Jones translated it into English in 1789. His excellent translation brought Sanskrit drama to the attention of the Western world. Goethe (1749-1832), the German writer was so impressed that he borrowed the convention of the Prologue from Shakuntala and used it in his own play Faust. Kalidasa, however, was not the only playwright that ancient India produced. In the Hindu period of the first nine centuries, we have three kings Shudraka, Harsha and Visakadatta who wrote plays that now form part of our great cultured heritage. Shudraka (circa 4 A.D.) wrote the famous Mrichkattakatn or The Little Clay Cart which features regularly in contemporary drama festivals as Mitti Ki Gadi. The Little Clay Cart is a social play. Vasantsena the beautiful courtesan loves Charudatta a noble Brahmin who is already married. Sansthanaka, the brother-inlaw of the king tries to make overtures to the courtesan who repulses him. His wicked schemes to implicate Charudatta in Vasantsena's alleged murder come to nought as Aryaka a shepherd rebel overthrows the king and sets both Charudatta and Vasantsena free to marry and live a happy life. Visakadatta wrote the powerful play Mudrarasaka (Raksasa captured through the Signet Ring). The play deals with two rival ministers- Chanakya and Raksasa. Chanakya represents intelligence and intrigue whereas Raksasa is a man of noble ideals and integrity. The play gives us an insight into the minds of power-hungry politicians. Bhasa wrote 134 plays comprising monologues, one-act plays, and six-act dramas. His masterpiece is SwapanaVasavadatta (Vasavadatta Seen in a Dream). The story is about King Udayana who is torn between his love for his wife Vasavadatta and the political necessity of marrying Padrnavati, the daughter of a neighbouring king. Harsha's (7th century) best-known play is Ratnavali. Ratnavali is somewhat similar in plot to SwapanaVasavadatta. Sanskrit drama was eclipsed with the advent of the Mohammedans in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries. Moreover, it has many rules and regulations such as there could be no tragic end, no violent or repulsive act could be depicted on stage, the hero and heroine had both to be charming and noble, the jester had to be greedy and fat. As opposed to this, folk theatre with its flexible and free form has changed, developed and adjusted itself to the changing social conditions reflecting the lives of the people.

Article 23

If one were to rank a list of civilization's greatest and most elusive intellectual challenges, the problem of "decoding" ourselves -- understanding the inner workings of our minds and our brains, and how the architecture of these elements is encoded in our genome -- would surely be at the top. Yet the diverse fields that took on this challenge, from philosophy and psychology to computer science and neuroscience, have been fraught with disagreement about the right approach.

In 1956, the computer scientist John McCarthy coined the term "Artificial Intelligence" (AI) to describe the study of intelligence by implementing its essential features on a computer. Instantiating an intelligent system using man-made hardware, rather than our own "biological hardware" of cells and tissues, would show ultimate understanding, and have obvious practical applications in the creation of intelligent devices or even robots.

Some of McCarthy's colleagues in neighboring departments, however, were more interested in how intelligence is implemented in humans (and other animals) first. Noam Chomsky and others worked on what became cognitive science, a field aimed at uncovering the mental representations and rules that underlie our perceptual and cognitive abilities. Chomsky and his colleagues had to overthrow the then-dominant paradigm of behaviorism, championed by Harvard psychologist B.F. Skinner, where animal behavior was reduced to a simple set of associations between an action and its subsequent reward or punishment. The undoing of Skinner's grip on psychology is commonly marked by Chomsky's 1959 critical review of Skinner's book *Verbal Behavior*, a book in which Skinner attempted to explain linguistic ability using behaviorist principles.

Skinner's approach stressed the historical associations between a stimulus and the animal's response -- an approach easily framed as a kind of empirical statistical analysis, predicting the future as a function of the past. Chomsky's conception of language, on the other hand, stressed the complexity of internal representations, encoded in the genome, and their maturation in light of the right data into a sophisticated computational system, one that cannot be usefully broken down into a set of associations. Behaviorist principles of associations could not explain the richness of linguistic knowledge, our endlessly creative use of it, or how quickly children acquire it with only minimal and imperfect exposure to language presented by their environment. The "language faculty," as Chomsky referred to it, was part of the organism's genetic endowment, much like the visual system, the immune system and the circulatory system, and we ought to approach it just as we approach these other more down-to-earth biological systems.

David Marr, a neuroscientist colleague of Chomsky's at MIT, defined a general framework for studying complex biological systems (like the brain) in his influential book *Vision*, one that Chomsky's analysis of the language capacity more or less fits into. According to Marr, a complex biological system can be understood at three distinct levels. The first level ("computational level") describes the input and output to the system, which define the task the system is performing. In the case of the visual system, the input might be the image projected on our retina and the output might our brain's identification of the objects present in the image we had observed. The second level ("algorithmic level") describes the procedure by which an input is converted to an output, i.e. how the image on our retina can be processed to achieve the task described by the computational level. Finally, the third level ("implementation level") describes how our own biological hardware of cells implements the procedure described by the algorithmic level.

The approach taken by Chomsky and Marr toward understanding how our minds achieve what they do is as different as can be from behaviorism. The emphasis here is on the internal structure of the system that enables it to perform a task, rather than on external association between past behavior of the system and the environment. The goal is to dig into the "black box" that drives the system and describe its inner workings, much like how a computer scientist would explain how a cleverly designed piece of software works and how it can be executed on a desktop computer.

As written today, the history of cognitive science is a story of the unequivocal triumph of an essentially Chomskyian approach over Skinner's behaviorist paradigm -- an achievement commonly referred to as the "cognitive revolution," though Chomsky himself rejects this term. While this may be a relatively accurate depiction in cognitive science and psychology, behaviorist thinking is far from dead in related disciplines. Behaviorist experimental paradigms and associationist explanations for animal behavior are used routinely

by neuroscientists who aim to study the neurobiology of behavior in laboratory animals such as rodents, where the systematic three-level framework advocated by Marr is not applied.

In May of last year, during the 150th anniversary of the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, a symposium on "Brains, Minds and Machines" took place, where leading computer scientists, psychologists and neuroscientists gathered to discuss the past and future of artificial intelligence and its connection to the neurosciences.

The gathering was meant to inspire multidisciplinary enthusiasm for the revival of the scientific question from which the field of artificial intelligence originated: how does intelligence work? How does our brain give rise to our cognitive abilities, and could this ever be implemented in a machine?

Noam Chomsky, speaking in the symposium, wasn't so enthused. Chomsky critiqued the field of AI for adopting an approach reminiscent of behaviorism, except in more modern, computationally sophisticated form. Chomsky argued that the field's heavy use of statistical techniques to pick regularities in masses of data is unlikely to yield the explanatory insight that science ought to offer. For Chomsky, the "new AI" -- focused on using statistical learning techniques to better mine and predict data -- is unlikely to yield general principles about the nature of intelligent beings or about cognition. This critique sparked an elaborate reply to Chomsky from Google's director of research and noted AI researcher, Peter Norvig, who defended the use of statistical models and argued that AI's new methods and definition of progress is not far off from what happens in the other sciences.

Chomsky acknowledged that the statistical approach might have practical value, just as in the example of a useful search engine, and is enabled by the advent of fast computers capable of processing massive data. But as far as a science goes, Chomsky would argue it is inadequate, or more harshly, kind of shallow. We wouldn't have taught the computer much about what the phrase "physicist Sir Isaac Newton" really means, even if we can build a search engine that returns sensible hits to users who type the phrase in.

Article 23

Adrienne Mayor's years of research challenge the widely held view that natural historians in classical Greece and Rome lacked the knowledge to interpret large vertebrate fossils as organic remains of the past. That conceptual breakthrough, representing the start of the modern science of paleontology, was supposedly made by the French naturalist Georges Cuvier in 1806. Yet, much like today's fossil hunters, Ms. Mayor found, ancient Greeks and Romans collected and measured the petrified bones they encountered and displayed them in temples and museums. They, too, recognized fossils as evidence of past life, now extinct, anticipating Cuvier by more than 2,000 years.

Still, the ancients often let their culture-bound imaginations run in unscientific directions. In her book, "The First Fossil Hunters: Paleontology in Greek and Roman Times," published in May by Princeton University Press, Ms. Mayor draws on a close study of classical texts to show that some of the more impressive and mysterious fossils were used as evidence supporting existing myths or creating new ones.

The Homeric legend of Heracles rescuing Hesione by slaying the Monster of Troy, for example, may have a paleontological origin. Ms. Mayor pointed out that in the earliest known illustration of the Heracles legend,

painted on a Corinthian vase, the monster's skull closely matched that of an extinct giraffe. Such fossils are plentiful on the Greek islands and western coast of Turkey and are mentioned in classical literature. The vase painting from the sixth century B.C., Ms. Mayor concluded, is most likely "the earliest artistic record of a vertebrate fossil discovery."

Fossils found and displayed in antiquity on the island of Samos probably inspired the story of savage monsters called Neades, whose reverberating bellows were said to tear the earth apart. The Greeks thus had a neat explanation for two perplexing phenomena, the gigantic bones and the earthquakes that frequently devastated their land. Other discoveries of huge mammal bones were viewed as confirmation of the ancient Greek belief in ancestral heroes as 15-foot giants. Mastodon fossils on Samos were hailed as the remains of the war elephants Dionysus is supposed to have deployed in his mythic battle with the Amazons.

And where did the idea of the griffin come from? Aristeas, a seventh-century B.C. traveler, wrote of the gold-seeking Scythians who fought creatures in the Gobi Desert that resembled "lions but with the beak and wings of an eagle." These fierce creatures presumably nested on the ground and guarded deposits of gold. In reality, Ms. Mayor concluded, the griffin "was based on illiterate nomads' observations of dinosaur skeletons in the deserts of Central Asia."

Ms. Mayor's success in piecing together the griffin legend encouraged her to examine other Greek and Roman texts for "the world's oldest written descriptions of fossil finds," which had been overlooked by most classics scholars and historians of science. On a visit to Samos, she studied a rich collection of prehistoric bones and skulls with which the ancients must have been familiar. She began to put texts and fossils together and saw the ancients in a new light. "Just as a fossil is 'petrified time,' so is an ancient artifact or text," she wrote. "The tasks of paleontologists and classical historians and archaeologists are remarkably similar -- to excavate, decipher and bring to life the tantalizing remnants of a time we will never see."

Although Ms. Mayor's interpretations may draw fire from some scholars, the response to her book has so far been favorable. John R. Horner, a dinosaur paleontologist at the Museum of the Rockies in Bozeman, Mont., has called it "the best account ever concerning the real meaning of mythical creatures."

Article 24

The vagal system is a stress response system that helps us deal with crises. It pits reason and emotion against one another, in states of emergency or high stress. When we're angry or upset or fearful, most of us find it difficult to think clearly. How often we come up with the perfect comeback long after the argument is over! The reverse is also true: If, when upset, you can get yourself to stop and think, you'll probably calm down to some degree. Along with reason, the other capacity that shuts down with strong negative emotion is social engagement, the set of various feelings thoughts, and behaviors that enables us to interact with one another in positive ways. The vagal system mediates these inverse, "push-me/pull-you" functions: clear thinking and social engagement vs. states of stress and emergency.

We can see this in Jane Austen's *Sense and Sensibility* when Lucy Steele tells Elinor (the heroine) of her secret engagement to Edward, the man Elinor loves: "Her [Elinor's] astonishment at what she heard was at first too great for words." Emotion runs high and so cognition shuts down, and Elinor momentarily loses her ability to speak, among the most social of our capabilities. It's only as she focuses on what she has to do to

maintain the conversation in a way that protects herself and deprives Lucy of her triumph (cognition in action) that she is able to answer, "forcing herself to speak, and to speak cautiously."

The relationship between states of mind and behavior operates at a neurobiological as well as a psychological level. Changes between stress and calm are mediated by the autonomic nervous system (ANS), the system that controls automatic bodily functions such as respiration, sleep, and digestion, and the physiological responses that generate emotion. When we're safe and in business-as-usual mode, our systems are dominated by the branch of the ANS called the parasympathetic nervous system (PNS), which enables clear thinking and social engagement as well as aforementioned ongoing bodily processes. But when the environment poses danger, such as a snake in your path or a nasty rival, the sympathetic division of the ANS (the SNS) takes over. Two of its most important subsystems associated with stress are the fight-or-flight response, which generates an immediate reaction to danger, and the hypothalamic-pituitary-adrenal axis, better known as the HPA axis response, which activates some time afterward (although this can be just minutes later) and which is necessary for a sustained reaction to stress.

Stephen Porges and his research team have formulated a convincing and widely accepted theory about how we switch from one system to the other. This is "the polyvagal perspective," called a perspective rather than a system because it's really a way of viewing how the ANS works. When you look at the ANS from the polyvagal perspective, you see that the vagal brake is the primary mechanism by which the body orchestrates the degree to which each system activates.

The ventral or "smart" vagus, which is in charge of these shifts between calm and stress, originates in the brainstem, the lowest area of the brain, continuous with the spine. In one direction, the ventral vagus connects to the heart's pacemaker, a muscle called the sinoatrial node. Its crucial function is to enable us to match our reactions to what the environment requires by varying heart rate, which is a cause as well as an indicator of excitement. If heart rate is sufficiently accelerated we go into fight-or-flight mode, and if the threat is sustained, we segue into HPA axis mode; the SNS dominates. If excitement is not required, heart rate slows down, and the PNS takes over. Porges calls this part of the ventral vagus (which controls heart rate), the "vagal brake," because it increases and decreases heart rate just as the brake on a car regulates speed. When Elinor hears of Edward's engagement, the vagal brake is lifted. When she recovers sufficiently to speak, the brake is applied, perhaps lightly in this case, since she's still upset.

The automotive metaphor makes sense if you think of driving downhill rather than on a level surface. You need to press the brake to keep cruising at an acceptable speed. Without the restraint of the vagal brake, we would quickly go downhill biologically. The heart would beat much more quickly, initiating sympathetic stress responses, and we all know how unhealthy it is to live in a constant state of stress. Actually without any vagal restraint, the heart would beat too quickly to sustain life.

Article 25

"It's a peculiar apparatus," said the Officer to the Traveller, gazing with a certain admiration at the device, with which he was, of course, thoroughly familiar. It appeared that the Traveller had responded to the invitation of the Commandant only out of politeness, when he had been asked to attend the execution of a soldier condemned for disobeying and insulting his superior. Of course, interest in the execution was not very high even in the penal colony itself. At least, here in the small, deep, sandy valley, closed in on all

sides by barren slopes, apart from the Officer and the Traveller there were present only the Condemned, a vacant-looking man with a broad mouth and dilapidated hair and face, and the Soldier, who held the heavy chain to which were connected the small chains which bound the Condemned Man by his feet and wrist bones, as well as by his neck, and which were also linked to each other by connecting chains. The Condemned Man, incidentally, had an expression of such dog-like resignation that it looked as if one could set him free to roam around the slopes and would only have to whistle at the start of the execution for him to return.

The Traveller had little interest in the apparatus and walked back and forth behind the Condemned Man, almost visibly indifferent, while the Officer took care of the final preparations. Sometimes he crawled under the apparatus, which was built deep into the earth, and sometimes he climbed up a ladder to inspect the upper parts. These were really jobs which could have been left to a mechanic, but the Officer carried them out with great enthusiasm, maybe because he was particularly fond of this apparatus or maybe because there was some other reason why one could not trust the work to anyone else. "It's all ready now!" he finally cried and climbed back down the ladder. He was unusually tired, breathing with his mouth wide open, and he had pushed two fine lady's handkerchiefs under the collar of his uniform.

"These uniforms are really too heavy for the tropics," the Traveller said, instead of asking some questions about the apparatus, as the Officer had expected. "That's true," said the Officer. He washed the oil and grease from his dirty hands in a bucket of water standing ready, "but they mean home, and we don't want to lose our homeland." "Now, have a look at this apparatus," he added immediately, drying his hands with a towel and pointing to the device. "Up to this point I had to do some work by hand, but from now on the apparatus should work entirely on its own." The Traveller nodded and followed the Officer. The latter tried to protect himself against all eventualities by saying, "Of course, breakdowns do happen. I really hope none will occur today, but we must be prepared for it. The apparatus is supposed to keep going for twelve hours without interruption. But if any breakdowns do occur, they'll only be very minor, and we'll deal with them right away."

"Don't you want to sit down?" he asked finally, as he pulled out a chair from a pile of cane chairs and offered it to the Traveller. The latter could not refuse. He sat on the edge of the pit, into which he cast a fleeting glance. It was not very deep. On one side of the hole the piled earth was heaped up into a wall; on the other side stood the apparatus. "I don't know," the Officer said, "whether the Commandant has already explained the apparatus to you." The Traveller made an vague gesture with his hand. That was good enough for the Officer, for now he could explain the apparatus himself.

"This apparatus," he said, grasping a connecting rod and leaning against it, "is our previous Commandant's invention. I also worked with him on the very first tests and took part in all the work right up to its completion. However, the credit for the invention belongs to him alone. Have you heard of our previous Commandant? No? Well, I'm not claiming too much when I say that the organization of the entire penal colony is his work. We, his friends, already knew at the time of his death that the administration of the colony was so self-contained that even if his successor had a thousand new plans in mind, he would not be able to alter anything of the old plan, at least not for several years. And our prediction has held. The New Commandant has had to recognize that. It's a shame that you didn't know the previous Commandant!"

Article 26

The fundamental cause of the Great Depression in the United States was a decline in spending (sometimes referred to as aggregate demand), which led to a decline in production as manufacturers and merchandisers noticed an unintended rise in inventories. The sources of the contraction in spending in the United States varied over the course of the Depression, but they cumulated in a monumental decline in aggregate demand. The American decline was transmitted to the rest of the world largely through the gold standard. However, a variety of other factors also influenced the downturn in various countries.

The initial decline in U.S. output in the summer of 1929 is widely believed to have stemmed from tight U.S. monetary policy aimed at limiting stock markets peculation. The 1920s had been a prosperous decade, but not an exceptional boom period; prices had remained nearly constant throughout the decade, and there had been mild recessions in both 1924 and 1927. The one obvious area of excess was the stock market. Stock prices had risen more than fourfold from the low in 1921 to the peak in 1929. In 1928 and 1929, the Federal Reserve had raised interest rates in hopes of slowing the rapid rise in stock prices. These higher interest rates depressed interest-sensitive spending in areas such as construction and automobile purchases, which in turn reduced production. Some scholars believe that a boom in housing construction in the mid-1920s led to an excess supply of housing and a particularly large drop in construction in 1928 and 1929.

By the fall of 1929, U.S. stock prices had reached levels that could not be justified by reasonable anticipations of future earnings. As a result, when a variety of minor events led to gradual price declines in October 1929, investors lost confidence and the stock market bubble burst. Panic selling began on "Black Thursday," October 24, 1929. Many stocks had been purchased on margin—that is, using loans secured by only a small fraction of the stocks' value. As a result, the price declines forced some investors to liquidate their holdings, thus exacerbating the fall in prices. Between their peak in September and their low in November, U.S. stock prices (measured by the Cowles Index) declined 33 percent. Because the decline was so dramatic, this event is often referred to as the Great Crash of 1929.

The stock market crash reduced American aggregate demand substantially. Consumer purchases of durable goods and business investment fell sharply after the crash. A likely explanation is that the financial crisis generated considerable uncertainty about future income, which in turn led consumers and firms to put off purchases of durable goods. Although the loss of wealth caused by the decline in stock prices was relatively small, the crash may also have depressed spending by making people feel poorer. As a result of the drastic decline in consumer and business spending, real output in the United States, which had been declining slowly up to this point, fell rapidly in late 1929 and throughout 1930. Thus, while the Great Crash of the stock market and the Great Depression are two quite separate events, the decline in stock prices was one factor contributing to declines in production and employment in the United States.

The next blow to aggregate demand occurred in the fall of 1930, when the first of four waves of banking panics gripped the United States. A banking panic arises when many depositors simultaneously lose confidence in the solvency of banks and demand that their bank deposits be paid to them in cash. Banks, which typically hold only a fraction of deposits as cash reserves, must liquidate loans in order to raise the required cash. This process of hasty liquidation can cause even a previously solvent bank to fail. The United States experienced widespread banking panics in the fall of 1930, the spring of 1931, the fall of 1931, and the fall of 1932. The final wave of panics continued through the winter of 1933 and culminated with the national "bank holiday" declared by President Franklin D. Roosevelt on March 6, 1933. The bank holiday closed all banks, and they were permitted to reopen only after being deemed solvent by government inspectors. The panics took a severe toll on the American banking system. By 1933, one-fifth of the banks in existence at the start of 1930 had failed.

By their nature, banking panics are largely irrational, inexplicable events, but some of the factors contributing to the problem can be explained. Economic historians believe that substantial increases in farm debt in the 1920s, together with U.S. policies that had encouraged small, undiversified banks, created an environment in which such panics could ignite and spread. The heavy farm debt stemmed in part from the high prices of agricultural goods during World War I, which had spurred extensive borrowing by American farmers wishing to increase production by investing in land and machinery. The decline in farm commodity prices following the war made it difficult for farmers to keep up with their loan payments.

Article 27

The other day I was struck by an ad for a mobile phone. Ads featuring mobile phones are even more common than ads featuring Amitabh Bachchan. So what was it about this ad that I found so unusual?

It was that the ad was promoting the mobile phone not as a mobile phone but as a camera with which to take pictures, preferably of oneself.

Mobile phones are increasingly being marketed not as phones but as cameras with which to take selfies, or as fashion accessories, or as mini computers, or anything else that makes you appy.

Such surrogate marketing – selling a product for something other than the purpose it was made for – is nothing new. Makers of washing machines sell their products in the rural heartland of Punjab not for the purposes of cleaning laundry but as giant lassi makers.

In what was then called Calcutta, the mid-1960s saw an acute shortage of baby food. No, there wasn't an unprecedented baby boom in the metropolis. The reason for the shortage of baby food was that the stuff wasn't going into babies but into the gulabjamuns and rassagullas that the local confectioners were making, having discovered that formula milk a la Nestle and Co made for more delectable sweetmeats than did regular cow milk.

Surrogate salesmanship is perhaps nowhere so common as in the world of politics.

Pakistan is one of the most notable examples of the art of surrogate marketing. The single biggest made-for-export product of that country is terrorism. But Islamabad cleverly markets its home-grown terrorists not as terrorists but as freedom fighters seeking to liberate Kashmir from the oppressive stranglehold of India.

In our own country, ever since Independence a closed-shop family business has sold itself to the public as the Grand Old Party of Indian politics, the Congress.

And more recently, what once was a democracy of the people, by the people and for the people is today finding ready buyers as a sarkar of the bhakts, by the bhakts and for the bhakts.

Article 28

Although Europe is still shaped by Luther's political and religious legacy, his musical contributions are less famous. In fact, music was crucial to his ideology, and encouraged radical singers long after his death. His popular musical style, meanwhile, is immediately comparable with some of the most well-known protest movements of the modern age. Before 1517, the Catholic Church controlled most religious music in Europe. Lay participation was minimal. In church, most people only heard austere plainchant, sung in Latin by a choir. Passion plays – rowdy dramas describing biblical stories – introduced religious ideas to people in their own languages. But by the 16th Century, these plays had often slumped into an excuse for slapstick humour. And anyway, vernacular music rarely crossed the church threshold.

Luther shattered these strict divisions, and transformed Christian musical life. For him, religious music was not just for remote priests and choirs. Instead, it was "next to theology" and a "gift from God". As such, it should be accessible to everyone. After all, he wrote, "by embellishing and ornamenting their tunes in wonderful ways, [singers could] lead others into a heavenly dance." Anyone who disagreed "deserved to hear nothing but the braying of asses and the grunting of hogs!"

Luther scrabbled to develop these ideas as fiercely as he did his thoughts on the Pope or the evils of indulgences (where time in purgatory could be slashed in return for a handy payment to the local priest). Latin chanting was dumped in favour of communal singing in everyday German. This style soon became a key part of his followers' identity. "Luther's use of German hymns was an important sign of change," explains Andreas Loewe, dean of St Paul's Cathedral in Melbourne and Luther expert. "It was just as obvious as having married clergy, or being able to receive a cup of wine at Holy Communion as a lay person."

Not that Luther promoted music just for abstract reasons of faith. He well understood how powerful music was in spreading his message. Like the best modern protest songs, his hymns were catchy and punchy. He added religious lyrics to recognisable folk songs, just as We Shall Overcome hatched from an old southern Gospel song. This was especially useful in an ignorant age. Even illiterate people – about 85% of the German population in 1500 – could learn songs and pass them on quickly.

Luther himself pushed these changes along. He encouraged children to learn music at school, and worked with other reformers to produce Protestant hymnbooks. Luther also wrote lyrics that "imitated the way people spoke," says Loewe. Luther himself stated that both music and lyrics should "grow out of the true mother tongue." *EinFeste Burg* (A Mighty Fortress) is typical of his rousing simplicity:
Our God is a mighty fortress,
A trusty shield and weapon!

Songs like this stiffened the hearts of Luther and his friends. They likely sang *EinFeste Burg* at the Diet of Worms, when Luther was interrogated by Charles V, the Holy Roman Emperor. This has striking parallels with more modern protest movements. After all, anti-Vietnam War protesters rallied to Give Peace A Chance in the face of violent backlash, while anti-Apartheid campaigners sang Soweto Blues after a racist massacre in South Africa.

Contemporaries valued the spread of this music. Writing 50 years after Luther died, theologian Cornelius Becker noted that "[Luther's] songs were carried to people in far-away places in the souls and minds of pious Christians. It was not easy to block their progress." Indeed, Lutheran hymns had soon skipped out of his stronghold in Saxony. They were sung in Catholic areas, and translated into English. All this shares much with modern protest music. Just as the socialist anthem The Internationale became famous from Madrid to

mbaguru
LEADER IN ADAPTIVE PREPARATION FOR CAT

Moscow – even among people who did not understand the niceties of Marxist dogma – Lutheran hymns bounced around Europe as a snappy mark of solidarity with unknown allies.

Luther's music stayed popular after his death. Protestant troops sang Lutheran hymns as they went into battle during the Thirty Years' War in the 17th Century. Later Protestant composers also covered his hymns. Johann Sebastian Bach expanded *EinFeste Burg* to a glorious 30-minute cantata, while Felix Mendelssohn added it to his aptly named Reformation symphony. This trend has continued to modern times: Lutheran hymns still feature in Catholic and Protestant hymnbooks. For Romantic writer Heinrich Heine, *EinFeste Burg* was nothing less than the "Marseillaise of the Reformation" that "has preserved to this day its inspiriting power."

Article 29

Modern education, in developing the intellect, offers more and more theories and facts, without bringing about the understanding of the total process of human existence. We are highly intellectual; we have developed cunning minds, and are caught up in explanations. The intellect is satisfied with theories and explanations, but intelligence is not; and for the understanding of the total process of existence, there must be an integration of the mind and heart in action. Intelligence is not separate from love.

For most of us, to accomplish this inward revolution is extremely arduous. We know how to meditate, how to play the piano, how to write, but we have no knowledge of the meditator, the player, the writer. We are not creators, for we have filled our hearts and minds with knowledge, information and arrogance; we are full of quotations from what others have thought or said. But experiencing comes first, not the way of experiencing. There must be love before there can be the expression of love.

Information, the knowledge of facts, though ever increasing, is by its very nature limited. Wisdom is infinite, it includes knowledge and the way of action; but we take hold of a branch and think it is the whole tree. Through the knowledge of the part, we can never realize the joy of the whole. Intellect can never lead to the whole, for it is only a segment, a part.

We have separated intellect from feeling, and have developed intellect at the expanse of feeling. We are like a three-legged object with one leg much longer than the others, and we have no balance. We are trained to be intellectual; our education cultivates the intellect to be sharp, cunning, acquisitive, and so it plays the most important rôle in our life. Intelligence is much greater than intellect, for it is the integration of reason and love; but there can be intelligence only when there is self-knowledge, the deep understanding of the total process of oneself.

What is essential for man, whether young or old, is to live fully, integrally, and that is why our major problem is the cultivation of that intelligence which brings integration. Undue emphasis on any part of our total make-up gives a partial and therefore distorted view of life, and it is this distortion which is causing most of our difficulties. Any partial development of our whole temperament is bound to be disastrous both for ourselves and for society, and so it is really very important that we approach our human problems with an integrated point of view.

To be an integrated human being is to understand the entire process of one's own consciousness, both the hidden and the open. This is not possible if we give due emphasis to the intellect. We attach great

importance to the cultivation of the mind, but inwardly we are insufficient, poor and confused. This living in the intellect is the way of disintegration; for ideas, like beliefs, can never bring people together except in conflicting groups.

As long as we depend on thought as a means of integration, there must be disintegration; and to understand the disintegrating action of thought is to be aware of the ways of the self, the ways of one's own desire. We must be aware of our conditioning and its responses, both collective and personal. It is only when one is fully aware of the activities of the self with its contradictory desires and pursuits, its hopes and fears, that there is a possibility of going beyond the self.

Only love and right thinking will bring about true revolution, the revolution within ourselves. But how are we to have love? Not through the pursuit of the ideal of love, but only when there is no hatred, when there is no greed, when the sense of self, which is the cause of antagonism, comes to an end. A man who is caught up in the pursuits of exploitation, of greed, of envy, can never love.

Without love and right thinking, oppression and cruelty will ever be on the increase. The problem of man's antagonism to man can be solved, not by pursuing the ideal of peace, but by understanding the causes of war which lie in our attitude towards life, towards our fellow-beings; and this understanding can come about only through the right kind of education. Without a change of heart, without goodwill, without the inward transformation which is born of self-awareness, there can be no peace, no happiness for men.

Article 30

Both Michell and Laplass thought of light as consisting of particles, rather like cannon ball that could be slowed down by gravity, and made to fall back on the star. But a famous experiment, carried out by two Americans, Michelson and Morley in 1887, showed that light always traveled at a speed of one hundred and eighty six thousand miles a second, no matter where it came from. How then could gravity slow down light, and make it fall back? This was impossible, according to the then accepted ideas of space and time. But in 1915, Einstein put forward his revolutionary General Theory of Relativity. In this, space and time were no longer separate and independent entities. Instead, they were just different directions in a single object called spacetime. This spacetime was not flat, but was warped and curved by the matter and energy in it. In order to understand this, consider a sheet of rubber with a weight placed on it to represent a star. The weight will form a depression in the rubber, and will cause the sheet near the star to be curved rather than flat. If one now rolls marbles on the rubber sheet, their paths will be curved rather than being straight lines. In 1919, a British expedition to West Africa looked at light from distant stars that passed near the Sun during an eclipse. They found that the images of the stars were shifted slightly from their normal positions. This indicated that the paths of the light from the stars, had been bent by the curved spacetime near the Sun. General Relativity was confirmed.

Consider now placing heavier and heavier, and more and more concentrated weights on the rubber sheet. They will depress the sheet more and more. Eventually, at a critical weight and size, they will make a bottomless hole in the sheet, that particles can fall into, but nothing can get out of.

What happens in spacetime, according to General Relativity, is rather similar. A star will curve and distort the spacetime near it, more and more, the more massive and more compact the star is. If a massive star that has burnt up its nuclear fuel, cools and shrinks below a critical size, it will quite literally make a bottomless

hole in spacetime, that light can't get out of. Such objects were given the name, black holes, by the American physicist, John Wheeler, who was one of the first to recognize their importance, and the problems they pose. The name caught on quickly.It suggested something dark and mysterious, But the French, being French, saw a more risky meaning. For years, they resisted the name claiming it was too obscene. In the end, they had to give in. Who can resist a name that is such a winner?

A black hole has a boundary, called the event horizon. It is where gravity is just strong enough to drag light back, and prevent it escaping. Because nothing can travel faster than light, everything else will get dragged back also. Falling through the event horizon is a bit like going over Niagra Falls in a canoe. If you are above the falls, you can get away if you paddle fast enough, but once you are over the edge, you are lost. There's no way back. As you get nearer the falls, the current gets faster. This means it pulls harder on the front of the canoe, than the back. There's a danger that the canoe will be pulled apart. It is the same with black holes. If you fall towards a black hole feet first, gravity will pull harder on your feet than your head, because they are nearer the black hole. The result is, you will be stretched out longwise, and squashed in sideways.. If the black hole has a mass of a few times our sun, you would be torn apart, and made into spaghetti, before you reached the horizon. However, if you fell into a much larger black hole, with a mass of a million times the sun, you would reach the horizon without difficulty. So, if you want to explore the inside of a black hole, choose a big one. There is a black hole of about a million solar masses, at the center of our Milkyway galaxy.

Although you wouldn't notice anything particular as you fell into a black hole, someone watching you from a distance would never see you cross the event horizon. Instead, you would appear to slow down, and hover just outside. You would get dimmer and dimmer, and redder and redder, until you were effectively lost from sight. As far as the outside world is concerned, you would be lost forever. Because black holes have no hair, in Wheeler's phrase, one can't tell from the outside what is inside a black hole, apart from its mass and rotation. This means that a black hole contains a lot of information that is hidden from the outside world. But there's a limit to the amount of information, one can pack into a region of space. Information requires energy, and energy has mass, by Einstein's famous equation, E = m c squared. So, if there's too much information in a region of space, it will collapse into a black hole, and the size of the black hole will reflect the amount of information. It is like piling more and more books into a library. Eventually, the shelves will give way, and the library will collapse into a black hole.

Article 31

Since when is "n-tier architecture combined with Web services frameworks in order to provide a seamless distributed application environment" something that mere mortals can master? If this jargon looks like gobbledygook, let me tell you that the underlying truth is much, much worse. The Web is not a friendly place for software developers–not in conception, development, or (especially) actual use. There are so many elements to take into consideration–clients, servers, databases, XML, HTML, scripts, and more. The industry is fraught with perils including broken connections, bad performance, unruly users, and hackers who delight in breaking your software.

Thinking about future technology tells me a great deal about the difficulties that lie ahead for software. Take nanotechnology. Big things are in store for this tiny realm (see the Pursuits columns from December 2001 and January 2002 on ComputerUser.com), but everywhere I look it's the equipment side that people talk about: the tunneling microscopes, nanotube circuits, and other devices. They simply presume that the software will be there to control and organize this ultra-complex and vastly numerous group of nanites.

On the other hand, I hear great bastions of software development such as IBM bewail the fact that software is getting out of hand: i.e., it's too complicated and too difficult to be reliable. We all know about the problems Microsoft had and is having with providing secure and reliable operating systems. Yet we have people basically shrugging and assuming that software to manage the potentials (dangers too) of nanotechnology is a "given." Well, it's not a given, or a gimme, or even a maybe-get.

A crisis in software is a buck a bundle–not a big deal, right? I've been hearing for decades about how hard it is to make good software (and, of course, it goes back further than that). The principle of "muddle through" seems to having taken hold long ago, and is still hanging on for dear life. Among other things we've invented modular programming, object orientation, and Xtreme programming to solve the software bottleneck. And yet, people are still decrying the lack of progress. That's probably because programmers continue to avoid "good programming practices" in favor of trying to get the job done–quick and dirty, if necessary.

Lord knows I've done enough preaching about good software development practices (nine books and a bunch of articles). But from the point of view of successful projects, programming today doesn't look a whole lot better than it did in the days of assembly languages (it looks different, not better). Recent surveys continue to show that only one out of five or six software projects is considered successful. We can do more with software, but more isn't necessarily a big improvement–for the user or the developer. Meanwhile, the rush of technological development continues to up the ante on software complexity.

It isn't that we can't write good, even great, software. Give a clutch of hotshots a lot of money and a single, relatively well-focused project and watch the code fly! Put another way, we can demo any kind of software–real one-of-a-kind brilliance. The problem is in replicating good software over many different projects, and especially in dealing with very large and long-term projects. In these cases, Herculean effort sometimes succeeds.

So software development, which is intimately linked to the success of most other future technologies, must get itself together before we get too much further down the road. When you evaluate new computer technology (or almost any other kind) be sure to ask, "Where's the software? How good is the software?" It's bad enough to have a premier channel of communication (the Internet) mucked up by faulty and poorly designed software security, but when it comes to splicing human genes or unleashing trillions of tiny robots.

If you think this diatribe is anomalous (cry wolf, lone columnist), take a gander at the IBM Web site. IBM is too chivalrous to use my kind of language, but the idea is similar: We cannot produce software to manage the kind of complexity we see now (much less the future) without a radical changes in the way hardware and software is designed and the way it functions.

What changes? In a nutshell, "Computer, fix thyself." IBM calls the approach autonomic computing, which is sufficiently esoteric to appeal to academics and digital theoreticians–the target audience of the first round of research. The reason for the research is that we don't really know how to make hardware and software self-managing and self-maintaining. Heck, we have a hard enough time getting humans to do those jobs. Maybe that's the point.

Article 32

Till pretty recently the public sector banks were seen as too conservative in offering of loans, especially to retail customers. This picture has changed. The banks now are not only aggressive in courting them but also offer rates that are often lower than the private sector banks. The lead was taken in this business by the State Bank of India. It decided to enter the business of car finance in a big way. For instance it is the exclusive partner with Tata to finance their Nano car, the vehicle that will revolutionise the way India will travel in a couple of years. The changes in the credit business mean every public sector bank now offers loans to retail customers in less than fifteen days that would earlier take at least a month, through less paperwork and faster documentation. But surpassing all these, the biggest change in the credit business is the teaser rates the public sector banks have introduced. The scheme works as follows. In the first year, the bank offers a rate of 8% as flat rate to its customers. This stays either constant or increases marginally in the next year. The rates are reset in the third year as per the prevailing rate. The attractive rates have already made the SBI the biggest player in the automotive market and the second largest player in the housing sector loans. The other major change introduced in the credit business is the business correspondent model. The banks have set up some of their employees to reach the customers like the labourers, rickshaw pullers or fruit sellers as business correspondent. The employees carry a machine that has a telecom linkage with the banks, and therefore the banks are able to update any transaction with the customers on real time. So if a rickshaw puller deposits a sum with the bank, the sum is punched in by the correspondent and is immediately reflected in the bank accounts even 15 kilometers away. The employee can also offer small time loans that are sanctioned on the spot. The popularity of the scheme is visible in the subzimandis at New Azadpur in Delhi for instance, where several hundred labourers deposit their daily collections and so cut back on stuff like booze.

Article 33

For Jean Baudrillard the entire society, the total culture was but a system of signs. In his books, such as Le système des objects (1968), and Le société de consommation(1970), the philosopher reconstructed the political economy of Marxism on the basis of the semiological theories of the sign. As Jameson once said, "No society has ever been saturated with signs and messages like this one." In making the role of the cultural sphere his main focus, Baudrillard examined the life of signs in society. To the extent there can be a subject (a dubious entity within Postmodernism), s/he is confronted by a controlling world of objects.

These objects are organized into systems of signification that are, in turn, broken down into non-functional objects, functional objects, and metafunctionlal objects. Baudrillard examined these objects from the perspective of Ferdinand de Saussure (signs) and Sigmund Freud (psychology) in order to reveal the secret life of objects and their hidden meanings. Objects lose their singular nature and are subordinated into systems that are relative to each other, just as language is understood only within a network of relationships which constitute meaning.

In other words, we consume the sign. We all live in a new world of leisure and mass media, which produce an alienation of conspicuous consumption and empty affluence ("affluenza") in which, in America, according to Baudrillard, the consumers desire what others have. This fundamental alteration in the human species from using or utilizing what is considered necessary to desiring what is not necessary, except psychologically (desire), has resulted in a culture of affluent individuals surrounded by objects (signs), not people (who are also signs). Everyday life is now determined by manipulation of commodities and messages, all of which become an organization and display of domestic goods to be desired and consumed. Commodities are part of a "system of objects" that are correlated with a system of needs. Objects are offered within the context of other objects, and the collection of objects creates a total meaning. As Baudrillard wrote, "It is even the ultimate in morality, since the consumer is simultaneously reconciled with himself and with the group. The becomes the perfect social being."

The brand name, which as Baudrillard stated is the principal concept of advertising, (which) summarizes well the possibilities of a 'language' of consumption, plays an essential role in imposing a coherent collective vision and this totalizing brand creates similitude, homogenizes and organizes everyday life into consumer items/signs/objects signifying "Jaguar," the "granite counter top," the Versace dress, and the Jimmy Choo shoes–all "brands" and objects of desire (not necessity). Consumer mentality is a kind of magical thought that generates consumption. Baudrillard noted, correctly, that this "code" constituted by brands is totalitarian and totalizing and that, for the first time in history is universal, a code that no one escapes. The code is a form of socialization but conversely, the code rules what is also a primitive mentality, which "believes in" the omnipotence of thoughts and in the omnipotence of signs. In contrast to traditional neo-Marxists, Baudrillard rejects the socio-cultural approach, insisting that there is no way to distinguish between "true" and "false" needs in a system that is governed by magical signs. In fact what is consumed is not the material goods themselves or actual objects–the point is that the actual objects are merely signs of needs and satisfaction of desire, a desire that will always return.

Consumption is a system that is a productive activity, requiring education and effort. One believes that s/he must insert be socialized into and become part of the consumer society. Consuming becomes a mode of social activity and becoming a walking sign (board) system of brands is now socially normative behavior. In other words, although consumption is a system that assumes the regulation of signs and the integration of the group, it should not be assumed that consumption brings either satisfaction or pleasure. Consumption is the production of coded values, a sign system which replaces moral values of days of yore. This consumer-based system of signs is organized by codes and rules of consumption, not guided by "natural" satisfaction but by and through a system of social indoctrination. The satisfaction involved is fleeting and momentary and is invested, not so much in the actual object itself but in the brand which is a signal of a certain kind to a certain group ordained to recognize and invested enough to care about the meaning of the sign.

The order of production of the signs manages the system of (cultural) "needs" by the order of signification that determines the social prestige of the purchaser and maintains the value of the system of goods to be consumed. The result of the belief system is fatal to classical Marxism: there are no revolutionary forces; no theory of subject as an active agent of social change; there is only reification in which the objects dominate the "subject" and human begins become thing-like or, more precisely, sign-like. From the Baudrillardian

perspective, we are now at a higher stage of reification and social domination by objects than described by the Frankfurt School. We (magically) believe in the social power of Jimmy Choo shoes and we believe in the stock market, until it collapses or implodes, weighted down by the false magic of the signs and wonders. According to Baudrillard, "In order to become object of consumption, the object must become sign."

Article 34

As diplomatic incidents go, it was not a big one, but for many people in Hong Kong and southern China it felt like the latest in a long line of slights. In May, Nintendo—a Japanese toy company— launched its most recent video games of Pokémon, a franchise of cute furry creatures, and announced that the names of the creatures would henceforth be written in characters that adhere to Mandarin pronunciation, not Cantonese. This, said the company, would help to provide unity across the greater Chinese market. On May 30th, a group of demonstrators gathered outside the Japanese consulate in Hong Kong to protest.

Behind Nintendo's announcement is a bigger linguistic and political issue. As part of its broader nation-building programme, the Communist Party has, since 1949, been trying to unify the country under the banner of spoken Mandarin. It has recently been pushing the project harder, and many companies are going along with it. Just as the British authorities tried to get rid of the Gaelic languages in Scotland and Ireland in the 18th century, the party has long been worried about separatist Tibetans and Uighurs using their language as a rallying point for independence. But central authorities are also now worried about any regional languages (which it insists on calling dialects) among the Han majority helping foster too much regional identity. Most worrying to the party is Cantonese, a language spoken by the same number of people who speak Italian (about 60m) in southern China and Hong Kong. In recent years it has mandated that many news broadcasts in Guangdong province switch to Mandarin from Cantonese.

This linguistic homogenisation is being enforced, however, just as a number of forces are pushing in the opposite direction. Technology is empowering regional languages, of which there are hundreds, and enhancing the centrifugal effect of migration, modernity and social change. Young people, empowered by mobile phones and computers, are changing the way they use their own language and breaking out of the straitjacket that has restricted communication for millennia. The trends in language mirror broader tensions between centralising, top-down forces trying to prevent dissent, and bottom-up trends among an increasingly empowered populace. They are adding to social fault lines that the Communist Party fears may threaten national unity.

Linguistically, China wants to be like America—a country where language and script are unified. In reality it is like medieval Europe—a continent full of different languages, nominally united by a written lingua franca. Before the 20th century, regional Chinese literati could communicate on paper in classical Chinese, but barely in conversation, just as European scholars communicated in Latin. The fracturing of Europe, politically and religiously, led to the emergence of written regional vernaculars like English and German.

But China never fractured—at least not permanently. And without an alphabetical writing system, no one in China could write down regional languages as the English or French or Germans could. When China adopted a common spoken vernacular as part of its modernisation in the 20th century, it was a form of one particular northern dialect called Mandarin—as though Europe had thrown away Latin and decided to enforce French across the continent.

The British decision on June 23rd to leave the European Union is the legacy of Europe's age-old divisions. Once Geoffrey Chaucer was inclined, and able, to write in English, it was a straight road to English nationalism and, by extension, Brexit. The Chinese push for linguistic unity is, economically, to facilitate education and development. But politically it is to prevent Hong Kong or Guangdong (or Tibet or Xinjiang) gaining so much regional identity and independence that they want to do a Brexit of their own.

Like Latin, classical written Chinese was a dead language, spoken by no one. A century ago, when language reformers began to introduce a common nationwide spoken tongue of Mandarin, they also abandoned the classical written language and replaced it with one that mirrored the spoken form, thus trying to synchronise their speech and their script. Some revolutionaries, including Mao Zedong, initially wanted to scrap Chinese characters altogether and replace them with an alphabet. They settled instead for a simplification of the characters and a standardisation of how they are pronounced and written in Roman letters, known as pinyin. Yet despite major success in literacy programmes, there are still 400m people in China who do not speak Mandarin, and some 100m who the government says cannot read at all. The actual number is undoubtedly higher.

Article 35

In some ways it was a re-run of the August 6, 1945 horror. On August 6, we woke up to the news that many of our favourite cold drinks were too dangerous to sip. The Centre for Science and Environment (CSE), Delhi had found residues of four `highly toxic' pesticides in the 12 branded soft drinks it had tested. On its test list were Pepsi, Coca Cola, Mirinda Lemon, Thums Up, Fanta, Mirinda Orange, Seven Up, Limca, Pepsi, Mountain Dew, Diet Pepsi and Sprite. These drinks fizzed with DDT, lindane, malathion and chlorpyrifos. Like the WW II bomb, the effects of these pesticides would last a long time and ruin the health of generations.

Scientists whose findings are taken seriously say (Toxics Link, November 2000) DDT, which is banned in agriculture, could cause chronic liver damage and cancer and reduce the body's ability to fight diseases. Lindane (banned again) causes cancer of the lungs and brain. Malathion (banned) non-Hodgkin's lymphoma. Chlorpyrifos attacks the nervous system and causes birth defects. The diseases show up after prolonged intake. You see, pesticides are slow, agonising killers.

"The deadly pesticide cocktails," reportedly contained 11 to 70 times more toxins than what's allowed in Europe and America. Countries there have strict rules over what is safe to drink and they are enforced. According to CSE, presence of poison in everyday drinks is not a breach of law in our country. Indian laws on food standards are "weak or non-existent". "You are legally allowed 50 times more arsenic (lead, copper and cadmium) in soft drinks than in bottled water," said the CSE's director. But officials of the rivals Pepsi and Coke have defended their products as being safe and world-class. "It is not about just pesticides in popular soft drinks," emphasises Bharat Jeyraj of the Consumers Action Group. "It is about pesticides in bottled water; in juices; in the food we eat; the vegetables we buy; most importantly in the water we use every day. It is about pollution of our water resources." Ninety per cent of any soft drink is water, he points out. And 6.6 billion 350-ml bottles are sold annually in the country. "We have passed the stage of risk management (doing something to help after a tragedy). We need to work on the precautionary principle (prevention is better than cure!)."

Who decides what is safe to sell? The Food Products Order and the Prevention of Food Adulteration Act. The FPO, charges the director, checks the sugar and the liquid glucose and not the water. "Who checks the water used in the making of drinks (fruit juices, any food item)? Is the ground water manufacturers use safe? Free of pesticides? What are our maximum residual limits (permissible level of toxins)? Do we have the system and equipment to inspect and analyse what is sold?" are some of the questions asked by consumer activists.

The results of the Government-ordered testing of cola samples are out. The health minister said: "All the 12 samples do not have the high amounts of pesticides found in the CSE report. They were well within the safety limits." The minister denied the presence of the lethal chemical malathion in the drinks. "If the CSE report had been correct on this point, we would have been dead," she said. The cola companies are celebrating. But CSE points out that the pesticides found in the 18 samples are at levels higher than allowed by the European Union and wants to know the testing method. It adds that levels of pesticides change with the seasons. It depends on the rainfall. Its own samples were still available for testing.

Well, the government agreed that 100 per cent of the samples did not have EU standards of safety. So it might bring rules to make sure the water content in the designer drinks followed EU norms. The minister thanked the CSE for highlighting a problem that needed looking into.

Many doctors and special educators see a direct connection between environmental pollution and the alarming increase in allergies, asthma and cancer among the young. "Students and young adults form the majority of cola fizz consumers," points out Mr. Jeyraj. "This is an opportunity to form a pesticide policy." Along with this he would like the government to promote organic pesticide-free farming and subsidise organic products. There may be several reasons why the drinks are popular. But ask any doctor, he'll tell you carbonated soft drinks have no nutritional value. (Gopichand, the ace shuttler refused to endorse a soft drink because he believes they are `bad for health') . Now the CSE says they contain water-borne toxic pesticides. Think about this when you reach for the fizz the next time.

Article 36

Renaissance art stripped Jesus, his family and close followers of their Jewish identity. That fact can be easily verified by a tour of any Renaissance art gallery, exhibit, or by examining books that display religious paintings from the Renaissance. You will be greeted in these experiences by images of dedicated first-century orthodox Jews transformed into Renaissance-era Christians by physical appearance, settings and artifacts. A graphic example is Pietro Perugino's fifteenth-century painting, *Baptism of Christ*.

The fact that John the Baptist is holding a crucifix as he baptizes Jesus tells the viewer that this is a Christian conversion. The anachronistic presence of other later-day Christian figures emphasizes this baptism as a Christian event. But this image is a falsification of biblical history. It was not a Christian event. Not only was there no Christianity at the time, or even the hint of a new religion, the cross itself was a hated symbol of Roman savagery; it would be another three hundred years before the crucifix would become a devotional Christian object.

Although Christianity did eventually emerge as a separate religion, similar falsifications of biblical history are rampant in collections of Renaissance art spanning hundreds of years. These distortions were not harmless. They imposed a dangerous division between Christians and Jews that lingers today.

Yet, as I learned when I researched my book (*Jesus, Jews, and Anti-Semitism in Art: How Renaissance Art Erased Jesus' Jewish Identity and How Today's Artists Are Restoring It*) most art historians casually dismiss the idea that ideology was behind the Christianization of Jewish Gospel figures in artworks. In my conversations with several noted experts, they insisted that Renaissance art was driven primarily by technical features and advances in art — particularly the advent of naturalism and realism and the revival of Greek idealism.

One prominent art historian was adamant that "artists are not interested in history or ideology — they are only interested in art." I was speechless. What immediately came to mind was Picasso's Guernica, which dramatically represents the horror of war and Diego Rivera's paintings, which expose the exploitation and oppression of workers and the poor. Of course there are many more.

And now, persuasive evidence has emerged that we should put to rest the notion that Renaissance art was not driven by ideology. In her important new book, *Dark Mirror: The Medieval Origins of Anti-Jewish Iconography*, historian Sara Lipton draws on extensive scholarly research to reveal that pictorial representations of Jews in Christian art, from Medieval times to the Renaissance era, are steeped in ideology. And ideology, she contends, pertains not only to Jews in the anti-Semitic Jewish themes in artworks, but to the general population of Christians as well. For example, she introduces the theme of "watching" – that in the Inquisitional society everyone is being watched for propriety and piety of behavior.

Lipton illustrates anti-Jewish iconography in her detailed examination of a trove of Medieval and early Renaissance artworks, many of which have slipped into obscurity and were not previously fully understood. In resurrecting these paintings and providing an astute analysis of their ideological content — political, social and theological – Lipton provides a valuable missing link that illuminates the emergence of anti-Semitism in artworks. Her book is a must read for anyone who seeks to understand the overlooked ideological underpinnings of anti-Semitism in Jewish iconography in Medieval and Renaissance art.

For the first thousand years after the crucifixion, Lipton notes, Western art showed Old Testament prophets, kings and other Jews, as well as New Testament figures, but no stereotyped physical markers separated Jews and Christians. Then, when Christian artworks proliferated after 1000 CE, images began to distinguish Jews from Christians. Notably, the "Jewish hat," distinguished by a point, appeared, and Jews were also sometimes identified by the presence of a beard.

Professor Lipton asks why Jews were included at all in Christian artworks. The answer, she explains, stems from the close historic connection between Judaism and Christianity. From the outset Christianity had a stormy love-hate relationship with Judaism. Christianity professed its authenticity by claiming it fulfilled numerous Old Testament (Torah) prophesies. Given this close tie to Judaism, Christianity faced a dilemma. How could it separate from its Jewish origins as a distinctly new religion while establishing not only difference from but superiority over Judaism?

A deft sleight of hand accomplished the task, from the Christian perspective. Church leaders proclaimed that Jews were blind to the prophesies of their own scriptures, which, according to Christians, had forecast again and again the coming of the Messiah Jesus. That's why, Lipton says, Jews were included in Christian art "as witnesses" to show their blindness to the divinity of Jesus. The appearance of these Jewish witnesses also confirmed the superiority of Christianity by displaying the defeated lowly status of the scattered and "pathetic" Diaspora Jews – who were forced to scatter as God's punishment for their blindness.

Article 37

As does much else in the universe, education moves in cycles. The 1960s and 1970s saw a swell of interest in teaching styles that were less authoritarian and hierarchical than the traditional watching of a teacher scribbling on a blackboard. Today, tastes have swung back, and it is fashionable to denigrate those alternatives as so much hippy nonsense. But evidence trumps fashion—at least, it ought to. And a paper just published in *Science*by Louis Deslauriers and his colleagues at the University of British Columbia suggests that at least one of the newfangled styles is indeed superior to the traditional chalk-and-talk approach.

Dr Deslauriers's lab rats were a group of 850 undergraduate engineering students taking a compulsory physics course. The students were split into groups at the start of their course, and for the first 11 weeks all went to traditionally run lectures given by well-regarded and experienced teachers. In the 12th week, one of the groups was switched to a style of teaching known as deliberate practice, which inverts the traditional university model. Class time is spent on problem-solving, discussion and group work, while the absorption of facts and formulae is left for homework. Students were given reading assignments before classes. Once in the classroom they spent their time in small groups, discussing specific problems, with the teacher roaming between groups to offer advice and respond to questions.

At the end of the test week, Dr Deslauriers surveyed the students and gave them a voluntary test (sold as useful exam practice, and marked on a 12-point scale) to see how much they had learned in that week and what they thought of the new teaching method. The results were striking (see chart). The traditionally taught group's average score was 41%, compared with 74% for the experimental group—even though the experimental group did not manage to cover all the material it was supposed to, whereas the traditional group did.

According to Dr Deslauriers and his team, their result is the biggest performance boost ever documented in educational research, making the new teaching style more effective even than personal, one-to-one tuition—although measuring the effect immediately after the experiment, rather than waiting for end-of-term exam results (as other research often has), may have inflated the number somewhat. The results are especially impressive given that the deliberate-practice method was applied by teachers with little prior experience of using it, whereas the traditionally taught students had the benefit of a seasoned lecturer with a long record of good ratings from pupils.

One frequent criticism of these sorts of studies concerns something called the Hawthorne effect, an idea which emerged from post-war work on productivity. This is that change of any sort will boost people's performance simply because of the novelty value it offers. But the exact nature of the Hawthorne effect, and even whether it exists at all, is controversial. Moreover, if it is real, it would be unlikely to apply in this case, because it is supposed to occur mainly among people doing routine jobs, for whom any change in working practices is welcome. That is not a description of a typical undergraduate's life.

A more serious objection is that the study's participants may be an atypical group. The sort of people who study engineering may react better (or, indeed, worse) to the deliberate-practice method than, say, those reading fine art or history.

Still, Dr Deslauriers and his team are bullish about the wider implications of their work, which adds to the evidence that it may be possible to improve on the long-established chalk-and-talk method. And the students seemed to enjoy the experience, too. Attendance in the experimental group rose by 20% over the course of the week that deliberate practice was used, and three-quarters of its members said that they would have learned more had the entire course been taught in the same way. In this case, then, the educational hippies may have been right.

Article 38

Drama, as we know, is quite different from a novel or a poem. We usually read a novel or a poem when we are alone. But drama is something more than words on the page-it is meant to be performed or enacted. The audience is an active participant in the theatrical presentation. So we respond to a play not alone but along with the other members of the audience. It is quite another matter that different people will respond differently. But then there are some plays which we do not see performed but read them as literature. How will he/she approach such plays? One must remember that playwrights usually expect their plays to be performed. It is for this reason that they present their themes through dialogue, action, music, song and dance so that the play is visually captivating. So when reading a play one should make full use of our imaginative powers. We must try to see the action -and scenes as well as hear the voices of the characters. It is only then that one will be able to experience the play in its different dimensions: as 'literature' as well as 'theatre'.

Modern Indian drama is influenced not only by classical sanskrit drama or local folk forms but also by Western theatre following the establishment of British rule in India. Sanskrit drama flourished in ancient India and produced Bharata'sNatayshastra, the great treatise on all aspects of drama. It is comparable in range and scope to Aristotle's Poetics. In the Poetics, Aristotle prioritizes tragedy as a higher art form as .opposed to comedy. But in classical Sanskrit drama there cannot be a tragic end. This is because of the Hindu worldview which considers the world a 'maya' or an 'illusion' and death not a final end, but a release of the soul into higher forms of being-an event to be celebrated rather than lamented. So there are no tragedies in Sanskrit drama.

People in the West first heard of Kalidasa'sShakuntala (circa 5th century) when Sir William Jones translated it into English in 1789. His excellent translation brought Sanskrit drama to the attention of the Western world. Goethe (1749-1832), the German writer was so impressed that he borrowed the convention of the Prologue from Shakuntala and used it in his own play Faust. Kalidasa, however, was not the only playwright that ancient India produced. In the Hindu period of the first nine centuries, we have three kings Shudraka, Harsha and Visakadatta who wrote plays that now form part of our great cultured heritage. Shudraka (circa 4 A.D.) wrote the famous Mrichkattakatn or The Little Clay Cart which features regularly in contemporary drama festivals as Mitti Ki Gadi. The Little Clay Cart is a social play. Vasantsena the beautiful courtesan loves Charudatta a noble Brahmin who is already married. Sansthanaka, the brother-inlaw of the king tries to make overtures to the courtesan who repulses him. His wicked schemes to implicate Charudatta in Vasantsena's alleged murder come to nought as Aryaka a shepherd rebel overthrows the king and sets both Charudatta and Vasantsena free to marry and live a happy life. Visakadatta wrote the powerful play Mudrarasaka (Raksasa captured through the Signet Ring). The play deals with two rival ministers- Chanakya and Raksasa. Chanakya represents intelligence and intrigue whereas Raksasa is a man of noble ideals and integrity. The play gives us an insight into the minds of power-hungry politicians. Bhasa wrote 134 plays comprising monologues, one-act plays, and six-act dramas. His masterpiece is SwapanaVasavadatta (Vasavadatta Seen in a Dream). The story is about King Udayana who is torn between his love for his wife Vasavadatta and the political necessity of marrying Padrnavati, the daughter of a neighbouring king. Harsha's (7th century) best-known play is Ratnavali. Ratnavali is somewhat similar in plot to SwapanaVasavadatta. Sanskrit drama was eclipsed with the advent of the Mohammedans in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries.Moreover, it has many rules and regulations such as there could be no tragic end, no violent or repulsive act could be depicted on stage, the hero and heroine had both to be charming and noble, the jester had to be greedy and fat. As opposed to this, folk theatre with its flexible and free form has changed, developed and adjusted itself to the changing social conditions reflecting the lives of the people. There are some of the basic principles of drama as laid out in the Natyashastra.

Article 39

Gandhi's interpretation of Hinduism remains one of the most enigmatic parts of his belief system. The constant interflow of the political and the religious is highlighted in retrospect when Gandhi's religious interests are assessed with respect to his political objectives. Gandhi's caste politics also seems to have emanated from similar convoluted cauldron of his religious beliefs along with the political and social objectives that he continuously stressed upon. Gandhi inherited a society where the social differentiations had grown for the last two thousand years and a vertical hierarchy was rigidly in place. In what can be seen as an extension of the work by other Hindu reformers, Gandhi attempted to persuade caste Hindus to humanize their interpretation of scriptures which were used to justify social exclusion and perennial servitude. This moral suasion of the caste Hindus also extended to incorporate harijans or the outcastes into the mainstream Hindu society. While he vehemently opposed the practice of untouchability and its presumed centrality to the Hindu religion, Gandhi believed in an idealized and egalitarian form of Varnavyastha which he endorsed to be the Hinduism's scientific contribution to the division of labour for the smooth functioning of any society.

Varnavyastha as a social construct is grounded into metaphysics of Hindu scriptures. Its social manifestation was followed by a deep adherence to the principle of heredity. Individual occupations were determined hereditarily thus offering little mobility over the course of rebirths. It is presumed "to have received divine sanction from the Rig Veda, the first book of Hindu scriptures. The four varnas-Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas and Shudras- are said to form part of the Purusa, the Cosmic Being. The organic functioning of the whole society depends on how every individual adheres to the prescribed dharma (divine duty) of his varna" (Gonsalves 124). The Rig Veda, however, maintains that each caste has a different role but is of equal importance to the one body of Purusa which represents the well being of the overall society. Thus equality was promised ontologically and presumed with respect to the stable functioning of the Hindu society. However, the sociological facts tell a completely different story (Gonsalves).

For Gandhi, the primary act of subversion and reformation originated from his abandoning the frameworks of contemporary state of Hinduism. In his frequent invocation of the Santana Dharma or the eternal law, there is an evident attempt at transcending the impurities of the contemporary state of Hinduism. The invocation of an original and pristine form of religion allows him to define Hinduism in terms of an eternal law, and a temporally and spatially removed golden age, which removed from his own times, is also free from the impurities. This is evident in his treatment of the scriptures. For him, Vedas stand for the sanctity of Hindu principles.

Hinduism for Gandhi seems to embody what he calls as "the spirit of the Vedas" in form of concepts like truth, purity, humility and forgiveness. "According to Santana Dharma taught by that venerable Mother, life does not consist in outward rites and ceremonial, but it consists in the uttermost inward purification and merging oneself, body, soul and mind, in the divine essence" (Gandhi 13). In retrospect, this can be seen as a profound reinterpretation of Hinduism in the first half of the twentieth century. Gandhi includes his sevamarg to other more ritualistic ways of attaining moksha. In bringing the individual and personal ethics to the forefront of religious engagement, Gandhi's Hinduism suddenly posed a threat to the traditional upper caste elites whose desperate attempts were to make a successful transition into a modern dominant class. As AshisNandy observes, "It is not just NathuramGodse, who is responsible for Gandhi's death, but the elite that provided the milieu for such hate politics. Thus, Gandhi's Hinduism was questioned and distrusted from both within and without. For the Santani brand of Hinduism, he appeared not Hindu enough and for other non-hindu forces, he was too Hindu.

Although Gandhi's attack against untouchability was constant, it did not follow in his reaction towards the Varnavyastha or the caste system. Gandhi's philosophical thoughts on untouchability made it into a grave

sin and can be related to his conviction that the afflictions that India as a nation was suffering, was a direct consequence of the oppression that the upper caste afflicted on the untouchables. For Gandhi, caste was not originally a principle of divisive politics. It did not entertain the differences of "high and low" but in fact, it was a rational principle of unity and respect for all modes of existence. Gandhi argues, "I am a firm believer in Varnashrama. I have not hesitated before now to consider it as a gift of Hinduism to mankind. Acceptance of that Dharma is, do far as I have been able to see, a condition of spiritual growth. The four divisions are not a vertical section, but a horizontal plane on which all stand on a footing of equality, doing the services respectively assigned to them" (Gandhi 14). It is against this core belief that Gandhi posits the four varnas as the parts of one Purusa.

Article 40

I lived in Master Hugh's family about seven years. During this time, I succeeded in learning to read and write. In accomplishing this, I was compelled to resort to various stratagems. I had no regular teacher. My mistress, who had kindly commenced to instruct me, had, in compliance with the advice and direction of her husband, not only ceased to instruct, but had set her face against my being instructed by any one else. It is due, however, to my mistress to say of her, that she did not adopt this course of treatment immediately. She at first lacked the depravity indispensable to shutting me up in mental darkness. It was at least necessary for her to have some training in the exercise of irresponsible power, to make her equal to the task of treating me as though I were a brute.

My mistress was, as I have said, a kind and tender- hearted woman; and in the simplicity of her soul she commenced, when I first went to live with her, to treat me as she supposed one human being ought to treat another. In entering upon the duties of a slaveholder, she did not seem to perceive that I sustained to her the relation of a mere chattel, and that for her to treat me as a human being was not only wrong, but dangerously so. Slavery proved as injurious to her as it did to me. When I went there, she was a pious, warm, and tender-hearted woman. There was no sorrow or suffering for which she had not a tear. She had bread for the hungry, clothes for the naked, and comfort for every mourner that came within her reach.

Slavery soon proved its ability to divest her of these heavenly qualities. Under its influence, the tender heart became stone, and the lamblike disposition gave way to one of tiger-like fierceness. The first step in her downward course was in her ceasing to instruct me. She now commenced to practise her husband's precepts. She finally became even more violent in her opposition than her husband himself. She was not satisfied with simply doing as well as he had commanded; she seemed anxious to do better. Nothing seemed to make her more angry than to see me with a newspaper. She seemed to think that here lay the danger. I have had her rush at me with a face made all up of fury, and snatch from me a newspaper, in a manner that fully revealed her apprehension. She was an apt woman; and a little experience soon demonstrated, to her satisfaction, that education and slavery were incompatible with each other.

From this time I was most narrowly watched. If I was in a separate room any considerable length of time, I was sure to be suspected of having a book, and was at once called to give an account of myself. All this, however, was too late. The first step had been taken. Mistress, in teaching me the alphabet, had given me the *inch*, and no precaution could prevent me from taking the *ell*.

The plan which I adopted, and the one by which I was most successful, was that of making friends of all the little white boys whom I met in the street. As many of these as I could, I converted into teachers. With their kindly aid, obtained at different times and in different places, I finally succeeded in learning to read. When I was sent of errands, I always took my book with me, and by going one part of my errand quickly, I found time to get a lesson before my return. I used also to carry bread with me, enough of which was always in the house, and to which I was always welcome; for I was much better off in this regard than many of the poor white children in our neighborhood. This bread I used to bestow upon the hungry little urchins, who, in return, would give me that more valuable bread of knowledge. I am strongly tempted to give the names of two or three of those little boys, as a testimonial of the gratitude and affection I bear them; but prudence forbids; — not that it would injure me, but it might embarrass them; for it is almost an unpardonable offence to teach slaves to read in this Christian country. It is enough to say of the dear little fellows, that they lived on Philpot Street, very near Durgin and Bailey's ship-yard. I used to talk this matter of slavery over with them. I would sometimes say to them, I wished I could be as free as they would be when they got to be men. "You will be free as soon as you are twenty-one, *but I am a slave for life!* Have not I as good a right to be free as you have?" These words used to trouble them; they would express for me the liveliest sympathy, and console me with the hope that something would occur by which I might be free.

Article 41

With unemployment at its highest level in decades, the U.S. Department of Labor issued a report Tuesday suggesting the crisis is primarily the result of millions of Americans just completely blowing their job interviews.

According to the findings, seven out of 10 Americans could have landed their dream job last month if they had known where they see themselves in five years, and the number of unemployed could be reduced from 14.6 million to 5 million if everyone simply greeted potential employers with firmer handshakes, maintained eye contact, and stopped fiddling with their hair and face so much.

"This economy will not recover until job candidates learn how to put their best foot forward," said Labor Secretary Hilda Solis, warning that even a small increase in stuttering among applicants who are asked to describe their weaknesses could cause the entire labor market to collapse. "If we're going to dig ourselves out of this mess, Americans need to stop wearing blue jeans to interviews, even if they're nice blue jeans, and even if that particular office happens to have a relaxed dress code."

"They also need to start bringing extra copies of their resumés, as it will show they are prepared and serious," Solis added. "And, by the way, how hard is it to send a hand-written thank-you note afterward? Anyone can dash off an e-mail."

A federal survey of employers found that nearly half of job-seeking Americans botched their interviews by responding no when asked, "So, do you have any questions for me?" Among candidates strongly qualified to perform the jobs they were applying for, 36 percent didn't bring a notepad or pen to the interview, and 16 percent were thrown off guard when the interviewer broached topics unrelated to work, such as the weather, sports, or personal hobbies.

Twelve percent, employers said, did this kind of nervous throat-clearing thing.

"If applicants would just say yes when asked if they played softball or liked golf, we could add 350,000 jobs to the private sector," Deputy Labor Secretary Seth Harris said. "The fact is, right now, today, approximately a third of the country's manufacturing positions are vacant. Auto plants across the country, especially in Detroit, are sitting there just waiting for people to come in and build cars."

"You may be a qualified candidate, but none of that matters if you walk into that interview lacking confidence," he added. "Don't act too confident, though. And don't joke around too much. And don't be overly friendly or ask too many questions. But be yourself."

The Labor Department confirmed their statistics don't take into account the estimated 20 million citizens who were unable to get interiews in the first place because of formatting errors in their resumés, or cover letters that slightly exceeded one page.

"At this point, hiring someone who doesn't use bulleted lists, strong action verbs, or boldfaced keywords is completely out of the question," said public relations executive Max Werner, who has been looking for office managers and a CFO since 2008. "And if you're going to end your cover letter with 'best wishes' instead of 'sincerely,' I don't care how experienced you are—you won't be working for me."

President Obama, who last week signed a law extending unemployment benefits, said the legislation would also address joblessness by creating a $1.2 billion program aimed at training Americans to use firm but approachable body language to make a great first impression.

"My administration remains fully committed to putting citizens back to work by making sure they show up at least 15 minutes early to their interview and never badmouth a previous boss," said Obama, flanked by unemployed Americans during an address from the White House Rose Garden. "Our new 'Nail the Interview, Score the Job' initiative will help regular Americans like Paul and Tracy here remember that they should prep ahead of time by learning a few things about the company they want to work for."

"And that little things," he continued, "like making sure your socks match, matter."

Article 42

FOR the first time since the construction of the Ganga Canal in 1847, water has stopped flowing in Har-ki-Pauri at Haridwar and through the Ganga canal that nourishes the entire western U.P. region of the Doab. Even the British colonisers did not stop the flow of Ganga at Har-ki-Pauri. Why has the Ganga disappeared at the peak of summer?

The argument that a bridge needs to be built for Ardh Kumbh in 2004 does not wash. Hundreds of bridges have been built since 1847; the flow of water in the Canal system was never stopped. And there is no imperative for beginning construction in the peak of summer when water requirement is greatest in agriculture and for domestic use.

The real reason seems to be engineer a water crisis — not a bridge — and use that to promote the idea of selling Ganga to private corporations like Suez. It also seems to be an experiment to test the social

resistance of people to disappearing rivers – an inevitability if rivers have to be dammed and diverted for the grandiose $200 billion River Linking Project.

The privatisation of the Ganga by Suez is, in fact, an example of river linking – of bringing the Ganga waters to the Yamuna.

The Yamuna has already been killed by pollution and, in spite of millions spent on cleaning, it continues to be unfit for drinking. Now, the powers that be want to make the poor rural communities of Uttaranchal and U.P. give up their water rights so that Ganga water can be commodified and sold to those with money — Delhi's elite. The Sonia Vihar plant of Suez was inaugurated on June 21, 2002. It is designed to treat 635 million litres of Ganga water a day. The contract is between Delhi Jal Board (the Water Supply Department of Delhi Government) and the French Company Ondeo Degremont (a subsidiary of Suez Lyonnaise des Eaux — the world's biggest water giant).

The water for the Suez-Degremont plant in Delhi will come from Tehri Dam through the Upper Ganga Canal upto Muradnagar in Western Uttar Pradesh and then through the giant pipeline to Delhi. The Upper Ganga Canal, which starts at Haridwar and carries the holy water of Ganga upto Kanpur via Muradnagar, is the main source of irrigation for this region.

The plant at Sonia Vihar is being built at a cost of Rs. 1.8 billion. However, the Tehri Dam — of which Suez will be a primary beneficiary — has already cost Rs. 100 billion, and the construction is far from complete. Further, the pipe to be laid over 30 km to bring water from the Ganga Canal at Muradnagar to Sonia Vihar is being built at public cost. Suez is not bringing in private foreign investment. It is appropriating public financial investment. Public-private partnerships are in effect private appropriation of public investment. But the financial costs are not the highest costs. The real costs are social and ecological.

The people of Tehri can never be compensated for the uprooting of their lives. The women are still on a dharna, refusing to move, even though the contractors to break down the homes to force people to move. All water schemes in the dam catchment have been cancelled, both on grounds that the government has no money and on grounds that every drop of Ganga water must flow into the dam, not to sustain lives of local communities.

Privatisation of water denies local communities their water rights and access to water in two ways. Firstly, the scarce and limited water resources are diverted, from the poor to the rich, from the countryside to towns, from agriculture to industry leaving water famines where people have no purchasing power, and providing water to those who have destroyed their own water resources through waste and pollution. Secondly, the state itself shifts from its functions in providing welfare to the needy and most marginalised communities to the new function of providing public subsidies for private profits. Small, decentralised rural schemes are starved of both water resources and financial resources.

It is not just women of Uttaranchal who are bearing the social costs for bringing the Ganga waters to Delhi. Farmers from U.P. will also lose their livelihoods and irrigation. The Upper Ganga Canal is one of the oldest canals in Western U.P and irrigates about 9,24,000 hectares of land.

What does diverting water to Delhi mean for national food security? The annual water diverted to Delhi from the Upper Ganga Canal at the rate of 635 million litres per day will result in critical reduction in the production of food crops in the region, and thus possible destruction of national food security.

In addition, the ecological and cultural costs are high. The damming of the Ganga at Tehri has already converted it into a cesspool of stagnant water. The Gangetic plain is one of the most fertile regions of the

world. In Bihar, farmers, before planting their seeds, put Ganga water in a pot and set it aside in a special place in the field to ensure a good harvest. It is this treatment of the organic as sacred that inspired Diana Eck the Harvard geographer to call the Ganges an "organic symbol".

For the Ganga's significance as a symbol is not just as a narrative. First, she is a river that flows with waters of life in a vibrant universe. Narrative myths come and go in history. They may shape the cosmos and convey meaning for many generations, and then they may gradually lose their hold upon the imagination and may finally be forgotten. But the river remains, even when the stories are no longer repeated. And it is this river that is disappearing as the market commodifies our most sacred symbols, our most vital needs.

But the Ganga is also being transformed from a river of life to a river of death both by the ecological consequences of damming as illustrated by the ecological risks of Tehri dam, and of diversion, as the disappeared Ganga in Haridwar and Western U.P. is showing.

The Tehri dam project is located in the outer Himalaya in the Tehri-Garhwal district of Uttaranchal. The dam will submerge 4,200 hectares of the most fertile flat land in the Bhagirathi and Bhilangana valleys. Moreover, the dam is located in a seismic fault zone. Between 1816 and 1991, the Garhwal region had witnessed 17 earthquakes, the most recent ones being at Uttarkashi in October 1991 and Chamoli in 1998.

In case the dam collapses due to an earthquake or any other fault, the devastation will be unimaginable. The huge reservoir built at such a height will be emptied in 22 minutes. Within 60 minutes Rishikesh will be under 260 meters of water. Soon after Haridwar will be totally submerged under 232 meters with next 23 minutes. Bijnor, Meerut, Hapur and Bulandshahar will be under water within 12 hours, says environmentalist Sunderlal Bahuguna. Thus the dam is potentially dangerous for large parts of north-western India, and large areas in the Gangetic plains could be devastated in the event of a mishap. The life of the dam is estimated to be not more than 30 years because of heavy sedimentation. Already, islands of silt are rising faster than the impounded water, confirming that Tehri dam will hold silt, not water and hence create floods, not prevent them.

The disappearance of the Ganga in the peak of the summer of 2003 is an experiment, a vivisection of our living rivers, our living cultures. It is an experiment to test how much violence as a society we can accept as mute dead witnesses of our own destruction. The people of Uttaranchal, U.P and Delhi can turn around this violent, abusive experiment to convert the lifeblood of our rivers into corporate commodities, and transform it into an experience for ensuring water justice and sustainability, and defence of our living waters.

Alternatives exist for Delhi. Delhi does not have to cannibalise the countryside of the Himalaya and Doab. At present Delhi has allocation of waters from the Yamuna, the Ganga and the Beas (Bhakra project), in addition to ground water resources. Delhi has sufficient water to meet its increased requirements of the next century and obviating the need to bring Tehri dam waters to Delhi.

Organisations are working to create awareness of and participation in sustainable water solutions to Delhi's water crisis and also with communities in Tehri and the Ganga Canal areas to sustain the Ganga.

On August 9, 2002, on the anniversary of the Quit India Day, more than 5,000 farmers of Muradnagar and adjoining areas of western Uttar Pradesh gathered at village Bhanera to protest the laying of a giant pipeline to supply the water from the Ganga to the Sonia Vihar water plant. The rally was launched from Haridwar — one of the oldest and holiest cities of India built on the banks of Ganga — where hundreds of farmers, together with priests, citizens and worshippers of Ganga announced that "Ganga is not for Sale", and vowed to defend the freedom of this holy river. Farmers and others in villages along the route joined the rally to declare that they would never allow Suez to take over Ganga water.

In March 2003, another Ganga Yatra took place, this time with Magsasay awardee Rajender Singh and Oscar Olivera, a leader of the Coalition in Bolivia which stopped water privatisation and drove out Bechtel. The Bolivian movement had the slogans "Water is God's gift and not a merchandise" and "Water is life". In India, our slogan is "The Ganga is not for sale".

Article 43

Now, five years in, the cable-watching public is awaiting the final stanzas next month in the Ballad of Walter White, who has evolved into a complicated and very contemporary folk hero. His Heisenberg pseudonym was borrowed from the physicist whose uncertainty principle is popularly understood to express the idea that the presence of an observer changes the nature of what is observed. And Walter, a sad-sack high school chemistry teacher who found a vocation cooking the finest methamphetamine money could buy, was always adept at shifting his appearance depending on who was watching.
In truth, though, his development over five seasons has been less a shocking transformation than a series of confirmations. Mr. Gilligan's busy and inventive narrative machinery has provided plenty of cleverly executed surprises, but these have all served to reveal the Walter White who was there all along. The sides of his personality — sociopath and family man, scientist and killer, rational being and creature of impulse, entrepreneur and loser — are not necessarily as contradictory as we might have supposed.

Or rather, if we insist on supposing that they are, it may be for our own sentimental reasons. We love our television antiheroes, sometimes blindly. When James Gandolfini's death last month revived our affection for Tony Soprano, New York magazine reposted "The Long Con," Emily Nussbaum's insightful 2007 post-mortem on "The Sopranos." In it, Ms. Nussbaum argued that at a certain point, Mr.Gandolfini and the show's creator, David Chase, fully acknowledged Tony's monstrosity, and that viewers' decision to empathize or identify with him was their own guilty choice. The key message to the audience — one many of us elected to ignore — was a line delivered by a psychologist to Tony's denial-prone wife, Carmela: "One thing you can never say, that you haven't been told."

We have been told about Don Draper, too, though in the most recent season of "Mad Men," his charm has begun to seem shopworn and sad, and his misbehavior more pitiful than demonic. And the truth about Walter White, played by Bryan Cranston in a career-defining, Emmy-dominating performance, has been there virtually from the beginning. Very early on, after he withdrew his savings so that he and his partner, Jesse, could buy the R.V. that served, for a time, as their mobile meth lab, Walter marveled that he felt "awake." Everything he did thereafter, from the first self-defensive killing to the coldblooded murders that followed, he did with his eyes open.

Walter may have wanted us to believe — and may, at moments, have convinced himself — that he was a decent man driven by desperate circumstances to do terrible things, but that notion was either wishful thinking or tactical deceit. Viewed as a whole, in optimal binge conditions, with the blinds pulled down and the pizza boxes and chicken wrappers piling up around the couch, "Breaking Bad" reveals itself as the story of a man mastering his vocation and fighting to claim his rightful place in the world. Its dark, morally scandalous vision has been imposed on the kind of tale that is, more conventionally, an inspiring parable of entrepreneurial gumption. This formula turns out to be well suited to the times.

The three principal antiheroes of 21st-century cable television inhabit different regions in the kingdom of modern capitalism. Tony Soprano is the inheritor of a family business, his managerial challenges complicated by kinship ties and tribal customs. Don Draper occupies a high-rise corporate zone of corner offices, mergers and expense accounts. As original as "The Sopranos" and "Mad Men" undoubtedly are, they also knowingly draw on a rich reservoir of popular-cultural meanings attached to their chosen worlds. They look at familiar material from a fresh perspective, without quite letting go of the inherited romance of the Mafia and the advertising industry.

Walter's corner of the economic landscape is a more shadowy and decidedly less glamorous place, and one whose main representations are a bunch of books and alt-country songs. Methamphetamine has a long history, first as a legitimate pharmaceutical product and then as an illegal recreational substance. For most of that time, meth lacked the cachet and the panic-inducing power of cocaine, marijuana or LSD (or alcohol, for that matter), but over the past 15 years or so, it has become more visible as a problem and, therefore, as a symbol of other social dysfunctions.

Just as crack in the 1980s and '90s was associated with the mostly black ghettos of deindustrializing Northern cities — the Baltimore of "The Corner" and "The Wire," to stay within the context of cable television — meth is linked to the fate of the rural and small-town working class. "Well, it's a war out there, and it's fought by poor white men" is how the alt-country band Old Crow Medicine Show sums up the situation in "Methamphetamine," a song that evokes Appalachia both in its lyrics and its musical idiom. Daniel Woodrell's novel "Winter's Bone" (faithfully adapted in Debra Granik's 2010 film) weaves meth production and use into the folkways of southwestern Missouri, where the drug is seen both to hold families together — providing work and income in hard times — and to tear them apart.

But perhaps the most panoramic view of meth-era America is James McMurtry's "Choctaw Bingo," an eight-and-a-half minute epic that the journalist Ron Rosenbaum once proposed as a new national anthem and that I prefer to think of as the Great American Novel set to music. On his concert album "Live in Aught-Three," Mr.McMurtry describes it as "a song about the north Texas-southern Oklahoma crystal methamphetamine industry," even though the drug is mentioned only once. In a series of verses built around a single chord, we are introduced to an extended clan that includes a long-haul trucker; a football coach and his wife, who are serious gun enthusiasts; and a pair of fun-loving sisters from a "hell-raising town way up in southeastern Kansas," who are the narrator's second cousins. All of them are en route to a family reunion at the home of one Uncle Slayton, who, among many other activities (fishing, gambling, being mean), "still makes whiskey 'cause he still knows how."

But while home distilling may be a hobby at this point, it is also a link between traditional and newfangled forms of contraband manufacture. An enterprising fellow with plenty of ways to make money, Uncle Slayton "cooks that crystal meth because the 'shine don't sell." Crank is for him what white lightning might have been to his father or grandfather: a cottage industry with a reliable customer base and tax-free revenue.

Not all meth production is local, of course. Home cooking of the kind practiced by Slayton (and, at least initially, by Walter White) is supplemented by and sometimes in competition with a wide-ranging trade pioneered by American motorcycle gangs in the '70s and later taken over by Mexican trafficking organizations. As Nick Reding suggests in "Methland," his rich journalistic account of the effects of the drug on an Iowa farming and meatpacking town, if meth "is a metaphor for anything, it is a metaphor for the cataclysmic fault lines formed by globalization."

On one side of the fault line is a displaced, marginalized and at times all but invisible working class, frequently imagined as both the makers and takers of meth. In Mr.McMurtry's songs, cooking speed is

roughly what slinging rock is in the rap of Jay Z or Young Jeezy: a signifier of authenticity, of demographic realness.

Which is precisely what Walter White lacks. The sociology of meth has never been the point of "Breaking Bad," which made its debut near the end of the meth panic of the mid-2000s. The whole premise of the series is that Walter's entrance into the drug trade is a wild anomaly, albeit one with a certain perverse logic. He may be out of his element, but in a business dominated by home cooks on one side and foreign conglomerates on the other, surely there is room for an enterprising scientist devoted, above all, to quality control.

The timing of the show's debut obscured Walter's true class identity. In the autumn of 2008, with the economy in free fall, it was easy to suppose that he was falling, too, from a precarious middle-class existence into an underworld of criminality. He was working two jobs with crummy health insurance, a baby on the way, a broken water heater and a Pontiac Aztek in the driveway of his Albuquerque split-level.

But almost as soon as we met him, we were given strong hints that his fall had already taken place. The humble teacher and henpecked husband — that was the disguise. How many such people have a plaque in their houses acknowledging their contributions to Nobel Prize-winning research? Heisenberg, his drug lord nom de guerre, was closer to Walter's true face than the stammering, shambling classroom cipher he showed to his students and colleagues, the nebbish he was with his brother-in-law, Hank, or the milquetoast who shared a bed with his wife, Skyler.

Walter was, right from the start, a disenfranchised member of the nerd aristocracy, exiled from his place in the elite by his own stubborn pride and the treachery of his erstwhile partners. He was a mighty empire builder out of an Ayn Rand novel, biding his time amid the weaklings and plotting his revenge.

Think of his rich friends Gretchen and Elliot, whose offer to pay for Walter's treatment was a source of much misunderstanding in Seasons 1 and 2. The party at their elegant estate is Walter White's Rosebud moment, during which his deep motivating secret is disclosed. Walter, who shows up with Skyler in garish, too-formal clothes at an event defined by neutral tones and soft fabrics, sees what his best friend and former girlfriend, now partners in a successful tech company, have made of his research, and his envy is intensified by entitlement. Their life should have been his. He will find a way to get even.

And so, using his superior technical know-how, Walter puts together a start-up, making a boutique product more consistent than that made by enthusiastic hackers and more pure than the stuff pushed by the soulless cartels over the border. This kind of project is not easy. Our self-made man is yoked to unreliable partners, harassed by ruthless competitors and constantly beset by supply-chain problems. Raw materials are sometimes scarce. At other times, distribution is a headache. Government regulation — in the form of the Drug Enforcement Agency — will gum up the works. Walter must deal with people dumber than he is, or who are threatened by his intelligence. No one really understands his vision.

It's a familiar story. Walter White is in "the empire business," which places him in the company of the other disrupters and innovators who started out in basements and garages and dorm rooms and shook up conventional business models. You know who I mean. Not that I'm suggesting that the Jobses and Zuckerbergs of the world are drug dealers, however habit-forming their wares may be. The allegory of "Breaking Bad" is hardly so blatant.

But the series is nonetheless a sustained and stringent critique of entrepreneurial ideology in the form of an unsparing character study. Walter is almost as good at self-justification as he is at cooking meth, and over the course of the series, he has not hesitated to give high-minded reasons for his lowest actions. In his own

mind, he remains a righteous figure, an apostle of family values, free enterprise and scientific progress. That's an old song. We all know the words. But Uncle Slayton's version might be more honest. He likes that money, he don't mind the smell.

Article 44

This year, the world's largest democracy, India, and the biggest country by area, Russia, are celebrating the 70th anniversary of establishment of diplomatic relations between them. Russia continues to be among India's major politico-diplomatic and defence partner nations. While India has inked separate strategic partnership pacts with more than two dozen countries, the Indian and Russian governments in December 2010 elevated their bilateral 'Strategic Partnership' to what they termed a "Special and Privileged Strategic Partnership."

The New Delhi-based think tank 'Foundation for National Security Research', which did a comparative assessment of India's strategic partnerships — meaning, 'political-diplomatic, defence and economic cooperation' (during the 10-year period prior to November 2011), had said, "Russia emerges as the most important strategic partner of India (followed by the U.S., France, the U.K., Germany and Japan in that order)." The November 2011 report had found that Russia had provided strong political and diplomatic support to India and helped enormously in building India's defence capability. However, it warned that the "economic content of the (India-Russia) partnership is extremely weak," and recommended that "urgent and vigorous steps need to be taken to improve economic relations if this (India-Russia) partnership is to be sustained and made durable."

New Delhi and Moscow are renewing efforts to bolster their seven-decade-old relationship regardless of the perception of India's increasing closeness to the U.S., Russia's growing friendship with China and even with Pakistan especially in the context of defence and strategic partnership, as well as criticism that India and Russia are neglecting the glory of their past ties due to their preoccupation with other parts of the world. In June this year, Indian Prime Minister NarendraModiis slated to take part as the Chief Guest in the St. Petersburg International Economic Forum — also known as the 'Russian Davos' after the World Economic Forum, which is an international organisation whose flagship annual meeting is held in Davos, Switzerland.

Until 1990-91, India and Russia — the main constituent of (the erstwhile) Soviet Union — had enjoyed robust trade ties. In 1990, the Soviet Union was India's top goods exports destination with shipments to the tune of $2.9 billion, according to data from the World Integrated Trade Solution (WITS) software. In the list of nations from where India imported goods, Soviet Union figured seventh in value terms with $922 million. Then in 1991, two watershed moments happened — economic liberalisation was introduced in India, and the Soviet Union was dissolved. In the following two-and-a-half decades, Russia remained India's strong politico-diplomatic and defence partner like the erstwhile Soviet Union used to be. However, since 1990-91, India's trade underwent further diversification and Russia is now not anywhere near the top in the list of India's trade partners. WITS data showed that in 2015, India exported goods worth $1.6 billion to Russia, but had shipped more items in value terms to 37 other countries. In 2015, India's imports from Russia were valued at $4.5 billion, but had imported goods worth more than that from 23 other nations.

This slippage in trade is a huge demotion for Russia, considering that the erstwhile Soviet Union was among India's leading trade partners. Worse still, India's goods exports in 2015 to Russia were worth just $1.6 billion as against $40.3 billion during that year to the U.S. — which was India's leading export

destination. Also, in 2015, India's goods imports from Russia were worth only $4.5 billion as against $61.6 billion from China — which was India's leading source of imports that year.

If one takes into account India's GDP of about $2 trillion and Russia's GDP of $1.3 trillion, it becomes clear that their bilateral trade and investment ties are far below potential. Pointing out that India-Russia trade in 2015-16 amounted to about $6.7 billion, a concept note by the New Delhi-based think-tank Research and Information System for developing countries (RIS) said while Russia comprised just 1% of India's total trade, India accounts for a minuscule 1.2% of Russia's overall trade.

Stating that both the countries have set a target to raise bilateral trade to $30 billion by 2025 and increase bilateral investment from $10 billion to $15 billion, the RIS suggested that expediting the conclusion of negotiations of the proposed India-Eurasian Economic Union (EEU) Free Trade Agreement would provide opportunities to India and Russia for regional cooperation and development as well as concessional trade and investment in the region. Members of the EEU include Russia, Armenia, Belarus, Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan. The September 2016 meeting of the India-Russia Inter-Governmental Commission on Trade, Economic, Scientific, Technological and Cultural Cooperation had identified expeditious implementation of the International North South Transport Corridor (INSTC) project as well as the launch of the 'Green Corridor' project for Customs facilitation (by easing Customs norms) as what would be major steps towards better connectivity and trade facilitation. According to the RIS, the INSTC — a multi-modal transportation route connecting the Indian Ocean and Persian Gulf to the Caspian sea through Iran and onward to Northern Europe through St. Petersburg in Russia — will enhance trade and investment linkages between these regions.

Referring to reports of Russia and China proposing to bring the EEU closer to China's One-Belt-One-Road (OBOR) initiative (a massive project to develop infrastructure in more than 60 countries, primarily in Asia and Europe), Ashok Sajjanhar, former ambassador of India to Kazakhstan, while addressing a recent RIS event, said India should study the impact of this development in the context of the proposed India-EEU FTA. Citing reports of the EEU being supportive of the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (or CPEC — the so-called 'flagship' project of OBOR), Mr.Sajjanhar said India should look into its impact as well. Incidentally, India has strategic concerns regarding the OBOR as the CPEC is expected to cover areas including Pakistan-occupied-Kashmir. Mr.Sajjanhar said India should also carry out an assessment of U.S.-Iran ties and its impact on INSTC as part of a study on the strategic relevance of INSTC. GulshanSachdeva, professor, Jawaharlal Nehru University, said instead of focusing only on the geo-political dimension of OBOR and CPEC, India should consider if it could gain from such mega infrastructure projects from a developmental perspective.

India-Russia trade ties have been below-potential and lopsided (in favour of Russia) as it is primarily a buyer-seller relationship and not one based on collaborations through investments, according to Pranav Kumar, Head (trade and international policy), Confederation of Indian Industry. Besides, if the emphasis continues to be on sectors such as defence, hydrocarbons and nuclear power, it would result in Russia gaining more, he added. Therefore, he said, to ensure a balance, sectors such as IT/ITeS, pharmaceuticals and healthcare — where India has considerable strength — should also be encouraged, apart from seeking Russian investments in India in areas including defence manufacturing to push the 'Make In India' programme and in infrastructure and space technology to take forward the Smart City and Digital India initiatives respectively.

What would also help in boosting bilateral ties is trading in local currencies, setting up pipelines for direct gas delivery from Russia to India as well as operationalisation of the proposed $1-billion fund through India's National Investment & Infrastructure Fund and the Russian Direct Investment Fund for investment in infrastructure and technology projects.

Article 45

The matter is now under a judicial inquiry, but the resignation recently of a minister in the Kerala government turns the spotlight once again on the tricky journalistic terrain of the sting operation. A new Malayalam television channel, Mangalam TV, had debuted on March 26 with a splash. It broadcast an audio recording allegedly of the then Transport Minister of Kerala, A.K. Saseendran, purportedly seeking sexual favours from a woman who had come to him for assistance. Her end of the conversation was not put out, and the channel reported that it had got the tape directly from the woman. Mr.Saseendran put up a defence imputing that all was not what it appeared on the broadcast — but in the ensuing storm, resigned. Four days later, on March 30, the CEO of the channel went on air to render an apology, presumably for misrepresenting matters, though we must await the inquiry report to get a final picture of what transpired. The CEO, significantly, admitted that a woman journalist with the channel had conducted the sting, suggesting this was in reality a kind of honey trap. As things stand, the CEO and eight other Mangalam employees have been booked under sections of the Information Technology Act and the Indian Penal Code. Mr.Saseendran, who had been the lone minister from the Nationalist Congress Party in the Left Democratic Front government in Kerala, must wait out the inquiry process before making a bid to regain his portfolio.

The ethics of sting operations is among the most fiercely debated issues in journalism. And while different jurisdictions and media groups around the world have varying guidelines on the subject, some things are generally agreed upon. Any such operation that uses false pretences, with its necessary violation of the interviewee's trust and privacy, must serve a larger public interest that far outweighs such violation. It also must be used as a last resort, when there is no other means of acquiring the information sought, and must be the outcome of considerable editorial deliberation. Stings were never intended to entrap or induce people into committing wrongdoing or, as seems likely in this case, embarrassing themselves badly. Stings are an ethical minefield and it is imperative that publications and broadcasters explain the vital public interest for conducting them. Journalists count on the readers' — indeed the public's — goodwill to evade the establishment's potentially vindictive response to an exposé. A sting cannot be an excuse to grab eyeballs with prurient (and essentially private) content, or a shortcut to make a point merely by shocking the reader or viewer. Doing so risks eroding that goodwill and leaving journalists facing harsh charges, often deservedly so.

Article 46

Autism primarily affects the areas of communication, social skills and behaviour. It can occur in all socio economic and racial groups but is four times more common in boys than girls. A majority of autistic children are intellectually challenged. They have intellectual limitations associated with seriously impaired adaptive behaviour and cannot attain a level of social responsibility and personal independence appropriate to their age. Some autistic individuals who are not mentally challenged may have unusual talents that appear at an early age either in the form of exceptional rote memory, a capacity for lightening fast calculations, precocious musical gifts, painting ability, or the ability to name the day of the week corresponding to any calendar date. These extraordinary individuals are known as autistic savants.

Social difficulties are at the helm of autism. They need to be attended to as they impact teaching and learning. Since education takes place in a social context, teaching social skills to these children is very important. There is an exhaustive list of treatments, medicines and therapies to help individuals of all ages but it was the efforts of Ramamoorthi who found that theatre/drama was best suited to them as therapy. The

unique feature of his drama therapy is use of masks. He was conscious of the fact that children with autism avoid eye contact because of the difficulty with processing sensory information they receive through the eyes. They feel overwhelmed when they are bombarded with visual stimuli. Therefore, in order to help them, he thought of giving them wearable masks. These masks help in cutting off the peripheral vision so that the child does not feel distracted or overwhelmed. This helped not only in making eye contact with another person but also improved attention span and their lack of understanding emotions. It also reduced hyperactivity and encouraged children and adults to play creatively.

Often individuals with autism are verbal but do not have the skills to speak and interact socially. Sometimes they repeat other people's words verbatim, recite speeches and dialogues in exactly the same way as the original. In the drama therapy the narrative or the content of any story used during the process, allows the individual to take on roles in order to learn from other characters. This makes it possible for them to connect with their own problem/emotions indirectly, working and solving through the fictional work. They apply the experience to the real people they encounter in everyday life and make adequate social adjustments.

Until recently, autism has been considered by many as hopeless, incurable and absolute condition. Now, however, research suggests that intensive behaviour intervention, begun when the child is between 2 and 5 years old, can have a significant and lasting positive impact. Typically children learn to understand how others feel, think, believe and operate by the age of 4 to 5 years. This ability comes naturally for most children but Children with ASD may never learn such skills. They need to be taught these skills. This is where drama therapy helps. Parents with young children are encouraged to try it. It is very effective at helping children with ASD improve self-confidence, work as a team and follow directions and instructions.

Article 47

One stock criticism of philosophers is their uselessness: they address useless matters or address useful matters in a way that is useless. One interesting specific variation is to criticize a philosopher for philosophically discussing matters of what might be. For example, a philosopher might discuss the ethics of modifying animals to possess human levels of intelligence. As another example, a philosopher might present an essay on the problem of personal identity as it relates to cybernetic replacement of the human body. In general terms, these speculative flights can be dismissed as doubly useless: not only do they have the standard uselessness of philosophy, they also have the uselessness of talking about what is not and might never be. Since I have, at length and elsewhere, addressed the general charge of uselessness against philosophy, I will focus on this specific sort of criticism.

One version of this sort of criticism can be seen as practical: since the shape of what might be cannot be known, philosophical discussions involve a double speculation: the first speculation is about what might be and the second is the usual philosophical speculation. While the exact mathematics of the speculation (is it additive or exponential?) is uncertain, it can be argued that such speculation about speculation has little value—and this assumes that philosophy has value and speculation about the future has value (both of which can be doubted).

This sort of criticism is often used as the foundation for a second sort of criticism. This criticism does assume that philosophy has value and it is this assumption that also provides a foundation for the criticism. The basic idea is that philosophical speculation about what might be uses up resources that could be used to

apply philosophy to existing problems. Naturally, someone who regards all philosophy as useless would regard philosophical discussion about what might be as being a waste of time—responding to this view would require a general defense of philosophy and this goes beyond the scope of this short essay. Now, to return to the matter at hand.

As an example, a discussion of the ethics of using autonomous, intelligent weapon systems in war could be criticized on the grounds that the discussion should have focused on the ethical problems regarding current warfare. After all, there is a multitude of unsolved moral problems in regards to existing warfare—there hardly seems any need to add more unsolved problems until either the existing problems are solved or the possible problems become actual problems.

This does have considerable appeal. To use an analogy, if a person has not completed the work in the course she is taking now, it does not make sense for her to spend her time trying to complete the work that might be assigned four semesters from now. To use another analogy, if a person has a hole in her roof, it would not be reasonable to spend time speculating about what sort of force-field roof technology they might have in the future. This is, of course, the classic "don't you have something better to do?" problem.

As might be suspected, this criticism rests on the principle that resources should be spent effectively and less effective uses of resources are subject to criticism. As the analogies given above show, using resources effectively is certainly reasonable and ineffective use can be justly criticized. However, there is an obvious concern with this principle: to be consistent in its application it would need to be applied across the board so that a person is applying all her resources with proper utility. For example, a person who prepares a fancy meal when she could be working on addressing the problems presented by poverty is wasting time. As another example, a person who is reading a book for enjoyment should be out addressing the threat posed by terrorist groups. As a third example, someone who is developing yet another likely-to-fail social media company should be spending her time addressing prison reform. And so on. In fact, for almost anything a person might be doing, there will be something better she could be doing.

As others have argued, this sort of maximization would be counterproductive: a person would exhaust herself and her resources, thus (ironically) doing more harm than good. As such, the "don't you have something better to do?" criticism should be used with due care. That said, it can be a fair criticism if a person really does have something better to do and what she is doing instead is detrimental enough to warrant correction.

In the case of philosophical discussions about what might be, it can almost always be argued that while a person could be doing something better (such as addressing current problems), such speculation would generally be harm free. That is, it is rather unlikely that the person would have solved the problem of war, poverty or crime if only she had not been writing about ethics and cyborgs. Of course, this just defends such discussion in the same way one might defend any other harmless amusement, such as playing a game of Scrabble or watching a sunset. It would be preferable to have a somewhat better defense of such philosophical discussions of the shape of things (that might be) to come.

A reasonable defense of such discussions can be based on the plausible notion that it is better to address a problem before it occurs than after it arrives in force. To use the classic analogy, it is much easier to address a rolling snowball than the avalanche that it will cause.

In the case of speculative matters that have ethical aspects, it seems that it would be generally useful to already have moral discussions in place ahead of time. This would provide the practical advantage of already having a framework and context in which to discuss the matter when (or if) it becomes a reality. One excellent illustration of this is the driverless car—it certainly seems to be a good idea to work out the

ethics of such matters of how the car should be programmed when it must "decide" what to hit and what to avoid when an accident is occurring. Another illustration is developing the moral guidelines for ever more sophisticated automated weapon systems. Since these are being developed at a rapid pace, what were once theoretical problems will soon be actual moral problems. As a final example, consider the moral concerns governing modifying and augmenting humans using technology and genetic modification. It would seem to be a good idea to have some moral guidance going into this brave new world rather than scrambling with the ethics after the fact.

Philosophers also like to discuss what might be in other contexts than ethics. Not surprisingly, the realm of what might be is rich ground for discussions of metaphysics and epistemology. While these fields are often considered the most useless aspects of philosophy, they have rather practical implications that matter—even (or even especially) in regards to speculation about what might be.

To illustrate this, consider the research being conducted in repairing, augmenting and preserving the human mind (or brain, if one prefers). One classic problem in metaphysics is the problem of personal identity: what is it to be a person, what is it to be distinct from all other things, and what is it to be that person across time? While this might seem to be a purely theoretical concern, it quickly becomes a very practical concern when one is discussing the above mentioned technology. For example, consider a company that offers a special sort of life insurance: they claim they can back-up a person to a storage system and, upon the death of the original body, restore the back-up to a cloned (or robotic) body. While the question of whether that restored backup would be you or not is clearly a metaphysical question of personal identity, it is also a very practical question. After all, paying to ensure that you survive your bodily death is a rather different matter from paying so that someone who thinks they are you can go to your house and have sex with your spouse after you are dead.

There are, of course, numerous other examples that can be used to illustrate the value of such speculation of what might be—in fact, I have already written many of these in previous posts. In light of the above discussion, it seems reasonable to accept that philosophical discussions about what might be need not be a waste of time. In fact, such discussions can be useful in a practical sense.

Article 48

"Which class are you in?"

"I am in Courage and she is Perseverance!" If the answer is unusual, it is because it comes from an unusual school!

Welcome to Mirambika, an alternative school located in and run by the Sri Aurobindo Ashram, New Delhi.

It is a widely prevalent feeling that the existing school education in our country, has innumerable drawbacks. The chief of these is that the Mainstream education does not have any high objectives, other than preparing the child for a lucrative career. During the process of learning, the child is meaninglessly burdened and deprived of the experience of creative joy and inner growth. This discontent spurred a group of thinkers and teachers to create an alternative form of education.

In 1981, Mirambika (Mira, from the name Mira Alfasa of the `Mother,' the disciple of Sri Aurobindo, and Ambika meaning "mother" in Sanskrit) was conceived, in an attempt to implement the educational agenda

of Sri Aurobindo and the Mother. It started with 57 children and today, after two decades it has managed to hold the number at under 150.

Sri Aurobindo felt `nothing can be taught'. His second principle was that, `the mind has to be consulted on its growth' and the third included, `work from the near to the far'. This signifies that early learning must be from all that the child can relate to before moving to abstract concepts. The main objective of education, he concluded should be only to develop the faculties for learning.

The atmosphere in the school is a proclamation of this ideology. The splendid architecture, its symmetry, openness, its harmony with nature are overwhelming. There is no school uniform. More importantly, there are no fixed classes for the children of the same age. In fact there are no typical classes from nursery to Std. X but just 12 groups called Red, Blue, Equality, Aspiration and others. The idea is that children should not be treated as objects of control in a hierarchical system of division and grading. There are no structured practices and the children engage in activities as they choose. Significantly though, this freedom does not degenerate into chaos. Instead, an alternative work culture has come to be where the children respect time and develop their own rhythm, without experiencing alienation from studies. Even very young children are seen to work on projects and bring out extensive material on the topic.

Getting admission into Mirambika is not easy. The school is very clear that the ethos of the family and that of the school have to be similar. For, if parents do not fully comprehend the true meaning of the alternative education, they are bound to create obstacles in the experimental pursuits.

Hence the aspiring parents are screened in two stages to make sure they are truly ready for the `risk' inherent in the alternative format. Leaving the atmosphere of this `dream' school, the big question that inevitably arises, is about how these children eventually adjust would to the `real' world. Parents and teachers concede that academically the children from Mirambika fare below their counterparts in the mainstream schools.

The school is not affiliated to any board and the children take up the National Open School Exam. This in effect, rules out the possibility of the children ever being able to compete with those from the mainstream in the entrance-exams to professional colleges. One sure gain from the experiment is that it has sparked the process of introspection among educationists and parents. This will in turn, surely bring about the much needed change and improvement in the present school scene.

Article 49

First came the atrocity, then came the vanity. The atrocity is what Jerry Sandusky has been accused of doing at Penn State. The vanity is the outraged reaction of a zillion commentators over the past week, whose indignation is based on the assumption that if they had been in Joe Paterno's shoes, or assistant coach Mike McQueary's shoes, they would have behaved better. They would have taken action and stopped any sexual assaults.

Unfortunately, none of us can safely make that assumption. Over the course of history — during the Holocaust, the Rwandan genocide or the street beatings that happen in American neighborhoods — the same pattern has emerged. Many people do not intervene. Very often they see but they don't see.

Some people simply can't process the horror in front of them. Some people suffer from what the psychologists call Normalcy Bias. When they find themselves in some unsettling circumstance, they shut down and pretend everything is normal.

Some people suffer from Motivated Blindness; they don't see what is not in their interest to see. Some people don't look at the things that make them uncomfortable. In one experiment, people were shown pictures, some of which contained sexual imagery. Machines tracked their eye movements. The people who were uncomfortable with sex never let their eyes dart over to the uncomfortable parts of the pictures.
As Daniel Goleman wrote in his book "Vital Lies, Simple Truths," "In order to avoid looking, some element of the mind must have known first what the picture contained, so that it knew what to avoid. The mind somehow grasps what is going on and rushes a protective filter into place, thus steering awareness away from what threatens."

Even in cases where people consciously register some offense, they still often don't intervene. In research done at Penn State and published in 1999, students were asked if they would make a stink if someone made a sexist remark in their presence. Half said yes. When researchers arranged for that to happen, only 16 percent protested.

In another experiment at a different school, 68 percent of students insisted they would refuse to answer if they were asked offensive questions during a job interview. But none actually objected when asked questions like, "Do you think it is appropriate for women to wear bras to work?"

So many people do nothing while witnessing ongoing crimes, psychologists have a name for it: the Bystander Effect. The more people are around to witness the crime, the less likely they are to intervene.

Online you can find videos of savage beatings, with dozens of people watching blandly. The Kitty Genovese case from the '60s is mostly apocryphal, but hundreds of other cases are not. A woman was recently murdered at a yoga clothing store in Maryland while employees at the Apple Store next door heard the disturbing noises but did not investigate. Ilan Halimi, a French Jew, was tortured for 24 days by 20 anti-Semitic kidnappers, with the full knowledge of neighbors. Nobody did anything, and Halimi eventually was murdered.

People are really good at self-deception. We attend to the facts we like and suppress the ones we don't. We inflate our own virtues and predict we will behave more nobly than we actually do. As Max H. Bazerman and Ann E. Tenbrunsel write in their book, "Blind Spots," "When it comes time to make a decision, our thoughts are dominated by thoughts of how we want to behave; thoughts of how we should behave disappear."

In centuries past, people built moral systems that acknowledged this weakness. These systems emphasized our sinfulness. They reminded people of the evil within themselves. Life was seen as an inner struggle against the selfish forces inside. These vocabularies made people aware of how their weaknesses manifested themselves and how to exercise discipline over them. These systems gave people categories with which to process savagery and scripts to follow when they confronted it. They helped people make moral judgments and hold people responsible amidst our frailties.

But we're not Puritans anymore. We live in a society oriented around our inner wonderfulness. So when something atrocious happens, people look for some artificial, outside force that must have caused it — like the culture of college football, or some other favorite bogey. People look for laws that can be changed so it never happens again.

Commentators ruthlessly vilify all involved from the island of their own innocence. Everyone gets to proudly ask: "How could they have let this happen?"

The proper question is: How can we ourselves overcome our natural tendency to evade and self-deceive. That was the proper question after Abu Ghraib, Madoff, the Wall Street follies and a thousand other scandals. But it's a question this society has a hard time asking because the most seductive evasion is the one that leads us to deny the underside of our own nature.

Article 50

On their own, sentences are implacably honest. They may be long, short, simple, complex, clear, ambiguous, even incoherent. But they don't try to hide those qualities. They are what they are and they say what they say. It's as plain as the words on their faces. The trouble is that most sentences have writers, a fact that readers are well aware of. That makes it hard to consider sentences entirely on their own. Other questions arise. What's she saying? What did he mean?

To these questions, I'd add another. Does the writer know what that sentence actually says? The answer is routinely no. After years of teaching creative writing, I still find this amazing. It means that, despite themselves, writers are often engaged in acts of unwitting self-contradiction.

Imagine how it works. A writer speaks the language, knows the vocabulary, and tries to honor the rules of grammar and syntax. Yet he regularly produces sentences of whose literal meaning he's completely unaware. In its own way, this is fantastic, like setting out to knit a cardigan, producing an armoire, and wondering why it's so loose in the shoulders.

Here's an example, written by a student several years ago: "I also had my father's thick fingers, fingers that I often hid underneath thighs." You see the problem of course. The author apparently hides his (or her) fingers under anyone's thighs, not just his (or her) own. This is what the sentence actually says, though not what the writer is hoping it says.

Here's another example: "Fixed-gear bikes are ridden exclusively on these tracks." This sentence is almost proud of its perfect ambiguity. It means one of two things: "People ride fixed-gear bikes only on these tracks" or "On these tracks people ride only fixed gear bikes." Both are statements about exclusivity, but one is about bikes, the other about tracks. The sentence as written offers no way to choose between them. It would be tempting to let the context make it clear if the context itself weren't so often ambiguous. Besides, context isn't for determining the literal meaning of a sentence. It's for helping us hear overtones and implications, allowing a writer to say more than what a sentence literally says.

Why didn't the writers catch these mistakes? Probably because they were looking at their intentions — what they meant to say — not the words they put on the page. The sentence, as written, was invisible to them. Readers also fail to catch such mistakes because they're good at guessing what the writer really means. It's not that they're under-reading — skipping past the problem in a sentence. They're nearly always over-reading, alive to the writer's intention, as if the writer were somehow immanent in the sentence, looking over the reader's shoulder, expecting the benefit of the doubt. We do this all the time in conversation. And so the sentence ceases to be a sentence — a verbal construct of a certain length, velocity

and rhythm with, at bottom, an unambiguous literal meaning. It becomes a sign instead that telepathic communication is about to commence.

For the writer — the maker of sentences —there's a contradiction here. You really are present, as present as it's possible to be in ink or pixels, in the sentences you make, no matter how plain they are. (Writers who feel they lack a certain style tend to forget this and burden the prose with markings of their own identity.)

Yet it's necessary to write as if your sentences will be orphaned, because they will be. When called to the stand in the court of meaning, your sentences will get no coaching from you. They'll say exactly what their words say, and if that makes you look ridiculous or confused, guess what?

Sentences are always literal, no matter how much some writers abhor the idea of being literal. In fact, nothing good can begin to happen in a writer's education until that sinks in. Your opinion of what your sentence means is always overruled by what your sentence literally says. A good reader may be good at following the leaps and bounds of your thinking but is also, always, reading literally, alive to the misdirection of ambiguous sentences.

This means you'll need to write, and revise, as if your intentions were invisible and your sentences will be doing all the talking, all on their own. This may be the hardest thing a writer has to learn. Looking at a sentence you've made is like looking at yourself in the shard of a mirror. A part of you has to be dreadfully literal-minded (and impervious to self-flattery) in order to do the work of making good, clear sentences. Seeing what your sentences actually say is never easy, but it gets easier with practice. There's even a certain pleasure in discovering the booby traps you've laid for yourself in your prose.

It's helpful to pretend you didn't write the sentence, but that's not enough (and self-deceit of that kind vanishes quickly). The trick is discovering a literal-mindedness in yourself and developing it until you can read with cunning. Try to practice reading your own sentences the way the reader does — with no advance knowledge of what they say. Be alert for ambiguities of every kind. Become a connoisseur of ambiguity. Sentences are wily and multifarious, secretive, mischievous. Language is inherently playful, eager to make nonsense and no-sense if it gets out of order. Inexperienced writers tend to trust that sentences will generally turn out all right — or all right enough. Experienced writers know that every good sentence is retrieved by will from the forces of chaos.

So don't be blinded by what you think you're saying. The sentence you make won't give you the benefit of the doubt, even though the reader may. And don't assume that the literal meaning of a sentence is the least important one. It's the only important one. Without the accuracy of being literal, there's nothing to build on. Even metaphors — the best ones anyway — are literal-minded. But that's a story for another day.

Article 51

The SEC's announcement on April 16 that it is bringing fraud charges against Goldman Sachs (NYSE: GS) has generated a server farm's worth of reporting, commentary, and chatter. However, the truth is that even if the SEC is able to establish that fraud occurred, that aspect of the case is actually a distraction from the broader issues at stake. Don't let the commotion over this case mislead you: Fraud was a minor element in the housing and credit bubble. The problem was not what was illegal, but rather what was sanctioned, and in some cases perpetrated by the government and regulators.

A single useful email

Of the emails that have been released by various parties since the SEC made its complaint public, I have found only one that demonstrates an awareness of the wider problems that led to this crisis. That email didn't originate at Goldman -- employees there had been soaking in the mortgage hot tub for years, so it no longer occurred to them to question whether or not the water was sanitary. Instead, the author was an executive at Paulson & Co., the hedge fund that bet against the infamous ABACUS 2007-AC1 collateralized debt obligation (CDO) and an outsider to the real estate securitization market. This is the available excerpt from this January 2007 email:

Exhibit 1: Paulson employee e-mail

It is true that the market is not pricing the subprime RMBS [residential mortgage-backed securities] wipeout scenario. In my opinion this situation is due to the fact that rating agencies, CDO managers and underwriters have all the incentives to keep the game going, while 'real money' investors have neither the analytical tools nor the institutional framework to take action before the losses that one could anticipate based [on] the 'news' available everywhere are actually realized.

In two sentences, this e-mail sums up the root of the credit crisis. The author is absolutely correct in his or her analysis of the exceptional mispricing that existed in subprime securities: Several key constituencies in the securitization market had enormous short-term incentives (primarily financial) to "keep the game going," rather than promote a well-functioning market.

At what price does an AAA rating come?

Credit rating agencies Moody's (NYSE: MCO) and Standard & Poor's (a unit of McGraw-Hill (NYSE: MHP)) -- a near duopoly -- were earnings fat fees for rating structured products and anointing them with the highly reassuring AAA rating. This line of business was substantially more profitable than their traditional bond rating activity.

The rating firms received those fees from the underwriters -- investment banks including Merrill Lynch (now part of Bank of America (NYSE: BAC)) or Citigroup (NYSE: C) -- who were selling the securities on to investors. Underwriters, who earn fees on a transaction basis, had the same incentive to keep "dancing" (to borrow the immortal expression of Citi's former CEO, Charles Prince). More and bigger transactions produce more fees and larger year-end bonuses for the individuals involved -- the Pied Piper himself couldn't have played a more captivating tune.

An unnamed culprit

As lucid as the Paulson & Co. email is, it does contain a glaring omission, for there was another major culprit in the historic misallocation of capital towards the housing market: The government, acting principally through government-sponsored entities (GSEs) Fannie Mae (NYSE: FNM) and Freddie Mac (NYSE: FRE).

Despite being shareholder-owned companies, the GSEs were policy instruments of elected officials who wanted to promote homeownership at all costs, without regard to the consequences. It is no exaggeration to say that "privatizing profits and socializing losses" is a full description of Fannie and Freddie's business model.

Institutional investors failed, too

Investors could have offered a counterweight to these forces and their skewed incentives by refusing to buy toxic securities at inflated prices. Alas, as the e-mail suggests, they lacked the "analytical tools" to do so. That's a euphemistic way of saying they were incapable of valuing the securities they were purchasing, which is how they came to outsource part of their due diligence to a dysfunctional agent, the credit rating firms.

mbaguru
LEADER IN ADAPTIVE PREPARATION FOR CAT

Who's left?
I am in no way opposed to financial speculation, but when the only people left to inject some sense of rational pricing are purely speculative interests (i.e., hedge funds such as Paulson & Co.), you don't have a functioning market. You can't fault a speculator for speculating; it is the other participants that failed to fulfill their roles.

To fix a problem, make sure you understand it first
When lawmakers and regulators try to solve a complex problem, I'm always careful to set my expectations exceptionally low with regard to the result (the problem is -- yet again -- one of incentives). As it is, the folks in Washington don't look ready to surprise me. Instead of grandstanding with Goldman executives, whose primary motivation is to shift blame away from themselves, perhaps lawmakers should spend more time talking to people who proved that they understood the dysfunctions within the real estate finance market.

Between high valuations and slow growth, investors should expect disappointing returns from U.S. stocks over the next several years. Tim Hanson explains how to make more in 2010.

Something big just happened
I don't know about you, but I always pay attention when one of the best growth investors in the world gives me a stock tip. Motley Fool co-founder David Gardner and his brother, Motley Fool CEO Tom Gardner, just revealed two brand new stock recommendations. Together, they've tripled the stock market's return over the last 13 years.* And while timing isn't everything, the history of Tom and David's stock picks shows that it pays to get in early on their ideas.

Article 52

What does a life of total dedication to the truth mean? It means, first of all, a life of continuous and never-ending stringent self-examination. We know the world only through our relationship to it. Therefore, to know the world, we must not only examine it but we must simultaneously examine the examiner. Psychiatrists are taught this in their training and know that it is impossible to realistically understand the conflicts and transferences of their patients without understanding their own transferences and conflicts. For this reason psychiatrists are encouraged to receive their own psychotherapy or psychoanalysis as part of their training and development. Unfortunately, not all psychiatrists respond to this encouragement. There are many, psychiatrists among them, who stringently examine the world but not so stringently examine themselves. They may be competent individuals as the world judges competence, but they are never wise. The life of wisdom must be a life of contemplation combined with action. In the past in American culture, contemplation has not been held in high regard. In the 1950s people labeled Adlai Stevenson an "egghead" and believed he would not make a good President precisely because he was a contemplative man, given to deep thinking and self-doubts. I have heard parents tell their adolescent children in all seriousness, "You think too much." What an absurdity this is, given the fact that it is our frontal lobes, our capacity to think and to examine ourselves that most makes us human. Fortunately, such attitudes seem to be changing, and we are beginning to realize that the sources of danger to the world lie more within us than outside, and that the process of constant self-examination and contemplation is essential for ultimate survival. Still, I am talking of relatively small numbers of people who are changing their attitudes. Examination of the world without is never as personally painful as examination of the world within, and it is certainly because of the pain involved in a life of genuine self-examination that the majority steer away from it. Yet when one is

dedicated to the truth this pain seems relatively unimportant-and less and less important (and therefore less and less painful) the farther one proceeds on the path of self-examination.

Article 53

Not long after Steve Jobs got married, in 1991, he moved with his wife to a nineteen-thirties, Cotswolds-style house in old Palo Alto. Jobs always found it difficult to furnish the places where he lived. His previous house had only a mattress, a table, and chairs. He needed things to be perfect, and it took time to figure out what perfect was. This time, he had a wife and family in tow, but it made little difference. "We spoke about furniture in theory for eight years," his wife, Laurene Powell, tells Walter Isaacson, in "Steve Jobs," Isaacson's enthralling new biography of the Apple founder. "We spent a lot of time asking ourselves, 'What is the purpose of a sofa?' "

It was the choice of a washing machine, however, that proved most vexing. European washing machines, Jobs discovered, used less detergent and less water than their American counterparts, and were easier on the clothes. But they took twice as long to complete a washing cycle. What should the family do? As Jobs explained, "We spent some time in our family talking about what's the trade-off we want to make. We ended up talking a lot about design, but also about the values of our family. Did we care most about getting our wash done in an hour versus an hour and a half? Or did we care most about our clothes feeling really soft and lasting longer? Did we care about using a quarter of the water? We spent about two weeks talking about this every night at the dinner table."

Steve Jobs, Isaacson's biography makes clear, was a complicated and exhausting man. "There are parts of his life and personality that are extremely messy, and that's the truth," Powell tells Isaacson. "You shouldn't whitewash it." Isaacson, to his credit, does not. He talks to everyone in Jobs's career, meticulously recording conversations and encounters dating back twenty and thirty years. Jobs, we learn, was a bully. "He had the uncanny capacity to know exactly what your weak point is, know what will make you feel small, to make you cringe," a friend of his tells Isaacson. Jobs gets his girlfriend pregnant, and then denies that the child is his. He parks in handicapped spaces. He screams at subordinates. He cries like a small child when he does not get his way. He gets stopped for driving a hundred miles an hour, honks angrily at the officer for taking too long to write up the ticket, and then resumes his journey at a hundred miles an hour. He sits in a restaurant and sends his food back three times. He arrives at his hotel suite in New York for press interviews and decides, at 10 p.m., that the piano needs to be repositioned, the strawberries are inadequate, and the flowers are all wrong: he wanted calla lilies. (When his public-relations assistant returns, at midnight, with the right flowers, he tells her that her suit is "disgusting.") "Machines and robots were painted and repainted as he compulsively revised his color scheme," Isaacson writes, of the factory Jobs built, after founding NeXT, in the late nineteen-eighties. "The walls were museum white, as they had been at the Macintosh factory, and there were $20,000 black leather chairs and a custom-made staircase. . . . He insisted that the machinery on the 165-foot assembly line be configured to move the circuit boards from right to left as they got built, so that the process would look better to visitors who watched from the viewing gallery."

Isaacson begins with Jobs's humble origins in Silicon Valley, the early triumph at Apple, and the humiliating ouster from the firm he created. He then charts the even greater triumphs at Pixar and at a resurgent Apple, when Jobs returns, in the late nineteen-nineties, and our natural expectation is that Jobs will emerge wiser and gentler from his tumultuous journey. He never does. In the hospital at the end of his

life, he runs through sixty-seven nurses before he finds three he likes. "At one point, the pulmonologist tried to put a mask over his face when he was deeply sedated," Isaacson writes:

Jobs ripped it off and mumbled that he hated the design and refused to wear it. Though barely able to speak, he ordered them to bring five different options for the mask and he would pick a design he liked. . . . He also hated the oxygen monitor they put on his finger. He told them it was ugly and too complex.

One of the great puzzles of the industrial revolution is why it began in England. Why not France, or Germany? Many reasons have been offered. Britain had plentiful supplies of coal, for instance. It had a good patent system in place. It had relatively high labor costs, which encouraged the search for labor-saving innovations. In an article published earlier this year, however, the economists Ralf Meisenzahl and Joel Mokyr focus on a different explanation: the role of Britain's human-capital advantage—in particular, on a group they call "tweakers." They believe that Britain dominated the industrial revolution because it had a far larger population of skilled engineers and artisans than its competitors: resourceful and creative men who took the signature inventions of the industrial age and tweaked them—refined and perfected them, and made them work.

In 1779, Samuel Crompton, a retiring genius from Lancashire, invented the spinning mule, which made possible the mechanization of cotton manufacture. Yet England's real advantage was that it had Henry Stones, of Horwich, who added metal rollers to the mule; and James Hargreaves, of Tottington, who figured out how to smooth the acceleration and deceleration of the spinning wheel; and William Kelly, of Glasgow, who worked out how to add water power to the draw stroke; and John Kennedy, of Manchester, who adapted the wheel to turn out fine counts; and, finally, Richard Roberts, also of Manchester, a master of precision machine tooling—and the tweaker's tweaker. He created the "automatic" spinning mule: an exacting, high-speed, reliable rethinking of Crompton's original creation. Such men, the economists argue, provided the "micro inventions necessary to make macro inventions highly productive and remunerative."

Was Steve Jobs a Samuel Crompton or was he a Richard Roberts? In the eulogies that followed Jobs's death, last month, he was repeatedly referred to as a large-scale visionary and inventor. But Isaacson's biography suggests that he was much more of a tweaker. He borrowed the characteristic features of the Macintosh—the mouse and the icons on the screen—from the engineers at Xerox parc, after his famous visit there, in 1979. The first portable digital music players came out in 1996. Apple introduced the iPod, in 2001, because Jobs looked at the existing music players on the market and concluded that they "truly sucked." Smart phones started coming out in the nineteen-nineties. Jobs introduced the iPhone in 2007, more than a decade later, because, Isaacson writes, "he had noticed something odd about the cell phones on the market: They all stank, just like portable music players used to." The idea for the iPad came from an engineer at Microsoft, who was married to a friend of the Jobs family, and who invited Jobs to his fiftieth-birthday party. As Jobs tells Isaacson:

This guy badgered me about how Microsoft was going to completely change the world with this tablet PC software and eliminate all notebook computers, and Apple ought to license his Microsoft software. But he was doing the device all wrong. It had a stylus. As soon as you have a stylus, you're dead. This dinner was like the tenth time he talked to me about it, and I was so sick of it that I came home and said, "Fuck this, let's show him what a tablet can really be."

Even within Apple, Jobs was known for taking credit for others' ideas. Jonathan Ive, the designer behind the iMac, the iPod, and the iPhone, tells Isaacson, "He will go through a process of looking at my ideas and say, 'That's no good. That's not very good. I like that one.' And later I will be sitting in the audience and he will be talking about it as if it was his idea."

Jobs's sensibility was editorial, not inventive. His gift lay in taking what was in front of him—the tablet with stylus—and ruthlessly refining it. After looking at the first commercials for the iPad, he tracked down the copywriter, James Vincent, and told him, "Your commercials suck."

"Well, what do you want?" Vincent shot back. "You've not been able to tell me what you want."

"I don't know," Jobs said. "You have to bring me something new. Nothing you've shown me is even close."

Vincent argued back and suddenly Jobs went ballistic. "He just started screaming at me," Vincent recalled. Vincent could be volatile himself, and the volleys escalated.

When Vincent shouted, "You've got to tell me what you want," Jobs shot back, "You've got to show me some stuff, and I'll know it when I see it."

I'll know it when I see it. That was Jobs's credo, and until he saw it his perfectionism kept him on edge. He looked at the title bars—the headers that run across the top of windows and documents—that his team of software developers had designed for the original Macintosh and decided he didn't like them. He forced the developers to do another version, and then another, about twenty iterations in all, insisting on one tiny tweak after another, and when the developers protested that they had better things to do he shouted, "Can you imagine looking at that every day? It's not just a little thing. It's something we have to do right."

The famous Apple "Think Different" campaign came from Jobs's advertising team at TBWAChiatDay. But it was Jobs who agonized over the slogan until it was right:

They debated the grammatical issue: If "different" was supposed to modify the verb "think," it should be an adverb, as in "think differently." But Jobs insisted that he wanted "different" to be used as a noun, as in "think victory" or "think beauty." Also, it echoed colloquial use, as in "think big." Jobs later explained, "We discussed whether it was correct before we ran it. It's grammatical, if you think about what we're trying to say. It's not think the same, it's think different. Think a little different, think a lot different, think different. 'Think differently' wouldn't hit the meaning for me."

The point of Meisenzahl and Mokyr's argument is that this sort of tweaking is essential to progress. James Watt invented the modern steam engine, doubling the efficiency of the engines that had come before. But when the tweakers took over the efficiency of the steam engine swiftly quadrupled. Samuel Crompton was responsible for what Meisenzahl and Mokyr call "arguably the most productive invention" of the industrial revolution. But the key moment, in the history of the mule, came a few years later, when there was a strike of cotton workers. The mill owners were looking for a way to replace the workers with unskilled labor, and needed an automatic mule, which did not need to be controlled by the spinner. Who solved the problem? Not Crompton, an unambitious man who regretted only that public interest would not leave him to his seclusion, so that he might "earn undisturbed the fruits of his ingenuity and perseverance." It was the tweaker's tweaker, Richard Roberts, who saved the day, producing a prototype, in 1825, and then an even better solution in 1830. Before long, the number of spindles on a typical mule jumped from four hundred to a thousand. The visionary starts with a clean sheet of paper, and re-imagines the world. The tweaker inherits things as they are, and has to push and pull them toward some more nearly perfect solution. That is not a lesser task.

Jobs's friend Larry Ellison, the founder of Oracle, had a private jet, and he designed its interior with a great deal of care. One day, Jobs decided that he wanted a private jet, too. He studied what Ellison had done. Then he set about to reproduce his friend's design in its entirety—the same jet, the same reconfiguration,

the same doors between the cabins. Actually, not in its entirety. Ellison's jet "had a door between cabins with an open button and a close button," Isaacson writes. "Jobs insisted that his have a single button that toggled. He didn't like the polished stainless steel of the buttons, so he had them replaced with brushed metal ones." Having hired Ellison's designer, "pretty soon he was driving her crazy." Of course he was. The great accomplishment of Jobs's life is how effectively he put his idiosyncrasies—his petulance, his narcissism, and his rudeness—in the service of perfection. "I look at his airplane and mine," Ellison says, "and everything he changed was better."

The angriest Isaacson ever saw Steve Jobs was when the wave of Android phones appeared, running the operating system developed by Google. Jobs saw the Android handsets, with their touchscreens and their icons, as a copy of the iPhone. He decided to sue. As he tells Isaacson:

Our lawsuit is saying, "Google, you fucking ripped off the iPhone, wholesale ripped us off." Grand theft. I will spend my last dying breath if I need to, and I will spend every penny of Apple's $40 billion in the bank, to right this wrong. I'm going to destroy Android, because it's a stolen product. I'm willing to go to thermonuclear war on this. They are scared to death, because they know they are guilty. Outside of Search, Google's products—Android, Google Docs—are shit.

In the nineteen-eighties, Jobs reacted the same way when Microsoft came out with Windows. It used the same graphical user interface—icons and mouse—as the Macintosh. Jobs was outraged and summoned Gates from Seattle to Apple's Silicon Valley headquarters. "They met in Jobs's conference room, where Gates found himself surrounded by ten Apple employees who were eager to watch their boss assail him," Isaacson writes. "Jobs didn't disappoint his troops. 'You're ripping us off!' he shouted. 'I trusted you, and now you're stealing from us!' "

Gates looked back at Jobs calmly. Everyone knew where the windows and the icons came from. "Well, Steve," Gates responded. "I think there's more than one way of looking at it. I think it's more like we both had this rich neighbor named Xerox and I broke into his house to steal the TV set and found out that you had already stolen it."

Jobs was someone who took other people's ideas and changed them. But he did not like it when the same thing was done to him. In his mind, what he did was special. Jobs persuaded the head of Pepsi-Cola, John Sculley, to join Apple as C.E.O., in 1983, by asking him, "Do you want to spend the rest of your life selling sugared water, or do you want a chance to change the world?" When Jobs approached Isaacson to write his biography, Isaacson first thought ("half jokingly") that Jobs had noticed that his two previous books were on Benjamin Franklin and Albert Einstein, and that he "saw himself as the natural successor in that sequence." The architecture of Apple software was always closed. Jobs did not want the iPhone and the iPod and the iPad to be opened up and fiddled with, because in his eyes they were perfect. The greatest tweaker of his generation did not care to be tweaked.

Perhaps this is why Bill Gates—of all Jobs's contemporaries—gave him fits. Gates resisted the romance of perfectionism. Time and again, Isaacson repeatedly asks Jobs about Gates and Jobs cannot resist the gratuitous dig. "Bill is basically unimaginative," Jobs tells Isaacson, "and has never invented anything, which I think is why he's more comfortable now in philanthropy than technology. He just shamelessly ripped off other people's ideas."

After close to six hundred pages, the reader will recognize this as vintage Jobs: equal parts insightful, vicious, and delusional. It's true that Gates is now more interested in trying to eradicate malaria than in overseeing the next iteration of Word. But this is not evidence of a lack of imagination. Philanthropy on the scale that Gates practices it represents imagination at its grandest. In contrast, Jobs's vision, brilliant and

perfect as it was, was narrow. He was a tweaker to the last, endlessly refining the same territory he had claimed as a young man.

As his life wound down, and cancer claimed his body, his great passion was designing Apple's new, three-million-square-foot headquarters, in Cupertino. Jobs threw himself into the details. "Over and over he would come up with new concepts, sometimes entirely new shapes, and make them restart and provide more alternatives," Isaacson writes. He was obsessed with glass, expanding on what he learned from the big panes in the Apple retail stores. "There would not be a straight piece of glass in the building," Isaacson writes. "All would be curved and seamlessly joined. . . . The planned center courtyard was eight hundred feet across (more than three typical city blocks, or almost the length of three football fields), and he showed it to me with overlays indicating how it could surround St. Peter's Square in Rome." The architects wanted the windows to open. Jobs said no. He "had never liked the idea of people being able to open things. 'That would just allow people to screw things up.'

Article 54

DNA methylation—changes to the activity of a DNA segment without changing the sequence—may be a rich source of raw material for natural selection, say the authors of a new study that analyzed DNA methylation, genotype, and gene expression data from five diverse human populations. They found that population-wide epigenetic changes happen much faster than changes in the DNA sequence.

The epigenome is at the interface between the genome and the environment, so studying it offers clues about different ways in which human populations respond to their surroundings, says Lluis Quintana-Murci, a human evolutionary geneticist at the Pasteur Institute in Paris who was not involved in the study. One way to adapt is through DNA sequence variation, which can be the substrate of natural selection. For instance, a mutation conferring increased resistance to malaria can increase in frequency in a given population through positive selection. But populations can respond, or possibly adapt, to environmental challenges through DNA methylation variation, too. When DNA methylation variation is under genetic control, it can be passed on through generations and participate in human adaptation, says Murci.

Research on global patterns of epigenetic diversity can be challenging to conduct, study coauthor Hunter Fraser, a geneticist at Stanford University, explains by email. For example, although scientists know that epigenetic variation plays a key role in regulating transcription, they still do not know which specific regions of the genome are involved for any given gene, and they don't know the consequences of altering epigenetic marks such as DNA methylation, he says.

The team wanted to determine how epigenetic diversity relates to patterns of variation in DNA and gene expression at a global scale. So Fraser and colleagues looked at genetic and epigenetic data, specifically, DNA methylation at CpG sites—regions of DNA where a cytosine nucleotide occurs next to a guanine—from individuals representing five populations: six Siberian Yakuts, seven Cambodians, seven Pakistani Pathans, seven Algerian Mozabites, and seven Mexican Mayans. These are highly distinct groups, which helped the team associate epigenetic patterns to genetic and transcriptional profiles, says HolgerHeyn of the Centre Nacionald'AnàlisiGenòmica in Barcelona who was not part of the research.

The results revealed a strong link between population-specific DNA methylation, mRNA levels, and genotypes. However, the CpG sites where methylation occurred that had the highest degree of population

specificity were more strongly associated with a local variation in a single nucleotide (SNP) compared with the association of mRNA levels with local SNPs. Population-specific DNA methylation patterns are therefore explained better by local genetic variants than population-specific expression levels, the team says.

Because the DNA methylation variation appears to be under genetic control, it could greatly affect human adaptability. Fraser notes, however, that the consequences of methylation still aren't clear. "It is likely that most of the variation we measured is not having any important impact, so the challenge is to figure out which genomic regions are important and how their DNA methylation impacts human traits," he says.

To answer that question and others about epigenetic diversity, researchers will need to better understand how populations with shared environments yet different genetic backgrounds behave in terms of DNA methylation variation. They will also need to examine populations with similar genetic backgrounds but exposed to very different environments, Quintana-Murci says, adding that there's "lots of work to be done." As Heyn points out, "we still do not fully understand the mechanisms that drive epigenetic variation in populations."

Article 55

It seems to be raining lawyers for the Delhi gang-rape accused. Three lawyers have told reporters on Thursday that they will be representing four of the five accused in the case.

ML Sharma, a Supreme Court lawyer, told media persons that he will be representing Mukesh, brother of main accused, Ram Singh.

Explaining how he became involved in the case, he said, "I have been interested in this case from the very first day. About eight days ago, I got a call from an unknown person and he said 'Baccho ko bachao' (save the boys). However, I remained undecided. And it was on January 7 (on the day accused where to be produced before the court), I decided to take up their case."

Incidentally, Sharma was at the receiving end of the commotion in the courtroom on Monday (7 January) when lawyers from Saket Court began to shout at him for coming forward to defend the accused. The Saket Bar Association had passed a resolution not defend accused. On the same day, the magistrate passed an order directing all hearings in the case to be held in-camera and ordered that any reporting or publishing of information relating to the legal proceedings in the case without permission of the court would be unlawful.

Asked if he had received any threats since, Sharma said: "You saw what happened on that day in court. I got some threatening calls. But it has stopped. The anger against me is over. Now every advocate wants to appear for the accused."

Sharma, a member of the Maharashtra Bar Council, says he has been practicing in the Supreme Court since 1990. Asked about some of the cases he has fought, Sharma mentions the PIL enquiring into the assets of former Chief Justice of India (CJI) KG Balakrishnan and another PIL in the Vodafone tax case that claimed that the then sitting CJI SH Kapadia had a conflict of interest in the case.

Not only did the apex court dismiss Sharma's petition in the Vodafone PIL but also fined him Rs 50,000 for it.

Another Supreme Court lawyer, AP Singh told reporters that he was representing two of the accused — Akshay Thakur and Vinay Sharma. Recounting how he came to be involved in the case, Singh said: "The family members of both the accused — Akshay Kumar and Vinay Sharma - met us. This was on 5-6 January. But at the time of the first meeting, I refused to take their case because it was a highlighted case and a number of public persons were protesting against it. The family member of accused contacted my mother again on 6-7 January. And it is not possible for me refuse the order of my mother."

As per Singh's visiting card, he is the All India General Secretary of the Bharatiya Sampurn Krantikari Party and has an office in Hong Kong.

The loudest of the three lawyers is VK Anand, who had created a ruckus in the courtroom on Monday after getting into a heated argument with another lawyer. Anand told reporters that he was representing the main accused Ram Singh.

The advocates told reporters that the next hearing in the case will be on 14 January.

The chargesheet in the gangrape case, where 23-year-old student and her friend were brutally assaulted in moving bus on December 16, was filed by the Delhi Police on 4 January. The victim succumbed to injuries on 29 December.

Five of the six accused have been charged with multiple offences including murder, attempt to murder, gang-rape, kidnapping, criminal conspiracy, dacoity, dacoity with murder and unnatural sexual offences. The sixth victim was identified by Delhi Police as a minor and will be tried by the juvenile justice board.

Article 56

As women who came of age in the campuses of the Sixties, many of us avidly read the first ever (1974) national report on the state of India's women, Towards Equality, cover to cover. It revealed, in no uncertain terms, that the rural agricultural sector was the biggest employer in India. However, unlike male farmers and cultivators, their female counterparts remained doubly burdened during their peak productive period with their reproductive role seen as fundamental to their gender while the duties it entailed were socially created.

Cut to the the 21st century. The latest census figures list only 32.8 per cent women formally as primary workers in the agricultural sector, in contrast to 81.1 per cent men. But the undeniable fact remains that India's agricultural industry, which employs 80 to 100 million women, cannot survive without their labour. From preparing the land, selecting seeds, preparing and sowing to transplanting the seedlings, applying manure/fertilisers/pesticides and then harvesting, winnowing and threshing, women work harder and longer than male farmers.

Maintaining the ancillary branches in this sector, like animal husbandry, fisheries and vegetable cultivation, depends almost solely on women. So where are these women while the male farmers and their kakas furiously debate the future of farming, loans, subsidies and irrigation matters? Men get more than their

share of visibility on TV, in governmental publicity material and within the banking sectors but millions of women farmers have no spokesperson from their ranks.

The primary reason for this is that they are usually not listed as primary earners and owners of land assets within their families. So getting loans, participating in mandipanchayats, assessing and deciding the crop patterns, liaising with the district officials, bank managers and political representatives and bargaining for MSPs (minimum support prices), loans and subsidies, remain male activities.
Over the last decade, as farming became less and less profitable and small and marginal farmers began migrating to cities, rural jobs for full-time women daily-wage labourers (those who do not own land but work at least 183 days in a year in someone's farm) in the agricultural sector have shrunk alarmingly. The Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employee Guarantee Act, that employed many of them in the interim period, has been curtailed sharply by the government that proclaims "sabkasaathsabkavikas" as its basic mantra. According to a recent study by the Evidence for Policy Design at Harvard University's Kennedy School, there has been a drop of almost 11 per cent in women's participation in the workforce.

When confronted with these facts, the usual laconic response has been: "Most of our educated young women do not wish to work in farms. They can now be teachers, nurses, Ashadidis". If only it were so. The same study also reveals that with so many well-educated men also competing for these white collar jobs, rural girls in urban homes, armed with a mere school certificate cannot find jobs. They must also have a college degree. So the vast sea of farmers' faces on our TV sets shows no female leaders. If they appear, they do so as sobbing widows and mothers of farmers who killed themselves or were killed by police bullets.

At a time when fundamentalism and neo-fascism are on the rise and unfettered consumerism and trade treaties are eroding old communities and threatening the environment, when measures like the ban on animal slaughter are impacting the dairy industry and destroying jobs, diseases due to the contamination of earth and water are erupting everywhere can we afford to sustain gender barriers between human beings unquestioningly? When not just the politicians and media persons but also the farmers regard the impoverished sea of women farmers as a faceless void, they deny them their humanity while diminishing their own.

Article 57

There is this funny story about the "Cobra Effect" based on an anecdote from British colonial time in Delhi. Apparently, the officials of the British government were terrified by a large number of venomous cobra snakes in the city. To solve the problem, someone came up with a brilliant idea of an exchange offer to the people of Delhi. Money for dead cobras. Guess what happened next? Soon, the enterprising Delhiites were breeding cobras. When the government found out, they scrapped the bounty scheme, whereupon the cobra breeders set the snakes free. And the cobra population went up, not down.

A similar incident occurred in Hanoi under the French colonial rule. There were too many rats, so the rulers introduced a bounty scheme for, of all things, rat tails. Pretty soon, Hanoi was full of tail-less rats running around. The bounty hunters never killed them. Instead, they just severed their tails, released them back into the sewers, so that they could continue to procreate and make more rats, which of course, increased the rat catchers' income. Why did both situations backfire? Because well-intentioned people who created the bounty

Charlie Munger complains that: Too little attention [is given] in economics to second order and even higher order effects. This defect is quite understandable, because the consequences have consequences, and the consequences of the consequences have consequences, and so on. It gets very complicated. It's fascinating to observe how this problem keeps on repeating over and over again. One variant is called "you get what you measure." For instance, if hospitals are asked to publish their mortality rate, the ones with the highest mortality rates are incentivised to turn away terminally ill patients. If someone is paid on a cost-plus basis (e.g. for generating electricity), you can be confident that there will be plenty of gaming in the form of cost padding. Businesses which pay their managers to deliver strong near-term earnings also create incentives for those managers to cut corners which increase near-term earnings (for example by cutting expenditures on brand building, research and development, and employee training) but destroy long-term value. Another variant of this issue is something I learnt from the famous investor Jim Rogers who, in one of his books wrote that you (i.e. a regulator) can either control the price of a product or a service, or its supply, but you can't do both. Back in the days of industrial licensing, the government wanted to fix both the maximum production of Bajaj Auto BSE 0.02 % scooters in a year and their maximum price. It failed to do both. Limiting production well below actual demand simply caused a black market to emerge and lucky allottees would simply sell their allotment letters at several times the maximum price allowed to be charged by the government. The US government spends tens of billions of dollars every year to stop addictive drugs from reaching its populace. Its prisons are full of drug dealers and drug addicts. All that money spent does nothing but increase the price of drugs and profit margin for those folks, who have an incentive to smuggle it across the US border. No matter how risky the US government makes it for smugglers and drug dealers to do whatever they do, the addicts can still buy the drugs. The more they try to stop it, the more they fail. In the meantime, tens of billions of dollars spent every year could have been spent on finding a solution for malaria. Also, in the meantime, in another country — the Netherlands — where drugs are legal, crime rates are so low that the government is shutting down prisons. Back in India, they price of urea so low that it gets smuggled across the borders to Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal and sold at much higher prices. Recently, the Indian government put a cap on the price of stents used in heart surgery — even for private, for-profit hospitals. Soon after the price controls were announced, some manufacturers announced their intention to withdraw their stents from the market. So In 1975, American economist Steven Peltzman studied the impact of seatbelt laws on automobile death rate. What he found was quite revealing. While the use of seatbelts made people safer inside the car, it also made people drive more rashly. As a result, there were more accidents causing more fatalities outside the cars. The two effects cancelled each other and there was no overall reduction in the number of automobile deaths. This effect, called the Peltzman effect, has wider applications. Basically, the idea is that whenever the government tries to regulate something, there will be an incentive for people to game the system. And gaming systems comes as naturally to some people as breathing. We all remember what happened during the hours after our PM appeared on TV on the night of November 8, 2016, don't we? One of the key elements of a good system design, therefore, is to avoid creating incentives to game it as much as possible. People who design systems should always ask a critically important question: "And then what?" to make them think of ways in which people will game them. This particular idea — of asking "and then what?" applies not just to regulators. It applies to everyone, including investors. As Warren Buffett writes: The key thing in economics, whenever someone makes an assertion to you, is to always ask, "And then what?" Actually, it's not such a bad idea to ask it about everything but you should always ask, "And then what?" Indeed, some of the best investment ideas occur when a great business encounters a problem which causes a temporary blip in its earnings growth but is perceived by the market as a significant-negative news. The loss of a customer which does not destroy the business. A flood. A fire. A strike. A few bad quarters caused by temporary factors — my current favourites are demonitisation and GST — which have absolutely no bearing on the business's bond with the customer and its ability to deliver profitable growth over the long term. The market is a pari-mutuel system wherein one is not betting against the house, but is betting against other investors. In such a system, the behaviour of others changes the odds. If temporary bad news causes stock prices to decline much more than they should, smart investors see that as an opportunity. Paradoxically, bad news for a business can be great news for an

investor, because it gives him a rare chance to buy at a fabulous price. Such an investor does not panic and run for the exit at the first time of trouble. He pauses. He reflects while others panic and sell. He quietens his mind so as to avoid jumping to hasty conclusions. He carefully studies the "bad" news. He notes the drop in price. And once in a while, his analysis shows that the market's reaction is overdone and he buys into a wonderful business at a bargain price. Thinking about first order effects is easy. Thinking about second or higher order effects is hard. But just because it's harder, doesn't mean one shouldn't do it. Indeed, the practice of routinely thinking about second and higher order effects by asking "and then what?" should not be limited to chess players and regulators. It should be adopted by investors as well.

Article 58

This year, the world's largest democracy, India, and the biggest country by area, Russia, are celebrating the 70th anniversary of establishment of diplomatic relations between them. Russia continues to be among India's major politico-diplomatic and defence partner nations. While India has inked separate strategic partnership pacts with more than two dozen countries, the Indian and Russian governments in December 2010 elevated their bilateral 'Strategic Partnership' to what they termed a "Special and Privileged Strategic Partnership."

The New Delhi-based think tank 'Foundation for National Security Research', which did a comparative assessment of India's strategic partnerships — meaning, 'political-diplomatic, defence and economic cooperation' (during the 10-year period prior to November 2011), had said, "Russia emerges as the most important strategic partner of India (followed by the U.S., France, the U.K., Germany and Japan in that order)." The November 2011 report had found that Russia had provided strong political and diplomatic support to India and helped enormously in building India's defence capability. However, it warned that the "economic content of the (India-Russia) partnership is extremely weak," and recommended that "urgent and vigorous steps need to be taken to improve economic relations if this (India-Russia) partnership is to be sustained and made durable."

New Delhi and Moscow are renewing efforts to bolster their seven-decade-old relationship regardless of the perception of India's increasing closeness to the U.S., Russia's growing friendship with China and even with Pakistan especially in the context of defence and strategic partnership, as well as criticism that India and Russia are neglecting the glory of their past ties due to their preoccupation with other parts of the world. In June this year, Indian Prime Minister NarendraModi is slated to take part as the Chief Guest in the St. Petersburg International Economic Forum — also known as the 'Russian Davos' after the World Economic Forum, which is an international organisation whose flagship annual meeting is held in Davos, Switzerland.

Until 1990-91, India and Russia — the main constituent of (the erstwhile) Soviet Union — had enjoyed robust trade ties. In 1990, the Soviet Union was India's top goods exports destination with shipments to the tune of $2.9 billion, according to data from the World Integrated Trade Solution (WITS) software. In the list of nations from where India imported goods, Soviet Union figured seventh in value terms with $922 million. Then in 1991, two watershed moments happened — economic liberalisation was introduced in India, and the Soviet Union was dissolved. In the following two-and-a-half decades, Russia remained India's strong politico-diplomatic and defence partner like the erstwhile Soviet Union used to be. However, since 1990-91, India's trade underwent further diversification and Russia is now not anywhere near the top in the list of India's trade partners. WITS data showed that in 2015, India exported goods worth $1.6 billion

to Russia, but had shipped more items in value terms to 37 other countries. In 2015, India's imports from Russia were valued at $4.5 billion, but had imported goods worth more than that from 23 other nations.

This slippage in trade is a huge demotion for Russia, considering that the erstwhile Soviet Union was among India's leading trade partners. Worse still, India's goods exports in 2015 to Russia were worth just $1.6 billion as against $40.3 billion during that year to the U.S. — which was India's leading export destination. Also, in 2015, India's goods imports from Russia were worth only $4.5 billion as against $61.6 billion from China — which was India's leading source of imports that year.

If one takes into account India's GDP of about $2 trillion and Russia's GDP of $1.3 trillion, it becomes clear that their bilateral trade and investment ties are far below potential. Pointing out that India-Russia trade in 2015-16 amounted to about $6.7 billion, a concept note by the New Delhi-based think-tank Research and Information System for developing countries (RIS) said while Russia comprised just 1% of India's total trade, India accounts for a minuscule 1.2% of Russia's overall trade.

India-Russia trade ties have been below-potential and lopsided (in favour of Russia) as it is primarily a buyer-seller relationship and not one based on collaborations through investments, according to Pranav Kumar, Head (trade and international policy), Confederation of Indian Industry. Besides, if the emphasis continues to be on sectors such as defence, hydrocarbons and nuclear power, it would result in Russia gaining more, he added. Therefore, he said, to ensure a balance, sectors such as IT/ITeS, pharmaceuticals and healthcare — where India has considerable strength — should also be encouraged, apart from seeking Russian investments in India in areas including defence manufacturing to push the 'Make In India' programme and in infrastructure and space technology to take forward the Smart City and Digital India initiatives respectively.

What would also help in boosting bilateral ties is trading in local currencies, setting up pipelines for direct gas delivery from Russia to India as well as operationalisation of the proposed $1-billion fund through India's National Investment & Infrastructure Fund and the Russian Direct Investment Fund for investment in infrastructure and technology projects.

Article 59

Why should anyone bother about metaphysical questions? Spending time discussing them may seem speculative and inconsequential. However, while all metaphysical reasoning is speculative, it is far from inconsequential. Taking up a metaphysical stance is both unavoidable and has profound consequences for human life. To take the case of God, there are practical consequences for believers, atheists, agnostics and even those who are indifferent to the whole question of God's existence. Practical metaphysics brings to our awareness both the nature of metaphysical thinking and the consequences that accompany and flow from it.

The first principle of practical metaphysics is that metaphysical propositions are never conclusively proved. The second is that human beings are obliged to believe at least some metaphysical propositions. The third is that belief in some unavoidable metaphysical propositions bring practical consequences. Metaphysical beliefs come with a price tag, and we do well to be aware of this in adopting one metaphysical stance or another.

A perfect example is the case of God. Does God exist? Can we prove or otherwise know that God exists? Can we know God's nature? Is God a Supreme Being or Beyond Being? These are weighty questions, and they have been answered at length many times. Different proofs or disproofs have been been offered. Various approaches have arisen in history, been swept away by new arguments, only to resurface later in other forms. For example, Aristotle's Argument from Design to the operation of an Unmoved Mover has morphed many times over the centuries, with Creationism and Intelligent Design as its latest versions. The ontological argument for God's existence has also resurfaced since it was laid out by St. Anselm in the 11th Century, particularly by Descartes and Leibniz.

Old metaphysical theories are never totally defeated. Their defenders simply die out. Once people forget that a metaphysical theory has been exploded by argument, it creeps back again, for it is always possible to hold any metaphysical theory, no matter how absurd it may seem to some. For example, I might persist in the belief that I exist in the Matrix, despite the fact that I have no empirical evidence for it, nor does any empirical experience make the hypothesis self-contradictory.

The case of God is perhaps the most urgent issue in practical metaphysics, for the simple reason that religious beliefs have the widest ranging practical implications. Such beliefs involve many aspects of life, including emotional responses and moral judgments. The stance of 'Righteousness", for example, is a metaphysical stance for it is founded on the Rock of the Lord. Living up to Divine Commandments is an exercise in practical metaphysics. The same can be said of Kierkegaard's formula of faith in God: resting transparently in the power that supports you. This idea of resting in God is a powerful one. Life is difficult, troubles mount, and the end is pathetic, if not tragic. It gets to be too much for an individual to bear. What a relief to give up one's troubles to God.

There is a kind of psychic economy here. I give up my burdens to God, and God buoys me up. This is a widely reported experience. There are many things that are out of an individual's control. Misfortune is always a possibility, no matter how well you manage what is within your power. It is a real comfort to think that there is a benign power loving and caring for each of us. You may be cut off from the love of family and friends, because they die, while you continue to live a bit longer, but you cannot be cut off from the love of a Divine Father who cares for you as of a child. God plays the role of provider and sustainer, and this metaphysical belief attracts many people. It does so, I would contend, precisely because of the practical benefits that the belief in things unseen brings to the imagination of the confessed believer.

William James adopts this sort of approach in his "Varieties of Religious Experience." He is not so much interested in logically proving God's existence as in looking at how human beings describe their religious experiences. He distinguishes between 'healthy souls' and 'sick souls'. So far I have been talking about the practical consequences of religious belief for the 'healthy' soul. The healthy soul concentrates on God's goodness, love, forgiveness and care for us. We have faith that all things will be well in the end. The 'sick' soul concentrates more on human sinfulness, particularly its own. Here is Jonathan Edwards' terrible God who holds us like spiders over the gaping pit of Hell. A perfect example of a sick soul is Stylites, the ascetic spiritual gymnast, who lived atop a pillar in the desert for twenty years to do penance for sins of the flesh. The practical consequences for the body are clear. The ascetic shows disdain for the body and welcomes its destruction in the name of a higher reality. Similarly, those for whom heaven and hell loom large in a post-terrestrial existence, will see life, not as a passing dream, but as a drama that is played out for eternal stakes in the life of each individual.

These are the sort of practical consequences that arise from having beliefs about God. Practical metaphysics helps us to explore them. For example, there are also practical consequences in believing that there is no God, that the existence of God is always in doubt, or that the whole question of God's existence is nothing to us one way or the other. All these positions have their costs and their benefits. With the last three, one

must forgo Divine comfort, a supernatural afterlife, and the belief that everything will come right in the end. On the positive side, non-believers are not troubled by thoughts of hell, the last judgment, or being observed by heavenly scribes. From this perspective, life is a dream, and nothing lasts forever. Living one's life in either of these ways is, or can be revealed to be, a choice or stance in life that has no other foundation than the metaphysical commitments of the individual.

Article 60

I was in the room when President Bill Clinton decided to reappoint Alan Greenspan, a lifelong Republican originally appointed by Ronald Reagan, as chairman of the Federal Reserve Board. A political adviser urged Mr. Clinton to choose an administration ally, but that was never seriously considered. The president's choice was not determined by party, or politics or ideology.

That's how it has been for decades: Federal Reserve chairmen and governors have been selected based on their ability to serve the country. President Barack Obama reappointed George W. Bush's nominee, Ben Bernanke, as chairman. President Reagan reappointed Jimmy Carter's nominee, Paul Volcker.

The Federal Reserve System was created by statute in 1913, but the independence of its monetary policy from congressional or presidential influence is not codified by law — and it wasn't always inviolable. In recent years, so-called reforms have been proposed to subject Fed monetary policy to congressional review, but its independence has so far been preserved.

For good reason: An independent Federal Reserve led by governors who are committed to pursuing its dual mandate of price stability and full employment, as well as effective regulation — and who make decisions based on facts and analysis — is critically important to our economy, the well-being of the people and the market credibility of Fed policy making.

But that independence is about to be severely tested. Daniel K. Tarullo stepped down from the Federal Reserve Board last week, adding to the board's two existing vacancies. Instead of remaining as governors, Chairwoman Janet Yellen and Stanley Fischer, the vice chairman, could step down when their terms expire next year. President Trump has already said that he will not reappoint Ms.Yellen as chairwoman because she's not a Republican.

Mr. Trump could therefore fill as many as five of the board's seven seats within the next year. I fear that he may appoint governors who lack a commitment to the Fed's dual mandate and will instead seek to please the White House.

There could also be an effort to scapegoat the Fed if (or rather, when) the administration's unrealistic economic growth estimates fail to materialize. The recent rejection of Congressional Budget Office health care estimates is a troubling sign. The administration could use rigged economic projections to attack the Fed over its decisions, rather than respecting its integrity and independence.

The Fed is not always right — no one can be on these matters. But it is staffed by, and the board consists of, immensely capable professionals who work with absolute intellectual integrity. That's why the Fed's work

is highly and widely respected in the United States and around the world. This credibility keeps market interest rates lower and liquidity greater. That, too, could change.

Efforts to denigrate the integrity of the Fed's work, and to inject groundless opinion, politics and ideology, must be rejected by the board — and that means governors and other members of the Federal Open Market Committee must be willing to withstand aggressive attacks.

In the short run, these attacks could occur if the Fed raises rates when the administration would prefer to avoid impediments to its wishful thinking on growth or to the continued run-up of the stock market. The Fed is expected to raise rates two or three times during the coming year, based on its widely shared view that unemployment is as low as it can be without triggering inflation. There is undoubtedly still some room to bring those who have dropped out of the labor market back in, but mainstream labor economists say not much, especially given the skills gap.

The path to greater growth over time is productivity-enhancing policy. While a small fiscal stimulus might increase real growth and wages, a highly expansive fiscal policy is very unlikely to meaningfully increase real growth, and the rest of the effect is likely to be inflationary, absent countervailing Federal Reserve action. Waiting until inflation gains momentum could force the Fed to take more dramatic action that could induce recession. With the administration's unwillingness to appreciate these realities, Fed rate hikes could provoke political backlash.

During my years as secretary of the Treasury, I had a weekly breakfast with Mr. Greenspan and Larry Summers, the deputy secretary. We discussed everything under the sun, from the outlook for the United States economy to the latest political gossip. But never once did Mr. Summers or I, even in the privacy of those meetings, raise monetary policy, nor did anyone in the Clinton administration comment on monetary policy.

As a result, the Fed chairman knew that the White House would not try to advance an agenda on that policy. And this trust enabled the Federal Reserve and the Treasury to engage fully with each other on other matters, such as the Mexican and Asian financial crises. Sooner or later, there will be other financial crises — in the United States and abroad — and maintaining a framework of trust for the Treasury and the Fed to work together is critical.

The administration's relationship to the Fed, and its appointment of governors, must be based not on politics but on the same question every president ought to ask: Who and what will best serve our country?

SET-3

Article 61

Like almost everyone else, I would prefer that there were far fewer abortions. While this might seem like a problematic claim to some, it actually is obviously true. People who oppose abortion obviously want there to be fewer abortions. However, those who are pro-choice are almost always not pro-abortion. That is, they do not want abortions to occur – they would prefer that women did not end up in situations where they see abortion as the best option.

While I do not fall into the pro-life camp in terms of political labelling, I do take a position in favor of life. To be specific, I prefer to avoid killing when doing so is possible and I fully accept that killing anything is an act of some moral significance. In some case, the ethics of killing are easy: I have no issue with killing the bacteria that are working hard to kill me and I accept the need to kill other living things in order to use them as food. In other case, like abortion, the ethics are rather more challenging. After all, abortion involves killing a potential human being and this is clearly an act with great moral significance. Because I have a general opposition to killing, I have the obvious general opposition to abortion. However, I do accept that killing can be morally justified and believe this does apply to certain cases of abortion. As such, I favor reducing the number abortions and support certain means of doing so. I do not, however, favor it being banned.

For those who follow abortion in American politics, the usual means of reducing abortions are aimed at making it harder for women to get abortions. Numerous states have passed laws requiring waiting periods and have imposed medically unwarranted restrictions on abortion clinics aimed at closing them. I am completely opposed to these means of reducing the number of abortions. While I have various reasons supporting my view, my main reason is that these approaches put the burden almost entirely on the woman. Roughly put, it is the woman who bears most of the cost of the moral and religious views of those who impose such restrictions. These costs can be extremely high and not only in terms of the financial cost.

The moral foundation for my opposition to this method of reducing abortions is based on the fact that such imposition is unfair and the fact that this method imposes an extremely high cost on women and society as a whole. It is the wrong way to reduce the number of abortions. As such, I favor approaches that would reduce the number of abortions while distributing the cost more fairly and also reducing the cost to women and society as a whole. To this end, I offer the following general proposals.

The first is doing what is required to reduce sexual violence against women – this would reduce the number of abortions and, rather importantly, make the world safer for women.

The second is to mandate effective and realistic sex education for the youth and also make effective contraception readily accessible. If people have a better understanding of sex and have access to the means to prevent pregnancy, there will be fewer unwanted pregnancies and hence fewer abortions. This has other obvious benefits, although some people do oppose birth control.

The third is to provide greater social support for mothers and children. This would include such things as affordable day car for all working mothers, financial support for lower income mothers, and other support that would make raising a child less of a financial burden. This would reduce the number of abortions by making the choice to have the child more viable.

The third is to address the numerous aspects of gender inequality that burden women. These include wage inequality, the glass ceiling, and other such things that contribute to making it difficult for women to have a

family and a career. This would lower the number of abortions by making being a woman and a mother less of a career handicap, thus giving women a greater opportunity to choose to continue an unplanned pregnancy.

There are, of course, some obvious objections against these proposals. The first is that doing so would require the use of public money. The "advantage" of the usual approaches is that they are initially free for the state and the cost is put upon the women. Such cost shifting is beloved by the morally shifty. As such, it comes down to the ethics of deciding who should bear the burden and cost. Being pro-life rather than anti-abortion, I hold that the cost should be shared – I am willing to pay a price for my principles rather than expecting others to bear that cost.

The second objection is that these approaches would require some radical changes to society. Those who oppose fairness and prefer the "traditional" approach of keeping the women burdened will find this problematic. However, they would seem to be wrong about this – morally defending unfairness is rather challenging.

The third objection is that this approach will still allow abortions to occur – there is no proposal to impose new restrictions or ban abortion. My reply is that I do acknowledge that it would be preferable to have no abortions – just like it would be preferable to never have to harm anyone or anything in any other context. However, if it is accepted that a person's interests can warrant harming another living being, then there are clear grounds for warranting abortion in many cases. As such, while I favor reducing the need for abortion, I cannot favor eliminating it – anymore than I can support a total rejection of ever doing harm. I do, of course, recognize that such complete pacifism could be morally commendable.

Article 62

Japan has long had a large population for its land area, especially since the Baby Boom following World War II. This is particularly true in Japan's cities. For example, according to a 2010 census, the metropolitan Tokyo-Yokohama area has an estimated 35 million residents. The population of the entire country is roughly 128 million. Tokyo-Yokohama is considered the most populous urban center in the world. Some Japanese cultural traditions have been attributed to such crowding. For example, the Japanese people use very formal behaviours like bowing, and use very formal language during social interactions. One theory is that this formality, at least in part, is a means of creating psychological distance and space between individuals, as sufficient physical space is lacking. The expression "too close for comfort" may aptly describe the situation in Japan's most crowded cities, and this physical proximity is offset by reducing social closeness.

Article 63

I spent last week "off the grid" on an island in Lake Michigan. No Internet, no email, no cell phones. It was different, interesting, and strange. I was actually glad to get back to the grid. But the experience made me think. The major difference for me was that I stopped "multi-tasking". Task switching, not multi-tasking –

A while ago I wrote a post about multi-tasking, and the research at Stanford that shows that even younger people aren't good at multi-tasking. But the term multi-tasking is actually a misnomer. People can't actually do more than one task at a time. Instead we switch tasks. So the term that is used in the research is "task switching". Task switching is "expensive" – There has been a lot of research on task switching. Here's what we know from the research: It takes more time to get tasks completed if you switch between them than if you do them one at a time. You make more errors when you switch than if you do one task at a time. If the tasks are complex then these time and error penalties increase. Each task switch might waste only 1/10th of a second, but if you do a lot of switching in a day it can add up to a loss of 40% of your productivity. Task switching involves several parts of your brain: Brain scans during task switching show activity in four major areas: the pre-frontal cortex is involved in shifting and focusing your attention, and selecting which task to do when. The posterior parietal lobe activates rules for each task you switch to, the anterior cingulate gyrus monitors errors, and the premotor cortex is preparing for you to move in some way. Does having more communication channels encourage task switching? When I was off the grid I found that I started doing one task at a time. I would do one thing for several minutes, and in many cases several hours. I believe that being online encourages task switching. When you can go from email to chat to texting to twitter to phone to Facebook you switch tasks more. When I was off the grid all my channels were gone. So instead I spent time with one task and with one program. One day I worked in IPhoto for 3 hours straight. Additional costs– One last insight from my week off the grid: I was much less agitated. It's my hypothesis that task switching not only wastes time and increases errors. Task switching causes fatigue, exhaustion and agitation. Less task switching = more happiness? – Now that I am back on the grid I wonder if I can break the task switching addiction and improve my mood, energy, happiness, productivity, and error rate? Can I beat the task switching habit? What do you think? Have you been able to do less task switching? Have you tried?

Article 64

In India, over the last few years, the rate of rise in prices of several items, including consumables, has been in focus. Popularly known as 'rate of inflation', its sudden rise has been in focus among the policymakers, the government and the consumers alike. This is because it has been impacting each of these stakeholders in the economy in different ways.

Of these three, however, consumers have been hit the most. And among the consumers, the policymakers and the people in the government, there is an overlapping category of people, the investors, who are being hurt badly by this inflation beast. But surprisingly, not many understand the scale of the damage inflation is capable of inflicting on their invested corpus when they look at it with a longer term view.

A crude example would probably help here. In a very basic sense of the term, an annual rate of inflation of, say 8%, would mean that an article that cost you Rs 100 a year ago would cost Rs 108 today. Now suppose you, as an investor, had put in Rs 10,000 in a bank fixed deposit (FD) with an 8% interest rate about a year ago. Today, you have Rs 800 as interest income on that investment. But if the rate of inflation was 8% in the past one year, a basket of products and services that you would need regularly and which cost you Rs 10,000 a year ago would cost you Rs 10,800 today. So, even if you kept your money in a bank fixed deposit that earned you an 8% rate of interest, at the end of the year, because of inflation, you are still at the same level in terms of your purchasing capacity.

You would actually be worse off if the rate of interest that you earned from the bank was lower than the rate of inflation. That is, suppose you earned interest at 8% or 9% and the rate of inflation was 10%, something that we all witnessed during the past several months. So, on a point-to-point basis, even though you saved over the last one year, in terms of your buying power you are actually worse off. Now juxtapose the impact of a 10%, 20% or a 30% rate of tax. If you are a taxpayer and face one of these three tax rates, you would be even worse off. In such a situation, going by your tax rate, you would end up getting about 7%, 6.3% or 5.5% net return.

Now to take this case a little farther: Think that you save every month some money, and you have done that over several years. But the rate of inflation makes you worse off every year (remember rate of interest in banks is closely linked to inflation). In that case, you could end up in a bad situation when you retire. So, what do you do now to save yourself from being affected by the inflation beast?

"Inflation leads to depreciation in the value of money. So, direct money investments do not take care of addressing this problem," says Arun Kejriwal, director, KRIS, an investment research and advisory service firm. The trick here is to aim for higher positive returns by investing in equities, equity-linked instruments and commodities, including precious metals. "Over the long term, these will definitely beat inflation," Kejriwal adds. The questions about how much you should be in equity, the ratio between equities and commodities, how much total investments should you do — all these are questions specific to each individual, and your financial planner and advisor should be able to guide you through this.

The trick here is to aim for a post-tax rate of return that would be higher than the rate of inflation. One of the tricks of achieving this is to invest in such instruments that, over the long term, they can give higher returns and also minimize the burden of tax on you.

"For any financial planning exercise, we always aim for positive returns," says Kartik Jhaveri, director, Transcend Consulting, a financial planning and advisory firm. In India, the long-term rate of inflation has been about 6-7%. So, the aim for every financial plan should be to have an inflation-plus return, or at least the returns should match the rate of inflation, financial planners say.

In India, since the general rate of interest in the economy is determined by the prevailing rate of inflation, the rate of interest you get in a bank FD is usually very close to the rate of inflation. For example, after the rate of inflation in India hovered above the double-digit mark, banking sector regulator Reserve Bank of India (RBI) also raised the key policy rates that determine the rate of interest in the economy, and FD rates also shot up to the current high rates of 9-10%. But here, the interest that you earn is taxable if you fall in the tax bracket.

The same is the case for several other investment instruments like bonds, debentures and some of the small savings schemes. However, there is a particular type of FD, of five-year maturity, in which the returns enjoy a tax-free status.

On the other hand, returns from equities, equity mutual funds and some other investment instruments, like the recently-introduced tax-free bonds, are tax free, provided these are held for the long term.

Among the mutual funds, equity linked savings schemes (ELSS) allow you tax rebate while you invest and also on the returns from these schemes. In addition, among all the investment vehicles that allow you tax rebate under Section 80C of the Income Tax Act, these schemes have the shortest lock-in — of three years only. All others have 5,7,10 years of lock-in. The government, however, is thinking of reducing the lock-in for qualified bank FDs from five years to three years — at par with ELSS.

Among mutual fund schemes, fixed maturity plans of more than one year are still attractive from the returns point of view, and also for their tax benefits, the latter coming from indexation. These instruments offer rates which are at least at par with bank FDs, but score over FDs in terms of tax advantages. All dividends and the redemption amount that you get from your long-term investments in mutual funds also are tax free. The same is the case for dividends you earn from your direct investments in equities.

Mutual funds also have the added advantage of diversification which also helps reduce your risks over the long term. Here, however, after the recent rally in the stock market, d iv i d e n d - yield stocks are not so attractive anymore.

"Markets have now gone up, and so calculations of one month ago do not apply in the dividend yield story anymore," says Kejriwal. "If you are investing for the long term and directly in equities, one should look at the brick-and-mortar stocks," he adds.

Kejriwal believes stocks of companies from sectors like FMCG, steel, automobile, cements, etc, are easier to understand than companies like software where a much larger number of factors influence the stock price. Among equities, historically it has been seen that stocks of companies with a solid business and a good track record have mostly beaten the rate of inflation over the long haul. Data show that over the past two decades, while the average rate of inflation was between 6-7%, the average rate of return in sensex was more than 15%.

Article 65

While some countries will pay ransoms to free hostages, the United States has a public policy of not doing this. Thanks to ISIS, the issue of whether ransoms should be paid to terrorists groups or not has returned to the spotlight.

One reason to not pay a ransom for hostages is a matter of principle. This principle could be that bad behavior should not be rewarded or that hostage taking should be punished (or both).

One of the best arguments against paying ransoms for hostages is both a practical and a utilitarian moral argument. The gist of the argument is that paying ransoms gives hostage takers an incentive to take hostages. This incentive will mean that more people will be taken hostage. The cost of not paying is, of course, the possibility that the hostage takers will harm or kill their initial hostages. However, the argument goes, if hostage takers realize that they will not be paid a ransom, they will not have an incentive to take more hostages. This will, presumably, reduce the chances that the hostage takers will take hostages. The calculation is, of course, that the harm done to the existing hostages will be outweighed by the benefits of not having people taken hostage in the future.

This argument assumes, obviously enough, that the hostage takers are primarily motivated by the ransom payment. If they are taking hostages primarily for other reasons, such as for status, to make a statement or to get media attention, then not paying them a ransom will not significantly reduce their incentive to take hostages. This leads to a second reason to not pay ransoms.

In addition to the incentive argument, there is also the funding argument. While a terrorist group might have reasons other than money to take hostages, they certainly benefit from getting such ransoms. The money they receive can be used to fund additional operations, such as taking more hostages. Obviously enough, if

ransoms are not paid, then such groups do lose this avenue of funding which can impact their operations. Since paying a ransom would be funding terrorism, this provides both a moral a practical reason not to pay ransoms.

While these arguments have a rational appeal, they are typically countered by a more emotional appeal. A stock approach to arguing that ransoms should be paid is the "in their shoes" appeal. The method is very straightforward and simply involves asking a person whether or not she would want a ransom to be paid for her (or a loved one). Not surprising, most people would want the ransom to be paid, assuming doing so would save her (or her loved one). Sometimes the appeal is made explicitly in terms of emotions: "how would you feel if your loved one died because the government refuses to pay ransoms?" Obviously, any person would feel awful.

This method does have considerable appeal. The "in their shoes" appeal can be seem similar to the golden rule approach (do unto others as you would have them do unto you). To be specific, the appeal is not to do unto others, but to base a policy on how one would want to be treated in that situation. If I would not want the policy applied to me (that is, I would want to be ransomed or have my loved one ransomed), then I should be morally opposed to the policy as a matter of consistency. This certainly makes sense: if I would not want a policy applied in my case, then I should (in general) not support that policy.

One obvious counter is that there seems to be a distinction between what a policy should be and whether or not a person would want that policy applied to herself. For example, some universities have a policy that if a student misses more than three classes, the student fails the course. Naturally, no student wants that policy to be applied to her (and most professors would not have wanted it applied to them when they were students), but this hardly suffices to show that the policy is wrong. As another example, a company might have a policy of not providing health insurance to part time employees. While the CEO would certainly not like the policy if she were part time, it does not follow that the policy must be a bad one. As such, policies need to be assessed not just in terms of how a persons feels about them, but in terms of their merit or lack thereof.

Another obvious counter is to use the same approach, only with a modification. In response to the question "how would you feel if you were the hostage or she were a loved one?" one could ask "how would you feel if you or a loved one were taken hostage in an operation funded by ransom money? Or "how would you feel if you or a loved one were taken hostage because the hostage takers learned that people would pay ransoms for hostages?" The answer would be, of course, that one would feel bad about that. However, while how one would feel about this can be useful in discussing the matter, it is not decisive. Settling the matter rationally does require considering more than just how people would feel—it requires looking at the matter with a degree of objectivity. That is, not just asking how people would feel, but what would be right and what would yield the best results in the practical sense.

Article 66

The conference of the World Trade Organisation currently underway at Cancun in Mexico was caught in a deadlock over attempts by the rich nations to steamroll their way on trade and investment issues as developing countries, including India, stoutly opposed bypassing the contentious subject of agriculture.

India and 15 other countries got into a new league G16 to oppose the conference taking up Singapore issues

like investment and competition policy rules, trade facilitation and transparency in government procurement. The new alliance of G16 includes China, Egypt, Bangladesh, Indonesia, the Philippines and Zambia.

Commerce Minister ArunJaitley and Malaysian Trade Minister Rafidah Aziz told a joint press conference that they would in no way to agree to starting negotiations on the four Singapore issues as they felt that the clarification process should continue. "I am afraid there are only two options on the issue – to either start negotiations or not to start and there is no third or soft option. We have decided that it should not be started at Cancun as there is no explicit consensus on the modalities for starting the negotiations," Rafidah said immediately after the first meeting of the grand alliance. "The countries who do not want negotiations are in majority. The countries who want to launch are in minority," she said ruling out any unbundling of the four issues as a compromise.

The two ministers said, "There is no trade-off or concession." Rafidah said the group of developing countries is for decoupling of issues and was against EU proposal to link time-bound elimination of farm subsidies to starting negotiations on Singapore issues.

As the minister got into the nitty-gritty of negotiations past midnight, five facilitators, appointed by the conference Chairman and Mexican Foreign Minister Louis Ernesto Debrez to resolve contentious issues like agriculture and Singapore, swung into action having parleys with member countries and pressure groups.

On the contentious Singapore issues which provides for among other things working out investment and competition rules within WTO, the facilitator, Canadian Trade Minister, Pierre Pettigrew (Canada) said that at the end of the first day that a number of developing countries including India have pointed out that it was evident that there was no consensus in negotiations on Singapore issues.

"There are two options – either to agree to launch a negotiation or refer the issue back to Geneva for clarification and India," he said on behalf of some members, "has submitted a paper identifying points for further clarification."

Article 67

One of the classic moral problems is the issue of whether or not we have moral obligations to people we do not know. If we do have such obligations, then there are also questions about the foundation, nature and extent of these obligations. If we do not have such obligations, then there is the obvious question about why there are no such obligations. I will start by considering some stock arguments regarding our obligations to others.

One approach to the matter of moral obligations to others is to ground them on religion. This requires two main steps. The first is establishing that the religion imposes such obligations. The second is making the transition from the realm of religion to the domain of ethics.

Many religions do impose such obligations on their followers. For example, John 15:12 conveys God's command: "This is my commandment, That you love one another, as I have loved you." If love involves

obligations (which it seems to), then this would certainly seem to place us under these obligations. Other faiths also include injunctions to assist others.

In terms of transitioning from religion to ethics, one easy way is to appeal to divine command theory—the moral theory that what God commands is right because He commands it. This does raise the classic Euthyphro problem: is something good because God commands it, or is it commanded because it is good? If the former, goodness seems arbitrary. If the latter, then morality would be independent of God and divine command theory would be false.

Using religion as the basis for moral obligation is also problematic because doing so would require proving that the religion is correct—this would be no easy task. There is also the practical problem that people differ in their faiths and this would make a universal grounding for moral obligations difficult.

Another approach is to argue for moral obligations by using the moral method of reversing the situation. This method is based on the Golden Rule ("do unto others as you would have them do unto you") and the basic idea is that consistency requires that a person treat others as she would wish to be treated.

To make the method work, a person would need to want others to act as if they had obligations to her and this would thus obligate the person to act as if she had obligations to them. For example, if I would want someone to help me if I were struck by a car and bleeding out in the street, then consistency would require that I accept the same obligation on my part. That is, if I accept that I should be helped, then consistency requires that I must accept I should help others.

This approach is somewhat like that taken by Immanuel Kant. He argues that because a person necessarily regards herself as an end (and not just a means to an end), then she must also regard others as ends and not merely as means. He endeavors to use this to argue in favor of various obligations and duties, such as helping others in need.

There are, unfortunately, at least two counters to this sort of approach. The first is that it is easy enough to imagine a person who is willing to forgo the assistance of others and as such can consistently refuse to accept obligations to others. So, for example, a person might be willing to starve rather than accept assistance from other people. While such people might seem a bit crazy, if they are sincere then they cannot be accused of inconsistency.

The second is that a person can argue that there is a relevant difference between himself and others that would justify their obligations to him while freeing him from obligations to them. For example, a person of a high social or economic class might assert that her status obligates people of lesser classes while freeing her from any obligations to them. Naturally, the person must provide reasons in support of this alleged relevant difference.

A third approach is to present a utilitarian argument. For a utilitarian, like John Stuart Mill, morality is assessed in terms of consequences: the correct action is the one that creates the greatest utility (typically happiness) for the greatest number. A utilitarian argument for obligations to people we do not know would be rather straightforward. The first step would be to estimate the utility generated by accepting a specific obligation to people we do not know, such as rendering aid to an intoxicated person who is about to become the victim of sexual assault. The second step is to estimate the disutility generated by imposing that specific obligation. The third step is to weigh the utility against the disutility. If the utility is greater, then such an obligation should be imposed. If the disutility is greater, then it should not.

This approach, obviously enough, rests on the acceptance of utilitarianism. There are numerous arguments against this moral theory and these can be employed against attempts to ground obligations on utility. Even for those who accept utilitarianism, there is the open possibility that there will always be greater utility in not imposing obligations, thus undermining the claim that we have obligations to others.

A fourth approach is to consider the matter in terms of rational self-interest and operate from the assumption that people should act in their self-interest. In terms of a moral theory, this would be ethical egoism: the moral theory that a person should act in her self-interest rather than acting in an altruistic manner.

While accepting that others have obligations to me would certainly be in my self-interest, it initially appears that accepting obligations to others would be contrary to my self-interest. That is, I would be best served if others did unto me as I would like to be done unto, but I was free to do unto them as I wished. If I could get away with this sort of thing, it would be ideal (assuming that I am selfish). However, as a matter of fact people tend to notice and respond negatively to a lack of reciprocation. So, if having others accept that they have some obligations to me were in my self-interest, then it would seem that it would be in my self-interest to pay the price for such obligations by accepting obligations to them.

For those who like evolutionary just-so stories in the context of providing foundations for ethics, the tale is easy to tell: those who accept obligations to others would be more successful than those who do not.

The stock counter to the self-interest argument is the problem of Glaucon's unjust man and Hume's sensible knave. While it certainly seems rational to accept obligations to others in return for getting them to accept similar obligations, it seems preferable to exploit their acceptance of obligations while avoiding one's supposed obligations to others whenever possible. Assuming that a person should act in accord with self-interest, then this is what a person should do.

It can be argued that this approach would be self-defeating: if people exploited others without reciprocation, the system of obligations would eventually fall apart. As such, each person has an interest in ensuring that others hold to their obligations. Humans do, in fact, seem to act this way—those who fail in their obligations often get a bad reputation and are distrusted. From a purely practical standpoint, acting as if one has obligations to others would thus seem to be in a person's self-interest because the benefits would generally outweigh the costs.

The counter to this is that each person still has an interest in avoiding the cost of fulfilling obligations and there are various practical ways to do this by the use of deceit, power and such. As such, a classic moral question arises once again: why act on your alleged obligations if you can get away with not doing so? Aside from the practical reply given above, there seems to be no answer from self-interest.

A fifth option is to look at obligations to others as a matter of debts. A person is born into an established human civilization built on thousands of years of human effort. Since each person arrives as a helpless infant, each person's survival is dependent on others. As the person grows up, she also depends on the efforts of countless other people she does not know. These include soldiers that defend her society, the people who maintain the infrastructure, firefighters who keep fire from sweeping away the town or city, the taxpayers who pay for all this, and so on for all the many others who make human civilization possible. As such, each member of civilization owes a considerable debt to those who have come before and those who are here now.

If debt imposes an obligation, then each person who did not arise ex-nihilo owes a debt to those who have made and continue to make their survival and existence in society possible. At the very least, the person is obligated to make contributions to continue human civilization as a repayment to these others.

One objection to this is for a person to claim that she owes no such debt because her special status obligates others to provide all this for her with nothing owed in return. The obvious challenge is for a person to prove such an exalted status.

Another objection is for a person to claim that all this is a gift that requires no repayment on the part of anyone and hence does not impose any obligation. The challenge is, of course, to prove this implausible claim.

A final option I will consider is that offered by virtue theory. Virtue theory, famously presented by thinkers like Aristotle and Confucius, holds that people should develop their virtues. These classic virtues include generosity, loyalty and other virtues that involve obligations and duties to others. Confucius explicitly argued in favor of duties and obligations as being key components of virtues.

In terms of why a person should have such virtues and accept such obligations, the standard answer is that being virtuous will make a person happy.

Virtue theory is not without its detractors and the criticism of the theory can be employed to undercut it, thus undermining its role in arguing that we have obligations to people we do not know.

Article 68

On an episode of the Late Show, host Stephen Colbert and Jane Lynch had an interesting discussion of guardian angels. Lynch, who currently stars as a guardian angel in "Angel from Hell", related a story of how her guardian angel held her in a protective embrace during a low point of her life. Colbert, ever the rational Catholic, noted that he believed in guardian angels despite knowing that they do not exist. The question of the existence of guardian angels is certainly an interesting one and provides yet another way to consider the classic problem of evil.

In general terms, a guardian angel is a supernatural, benevolent being who serves as the personal protector of someone. The nature of their alleged guarding varies considerably. For some, the guardian angel is supposed to serve in the classic "angel on the shoulder" role and provide good advice. For others, the angel provides a comforting presence. Some even claim that guardian angels take a very active role, such as reducing a potentially fatal fall to one that merely inflicts massive bodily injury. My interest is, however, not with the specific functions of guardian angels, but with the question of their existence.

In the context of monotheism, a guardian angel is an agent of God. As such, this ties them into the problem of evil. The general problem of evil is the challenge of reconciling the alleged existence of God with the existence of evil. Some take this problem to decisively show that God does not exist. Others contend that it shows that God is not how philosophers envision Him in the problem—that is, He is not omniscient, omnibenevolent or omnipotent. In the case of guardian angels, the challenge is to reconcile their alleged existence with evil.

One merely has to look through the news of the day to see a multitude of cases in which a guardian angel could have saved the day with fairly little effort. For example, a guardian angel could inform the police about the location of a kidnapped child. As another example, a guardian angel could exert a bit of effort to keep a ladder from slipping. They could also do more difficult things, like preventing cancer from killing children or deflecting bullets away from school children. Since none of this ever seems to happen, one obvious conclusion is that there are no guardian angels.

However, as with the main problem of evil, there are some ways to try to address this specific problem. One option, which is not available in the case of God, is to argue that guardian angels have very limited capabilities—that is, they are incredibly weak supernatural beings. Alternatively, they might operate under very restrictive rules in terms of what they are allowed to do. One problem with this reply is that such weak angels seem indistinguishable in their effects from non-existent angels. Another problem ties this into the broader problem of evil: why wouldn't God deploy a better sort of guardian or give them broader rules to operate under? This, of course, just brings up the usual problem of evil.

Another option is that not everyone gets an angel. Jane Lynch, for example, might get an angel that hugged her. Alan Kurdi, the young boy who drowned trying to flee Syria, did not get a guardian angel. While this would be an explanation of sorts, it still just pushes the problem back: why would God not provide everyone in need with a guardian? Mere humans are, of course, limited in their resources and abilities, so everyone cannot be protected all the time. However, God would not seem to suffer from such a limitation.

It is also possible to make use of a stock reply to the problem of evil and bring in the Devil. Perhaps Lucifer deploys his demonic agents to counter the guardian angels. So, when something bad happens to a good person, it is because her guardian angel was outdone by a demon. While this has a certain appeal, it would require a world in which God and the Devil are closely matched so that the Devil can defy God and His angels. This, of course, just brings in the general problem of evil: unless one postulates two roughly equal deities, God is on the hook for the Devil and his demons. Or rather, God's demons.

As should be expected, guardian angels seem to fare no better than God in regards to the problem of evil. That said, the notion of benevolent, supernatural personal guardians predates monotheism. Socrates, for example, claimed to have a guardian who would warn him of bad choices (which Stephen Colbert also claims to have).

These sort of guardians were not claimed to be agents of a perfect being, as such they do avoid the problem of evil. Supernatural beings that are freelancers or who serve a limited deity can reasonably be expected to be limited in their abilities and it would certainly make sense that not everyone would have a guardian. Conflict between opposing supernatural agencies also makes sense, since there is no postulation of a single supreme being.

While these supernatural guardians do avoid the problem of evil, they run up against the problem of evidence: there does not appear to be adequate evidence for the existence of such supernatural beings. In fact, the alleged evidence for them is better explained by alternatives. For example, a little voice in one's head is better explained in terms of the psychological rather than the supernatural (a benign mental condition rather than a supernatural guardian). As another example, a fall that merely badly injures a person rather than killing them is better explained in terms of the vagaries of chance than in terms of a conscious, supernatural intervention.

Given the above discussion, there seems to be little reason to believe in the existence of guardian angels. The world would be rather different if they did exist, so clearly they do not. Or they do so little as to make no meaningful difference—which is rather hard to distinguish from not existing.

I certainly do not begrudge people their belief in guardian angels—if that belief leads them to make better choices and feel safer in a dangerous world, then it is a benign belief. I certainly have comfort beliefs as well—as we all do. Perhaps these are our guardian angels. This, obviously, points to another discussion about such beliefs.

Article 69

The traditional notion that hunter-gatherers must carry on a solitary, unremitting search for food, that they supposedly wake each morning not knowing whether or not they will find the day's supply, and that they usually die young from famine happens to be untrue.

Hunter-gatherers, who are solitary but live in small bands and observe many intricate social rules for the distribution of food, are far from impoverished.

The San in the bleak Kalahari Desert forage for food for not more than a few hours a day on the average; moreover, the unmarried young people and those older than fifty do hardly any work at all.

Medical examinations of the San have shown that their diet, both abundant and nutritious, has enabled them to escape many of the health problems associated with diets that are common in modern societies; obesity and 'middle-age spread', dental cares, hypertension and coronary heart disease, and elevated levels of cholesterol. And far from being short-lived, many of the San live into their sixties and seventies.

An important point made by the studies of surviving hunters-gatherers is that their generally excellent nutrition extends to all members of the society and not just to a privileged few- simply because the prevalence of sharing insures that everyone eats the same way.

In those rare hunter-gatherer societies where some individuals were notably more privileged, as were the chiefs of the Northwest Coast Indian tribes, the inequality did not usually extend to nutrition.

Article 70

Time is money in the West. Workers are paid by the hour, lawyers charge by the minute, and advertising is sold by the second ($117,000 per second at this year's Super Bowl). Think about this: The civilized mind has reduced time, the most obscure and amorphous of all intangibles, to the most objective of all quantities -- money. With time and things on the same value scale, I can tell you how many of my working hours equal the price of the computer I am typing on.

Can I really? As a social scientist, I've spent much of the last 25 years studying the "personalities" of places. Much of this work has focused on the attitudes toward time held by those who inhabit those places. My colleagues and I have found vast cultural differences in definitions of what constitutes early and late, waiting and rushing, the past, the present, and the future.

Perhaps the biggest clash is between cultures that operate on clock time and those that work on event time. Under clock time, the hour on the timepiece governs the beginning and ending of activities. Lunch begins at 12 and ends at 1. Punctuality is the governing principle. When event time predominates, schedules are spontaneous. Events begin and end when, by mutual consensus, participants "feel" the time is right. Many countries exhort event time as a philosophy of life. In Mexico, for example, there is a popular adage, "Give time to time" ("Darle tiempo al tiempo"). In Liberia it is said, "Even the time takes its time." In Trinidad it is something of a cultural bedrock that "any time is Trinidad time."

Our own research has compared the pace of life in different cities. In an early study we conducted field experiments in the largest or other major city in each of 31 countries. One experiment, for example, timed the average walking speed of randomly selected pedestrians over a distance of 60 feet. Another experiment sampled speed in the workplace -- specifically, how long it took postal clerks to fulfill a standard request for stamps. All measurements were taken during main business hours in main downtown areas under similar conditions. More recently, my colleague Stephen Reysen and I replicated these experiments in 24 cities across the United States.

We've found large differences in these studies. The fastest big cities in the international study, for example, tended to come from Western Europe and prosperous Asian countries, while those from traditional event-time countries (such as Mexico, Brazil, and Indonesia) tended to be slowest. The differences were often substantial. For example, on the walking-speed measure we found that pedestrians in Rio de Janeiro walked only two-thirds as fast as did pedestrians in Zurich, Switzerland. (For further details, see, for example, Levine, A Geography of Time [Basic Books]). We've found these differences are to at least some degree predictable by demographic, economic, and environmental characteristics of the places, and, more importantly, they have consequences for the well-being of individuals and their communities.

The consequences are mixed. On the positive side, people in faster places tend to say they are happier with their lives. We believe this reflects the economic rewards that result from making every minute "productive": Faster cities in our studies tended to have healthier economies, and we know from other studies that people who have difficulty meeting their minimal needs tend to be less happy. (A sidebar: Money does not, however, appear to affect happiness beyond poverty. There is little difference in happiness between moderately wealthy and very wealthy individuals.)

But a fast pace of life has its costs. In another series of experiments, conducted in many of the same cities, we compared the likelihood that a passerby would assist a stranger in need. In one experiment, for example, we observed the proportion of people who went out of their way to return an inadvertently dropped pen. In another, we observed the proportion who assisted a man with an injured leg trying to pick up a dropped magazine. Not surprisingly, there were strong differences between cities (see "The Kindness of Strangers"). Perhaps the most notable finding was a negative relationship between the pace of life and helping: People in faster places were less likely to take the time to assist a stranger in need.

The problem may not be speed per se so much as feeling rushed. In a now-classic experiment, John Darley and Daniel Batson gathered a group of Princeton University Seminary students for what they understood to be a study about religious education. The students were told they'd be giving a brief talk, either about the types of jobs seminary graduates are suited for or about the parable of the "good Samaritan." They were then directed to walk to a recording studio across campus. Along the way, they passed a man slumped in a doorway who was coughing and groaning loudly. The students were divided into two groups. Half of them were told there was no need to rush in getting to the recording studio. Almost two-thirds of this group stopped to help the suffering man. The other half of the students were told they were late and needed to hurry to the studio. Among this group, only 10 percent helped. Ninety percent were apparently too busy to

stop. "Indeed, on several occasions, a seminary student going to give his talk on the parable of the Good Samaritan literally stepped over the victim as he hurried on his way," Darley and Batson recalled.

People may ignore strangers for a variety of reasons. They may be too busy to notice, or too busy to care. They may fear how the stranger will react. Or they might simply be uncaring jerks. To the stranger in need, however, reasons are beside the point. The only thing that matters is whether they get help.

When did it become acceptable in America to treat helping strangers as "wasted time"? Everyone in the world agrees -- they should, anyway -- that time is our most precious commodity. But peoples' definitions of "wasted" are another great cultural divider. To a time-is-money clock-timer it refers to anything that distracts from the task at hand. To an event-timer, however, there is nothing more wasteful than carving one's life into inflexible, inorganic units.

I'll never forget a conversation I once had with an exchange student from Burkina Faso in Eastern Africa. I was complaining that I'd just wasted my morning yakking in a café instead of doing my work. He looked confused. "How can you waste time? If you're not doing one thing, you're doing something else. Even if you're just talking to a friend or sitting around, that's what you're doing." He said he was taught that what's wasteful -- sinful, to some -- is to not make sufficient time available for the people in your life.

What does it say about a culture when schedules take precedent over the life in front of your eyes, when the ticking of a clock discourages compassionate behavior? There are plenty of experts in the United States you can pay to help plan your days more efficiently. Here's another suggestion. Try beginning your day with a question people often ask in Brunei: "What is not going to happen today?" While you're at it, don't forget to give time to time.

Article 71

Unless there are signs that we are reinventing the state, all promises will prove illusory
Beyond the jugglery of numbers, there is one unambiguous message we should take away this season: India's future depends on the state of its state. And the evidence provided by the Union budget, particularly the economic survey, on the state is truly dispiriting. The state is now the black hole of reforms, swallowing everything thrown at it.

The core of India's economic challenge is managing inflationary expectations. Everything from the savings rate to investor confidence depends on giving some signal about what kind of world to expect in terms of inflation. Fiscal tightening might signal a resolve to manage those expectations. But the state has done nothing to lessen the uncertainties over inflation. If anything, the budget suggests even more inflationary pressures. The government lost credibility because for three years it was being mendacious about inflation diagnostics. Was it labour cost push? Was it energy prices? Was it government expenditure growth not being linked to productivity increases? Without a diagnostic that is clearly addressed in the budget, there is no credible roadmap to managing inflation, and this will create choppy seas.

The second black hole of the state is regulatory certainty. The biggest regression over UPA 2 was that it continued to multiply regulators, while at the same time moving away from principled regulation. It got into trouble in sector after sector because it could not stick to regulatory frameworks with credibility; even in PPPs, it was amenable to arbitrary discretion. This also created openings where other institutions like courts

could compound uncertainties. So here is a non-rhetorical question. Do we have any reason to have more confidence that the regulatory capacity of the state is going to improve? The answer is probably, no.

The third black hole of the state is that it still does not seem to understand the importance of a framework for justifying its decisions in terms of public reason. The issue is not tax rates. A good case could have been made for taxing the super-rich. But it should have been made with courage of conviction and on principled grounds. Instead, what we got was something like, "We are in trouble, so let us do this for a year and then we will roll back." This will hardly cement the state's reputation as a credible taxer.

The fourth black hole comes out most clearly in the economic survey. This is that every single item required for future growth is premised on a radically different kind of state. The survey tries to do a fair-minded assessment of the deep dynamics of growth and the more contingent drivers. The survey is wonderful at emphasising the need for job growth. It then offers a good comparative analysis of issues we have to face: labour laws, the ease of doing business, formalisation, education and skilling and so forth. The survey often draws comparisons with East Asia, but then tellingly leaves out the most important question: do we have similar state capacity? In fact, in the short to medium run, state capacity may actually decline. Take the items in turn.

The government has finally woken up to the fact that without a manufacturing base of some kind, we will be doomed. So here is the nasty question. Can you think of one example where a country has managed to create a strong manufacturing base without an industrial policy of some kind? But here we cannot even leverage defence spending to boost domestic manufacturing, let alone create the kinds of winners East Asia did. The state does not even trust itself to do contracting. The survey talks a lot about the "missing middle" in India's firm size, though it underestimates the degree to which this seems like a global phenomenon. It talks a lot about the way in which the informal sector is a drag on Indian productivity. The function of informality is more debatable. But it is hard to argue that making the transition from informality to formality will require vastly deepened state capacity. But the East Asian examples also suggest that the formalisation happened under the aegis of what AtulKohli called state-directed development, not simply private sector expansion.

The survey talks about skilling and human capital requirements. But it is hard to imagine a single case where a system of robust public education and more intelligent public outlays was not the bedrock of human capital enhancement. The survey points out, not for the first time, that we have arcane labour laws. It would have been nice, though, if it had provided some explanation of why there is so much variation in manufacturing prowess, where states like Haryana, Tamil Nadu and Gujarat still manage to clock impressive numbers. It also does not dwell adequately on the fact that the bargaining power of labour has been declining, as evidenced in the share of profits to wages, or the ratio of lockouts to strikes. But the crucial point is that it is hard to wish labour issues away. Indeed, the real issue now is that the gap between organised formal workers and informal workers in the organised sector will lead to greater militancy amongst workers. Can the state redefine its relationship to labour, as it did in East Asia?

Again, not for the first time we come to that grand idea, "the ease of doing business", where India ranks close to the bottom. But here is the nasty question. If after two decades of reform, there is not an iota of progress in this area, except perhaps for the very big guys, is there any reason to suppose that anything is going to change on this front? This is a tough one to crack because the cumulatively hostile environment for business is a product of innumerable small decisions, each of which has a bureaucratic logic of its own.

In short, no matter which direction you look in, you hit the brick wall of the kind of state we have. It is being said that the economic survey is optimistic in its growth projections. But its diagnosis of what we need to do raises serious and dispiriting questions. These days, it is considered unpatriotic to talk India's

prospects down. But it is foolish to think that India can grow without tackling the infirmities of its state. A fiscal deficit number will give a small assurance that we are not bankrupting ourselves to high heaven. India has enormous energy and inventiveness. But unless you see signs that we are reinventing the state all promises will prove illusory. Unfortunately, we have replaced the art of state-building with the science of number-crunching.

Article 72

First, you get rid of the notion that anything about your life is *really* at stake. Whatever happens, you will be fine. You are not deciding whether to opt for chemotherapy or not. That is to say- calm down. We, the young and ambitious, deal almost exclusively with rich- white-people problems. We are not going to starve if we make the wrong decision. There is very little we cannot undo.

Of course, that does not make life-changing decision any less intimidating or take away the fact that the adults in our lives did next to nothing in the way of preparing us. I think that is why since I dropped out of school (and wrote about it as it was happening) people have been coming to me as though I have some special insight on making these kinds of calls. Since I did it then and have done it several times since, they think I know the secret. I do not, but I do have some tricks.

When I get these emails I almost always ignore the specific details and respond with few simple questions. Stuff like: "What is the absolute worst thing that could happen?" "What would you miss out on if you did it?" "Are you fighting for a piece of a shrinking dying industry or are you getting something whose value will hold up over time?" I never tell them what to do. I just pose questions.

These are no rhetorical questions, though I am sure they seem that way to someone just looking for advice. I intend for the person to answer them. Think about like a math equation for a second. It seems like a jumble of symbols and unknowns at first, but when you stop, breathe and break it down, the process basically takes care of itself. Isolate the variables, solve for them and all that is left is your answer.
Answer the questions and the right choice becomes clear.

This strategy gives you the single most important tactic when you are trying to make life-changing decisions:
Get information, not advice. See most people—no matter how wise or successful—give horrible advice. They will send you astray. So do not ask for advice. Ask them for *information* that you can translate *into* advice.

Isolate the various issues that will influence your decision and ask then people about that. By zeroing in on specifics rather than the big picture, you avoid the trap of *their* (distorted) picture. Simplify your decision into [If this] then [x] or [If that] then [y]. Then use the smart people in your life to help solve for the variables.

It is the difference between asking: "What should I do?" and "Do you know anyone who ran into problems taking some time off from school?" To me, this difference was the world. I asked the latter question to someone when I was dropping out and their answer was brilliant. 'Problems?' he said, 'I got really sick when I was in college and had to spend a year in the hospital. Do you think that matters at all to anyone 20 years later?'

So try it: What is the worst thing that can happen? *Well, it could cost me some money.* Ok, well money is replaceable so that is a stupid reason not to do something with so much potential upside. Is this a once in a lifetime opportunity? *Yes.* Really, never again? I do not know… *Then you have not thought about this enough.* And so and so on.

After that, this is what else is important:
-Think about where you want to go, back out your decisions from there. Let us say you want to be a politician way down the line. Well, what does the biography of a politician look like? Probably some military service, success in the private sector, multiple degrees, clean private life, good connections, rich benefactors, a public profile, one or two key (untouchable) stances, sense of style, etc. Ok, now when you make decisions all you have to do is ask yourself: Does this help me check off any of those boxes? If it does not, it is probably not the right thing to do.

-Remember to consider opportunity costs.
-"Enter Action With Boldness" and sometimes, you may have "Act Before You Are Ready"
-It does not matter how much other people 'get' you, they will never fully understand your aspirations so do not go around expecting them to. It is too hard for them to see past their own experiences. Prepare to be misunderstood, both when you ask for advice and when you finally take action.
-Scared about making the wrong choice? You would not ever know if you did. Cognitive dissonance would not let you.
-Strategy is a matter of options. Generally, the aim is to act in a way that leaves as many possible options open as possible (remember, opportunity costs). Keep this in mind as you make your decision. What gives me the most options? What gives me the most freedom and creates the most opportunities? Do not discount the things you do not yet know are important.
-Books. Books. Books. People have been doing [whatever it is you are deciding about] for a while now. They have been moving West, leaving school, investing their savings, getting dumped or filing for divorce, starting businesses, quitting their jobs, fighting, dying and fucking for thousands of years. This is all written down, often in the first person. Read it. Stop pretending you are breaking new ground.
Finally, do not feel guilty for asking for help. There is NOT A CHANCE that the successful people you know today did not rely on the successful people they knew in order to get where they are. That is the cycle. It is why I respond to these emails and do my best to walk people through it however I can. So if you do not have anyone else to ask, you can also come to me as a last resort. You know where to find me.

**When I made the decision to leave my life behind and write my book, I asked Tucker: "Is there anything I should be worried about when I am doing this?" His answer: "Nothing about any of this should worry you. It is all upside."*

Article 73

We know that if we eat the right food, in the right quantities, at the right time, our digestive system will remain healthy. Similarly, if we breathe right, our respiratory system will function efficiently. If our hearts are in good shape, and the arteries ensure that blood reaches where it must, our circulatory system is in order. Pathology tests can verify the efficacy of our bodily functions.

But how does one keep in shape an invisible system? Our energy system helps us process *pranachiki* or the life force. Like food, air or blood, it flows through our bodies, is processed and transformed before leaving us. The manner in which it does this tells us how energetic we are. We need go no further than our body to

gauge our emotions. If we are feeling distressed, upset, guilty, angry, irritated or resentful, we can safely assume that energy is leaving our body in fear. If, on the other hand, we are in a joyful, contented, vibrant mood, we are processing our energy lovingly.

All emotions flow from two basic emotions: Love and fear. One group of emotions makes us feel restless and uneasy, the other brings about balance and harmony. We label the two as positive and negative. It also encourages us to accept the happy ones and reject the others. We grow up with the understanding that while it is correct to feel happy, joyful, and grateful, it is in bad form to feel guilty, irritated, stressed or sad. These are emotions, which make us weak and we could be pushed into being a loser, unable to cope. Not only do we get into the habit of being unable to acknowledge what we are feeling but worse, gradually, we begin to suppress those feelings as they arise.

See how naturally this happens. A young child, jealous of his newborn sibling, is made to feel bad about his emotion; when he suffers hurt, he is distracted so he doesn't feel it fully; he is taught that it is brave not to cry. Seeds of emotional processing begin to take root in young, fertile minds. By the time we are adults, we have become outwardly poised, calm individuals, in control of our surroundings and expert at keeping our emotions in careful check.

Where do we hide our feelings? We repress them within – in various parts of our body. Anger hides in our liver, ruining our digestion and creating acidity; responsibility sits heavy on our shoulders; inability to let go of the past, of hurt and resentment causes constipation; financial insecurity might cause us discomfort in our lower back. Although these might seem like generalisations, they are the emotional components of our physical aches and pains. Understanding them can help us heal totally from the most dreaded disease. Will we take responsibility for our emotional health?

Let us learn to manage our emotions. All negative thoughts are caused by a disruption in the body's energy system. By learning a simple routine of tapping certain parts of our face and hands, the end points of energy meridians, these disruptions can be fixed – often within minutes. With awareness, we can lift ourselves out of irritation, restlessness, anxiety, fear and more. We can equally let go of long-term hurts and bitterness. We can manage stress, which needlessly saps our energy. We can also heal physical aches and pains with the same tool.

Once we begin emotion-management, we will begin to feel empowered. We will live in the present moment free of past burdens and future worries. We will learn the meaning of emotional freedom.

Article 74

Most of us think we know how to give feedback. Positive comments are better - and more useful - than negative ones. And if you do have to point out something wrong, start with a compliment, move on to the problem, then end on a high note.
It turns out that it's not that simple. Those who have studied the issue have found that negative feedback isn't always bad and positive feedback isn't always good. Too often, they say, we forget the purpose of feedback - it's not to make people feel better, it's to help them do better.

A recent research paper, "Tell Me What I did Wrong: Experts Seek and Respond to Negative Feedback," in The Journal of Consumer Research, says that when people are experts on a subject, or consider themselves

experts, they're more eager to hear negative feedback, while those who are novices are more likely to seek positive responses.

One experiment surveyed students in beginning-level French classes and advanced-level French literature classes. Participants completed a questionnaire (which they thought was from the French department) about choosing an instructor. They were asked if they would prefer an instructor who emphasized what students were doing well in class and talked about their strengths, such as when they pronounced new words well, or an instructor who focused mostly on what mistakes they made and how to fix those mistakes.

Those who had just started learning the language wanted the positive feedback, while those who had been taking the French classes longer were more interested in hearing about what they did wrong and how to correct it.

Why is that? One reason is that as people gain expertise, feedback serves a different purpose. When people are just beginning a venture, they may not have much confidence, and they need encouragement. But experts' commitment "is more secure than novices and their focus is on their progress," the paper's authors said. Even labelling feedback as either negative or positive isn't helpful, said Tim Harford, author of "Adapt: Why Success Always Starts with Failure." He noted that his karate teacher told him specific things to do, like bending his toes backward or rotating his hips.

"It's not useful to say, 'That's really good or that's really bad,'" Harford said. "We need to separate the emotional side from the technical points."

That, of course, is much easier said than done, which is why most of us have such trouble giving or getting critiques.

We don't want to be the bad guy. But Laura Ching, now chief design officer for Shutterfly Inc., found that she wasn't helping anyone when she tried to be, as she said, a people pleaser.

Early in her career, when she worked at Wal-Mart, she had to tell an employee that she wasn't doing a good job. But instead of spending 90 percent of the time telling her what she needed to do better and 10 percent encouraging her, "I probably did 50-50," Ching said. "And she heard only the positive. So when the annual review time came, and she got, 'does not meet expectations,' there was such a disconnect."

Harford knows the problem well. He calls it the "praise sandwich," where we stuff the bad stuff between two slices of compliments. But people often hear only the praise.

"We say, 'That was a great piece of work, there was just a small problem,'" Harford said. "What we tend to hear is, 'That was a great piece of work.'"

The better way, Ching said, is to be straightforward.
Research bears that out. In a class she teaches, AyeletFishbach, a professor of behavioral science and marketing at the University of Chicago Booth School of Business and co-author of the paper "Tell Me What I Did Wrong," conducts a simulation where half the class gives one-on-one feedback to the other half. Although the feedback givers were supposed to indicate that performance was unsatisfactory, that improvement was needed and to offer ways to do better, in surveys filled out later, the half getting the feedback "thinks they're doing great," she said. While many of us have a tendency to hear what we want to hear, Fishbach says she thinks the problem lies more with those providing the feedback.

"The negative feedback is often buried and not very specific," she said.

Fishbach also said people giving feedback often didn't give enough information, offered it too late or told subordinates what would happen if they did something wrong rather than what they were actually doing wrong. Employees need to know in detail what they should do to get promoted, for instance. If you tell them simply that they're not going to get promoted, she said, "That's not feedback - it's already an outcome."

Some companies have developed their own terminology for feedback. Peter Sims, author of "Little Bets: How Breakthrough Ideas Emerge From Small Discoveries," said the film company Pixar used an idea it called "plussing." The point, he said, is to "build and improve on ideas without using judgmental language."

Here's an example he offers in his book. An animator working on "Toy Story 3" shares her rough sketches and ideas with the director. "Instead of criticizing the sketch or saying 'no,' the director will build on the starting point by saying something like, 'I like Woody's eyes, and what if his eyes rolled left?"

Using words like "and" or "what if," rather than "but" is a way to offer suggestions and allow for the creative juices to flow without fear, Sims said.

Brain scans of people show that judgmental language - or even being told you have to do things in a certain way - lead to self-censoring, Sims told me. Such scans show that when a musician is playing scales, for example, "the part of the brain responsible for judging lights up," he said. "That doesn't happen when playing jazz improvisation."

Plussing is particularly helpful in the early stages, when there are lots of ways a character can progress, he said, but as ideas become more developed, it gets tougher.

"Animators at Pixar freely describe how painful it can be to have directors plussing their ideas until the smallest details, say a sliver of hair, seems just perfect," he writes in his book. "But plussing allows for both pointed critique and positive feedback simultaneously, so that even such persistent criticism is not deflating."

That's the trick then: making negative feedback precise and timely enough so that it's helpful but neutral enough so that it's not perceived as harshly critical. That's particularly difficult in a culture like ours, where anything short of effusive praise can be viewed as an affront.

But, again, if we look at feedback as an opportunity to make someone work better rather than feel better, we're more likely to do it successfully. As Fishbach said, "We're probably unaware that people would like to know how to improve, and they deserve to know it. It's their right.

Article 75

Many years ago, one mustard dominated the supermarket shelves: French's. It came in a plastic bottle. People used it on hot dogs and bologna. It was yellow mustard, made from ground white mustard seed with turmeric and vinegar, which gave it a mild, slightly metallic taste. if you looked hard in the grocery store, you might find something in the speciality-foods section called Grey Poupon, which was Dijon mustard, made from the more pungent brown mustard seed. In the early seventies, Grey Poupon was no more than a hundred-thousand dollar-a-year business. Few people knew what it was or how it tasted, or had any

particular desire for an alternative to French's or the runner-up, Gulden's. Then one day, the Heublein Company, which owned Grey Poupon, discovered something remarkable: if you gave people a mustard taste test, a significant number had only to try Grey Poupon once to switch from yellow mustard. In the food world that almost never happens; even among the most successful food brands, only about one in a hundred has that kind of conversion rate. Grey Poupon was magic.

So Heublein put Grey Poupon in a bigger glass jar, with an enamelled label and enough of a whiff of Frenchness to make it seem as if it were still being made in Europe (it was made in Hartford, Connecticut, from Canadian mustard seed and white wine). The company ran tasteful print ads in upscale food magazines. They put the mustard in little foil packets and distributed them with airplane meals — which was a brand-new idea at the time. Then they hired the Manhattan ad agency Lowe Marschalk to do something, on a modest budget, for television The agency came back with an idea: A Rolls-Royce is driving down a country road. There's a man in the backseat in a suit with a plate of beef on a silver tray. He nods to the chauffeur, who opens the glove compartment. Then comes what is known in the business world as the *reveal*. The chauffeur hands back a jar of Grey Poupon. Another Rolls Royce pulls up alongside. A man leans his hand out of the window. "Pardon me. Would you have any Grey Poupon?"

In the cities where the ads ran, sales of Grey Poupon leaped 40 to 50 percent, and whenever Heublein bought airtime in new cities sales jumped 40 to 50 percent again. Grocery stores put Grey Poupon next to French's and Gulden's. By the end of the 1980's Grey Poupon was the most powerful brand in mustard. "The tagline in the commercial was that this was one of life's finer pleasures." Larry Elegant, who wrote the original Grey Poupon spot, says, "and that, along with the Rolls Royce, seemed to impart to people's minds that this was something truly different and superior." The rise of Grey Poupon proved that the American supermarket shopper was willing to pay more –in this case $3.99 instead of $1.49 for eight ounces – as long as what they were buying carried with it an air of sophistication and complex aromatics. Its success showed, furthermore, that the boundaries of taste and custom were not fixed: that just because mustard had always been yellow didn't mean that customers would use 'only' yellow mustard. It is because of Grey Poupon that the standard American supermarket today has an entire mustard section. And it is because of Grey Poupon that a man named Jim Wigon decided, four years ago, to enter the ketchup business. Isn't the ketchup business today exactly where mustard was thirty years ago? There is Heinz and, far behind, Hunt's and Del Monte and a handful of private label brands. Jim Wagon wanted to create the Grey Poupon of ketchup. Wigon is from Boston. He runs his ketchup business under the brand World's Best Ketchup-out of the catering business of his partner, NichSchiarizzi, in Norwood, Massachusetts. He starts with red peppers, Spanish onions, garlic. and a high-end tomato paste. Basil is chopped by hand, because the buffalo chopper bruises the leaves. He uses maple syrup, not corn syrup, which gives him a quarter of the sugar of Heinz, He pours his ketchup into a clear ten-ounce jar, and sells its for three times the price of Heinz, and for the past few years he has crisscrossed the country, peddling World's Best in six regular, sweet, dill, garlic, caramelized onion, and basil to specialty grocery stores and supermarkets. If you were in Zabar's on Manhattan's Upper West Side a few months ago, you would have seen him at the front of the store, in the spot between the sushi and the fish. In front of him, on a small table, was a silver tureen filled with miniature chicken and beef meatballs, a box of toothpicks, and a dozen or so open jars of his ketchup. "Try my ketchup!" Wigon said, over and over, to anyone who passed. "If you don't try it, you're doomed to eat Heinz the rest of your life."

In the same aisle at Zabar's that day two other demonstrations were going on, so that people were starting at one end with free chicken sausage, sampling a slice of prosciutto, and then pausing at the World's Best stand before heading for the cash register. They would look down at the array of open jars, and Wigon would impale a meatball on a toothpick, dip it in one of his ketchups, and hand it to them with a flourish. The ratio of tomato solids to liquid in World's Best is much higher than in Heinz, and the maple syrup gives it an unmistakable sweet kick. Invariably, people would close their eyes, just for a moment, and do a subtle

double take. Some of them would look slightly perplexed and walk away, and others would nod and pick up a jar. "You know why you like it so much?" he would say, in his broad Boston accent, to the customers who seemed most impressed. "Because you have been eating bad ketchup all your life!" Jim Wigon had a simple vision: build a better ketchup – the way GreyPoupon built a better mustard – and the world will beat a path to your door.

Article 76

The American President Ronald Reagan once quipped, "The nine most terrifying words in the English language are, 'I'm from the government and I'm here to help.'" I get the same shivers when someone introduces themselves as an economist.

For, in its current form, the economics curriculum at Oxford and other Anglo-Saxon universities is far too detached from reality. Demand curves, utility maximization equations and abstract mathematical models serve only to distort the worldview of undergraduate students.
Why does this matter? It is simple. Oxford in particular has a firm grip on the British establishment. These bright young things will soon be entering the top echelons of corporate, finance and government circles. And as soon as they step into those offices, the same tired way of thinking about economics will perpetuate.

Economics is a social science. It is not a natural one, like psychics. Rather, economics is about people and their behavior. Some dismal scientists like to think otherwise. The heavy emphasis placed on mathematics, particularly at the postgraduate level, helps to lend a thin veneer of natural scientific legitimacy to the subject.

But it is the mark of an immature, insecure science when its practitioners speak in a convoluted, esoteric language known to only a chosen few. It wasn't always like this. The English economist John Maynard Keynes, a gifted statistician, didn't feel the need to write equation after equation in his famous work *The General Theory*. That didn't stop him getting his point across. Nor should it stop economists today.

Of course, there is no perfect way for a student to learn economics. Several "schools" of economic thought still rival each other for dominance in departments across the world. Interpretations of historical events, whether it's the Great Depression or the recent global financial crisis, can lead to fiery debates. Indeed, these divisions have given rise to a joke about economics exams: the questions remain the same each year, but the "correct" answers always change depending on which "school" is in vogue.

Students should therefore read widely and decide which theory, in their opinion, best fits our chaotic world. Well, at least that is the ideal scenario. The reality is somewhat different. In class students are usually given just one textbook, with one standard interpretation of how the world works. There are no debates, no contest of ideas and certainly no room for free thinking.

To pass exams, then, students often have to learn mathematical models that bear no relation to reality given the amount of unrealistic assumptions attached to the analysis. As a result, graduates leave the college gates with a bastardized version of economics, one that sticky-tapes bits of neoclassical, monetarist and rational expectations theory together in an incoherent fashion.

Oxford University has a proud history. Look at the origins of Politics, Philosophy and Economics (PPE), for instance, a course that schooled generations of leading politicians. The course traces its origins back to

1920, a time when economics was studied closely alongside its two brothers, politics and philosophy. Now, however, PPE students study the subject in complete isolation. There is little, if any, overlap with its erstwhile siblings. This is a dangerous situation.

What is to be done? An interdisciplinary approach is required from the start. Four key points stand out. First, introduce far more historical analysis to the undergraduate curriculum. Offer historical examples through which students can better understand and anchor a given theory. Secondly, acknowledge in lectures the fierce debates that are tearing the subject apart. This won't scare students. Rather, it will entice their interest and make economics sound like the exciting subject it actually is: a battlefield where ideas and policies fight it out.

Thirdly, offer more criticism to the mathematical models studied in class. Students aren't idiots. By highlighting flaws, you are allowing them to think critically while learning. The fourth point relates to language. Economists need to learn how to communicate their message effectively to a wider audience – for mathematical models can only show so much. Economists must learn to talk in simple, plain English.

All these changes need to happen soon. The dismal scientists like to talk about supply and demand. Well, how does the following sound? Economics departments are supplying us with a poor, naïve brand of economics. Let us demand a better one.

Article 77

Every conscious mental state has a qualitative character that we refer to as mood. We are always in a mood that is pleasurable or unpleasurable to some degree. It may be that bad moods relate to their being too positive reinforcement in a person's current life and too many punishments. In any case, moods are distinguished from emotions proper by not being tied to any specific object. But, this distinction is not watertight, in that emotions need not be directed at objects that are completely specific (we can be angry just at people generally) while there is always a sense of a mood having a general objective like the state of the world at large. Moods manifest themselves in positive or negative feelings that are tied to health, personality, or perceived quality of life. Moods can also relate to emotions proper as in the aftermath of an emotional incident such as the failure to secure a loan. A mood on this basis is the mind's judgment on the recent past. For Goldie, emotion can bubble up and down within a mood, while an emotion can involve characteristics that are non-object specific.

What is important fir marketing is that moods colour outlook and bias judgements. Hence the importance of consumer confidence surveys, as consumer confidence typically reflects national mood. There is mood congruence when thoughts and actions fall in-line with mood. As Goleman says, there is a "constant stream of feeling" that runs "in perfect to our steam of thought". Mood congruence occurs because a positive mood evokes pleasant associations that lighten subsequent appraisals (thoughts) and actions, while a negative arouses future judgment and behavior. When consumers are in a good mood, they are more optimistic about buying more confident in buying, and much more willing to tolerate things like waiting in line. On the other hand, being in a mood makes buying behaviour in the "right mood" by the use of music and friendly staff or, say, opens bakeries in shopping malls that delight the passer-by with the smell of fresh bread.
Thayer views moods as a mixture of biological and psychological influences and, as such, a sort of clinical thermometer, reflecting all the internal and external events that influence us. For Thayer, the key components of mood are energy and tension in different combinations. A specific mixture of energy and tension, together with the thoughts they influence, produces moods. He discuss four mood states:

- Calm - energy: he regards this as the optimal mood of feeling good

- Calm - tiredness: he regards this as feeling little tired without any stress, which can be pleasant.
- Tense - energy: involves low level of anxiety suited to a fight - or - flight disposition.
- Tense - tiredness: is mixture of fatigue and anxiety, which underlines the unpleasant feeling of depression.

People generally can "feel down" or "feel good" as result of happenings in the world around them. This represents the national mood. People feel elated when the national soccer team wins an international match or depressed when their team has lost. An elated mood of calm -energy is an optimistic mood, which is good for business. Consumers, as socially involved individuals, are deeply influenced by the prevailing social climate. Marketers recognize the phenomenon and talk about the national mood being, say for or against conspicuous consumption. Moods do change, though. Writing early in the nineteenth century.

Toqueville describers an American elite embarrassed by the ostentation of material display; in the "Gilded Age", sixty years later, many were only too eager to embrace a materialistic vulgarity. The problem lies in anticipating changes in national mood, since a change in mood affects everything from buying of equities to the buying of houses and washing machines. Thayer would argue that we should be interested in national events that are likely to produce a move towards a tense - tiredness state or toward a cam – energy state, since these are the polar extremes and are more likely to influence behavior. Artists sensitive to national moods express the long-term changes. An example is the long - tem emotional journey from hales Dickens' depiction of the death of little Nell to Oscar Wilde's cruel flippancy about it. "One would have to have a heart of stone not to laugh at the death of little Nell". Which reflects the mood change from high Victorian sentimentality to the acerbic cynicism of the end of the century, as shown in writers like Thomas Hardy and artists like Aubrey Beardsley.

Whenever the mid is not fully absorbed, consciousness is no longer focused and ordered. Under such conditions the mind falls into dwelling on the unpleasant, with a negative mood developing.

Csikszentmihalyi argues that humans need to keep consciousness fully active is what influences a good deal of consumer behaviour. Sometimes it does not matter what we are shopping for - the point is to shop for anything, regardless, as consuming is one way to respond to the void in consciousness when there is nothing else to do.

Article 78

It was a bright cold day in April, and the clocks were striking thirteen. Winston Smith, his chin nuzzled into his breast in an effort to escape the vile wind, slipped quickly through the glass doors of Victory Mansions, though not quickly enough to prevent a swirl of gritty dust from entering along with him.

The hallway smelt of boiled cabbage and old rag mats. At one end of it a coloured poster, too large for indoor display, had been tacked to the wall. It depicted simply an enormous face, more than a metre wide: the face of a man of about forty-five, with a heavy black moustache and ruggedly handsome features.

Winston made for the stairs. It was no use trying the lift. Even at the best of times it was seldom working, and at present the electric current was cut off during daylight hours. It was part of the economy drive in preparation for Hate Week. The flat was seven flights up, and Winston, who was thirty-nine and had a varicose ulcer above his right ankle, went slowly, resting several times on the way. On each landing,

opposite the lift-shaft, the poster with the enormous face gazed from the wall. It was one of those pictures which are so contrived that the eyes follow you about when you move. BIG BROTHER IS WATCHING YOU, the caption beneath it ran.

Inside the flat a fruity voice was reading out a list of figures which had something to do with the production of pig-iron. The voice came from an oblong metal plaque like a dulled mirror which formed part of the surface of the right-hand wall. Winston turned a switch and the voice sank somewhat, though the words were still distinguishable. The instrument (the telescreen, it was called) could be dimmed, but there was no way of shutting it off completely. He moved over to the window: a smallish, frail figure, the meagreness of his body merely emphasized by the blue overalls which were the uniform of the party. His hair was very fair, his face naturally sanguine, his skin roughened by coarse soap and blunt razor blades and the cold of the winter that had just ended.

Outside, even through the shut window-pane, the world looked cold. Down in the street little eddies of wind were whirling dust and torn paper into spirals, and though the sun was shining and the sky a harsh blue, there seemed to be no colour in anything, except the posters that were plastered everywhere. The black-moustachio'd face gazed down from every commanding corner. There was one on the house-front immediately opposite. BIG BROTHER IS WATCHING YOU, the caption said, while the dark eyes looked deep into Winston's own. Down at streetlevel another poster, torn at one corner, flapped fitfully in the wind, alternately covering and uncovering the single word INGSOC. In the far distance a helicopter skimmed down between the roofs, hovered for an instant like a bluebottle, and darted away again with a curving flight. It was the police patrol, snooping into people's windows. The patrols did not matter, however. Only the Thought Police mattered.

Behind Winston's back the voice from the telescreen was still babbling away about pig-iron and the overfulfilment of the Ninth Three-Year Plan. The telescreen received and transmitted simultaneously. Any sound that Winston made, above the level of a very low whisper, would be picked up by it, moreover, so long as he remained within the field of vision which the metal plaque commanded, he could be seen as well as heard. There was of course no way of knowing whether you were being watched at any given moment. How often, or on what system, the Thought Police plugged in on any individual wire was guesswork. It was even conceivable that they watched everybody all the time. But at any rate they could plug in your wire whenever they wanted to. You had to live — did live, from habit that became instinct — in the assumption that every sound you made was overheard, and, except in darkness, every movement scrutinized.

Winston kept his back turned to the telescreen. It was safer, though, as he well knew, even a back can be revealing. A kilometre away the Ministry of Truth, his place of work, towered vast and white above the grimy landscape. This, he thought with a sort of vague distaste — this was London, chief city of Airstrip One, itself the third most populous of the provinces of Oceania. He tried to squeeze out some childhood memory that should tell him whether London had always been quite like this. Were there always these vistas of rotting nineteenth-century houses, their sides shored up with baulks of timber, their windows patched with cardboard and their roofs with corrugated iron, their crazy garden walls sagging in all directions? And the bombed sites where the plaster dust swirled in the air and the willow-herb straggled over the heaps of rubble; and the places where the bombs had cleared a larger patch and there had sprung up sordid colonies of wooden dwellings like chicken-houses? But it was no use, he could not remember: nothing remained of his childhood except a series of bright-lit tableaux occurring against no background and mostly unintelligible.

The Ministry of Truth—Minitrue, in Newspeak*—was startlingly different from any other object in sight. It was an enormous pyramidal structure of glittering white concrete, soaring up, terrace after terrace, 300

metres into the air. From where Winston stood it was just possible to read, picked out on its white face in elegant lettering, the three slogans of the Party:
WAR IS PEACE
FREEDOM IS SLAVERY
IGNORANCE IS STRENGTH

The Ministry of Truth contained, it was said, three thousand rooms above ground level, and corresponding ramifications below. Scattered about London there were just three other buildings of similar appearance and size. So completely did they dwarf the surrounding architecture that from the roof of Victory Mansions you could see all four of them simultaneously. They were the homes of the four Ministries between which the entire apparatus of government was divided. The Ministry of Truth, which concerned itself with news, entertainment, education, and the fine arts. The Ministry of Peace, which concerned itself with war. The Ministry of Love, which maintained law and order. And the Ministry of Plenty, which was responsible for economic affairs. Their names, in Newspeak: Minitrue, Minipax, Miniluv, and Miniplenty.

The Ministry of Love was the really frightening one. There were no windows in it at all. Winston had never been inside the Ministry of Love, nor within half a kilometre of it. It was a place impossible to enter except on official business, and then only by penetrating through a maze of barbed-wire entanglements, steel doors, and hidden machine-gun nests. Even the streets leading up to its outer barriers were roamed by gorilla-faced guards in black uniforms, armed with jointed truncheons.

Article 79

DO YOU WANT TO IMPROVE an important aspect of your life? Perhaps lose weight, find your perfect partner, obtain your dream job, or simply be happier? Try this simple exercise. …

Close your eyes and imagine the new you. Think how great you would look in those close-fitting designer jeans, dating Brad Pitt or Angelina Jolie, sitting in a luxurious leather chair at the top of the corporate ladder, or sipping a piña colada as the warm waves of the Caribbean gently lap at your feet.

The good news is that this type of exercise has been recommended by some in the self-help industry for years. The bad news is that a large body of research now suggests that such exercises are, at best, ineffective and, at worst, harmful. Although imagining your perfect self may make you feel better, engaging in such mental escapism can also have the unfortunate side effect of leaving you unprepared for the difficulties that crop up on the rocky road to success, thus increasing the chances of your faltering at the first hurdle rather than persisting in the face of failure. Fantasizing about heaven on earth may put a smile on your face, but it is unlikely to help transform your dreams into reality.

Other research suggests that the same goes for many popular techniques that claim to improve your life. Attempting to "think yourself happy" by suppressing negative thoughts can make you obsess on the very thing that makes you unhappy. Group brainstorming can produce fewer and less original ideas than individuals working alone. Punching a pillow and screaming out loud can increase, rather than decrease, your anger and stress levels.

Then there is the infamous "Yale Goal Study." According to some writers, in 1953 a team of researchers interviewed Yale's graduating seniors, asking them whether they had written down the specific goals that they wanted to achieve in life. Twenty years later the researchers tracked down the same cohort and found that the 3 percent of people who had specific goals all those years before had accumulated more personal wealth than the other 97 percent of their classmates combined. It is a great story, frequently cited in self-help books and seminars to illustrate the power of goal setting. There is just one small problem—as far as anyone can tell, the experiment never actually took place. In 2007 writer Lawrence Tabak, from the magazine Fast Company, attempted to track down the study, contacting several writers who had cited it, the secretary of the Yale Class of 1953, and other researchers who had tried to discover whether the study had actually happened. No one could produce any evidence that it had ever been conducted, causing Tabak to conclude that it was almost certainly nothing more than an urban myth. For years, self-help gurus had been happy to describe a study without checking their facts.

Both the public and the business world have bought into modern-day mind myths for years and, in so doing, may have significantly decreased the likelihood of achieving their aims and ambitions. Worse still, such failure often encourages people to believe that they cannot control their lives. This is especially unfortunate, as even the smallest loss of perceived control can have a dramatic effect on people's confidence, happiness, and life span. In one classic study conducted by Ellen Langer at Harvard University, half of the residents in a nursing home were given a houseplant and asked to look after it, while the other residents were given an identical plant but told that the staff would take responsibility for it. Six months later, the residents who had been robbed of even this small amount of control over their lives were significantly less happy, healthy, and active than the others. Even more distressing, 30 percent of the residents who had not looked after their plant had died, compared to 15 percent of those who had been allowed to exercise such control. Similar results have been found in many areas, including education, career, health, relationships, and dieting. The message is clear—those who do not feel in control of their lives are less successful, and less psychologically and physically healthy, than those who do feel in control.

Article 80

One way to think about work-life balance is with a concept known as The Four Burners Theory. Here's how it was first explained to me:

Imagine that your life is represented by a stove with four burners on it. Each burner symbolizes one major quadrant of your life.

The first burner represents your family.
The second burner is your friends.
The third burner is your health.
The fourth burner is your work.
The Four Burners Theory says that "in order to be successful you have to cut off one of your burners. And in order to be really successful you have to cut off two."

Three Views of the Four Burners
My initial reaction to The Four Burners Theory was to search for a way to bypass it. "Can I succeed and keep all four burners running?" I wondered.

Perhaps I could combine two burners. "What if I lumped family and friends into one category?"

Maybe I could combine health and work. "I hear sitting all day is unhealthy. What if I got a standing desk?" Now, I know what you are thinking. Believing that you will be healthy because you bought a standing desk is like believing you are a rebel because you ignored the fasten seatbelt sign on an airplane, but whatever.

Soon I realized I was inventing these workarounds because I didn't want to face the real issue: life is filled with tradeoffs. If you want to excel in your work and in your marriage, then your friends and your health may have to suffer. If you want to be healthy and succeed as a parent, then you might be forced to dial back your career ambitions. Of course, you are free to divide your time equally among all four burners, but you have to accept that you will never reach your full potential in any given area.

Essentially, we are forced to choose. Would you rather live a life that is unbalanced, but high-performing in a certain area? Or would you rather live a life that is balanced, but never maximizes your potential in a given quadrant?

What is the best way to handle these work-life balance problems? I don't claim to have it figured out, but here are three ways of thinking about The Four Burners Theory.

Before we talk about how to get started, I wanted to let you know I researched and compiled science-backed ways to stick to good habits and stop procrastinating. Want to check out my insights? Download my free PDF guide "Transform Your Habits" here.

Option 1: Outsource Burners
We outsource small aspects of our lives all the time. We buy fast food so we don't have to cook. We go to the dry cleaners to save time on laundry. We visit the car repair shop so we don't have to fix our own automobile.

Outsourcing small portions of your life allows you to save time and spend it elsewhere. Can you apply the same idea to one quadrant of your life and free up time to focus on the other three burners?

Work is the best example. For many people, work is the hottest burner on the stove. It is where they spend the most time and it is the last burner to get turned off. In theory, entrepreneurs and business owners can outsource the work burner. They do it by hiring employees.

In my article on The 3 Stages of Failure, I covered Sam Carpenter's story about building business systems that allowed him to work just 2 hours per week. He outsourced himself from the daily work of the business while still reaping the financial benefits.

Parenting is another example. Working parents are often forced to "outsource" the family burner by dropping their children off at daycare or hiring a babysitter. Calling this outsourcing might seem unfair, but—like the work example above—parents are paying someone else to keep the burner running while they use their time elsewhere.

The advantage of outsourcing is that you can keep the burner running without spending your time on it. Unfortunately, removing yourself from the equation is also a disadvantage. Most entrepreneurs, artists, and creators I know would feel bored and without a sense of purpose if they had nothing to work on each day. Every parent I know would rather spend time with their children than drop them off at daycare.

Outsourcing keeps the burner running, but is it running in a meaningful way?

Option 2: Embrace Constraints
One of the most frustrating parts of The Four Burners Theory is that it shines a light on your untapped potential. It can be easy to think, "If only I had more time, I could make more money or get in shape or spend more time at home."

One way to manage this problem is to shift your focus from wishing you had more time to maximizing the time you have. In other words, you embrace your limitations. The question to ask yourself is, "Assuming a particular set of constraints, how can I be as effective as possible?"

For example:
Assuming I can only work from 9 AM to 5 PM, how can I make the most money possible?
Assuming I can only write for 15 minutes each day, how can I finish my book as fast as possible?
Assuming I can only exercise for 3 hours each week, how can I get in the best shape possible?
This line of questioning pulls your focus toward something positive (getting the most out of what you have available) rather than something negative (worrying about never having enough time). Furthermore, well-designed limitations can actually improve your performance.

Of course, there are disadvantages as well. Embracing constraints means accepting that you are operating at less than your full potential. Yes, there are plenty of ways to "work smarter, not harder" but it is difficult to avoid the fact that where you spend your time matters. If you invested more time into your health or your relationships or your career, you would likely see improved results in that area.

Option 3: The Seasons of Life
A third way to manage your four burners is by breaking your life into seasons. What if, instead of searching for perfect work-life balance at all times, you divided your life into seasons that focused on a particular area?

The importance of your burners may change throughout life. When you are in your 20s or 30s and you don't have children, it can be easier to get to the gym and chase career ambitions. The health and work burners are on full blast. A few years later, you might start a family and suddenly the health burner dips down to a slow simmer while your family burner gets more gas. Another decade passes and you might revive relationships with old friends or pursue that business idea you had been putting off.

You don't have to give up on your dreams forever, but life rarely allows you to keep all four burners going at once. Maybe you need to let go of something for this season. You can do it all in a lifetime, but not at the same damn time. In the words of Nathan Barry, "Commit to your goal with everything you have—for a season."

Furthermore, there is often a multiplier effect that occurs when you dedicate yourself fully to a given area. In many cases, you can achieve more by going all-in on a given task for a few years than by giving it a lukewarm effort for fifty years. Maybe it is best to strive for seasons of imbalance and rotate through them as needed.

For the last five years, I have been in my entrepreneurship season. I built a successful business, but it came with costs. I turned my friends burner way down and my family burner is only running halfway.

What season are you in right now?

Work-Life Balance: Which Burners Have You Cut Off?

The Four Burners Theory reveals a truth everyone must deal with: nobody likes being told they can't have it all, but everyone has constraints on their time and energy. Every choice has a cost.

Which burners have you cut off?

Article 81

Mike J. is a venture capitalist who works on Silicon Valley's famed Sand Hill Road. He's good at his job–rising from intern to principal in only two years. His secret? An Excel spreadsheet he uses to track how he spends every hour of his workday.

To understand the importance of this spreadsheet, you should first understand the difference between working hard and actually getting better at your job.

Most knowledge workers—a group that, I suspect, includes just about anybody reading these words—don't differentiate among their activities; any time spent at the office counts as "work." Mike, by contrast, embraces a conclusion that's well supported in the field of performance psychology, the discipline that studies how people become great at what they do: Not all work is equal.

Simply put, there's a difference between doing things you already know how to do and doing things that force you to stretch and improve your skills. Psychology professor K. Anders Ericsson, a leader in this field, explains that a person in a new job usually spends some time training or shadowing someone else to get up to speed, but after that, his or her abilities tend to plateau. Beyond this point, they don't get much better at their job, though they grow more experienced.

To get better—and win the promotions and opportunities most of us dream about—we must set out to intentionally improve our performance. In studying why some people develop remarkable careers, this is a key unheralded distinction between the average knowledge worker and the stars at most companies: the former work hard while the latter systematically train hard skills. Ericsson called this type of structured activity *deliberate practice*, and in his decades of research on the topic he's found it to be the key for expert performance in every field he has studied—from elite scientists to elite jugglers.

This brings us back to Mike. His spreadsheet tracking forces him to spend a certain number of hours each week not just working but instead deliberately improving his skills. In the spreadsheet he shared with me, he spent around 60% of his time pushing himself, performing difficult, and ultimately crucial training tasks such as calling potential investors or polishing due diligence reports.

Here's how to integrate this strategy into your workday:
Deliberate practice requires clarity. Set a clear goal slightly beyond your current abilities, but not too far beyond, and list specific actions that advance you toward your goal. In Mike's example, a specific goal might include increasing the rate at which potential investor calls prompt follow-up conversations. The specific actions might include making a certain number of these calls each week (regardless of whether he feels like it) and giving his full focus in each call toward deploying his best pitch.

Deliberate practice requires feedback. Assuming you don't reach your goal on the first try, you need a source of objective feedback so that you can improve on your next iteration. Without frank, even harsh,

feedback, your progress will likely stall. Returning to Mike's example of investor calls, he could keep careful notes on what differentiated the successful and non-successful interactions, or he could ask a partner at the firm to listen in and then offer thoughts.

Deliberate practice is unpleasant. You have to stretch yourself beyond where you're currently comfortable—not a pleasant feeling. Most knowledge workers inadvertently end up avoiding deliberate practice-style activities because they retreat to checking email the moment a task gets too difficult. To make deliberate practice work, you must not only tolerate unpleasantness (and stick with the task, regardless of your urge for relieving distraction), but learn to seek it, like a bodybuilder seeks muscle burn. Mike recognized that, if left unchecked, his instinct would be to reply to e-mails all day, so he used his time-tracking spreadsheet to force himself to engage in unpleasant, though ultimately rewarding work. If you don't have a similar strategy in your schedule, it's unlikely to happen.

Success in knowledge work requires more than simply showing up early, staying late, and responding quickly to every email. True standouts systematically develop rare and valuable skills. Building these skills requires practice, and it is not something that you gravitate toward naturally. Like Mike, you must take a rigorous approach to improve your workday.

Article 82

"To get something you never had, you have to do something you never did." ~Unknown
Heroes inspire us all. They are strong, smart, and powerful. They manage to win against all odds. They will keep going no matter what.

They may feel fear but fear does not get them. And just when you thought that they were done, it was over, and that there was no way they could overturn the situation, they rise back out of the blue, strike, and win!

Then they cross the finish line. Glory awaits them. From now on everyone will remember them for the great people they were.
Oh, the path of glory.

We get addicted to this path. We want to be heroes so badly. And we fight, we do our best, we give our all, yet many of us are failing.

I didn't recognize the reason behind our shortcomings until I realized that there are actually two types of heroes: the glory-focused type and the down-to-earth type.
Let's take exercise and healthy eating as an example.
Many people decide to live healthier, especially in January with New Year's Resolutions.
They believe that this time they will make it happen! Glory awaits them! And they march. Full-speed. They do very well—at least in the first few weeks.

Then they slowly start running out of steam. They cannot hold on to their diets as they did, and they skip more and more workouts. A large percentage of them will have quit by the second week of February.
No glory for the quitters, only blame and guilt. They didn't try hard enough. They gave up too easily. They were lazy. Or, they just did not want to change badly enough.

That's what I thought a few years back when I realized that, despite my best intentions, I had gained twelve pounds in two years, I was eating out most of the time, and my exercise habits were yo-yoing.

This is when I realized that if I let this trend continue, I would become fat and unhealthy in just a few years. Because that's how pounds creep in—insidiously. We put on a few every year until one day we wake up and wonder how we got there.

I needed to find a way to change my lifestyle, and do so permanently. No more exercise five times this week, but no exercise next week. No more salads daily for two weeks, and then a more or less permanent break from vegetables.
I needed to create healthy habits—ones that stick.
So I got into researching how habits work, and here is what I found out, to my surprise:

The truth is that most of us who are inconsistent or quit our journey are not lazy, do not give in too easily, and did try our best!
We failed because we focused on pushing toward glory.

This approach is great for short-term quests. Motivation and willpower are great tools to tackle short-term goals. However, living healthier is a long-term lifestyle change, and it requires a different approach.
Motivation naturally drops after we get started with the quest, and just living life depletes willpower—going to work, doing things for our family we didn't really want to do, going through a decluttering project that leaves us super-tired…

Why? Because this is how our brain is wired.
For the sake of simplicity, let's divide the mind in the executive (or conscious) and habitual (or unconscious) parts.

The conscious part is responsible for your rational thoughts and speech, while the unconscious part takes care of your emotions and reactions, as well as everything you do when you are on auto-pilot: driving, eating, brushing your teeth, and so on.

Guess which part of your brain controls our habits? You are right; it's the unconscious one.
Translation?
Well, you cannot, for example, decide that from now on you will be going to the gym six times a week for an hour and a half each time.
To be accurate, you *can* actually make this decision, but even if you do, it won't matter—at least not after the first week.
Why?

Because you make these decisions with rational thought, using the conscious part of your brain. However, the conscious part of your brain has no control over habits.

You've just decided to alter your habits, but the unconscious part of your brain is the habits lord and the boss! What you have control of is maybe the following week, but the following year? No. This is under the boss' authority.
Did the unconscious part of your brain agree with your well-thought-out resolution to become a gym junkie?

Not really.

If the boss does not approve the plan, then the plan does not get carried out. If you would like to live healthier and yet you don't, then the boss hasn't approved your plan yet.
This is why so many people quit their resolutions in February. They haven't yet persuaded the boss! This is how I gained twelve pounds in two years—the boss had not approved any of my healthy-living plans.
So the question becomes: How can you persuade the boss to make a lasting lifestyle change?

The boss does not respond well to the glory-seeking hero's journey. That hero's journey is great for our executive brain, but not for our habitual brain.

Our habitual brain (the boss) actually responds well to the exact opposite—the down-to-earth hero's journey.
1. Glory-seeking heroes attempt *big* change. Down-to-earth heroes go for mini change.
Big changes turn on your boss' fight-or-flight response (run by the amygdala in your brain). When change is big, the boss chooses flight.
Try mini change instead to avoid waking up the amygdala. Five minutes of exercise a day may not impress your executive brain, but they do wonders with the boss.

2. Glory-seeking heroes take quests that are hard. Down-to-earth heroes take quests that feel easy.
Easy quests make you feel accomplishment and send positive messages to the boss to keep going.
The boss cannot wait to get more of that! It loves feeling accomplished. Habits are built and you are well on your way to success.

Now, I have nothing against glory-seeking heroes. I think they are awesome! But at the same time I think that the path of glory led me astray, and keeps leading astray many others.
Long-term success is not just about the amount of effort you devote, even though effort does work for short-term goals. Long-term goals need consistency.

In their quest for glory many people lose weight only to gain it back later. They didn't have the boss' approval. They didn't build the habits that would help them with weight maintenance.

I've learned that if I follow the boss' way, I will get the results I want. And I will get to glory. I will be a hero, not just for a few months but also for the rest of my life.
And I will do all that without guilt, trying harder, or self-whipping—evidence of a boss that has not approved the plan yet. Instead, I will do it with ease and comfort.

I now exercise five times a week consistently, I have learned to cook, and I eat at home every day! Oh, and the side effect? Losing the twelve pounds I had put on.
What change are you trying to create, and what mini step can you take today to start forming a habit that sticks?

Article 83

Let's face it. Looks are important, even if your car is being used just to take you from A to B. Though looks are subjective, you need to know how good your car is under the skin. Is it tough enough to withstand the rigours of our roads or even an accident?

The Beat is the most modern design over here. Face-lifted in mid-2012, it's a stunning design with those gorgeous detailing likes those clear headlamps and shapely tail-lights. It is well proportioned, the wide track giving it a squat and purposeful look. The Beat's chassis or body is the toughest around, with an extra helping of stiffness and rigidity to withstand the worst roads in the world. The Beat is a heavy car, the heaviest in its class. But what does weight mean to you? A rule of thumb is that the heavier the car the more safe and sturdy it is, but on the flip side weight penalizes fuel economy and makes a car more ponderous to drive.

Similar in size and mirroring virtually the same design concept, the Polo is the Beat's natural rival. To many it is even better looking, even though it is such a familiar face. But the Polo's real plus point is its size, even larger than the Beat in key areas like width and wheelbase; this generates more passenger space. Though the build quality and fit and finish are not on a par with the Beat, the improved V2 model should not give owners much to complain about.

The Zen is a car that has aged gracefully. Several minor spruce-ups along the way have helped. Customers still love its cheeky looks, one of the reasons why it continues to sell so well. Light and compact, it comes with that 'halka' Maruti feel which you experience every time you shut the door. Fit and finish of the Zen is still good after all these years but rattles do tend to creep in after hard use.

The Alto, which is essentially the next-generation Zen, is a much more modern car, though ironically the styling is seen to be more conservative. The Alto's chunky design with its fat C-pillar looks more robust than the Zen and not surprisingly it is. The Alto's body is surprisingly rigid and tough for a car of its size. Don't forget the more modern a car the tougher it has to be to meet safety standards. It's not a car that will turn heads, but neither will it turn anyone off.

That honour goes to the Wagon R and Santro-Xing. Both these tall boys look like skyscrapers on wheels, the Wagon R more so as it is 70 mm taller than the Santro. Under that quirky styling is a clever little car with solid underpinnings and neat packaging. The amount of space the Wagon R has managed to liberate in the footprint the size of the Alto's is amazing. It's the same with the Santro, which comes with similar philosophy of a high-rise building. The only way to provide more space within a given area is to go up. Though the Santro is better proportioned, we still can't get used to its hideous styling. But after a few face-lifts and the fact that it has earned an awesome reputation as a great little car for itself, the looks have become palatable to many.

The Spark, essentially the erstwhileMatizre-christened by GM, still comes as a breath of fresh air and its stylish looks has been one of its strongest assets. It's a well-designed and packaged car as well. The tight packaging of the engine and stretch of the A-pillar gives it a semi-monospace design that maximizes passenger space. In fact, the Spark has more rear legroom than some of the bigger cars!

Article 84

While pursuing higher studies in the US, we often had these so-called patriotic discussions and talks of entering politics to clean the mess. During one such discussion, I remember one of my friends saying something which I can very well relate today - people in India will lap up NRIs entering politics. Dissecting this sentence further, what he exactly meant was that people in India are usually impressed with "foreign

returned" Indians who speak fluent English and hence, it will be relatively easy for the NRIs to enter politics.

Irrespective of the NRI status, over the years I have realised that fluent English goes a long way in impressing a large section of us. And especially when it is social media, where the only way you can impress is either by your intelligence or by flaunting a good vocabulary (well there are other ways too ...like joining the pseudo-secular bandwagon). The recent incident on Twitter of one such conman from Assam known for his nice vocabulary is a case in point. NilimDutta masqueraded as an executive director of some strategic and research organisation and if reports are to be believed as a fake RAW agent. His expose left several folks on Twitter in shock although there were many who already knew about his alleged frauds.

But this blog is not about him and his alleged frauds. It is about a more worrying trend in India - our attitude of admiration towards fluent English speaking folks and taking them at face value. Two major areas where a large section of Indians have shown such a gullible mindset are media and politics. The fact that several in the media fraternity are being treated as celebs (mostly from English media) is a testimony to the fact that if you speak fluent English, articulate your thoughts well, more often than not you will get away with some illogical and at times nonsensical arguments. We all know about the infamous Radia tapes. The journalists involved without a doubt were extremely fluent in English but the controversy made us realise that there is much more beyond fluent English. I would like to add that of late, these celebs are getting some severe criticism as people have started to look beyond their fluent English.

Even in politics, this attitude of being awe-struck at hearing politicians speak fluent and articulate English and accepting their gibberish is becoming a norm. Why is that we make fun of Mamata Banerjee and get impressed by a worse performing Omar Abdullah? Not too long ago we all were highly impressed by the suave US and UN-returned ShashiTharoor. In our polity where grassroots leaders are not that fluent in English, not that articulate while speaking in English, and probably perceived as more corrupt, it was a welcome relief to see educated folks entering the stage. ShashiTharoor fitted the bill perfectly for an Indian middle class which was longing for some suave and educated faces in politics. But then came the sweat equity issue. Perhaps for AshishNandy, his ilk, and the English media, this was not a major controversial issue since it involved one of their like-minded well spoken Mr Tharoor. Then you have the likes of Harvard-educated Mr Chidambaram, Oxford-educated Mr Khurshid, and our dear Prime Minister, the Oxford-educated Dr Manmohan Singh. Interestingly, English media chooses not to go ballistic on alleged corruption charges on them while they will demand immediate answers in their kangaroo courts from lesser suave men. A quick look at the so-called social activists at prime time debates who have almost zilch to show on their resumes regarding their "social" contribution get away with absurd arguments by dint of their fluency.

I am not against fluent English speaking and foreign-educated people. There are many both in media and in politics (cutting across party lines) who are doing a decent job and we need them. All I am saying is to never take anyone at face value. Let us not give benefit of doubt to people just because they are well-educated and can articulately give a spin to their misdeeds. Let us all learn to look beyond their fluent English, suavity, and foreign degrees. There are many people in India who may not be as articulate and fluent in English but are doing a commendable job in their fields.

Lastly, as the 2014 elections close in, several comparisons will be made between the Gandhi scion, Rahul Gandhi, and BJP's development mascot NarendraModi. I have a feeling that one of those comparisons will be along the lines of suavity, foreign education and fluency in English. How the future of India is decided will depend on whether we want to look beyond suavity and fluent English.

Article 85

Have you tagged a price to your dream? Are you ready to sell your dream for a cost? Or would you hold on to your dream and not sell it for a fortune?

I will tell you the story, a real story, of **Sylvester Stallone**. When Sylvester Stallone was not **the** Sylvester Stallone as we know him today life was miserable for him. Before his big breakthrough with **ROCKY**, he was a nobody. He earned a bare minimum for his survival from film roles that no one wanted.

During the early part of his acting career, he took part in some soft porn films. It was a matter of survival for him. Once he recounted how he had to live at a New York City Port Authority bus station for three weeks while waiting for an assignment that eventually paid him $200.

Yes, it is true that at that time he was a nobody to people, but he was someone big to himself. His only dream in life was to become a writer/actor. He clinched on to that dream even when the environment he was in and people around him beat him to the ground. He knew how to and he did get up and continue living his dream. And this courage and spirit did become the trademark of all his ROCKY films.

His big break came after watching a boxing match involving the great Muhammad Ali and Chuck Wepner in March of 1975. Wepner was a nobody against the greatest heavyweight champion of the world. Yet, he never knew how to quit. This was enough to inspire someone like Stallone. He was so inspired that he came home and wrote the original script of ROCKY in 20 straight hours.

Stallone did not just write the script, but he also knew that this was his own dream. He must be ROCKY no matter what. This was the dream he wanted to live and as time tells us he did.

A film producer did decide to take his script and start the movie production, and the company was willing to pay Stallone big bucks for it, the only problem was – Stallone wanted to be ROCKY.

But the producers were not willing to put an ugly guy (it was their perception of Stallone, I still think he is raw and handsome as hell) who could not speak properly as the male lead. But Stallone was not yielding, so they began raising the offer to prevent Stallone from starring in his own movie. That price eventually came to $325,000. And let me tell you, that amount was a fortune in 1970s. But Stallone was not ready to sell his dream at any cost, even the entire world. He did not relent and was ready to walk out of the deal. This was how strongly he believed in his dream.

Finally, the producers relented and allowed Stallone to be ROCKY in their new movie, but they also reduced the amount paid to Stallone to $35,000. Stallone was ready to hold on to his dream no matter what.

ROCKY eventually won Best Picture, Best Directing and Best Film Editing at the Academy Awards. Since then, there were another five ROCKY films, each inspiring millions more to look at their lives and live their dreams no matter what.

What would have happened if Stallone sold his script for $325,000? He would not have done justice to the very spirit of ROCKY itself.

ROCKY is always about getting knocked down but never knocked out. It epitomized the true human spirit of going the distance no matter what. How have you been knocked down lately? How are you reacting to those knockdowns? Is life too hard sometimes?

Life is hard because it calls on us to do the impossible. Life believes in us! Do we believe in ourselves? I end with this famous quote from **ROCKY BALBOA** in the last of the ROCKY films:

The world isn't all sunshine and rainbows. It's a very mean and nasty place and it don't care how tough you are, it will beat you to your knees and keep you there permanently if you let it. You, me, or nobody is going to hit as hard as life. But it isn't about how hard you hit. It's about how hard you can get it and keep moving forward. How much you can take and keep moving forward. That's how winning is done!
- ROCKY BALBOA

SET-4

Article 86

The Matrix presents a version of an old philosophical fable: the brain in a vat. A disembodied brain is floating in a vat, inside a scientist's laboratory. The scientist has arranged that the brain will be stimulated with the same sort of inputs that a normal embodied brain receives. To do this, the brain is connected to a giant computer simulation of a world. The simulation determines which inputs the brain receives. When the brain produces outputs, these are fed back into the simulation. The internal state of the brain is just like that of a normal brain, despite the fact that it lacks a body. From the brain's point of view, things seem very much as they seem to you and me.

The brain is massively deluded, it seems. It has all sorts of false beliefs about the world. It believes that it has a body, but it has no body. It believes that it is walking outside in the sunlight, but in fact it is inside a dark lab. It believes it is one place, when in fact it may be somewhere quite different. Perhaps it thinks it is in Tucson, when it is actually in Australia, or even in outer space.

Neo's situation at the beginning of The Matrix is something like this. He thinks that he lives in a city, he thinks that he has hair, he thinks it is 1999, and he thinks that it is sunny outside. In reality, he is floating in space, he has no hair, the year is around 2199, and the world has been darkened by war. There are a few small differences from the vat scenario above: Neo's brain is located in a body, and the computer simulation is controlled by machines rather than by a scientist. But the essential details are much the same. In effect, Neo is a brain in a vat.

Let's say that a matrix (lower-case "m") is an artificially-designed computer simulation of a world. So the Matrix in the movie is one example of a matrix. And let's say that someone is envatted, or that they are in a matrix, if they have a cognitive system which receives its inputs from and sends its outputs to a matrix. Then the brain at the beginning is envatted, and so is Neo.

We can imagine that a matrix simulates the entire physics of a world, keeping track of every last particle throughout space and time. (Later, we will look at ways in which this set-up might be varied.) An envatted being will be associated with a particular simulated body. A connection is arranged so that whenever this body receives sensory inputs inside the simulation, the envatted cognitive system will receive sensory inputs of the same sort. When the envatted cognitive system produces motor outputs, corresponding outputs will be fed to the motor organs of the simulated body.

When the possibility of a matrix is raised, a question immediately follows. How do I know that I am not in a matrix? After all, there could be a brain in a vat structured exactly like my brain, hooked up to a matrix,

with experiences indistinguishable from those I am having now. From the inside, there is no way to tell for sure that I am not in the situation of the brain in a vat. So it seems that there is no way to know for sure that I am not in a matrix.

Let us call the hypothesis that I am in a matrix and have always been in a matrix the Matrix Hypothesis. Equivalently, the Matrix Hypothesis says that I am envatted and have always been envatted. This is not quite equivalent to the hypothesis that I am in the Matrix, as the Matrix is just one specific version of a matrix. For now, I will ignore the some complications that are specific to the Matrix in the movie, such as the fact that people sometimes travel back and forth between the Matrix and the external world. These issues aside, we can think of the Matrix Hypothesis informally as saying that I am in the same sort of situation as people who have always been in the Matrix.

The Matrix Hypothesis is one that we should take seriously. As Nick Bostrom has suggested, it is not out of the question that in the history of the universe, technology will evolve that will allow beings to create computer simulations of entire worlds. There may well be vast numbers of such computer simulations, compared to just one real world. If so, there may well be many more beings who are in a matrix than beings who are not. Given all this, one might even infer that it is more likely that we are in a matrix than that we are not. Whether this is right or not, it certainly seems that we cannot be certain that we are not in a matrix.

Serious consequences seem to follow. My envatted counterpart seems to be massively deluded. It thinks it is in Tucson; it thinks it is sitting at a desk writing an article; it thinks it has a body. But on the face of it, all of these beliefs are false. Likewise, it seems that if I am envatted, my own corresponding beliefs are false. If I am envatted, I am not really in Tucson, I am not really sitting at a desk, and I may not even have a body. So if I don't know that I am not envatted, then I don't know that I am in Tucson, I don't know that I am sitting at a desk, and I don't know that I have a body.

The Matrix Hypothesis threatens to undercut almost everything I know. It seems to be a skeptical hypothesis: a hypothesis that I cannot rule out, and one that would falsify most of my beliefs if it were true. Where there is a skeptical hypothesis, it looks like none of these beliefs count as genuine knowledge. Of course the beliefs might be true — I might be lucky, and not be envatted — but I can't rule out the possibility that they are false. So a skeptical hypothesis leads to skepticism about these beliefs: I believe these things, but I do not know them.

To sum up the reasoning: I don't know that I'm not in a matrix. If I'm in a matrix, I'm probably not in Tucson. So if I don't know that I'm not in a matrix, then I don't know that I'm in Tucson. The same goes for almost everything else I think I know about the external world

Article 87

Who founded Reader's Digest and when? As De Witt Wallace lay in bed recovering from injuries sustained in World War I, he found there was a wealth of interesting information to read and absorb. Realising few people would have the time to get through all this information, he knew exactly what to do. In 1920, the entrepreneurial young American submitted a sample magazine containing condensed articles to publishers across America. All turned him down. Undeterred, De Witt and his new bride Lila Bell Acheson published the first issue of Reader's Digest in February 1922. Working from home, the Wallaces printed 5000 copies,

which were sold exclusively by mail to 1500 subscribers and priced at 25 cents. From these humble beginnings grew the world's most widely read magazine.

What happened next? The magazine flourished and, by 1935, circulation topped one million. In 1938, the first international edition was published in the United Kingdom. During World War II, editions were published for the first time in Latin America and Sweden. After the war, Reader's Digest moved into Australia, Belgium, Canada, Denmark, Finland, France, Germany, Italy, Norway, South Africa and Switzerland. In 1950, Reader's Digest launched its Condensed Books (now known as Select Editions in Australia). In 1959, music, the first non-print product line, was introduced. In 1962, Reader's Digestrevolutionised direct mail by introducing easy-to-enter sweepstakes and a year later the first Reader's Digest general book was published. In 1986, video was added to the Reader's Digest product line up.

And what about now? In 1973, the Wallaces gave up active management of Reader's Digest. De Witt died in 1981 aged 91; Lila in 1984 aged 94. With no heirs to the Wallace Empire to take control, Reader's Digest became a public company in the early 1990s and is now headed by a Chief Executive Officer and Chairman of the Board.

How many editions of the Reader's Digest are there around the world? Reader's Digest is one of the most successful publishing stories in the history of global magazine. It now appears in 48 editions in 19 languages, with just under 100 million readers every month.

What are the 19 languages Reader's Digest are published in? English, French, Norwegian, Italian, Spanish, Portuguese, Chinese, Russian, Czech, Slovak, Polish, Hungarian, Thai, Korean, Finnish, Danish, German, Dutch and Swedish.

What type of magazine articles/information will I find in the Reader's Digest magazine? Reader's Digest is based on a winning formula. In every issue you will find politics, travel, drama, medicine, science, nature, humour, human interest, self-help, biographies and adventure. Reader's Digest is one of the most reliable sources of information available. Hours of research go into providing articles of lasting endurance with every fact, figure and quote in the magazine thoroughly checked.

When did Reader's Digest come to Australia? The first Reader's Digest was published in Australia in 1946.

Is the Australian magazine written and produced in Australia? We have a team of dedicated Australian editors and researchers who strive to provide the most relevant stories and information for Australians. Each month the Australian Reader's Digest has Australian articles complemented by articles sourced from all over the world to produce a well-balanced publication.

What is the current circulation and readership for the Australian Reader's Digest magazine? Circulation: 405,000 (ABC June '11). We are the third largest selling magazines in the country Readership: 1,149,000.

How do I subscribe to the Reader's Digest? Visit our Magazine subscription area on this website to order a subscription or call our Customer Service representatives directly on 1300 300 030 from 6:00am to 10:00pm Monday to Friday, Eastern Standard Time.

Will I get paid for my contributions? Payments for contributions that are published begin at $50 for interesting or amusing short anecdotes that can be used as fillers at the end of articles. A successful "All in a Day's Work" or "Life's Like That" contribution will get you $250 while an accepted item for "Laughter, the Best Medicine" will see you pocket $150.

Article 88

The liberal centre has no political voice as parties mistakenly do not see its potential
India daily abridges its right to be called a liberal democracy. There is a virtual contagion of attacks on art and free speech. How are we to understand this? How do we square this intolerance with the astonishing energy, creativity and contention that we are also seeing unleashed at different levels of society? Are we on the path to greater intolerance or do the underlying trends tell a different story?

At a moment when art is being targeted, film stars are not safe, 15-year-old girls are being asked to pay a horrendous social price for creating a rock band and political dissent is being suppressed, the future of free expression looks very bleak indeed. But it is important to diagnose this malaise correctly. Rather than assume that it portends a more intolerant society, it could be the case that society is actually getting more tolerant. It is the state and the political structures that do not understand these profound changes.

Mark Twain once said that Americans have the most perfect right to freedom of speech, but also the good sense never to use it. The deep truth in his remark was that often free speech seems easy to defend when the underlying mechanisms of social control are strong: speech seems safe when its limits are not tested too much. We often underestimate the degree to which even in the most liberal of democracies, freedom of speech seems safe because its limits are not tested. In the US, for example, a panoply of self-restraints does not push the limits of free expression as much as you might expect: it is, for example, a very taciturn culture when it comes to religion. So the fact that India is experiencing more contention around free speech could be a sign that inhibiting social restraints are finally beginning to wear off. This is largely a good thing, but it will generate the appearance of more conflict.

Threats to the freedom of expression come largely from three sources. In some states like West Bengal, there is outright political thuggery: criticise the leader and pay the price. Many states have milder versions of this phenomenon. In some states, sedition laws have been used to quell dissent. The second threat comes from patriarchy. The crisis of patriarchy is finding its most potent expression on the ground of speech. From hoodlums targeting girls in pubs in Mangalore to muftis finding a teenage rock band a threat to civilisation, the concerted effort is to inhibit freedom for women. This trend is disconcerting, but again, it takes place against the backdrop of momentous social change, where women are participating more, and on their own terms. The third threat comes from the vicious cycle of competitive offence-mongering that still remains a tempting axis of mobilisation in our society. A secularism that emphasised parity between groups rather than individual freedoms was bound to generate this escalating dynamic, where you test the state on how much it protects your group. But even this attempt to consolidate group identities through a politics of competitive hurt takes place against a backdrop where identities are becoming more fluid and open. Indeed, groups are attempting to impose the yoke of community, precisely because the actual power to control is diminishing. It is more a sign of desperation than a harbinger of community power. This is why so many seeking community salvation in feigning hurt seem increasingly unrepresentative.

So it could be the case that the foundations of society are being increasingly liberalised, even as the political incentives to curb free expression continue to exist. Recognising this is important for a reason. Nothing serves suppressing tyrants more than the idea that they are in some ways representative of larger society, or even the groups they claim to speak for. The biggest failure of our times is not that society is becoming more regressive (compared to when?). The biggest danger is that small minorities or fringe groups who attack free expression are being presented as if they represented public opinion. Here, as elsewhere, the whole concept of public opinion has become a self-fulfilling construct. Public opinion is often not an objective fact. It is, in part, a creation of what people think public opinion is. The loony fringe's greatest success is to somehow get people to think that they represent public opinion. This is confusing politicians as

much as everyone else. Which is why it is important to articulate that there is a large liberal India that is growing.

We used to think that the Indian state was a progressive entity out of sync with social reality. It could be argued that now the opposite is the case: the Indian state is still entrenched in the old mould, while society is actually experiencing far-reaching changes. That many of these are taking a more liberal direction is disguised by three things. First, unlike the loony fringes, the liberal centre has no organised political voice; political parties mistakenly do not see its potential. Second, those who engage in violence always get more visibility. The state is unable to protect ordinary citizens, and covers up its abdication by taking recourse to a vastly exaggerated community sentiment. Third, the state is slow to recognise social change. It has to be said that the Supreme Court of India's track record on sending a clear signal on freedom of expression is equivocal at best. It defers too much to "reason of state". We have had great social rights jurisprudence; ironically, the free speech jurisprudence is not nearly at the same level.

The court has not challenged a self-fulfilling construction enshrined in the law, that Indian citizens are somehow infantile, so uniquely in the grip of their communal passions that they cannot handle freedom. It has, therefore, changed the presumptions: almost as if freedom, rather than its abridgement, needs to be justified. Changing this legal culture will take time. But, cumulatively, the problem for liberals is not that they do not exist in sufficient numbers. It is that they have no organised instrumentality, whether in state, parties or electronic media, to register their presence with full force.

But politicians will wake up. Omar Abdullah is taking action against those targeting the girls rather than hiding behind community sentiment; Manish Tewari has been quoted as saying something you never thought an Indian politician would say, namely that freedom of expression must include the right to offend. The battle for free expression must be fought hard. But concluding that free expression has no traction in India would be a mistake. It is exactly the sort of demoralisation on which enemies of freedom wear us down. History is on our side.

Article 89

Depending on time, culture and country, feminists around the world have sometimes had different causes and goals. Most western feminist historians assert that all movements that work to obtain women's rights should be considered feminist movements, even when they did not (or do not) apply the term to themselves. Other historians assert that the term should be limited to the modern feminist movement and its descendants. Those historians use the label "protofeminist" to describe earlier movements.

The history of the modern western feminist movements is divided into three "waves". Each is described as dealing with different aspects of the same feminist issues. The first wave refers mainly to women's suffrage movements of the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries (mainly concerned with women's right to vote). The second wave refers to the ideas and actions associated with the women's liberation movement beginning in the 1960s (which campaigned for legal and social equality for women). The third wave refers to a continuation of, and a reaction to, the perceived failures of second-wave feminism, beginning in the 1990s.

First-wave feminism was a period of activity during the nineteenth century and early twentieth century. In the U.K. and U.S., it focused on the promotion of equal contract, marriage, parenting, and property rights

for women. However, by the end of the nineteenth century, activism focused primarily on gaining political power, particularly the right of women's suffrage, though some feminists were active in campaigning for women's sexual, reproductive, and economic rights at this time.

Second-wave feminism is a feminist movement beginning in the early 1960s and continuing to the present, and it coexists with third-wave feminism. Second wave feminism is largely concerned with issues of equality other than suffrage, such as ending discrimination.

Second-wave feminists see women's cultural and political inequalities as inextricably linked and encourage women to understand aspects of their personal lives as deeply politicized and as reflecting sexist power structures. The feminist activist and author Carol Hanisch coined the slogan "The Personal is Political", which became synonymous with the second wave.

The term post-feminism is used to describe a range of viewpoints reacting to feminism since the 1980s. While not being "anti-feminist", post-feminists believe that women have achieved second wave goals while being critical of third wave feminist goals. The term was first used to describe a backlash against second-wave feminism, but it is now a label for a wide range of theories that take critical approaches to previous feminist discourses and includes challenges to the second wave's ideas. Other post-feminists say that feminism is no longer relevant to today's society. Amelia Jones has written that the post-feminist texts which emerged in the 1980s and 1990s portrayed second-wave feminism as a monolithic entity and criticized it using generalizations.

In the early 1990s in the USA, third-wave feminism began as a response to perceived failures of the second wave and to the backlash against initiatives and movements created by the second wave. Third-wave feminism seeks to challenge or avoid what it deems the second wave's essentialist definitions of femininity, which, they argue, over-emphasize the experiences of upper middle-class white women. Third-wave feminists often focus on "micro-politics" and challenge the second wave's paradigm as to what is, or is not, good for women, and tend to use a post-structuralist interpretation of gender and sexuality. Feminist leaders rooted in the second wave, such as Gloria Anzaldua, bell hooks, Chela Sandoval, Cherrie Moraga, Audre Lorde, Maxine Hong Kingston, and many other black feminists, sought to negotiate a space within feminist thought for consideration of race-related subjectivities.

Third-wave feminism also contains internal debates between difference feminists, who believe that there are important differences between the sexes, and those who believe that there are no inherent differences between the sexes and contend that gender roles are due to social conditioning.

Article 90

Just how do you go about trying to persuade someone to offer you a job? There is an old joke about a man being interviewed for a new job and being told, "You know, in this job we really need someone who is responsible." The man thinks for a moment, then replies, "I am perfect for you. In my last job lots of things went badly wrong, and they always said that I was responsible."

Unfortunately, disastrous replies are common in actual interviews—but help is at hand. Over the past thirty years, psychologists have investigated the key factors that impress interviewers, and the work has resulted

in several quick and effective techniques that can significantly increase your chances of being offered your dream job.

Ask any employer to explain why they choose one applicant in preference to another, and they will tell you that it is a matter of which candidate has the best qualifications and personal skills for the job. To make the process as rational and fair as possible, many draw up a list of key skills that the successful candidate must possess, study each applicant's résumé for evidence of those skills, and then use a face-to-face interview to discover a little more information. But research conducted by Chad Higgins from the University of Washington and Timothy Judge from the University of Florida suggests that interviewers are often deluding themselves about how they make up their minds. In reality they are unconsciously swayed by a mysterious and powerful force.

Higgins and Judge followed the fortunes of more than a hundred former students as they tried to obtain their first job after college. At the start of the study, the researchers examined the résumé of each student, measuring the two factors that interviewers consistently claim play a key role in separating successful and unsuccessful candidates—qualifications and work experience. After each job interview, students completed a standard questionnaire about how they had behaved, including whether, for example, they made the most of their positive points, took an interest in the company, or asked the interviewers about the type of person they were looking for. The research team also contacted the interviewers and asked them to provide feedback on several factors, including the candidate's performance, how well they would fit in with the organization, whether they possessed the necessary skills for the job, and, perhaps most important of all, whether they would be offered the job.

After analyzing the mass of data, the research team exploded some of the myths about why interviewers choose candidates for a job, discovering a surprising reality. Did the likelihood depend on qualifications? Or was it work experience? In fact, it was neither. It was just one important factor—did the candidate appear to be a pleasant person? Those who had managed to ingratiate themselves were very likely to be offered a position, and they charmed their way to success in several different ways. A few had spent time chatting about topics that were not related to the job but that interested the candidate and the interviewer. Some had made a special effort to smile and maintain eye contact. Others had praised the organization. This barrage of positivity had paid dividends, convincing the interviewers that such pleasant and socially skilled applicants would fit well in the workplace and so should be offered a job.

Higgins and Judge's study clearly demonstrates that in order to get your dream job, going out of your way to be pleasant is more important than qualifications and past work experience. However, try explaining away twelve counts of murder and two convictions for major corporate fraud, and you will quickly discover that such ingratiation has its limitations. With respect to your weaknesses, then, what is the best way of dealing with the less-impressive side of your résumé? Should you mention weaknesses toward the start of the interview, or hope to make a good first impression and introduce possible problems only at the end?

This issue was investigated in an important study conducted in the early 1970s by Edward Jones and Eric Gordon from Duke University. Participants were presented with a tape recording of a man (actually an accomplice of the experimenters) talking about his life. They were then asked to rate the degree to which he sounded likeable. During the interview the man told how he had not completed a school semester because he had been caught cheating and had been expelled. The researchers edited the tape so that half of the participants heard this bombshell toward the beginning, while the others heard it toward the end. This manipulation had a large impact on how much the participants liked the man. When the cheating was mentioned toward the start of the tape, the man appeared far more likeable than when it was mentioned toward the end. Additional work has confirmed exactly the same effect in other contexts, with, for example,

lawyers being judged to have a stronger case when presenting a weakness in their argument at the beginning of a trial.

It seems that presenting weaknesses early is seen as a sign of openness. This is a lesson that many politicians, such as Bill Clinton, have yet to learn. Interviewers believe that they are dealing with someone who has the strength of character and integrity to bring up potential difficulties at the outset, and they therefore conclude that the applicant is not attempting to mislead them.

Can the same be said of the more positive aspects of your résumé? Actually, no. In another part of the same study, participants heard a positive reason for the skipped semester ("I was awarded a prestigious scholarship to travel around Europe"), with the information presented either early or late on the tape. Now the effect was reversed, with the man appearing far more likeable when he mentioned the award later. It seems that modesty, rather than honesty, is critical for positive aspects of your past. By delaying mention of such details, you appear to prefer letting your strengths emerge naturally, while playing your cards early is seen as boastful.

So, you have polished up your ingratiating skills, are willing to declare your weaknesses early, and intend to leave the best till last. Does that mean that you are guaranteed to be a success? Unfortunately, no. Despite the best of intentions and the most extensive preparations, we all make mistakes. Perhaps you will knock a glass of water into your lap, inadvertently insult your interviewer, or give an answer that is as bumbling as it is unconvincing. The fact is, you need to be able to cope with the odd unexpected disaster or two. To help, Thomas Gilovich of Cornell University and his colleagues undertook a series of studies in which they forced people to wear Barry Manilow T-shirts.

In a typical study, Gilovich arranged for five participants to arrive at the same time at his laboratory. Everyone was led into a room, asked to sit along one side of a table, and to complete a questionnaire. The group began to check off various boxes, unaware that the researchers had arranged for another participant to arrive five minutes late. This latecomer was met before entering the room and told to wear a Tshirt bearing a large picture of Barry Manilow. Why Manilow? Well, the study was about the psychology of embarrassment, and carefully controlled pretesting had revealed that the majority of Cornell students wouldn't be caught dead in a Barry Manilow T-shirt. Moments after putting on the T-shirt, the latecomer was bundled into the room, only to be confronted by a row of staring fellow students. After a few moments, the experimenter explained that it might be better to wait outside for a while, and promptly escorted the latecomer out of the room.

Two things happened next. Everyone in the room was asked if they had noticed the image on the latecomer's T-shirt, while the latecomer was asked to estimate the percentage of students who would have noticed the embarrassing image. The results from a series of experiments revealed that on average about 20 percent of the people in the room noticed Barry. However, the latecomers were convinced that the image had been far more eye-catching, and they estimated that on average about 50 percent of the group would have noticed the T-shirt. In short, the latecomers significantly overestimated the impact of their embarrassing encounter.

This bias, known as the "spotlight" effect, has been found in many different settings. From assessing the effects of a bad-hair day to performing poorly in a group discussion, those who feel embarrassed are convinced that their mistakes are far more noticeable than they actually are. Why? It seems that we focus on our own looks and behavior more than on those of others, and so we are likely to overestimate the impact of our situation. So, if you make a mortifying mistake in an interview, think about the man in the Barry Manilow T-shirt and remember that it probably feels far worse than it is.

mbaguru
LEADER IN ADAPTIVE PREPARATION FOR CAT

Article 91

One major source of the resilience and rapid territorial expansion of so called Islamic State (IS) lies in the group's ability to invest in death through managing it strategically to achieve significant military gains. It is astonishing to realise that over the course of 2016, IS launched nearly a 1000 suicide attacks in Syria and Iraq. Although resorting to suicide operations is not new to radical Islamist organisations, IS' deployment of such a staggering number of suicide attackers is an unprecedented phenomenon in the history of modern Islamist activism.
How is this possible? What is new in IS' rhetoric and mobilisation strategies?

To answer this key question, it is vital to contextualise the practices of IS, historically and doctrinally, focusing on certain themes such as martyrdom, jihad, life, death, and afterlife. To that end, we studied the ideological and doctrinal underpinnings of the group by reference to the relevant Qur'anic verses and Prophetic sayings in addition to the way they were interpreted and appropriated. We reviewed around 60 videos released by the group since October 2016 as well as many anāshīd (religious songs) produced and used in these releases. This is meant to make it easier to understand IS propaganda and the apparent appeal of the group's media messages.

The main argument revolves around the idea that, with IS, the entire Islamic rhetoric on life and death has been appropriated to advance the political project of the Islamic Caliphate. IS propaganda suggests a worldly solution to the intrinsic ills of this life, i.e. living under the Islamic Caliphate.

Ideals and dogmatic convictions are central to the processes of radicalisation. Radical Islamist groups, such as IS and al-Qaeda, capitalise on certain psychosocial vulnerabilities to mobilise people and to effect their strategic plans. These groups realise that there are two prerequisites for becoming actively receptive to the jihadi messages.
The first condition is the lack of any sense of belonging to this world which results from a state of cultural, social or economic alienation. The second condition is a psychological one and is characterised by a state of disorientation concerning the meaning and purpose of life. These psychosocial gaps are essential preconditions for an individual to become engrossed in a process of radicalisation, leading eventually to him/her justifying or even committing horrendous acts of violence.

Nevertheless, despair, anger, alienation, and poverty remain insufficient to trigger acts of mass violence. They necessarily need ideological channelling before transforming into an all-out destructive force. Unlike low-risk activism, such as protesting or social media campaigning, suicide attacks require full commitment to a cause or a dogmatic conviction.

In the case of radical Islamism, Olivier Roy states that "young radicals are sincere believers: they truly believe that they will go to heaven, and their frame of reference is deeply Islamic." As such, ideas matter, and the discourse of Salafi-Jihadism is not insignificant; rather, it is at the heart of the process of radicalisation.
In this equation of radicalisation, the role of radical preachers is to offer a simple blueprint for life within which approaching death is presented as an empowering and emancipatory act.

Media messages that are produced and disseminated by radical Islamists have for a long time exploited the Islamically, 'widely-accepted' framing of life, death, and salvation. The vast majority of Islamic sources tends to portray the worldly life as a temporary, insignificant phase wherein believers are faced with pains and hardships. Also, 'true Muslims' are encouraged to abandon the pleasures of this life and focus, instead, on fulfilling their religious duties which will lead them to an eternal life in Paradise.

Thus, pain and sadness are normalised and presented as inescapable if one is a devoted Muslim whose aim is God's satisfaction and the everlasting pleasures of the Hereafter. To emphasise the latter idea, preachers refer to the Hadith: 'This world is the believer's prison and the infidel's Jannah (Heaven).

IS provides a partially different rhetoric concerning the meaning of life. With IS, the narrative on life and death tends to suggest a worldly solution to the intrinsic ills of this life, i.e. living under the Islamic Caliphate.

Establishing and expanding the Islamic Caliphate where shari'a is upheld has become the only purpose of life, and death has been managed in a way that serves the purpose of sustaining the Caliphate. The group's propaganda messages encourage young Muslims to give up on the worldly pleasures and intentionally seek death to deter oppressors and enable other Muslims live with dignity and safety under the Islamic Caliphate.

The group frames suicide attacks as a formidable strategic asset that will pave a way for establishing the Islamic State and instating the rule of shari'a. Using IS rationale, the individual interest does not matter, what matters is the welfare of the Muslim community and future generations. This entails that the irrational decision to carry out a suicide attack is framed as rational and strategic from the perspective of the wider community of believers under the Islamic Caliphate; and that is what should matter.

As such, the entire Islamic rhetoric on life and death has been appropriated by IS to advance the project of the Islamic Caliphate. IS propaganda messages provide an important insight into the terror group inner thinking with regard to life and death.

Article 92

I smoke. I have been smoking for 32 years now. I know it's supposed to be bad for my health. Maybe I'll give it up some day. That's not difficult. As Mark Twain said: "Quitting smoking is easy. I've quit so many times." In other words, I am the worst nightmare of the World Health Organization, the ministry of health in India, and all so-called well-meaning human beings who believe that we can evolve to be better creatures if only we forsook tobacco. I am an unregenerate unrepentant happy-to-be-suicidal smoker.

As everyone knows, I am under serious threat from all quarters. Restaurants don't allow me to smoke, unless I move to a cramped smoking zone where no seating arrangements are provided, and very few restaurants anyway have invested in smoking zones. So if the urge comes upon a smoker, he or she has to step out onto the street and grab a few puffs. Most of the major Indian airports now have smoking zones, though not, for some strange reason, Kolkata, the mecca of smokers (defying the law, several large corporate houses in Kolkata retain some conference rooms where smoking is allowed. Helps managerial analysis and strategizing).

But being India, we get overzealous and then can't pull it through. Unlike most countries, including in the so-called developed world, India does not allow match boxes to be carried in hand baggage. This is overzealous, nay stupid, especially when you consider that the security scanners at the airports can't detect match boxes. I've been carrying match boxes in my handbag with impunity while travelling, so I can light up comfortably in the smoking zone. The smoking zones do provide electronic lighters embedded in the walls, but they often don't work. Besides, when you land in your destination city, it's very irritating to stop your car midway and hunt for shops that sell match boxes or lighters.

Some months ago, all TV shows and films started carrying "smoking/ tobacco is injurious" slogans at the bottom of the screen every time someone took out a cigarette. This no doubt provides gainful employment to hundreds of people, and this is good news in this era of "jobless growth". But these hawk-eyed sub-titlers clearly need to be more alert. In the Hindi film, *Barfi*, for example, while the warning appeared every time **RanbirKapoor** lit a bidi, when an elderly gentleman smoked a pipe, there were no dire threats on the screen. Our keen well-wishers don't know that a pipe is also a smoking instrument! Or is this some class thing, awe at the implied aristocracy of the pipe?

Now, in theatres, the government has started showing a three-minute film before the feature film begins and once more when intermission ends. Again, they've screwed up. The film starts with a black screen with one word on it: "Disclamer" (sic). Do a damn spell check, morons! The next screen tells us that "the characters in the film who are shown smoking do not endorse smoking or consumption of tobacco." The characters? If the characters are smoking, they obviously do endorse smoking! Unless of course, every character seen smoking in a film is at heart some sort of deeply disturbed martyr-complexed loser who's doing something that he doesn't like, thus adding an existential subtext to every scene, even if it's a slapstick comic sequence.

The Hindi version is more enlightening. It uses the word *kalakaar*, which means actor, not character. But even then, how does the government know that the actor doesn't like to smoke? Who is the government to speak for these individuals, without taking their consent? And why only the actors? What about the screenplay writer and the director, who put the smoking bit into the film—the actor hardly lit up on screen just because he wanted to, it would have been because it was in the script and had the director's approval. This "disclamer" is a typical Indian case of entirely unnecessary application of poor-quality thought. Whichever ministry is responsible for this should be ashamed that they can't get a simple thing like this right.

Everyone who smokes today is doing it of his or her own free will. We know that it's bad for health and we have chosen to take that risk. This is a matter of an individual's freedom of choice, which lies at the core of all democratic principles.

Did I hear someone mention "passive smoking"? I urge you to go through the scientific research on this, and before you start reading, please check who the research is sponsored by. Disregard the findings if it is sponsored by WHO or any other health-related organization. Disregard it if it is sponsored by the tobacco industry (you have to be careful here, because the tobacco industry, in these cases, tries to hide behind dummy organizations). Look for independent research. The ill-effects of passive smoking are not, I repeat not, proven by any independent scientific research, beyond even a little reasonable doubt.

Yes, a non-smoker in the company of smokers may find the fumes obnoxious, and then the smokers must stub their cigarettes or go somewhere else to indulge themselves. That is human decency and courtesy, not a life-saving act. We are not murderers, even if various governments and agencies want to portray us as that. In fact, any civilized smoker should not—and I hope, does not—smoke if anyone in his or her company feels physically uncomfortable.

And finally, why is smoking so high on the government's agenda? Why can't it show films on female foeticide, girl child education, simple ways to prevent child malnutrition in theatres before the feature films? Surely these are much bigger problems with much greater repercussions for us as a people, society, nation, economy?

Why don't we ban tobacco products altogether and be done with it? Oh no, that we can't do. That'll have a serious impact on state finances, since sales tax on cigarettes is a very significant source of income for state governments. Plus there are lakhs of tobacco farmers whose lives will be destroyed. Think of the political fall-out.

There is a hypocrisy here and, I suspect, very large sums of international aid funds involved. And what is the consequence? After years of cigarette consumption going down in India, in number of sticks sold (which is the best way to measure consumption), in 2011-12, it actually rose by 4.19%. And this happened right after all these draconian and foolishly implemented measures were introduced. What a success! One can conjecture that all these fiats made smokers even more determined, and got more people to try out and see what this lethal taboo was all about. Talk about misplaced priorities, wasted money, decisions based on insufficient information, and violation of individual freedom of choice!

My piece is done. Now to sit in my rocking chair and have a good satisfying smoke. Ah, the pleasure of that!

Article 93

Greek mythology has changed over time to accommodate the evolution of their culture, of which mythology, both overtly and in its unspoken assumptions, is an index of the changes. Greek mythology's surviving literary forms, as found mostly at the end of the progressive changes, are inherently political, as Gilbert Cuthbertson has urged.
The earlier inhabitants of the Balkan Peninsula were an agricultural people who, using 'Animism,' assigned a spirit to every aspect of nature. Eventually, these vague spirits assumed human forms and entered the local mythology as gods. When tribes from the north of the Balkan Peninsula invaded, they brought with them a new pantheon of gods, based on conquest, force, prowess in battle, and violent heroism. Other older gods of the agricultural world fused with those of the more powerful invaders or else faded into insignificance.

After the middle of the Archaic period, myths about relationships between male gods and male heroes become more and more frequent, indicating the parallel development of pedagogic pederasty, thought to have been introduced around 630 BC. By the end of the fifth century BC, poets had assigned at least one eromenos, an adolescent boy who was their sexual companion, to every important god except Ares and to many legendary figures. Previously existing myths, such as those of Achilles and Patroclus, also then were cast in a pederastic light. Alexandrian poets at first, then more generally literary mythographers in the early Roman Empire, often readapted stories of Greek mythological characters in this fashion.

The achievement of epic poetry was to create story-cycles and, as a result, to develop a new sense of mythological chronology. Thus Greek mythology unfolds as a phase in the development of the world and of humans. While self-contradictions in these stories make an absolute timeline impossible, an approximate chronology may be discerned. The resulting mythological "history of the world" may be divided into three or four broader periods

Article 94

Considering the difficulties which men have had to hold to a newly acquired state, some might wonder how, seeing that Alexander the Great became the master of Asia in a few years, and died whilst it was scarcely settled (whence it might appear reasonable that the whole empire would have rebelled), nevertheless his successors maintained themselves, and had to meet no other difficulty than that which arose among themselves from their own ambitions.

I answer that the principalities of which one has record are found to be governed in two different ways; either by a prince, with a body of servants, who assist him to govern the kingdom as ministers by his favour and permission; or by a prince and barons, who hold that dignity by antiquity of blood and not by the grace of the prince. Such barons have states and their own subjects, who recognize them as lords and hold them in natural affection. Those states that are governed by a prince and his servants hold their prince in more consideration, because in all the country there is no one who is recognized as superior to him, and if they yield obedience to another they do it as to a minister and official, and they do not bear him any particular affection.

The examples of these two governments in our time are the Turk and the King of France. The entire monarchy of the Turk is governed by one lord, the others are his servants; and, dividing his kingdom into sanjaks, he sends there different administrators, and shifts and changes them as he chooses. But the King of France is placed in the midst of an ancient body of lords, acknowledged by their own subjects, and beloved by them; they have their own prerogatives, nor can the king take these away except at his peril. Therefore, he who considers both of these states will recognize great difficulties in seizing the state of the Turk, but, once it is conquered, great ease in holding it. The causes of the difficulties in seizing the kingdom of the Turk are that the usurper cannot be called in by the princes of the kingdom, nor can he hope to be assisted in his designs by the revolt of those whom the lord has around him. This arises from the reasons given above; for his ministers, being all slaves and bondmen, can only be corrupted with great difficulty, and one can expect little advantage from them when they have been corrupted, as they cannot carry the people with them, for the reasons assigned. Hence, he who attacks the Turk must bear in mind that he will find him united, and he will have to rely more on his own strength than on the revolt of others; but, if once the Turk has been conquered, and routed in the field in such a way that he cannot replace his armies, there is nothing to fear but the family of this prince, and, this being exterminated, there remains no one to fear, the others having no credit with the people; and as the conqueror did not rely on them before his victory, so he ought not to fear them after it.

The contrary happens in kingdoms governed like that of France, because one can easily enter there by gaining over some baron of the kingdom, for one always finds malcontents and such as desire a change. Such men, for the reasons given, can open the way into the state and render the victory easy; but if you wish to hold it afterwards, you meet with infinite difficulties, both from those who have assisted you and from those you have crushed. Nor is it enough for you to have exterminated the family of the prince, because the lords that remain make themselves the heads of fresh movements against you, and as you are unable either to satisfy or exterminate them, that state is lost whenever time brings the opportunity.

Now if you will consider what was the nature of the government of Darius, you will find it similar to the kingdom of the Turk, and therefore it was only necessary for Alexander, first to overthrow him in the field, and then to take the country from him. After which victory, Darius being killed, the state remained secure to Alexander, for the above reasons. And if his successors had been united they would have enjoyed it securely and at their ease, for there were no tumults raised in the kingdom except those they provoked themselves.

But it is impossible to hold with such tranquillity states constituted like that of France. Hence arose those frequent rebellions against the Romans in Spain, France, and Greece, owing to the many principalities there were in these states, of which, as long as the memory of them endured, the Romans always held an insecure possession; but with the power and long continuance of the empire the memory of them passed away, and the Romans then became secure possessors. And when fighting afterwards amongst themselves, each one was able to attach to himself his own parts of the country, according to the authority he had assumed there; and the family of the former lord being exterminated, none other than the Romans were acknowledged.

When these things are remembered no one will marvel at the ease with which Alexander held the Empire of Asia, or at the difficulties which others have had to keep an acquisition, such as Pyrrhus and many more; this is not occasioned by the little or abundance of ability in the conqueror, but by the want of uniformity in the subject state.

It remains now to see what ought to be the rules of conduct for a prince towards subject and friends. And as I know that many have written on this point, I expect I shall be considered presumptuous in mentioning it again, especially as in discussing it I shall depart from the methods of other people. But, it being my intention to write a thing which shall be useful to him who apprehends it, it appears to me more appropriate to follow up the real truth of the matter than the imagination of it; for many have pictured republics and principalities which in fact have never been known or seen, because how one lives is so far distant from how one ought to live, that he who neglects what is done for what ought to be done, sooner effects his ruin than his preservation; for a man who wishes to act entirely up to his professions of virtue soon meets with what destroys him among so much that is evil.

Hence it is necessary for a prince wishing to hold his own to know how to do wrong, and to make use of it or not according to necessity. Therefore, putting on one side imaginary things concerning a prince, and discussing those which are real, I say that all men when they are spoken of, and chiefly princes for being more highly placed, are remarkable for some of those qualities which bring them either blame or praise; and thus it is that one is reputed liberal, another miserly, using a Tuscan term (because an avaricious person in our language is still he who desires to possess by robbery, whilst we call one miserly who deprives himself too much of the use of his own); one is reputed generous, one rapacious; one cruel, one compassionate; one faithless, another faithful; one effeminate and cowardly, another bold and brave; one affable, another haughty; one lascivious, another chaste; one sincere, another cunning; one hard, another easy; one grave, another frivolous; one religious, another unbelieving, and the like. And I know that every one will confess that it would be most praiseworthy in a prince to exhibit all the above qualities that are considered good; but because they can neither be entirely possessed nor observed, for human conditions do not permit it, it is necessary for him to be sufficiently prudent that he may know how to avoid the reproach of those vices which would lose him his state; and also to keep himself, if it be possible, from those which would not lose him it; but this not being possible, he may with less hesitation abandon himself to them. And again, he need not make himself uneasy at incurring a reproach for those vices without which the state can only be saved with difficulty, for if everything is considered carefully, it will be found that something which looks like virtue, if followed, would be his ruin; whilst something else, which looks like vice, yet followed brings him security and prosperity.

Article 95

mbaguru
LEADER IN ADAPTIVE PREPARATION FOR CAT

If we refuse any neat separation between *cult* and *religion*, aren't we therefore obligated to condemn both? Only ontological metaphysical truth can possibly justify the demands that any religion makes upon its adherents. And if we take as writ the proposition that God isn't real (or that we can never know what God wants), it's easy to collapse the distinction with a wave of a hand: all religions are cults, and all are probably pretty bad for you.

Accusations of cultism have been levelled at secular or semi-secular organisations as well as metaphysically inclined ones. Any organisation offering identity-building rituals and a coherent narrative of the world and how to live in it is a target, from Alcoholics Anonymous to the vegan restaurant chain the Loving Hut, founded by the Vietnamese entrepreneur-cum-spiritual leader Ching Hai, to the practice of yoga (itself rife with structural issues of spiritual and sexual abuse), to the modern phenomenon of the popular, paleo-associated sport-exercise programme CrossFit, which a Harvard Divinity School study used as an example of contemporary 'religious' identity. If the boundaries between *cult* and *religion* are already slippery, those between *religion* and *culture* are more porous still.

In his seminal book on religion, *The Interpretation of Cultures* (1973), the anthropologist Clifford Geertz denies that human beings can live outside culture. Religion, too, functions within culture as a series of ascriptions of meaning that define how we see ourselves, others, and the world. Such a definition of religion isn't limited to groups with formal doctrines about 'God', but encompasses any wider cultural narrative of the self in the world.

Geertz's definition – somewhat dated now – has been updated: most notably by postcolonial thinkers such as Talal Asad, who argue that Geertz overlooks one of the most significant mechanisms for meaning-making: *power*. How we conceive of God, our world, our spiritual values (a hunger for 'cleansing' in yoga, or for proof of strength, as in CrossFit, or for salvific grace) is inextricable both from our own identities and our position within a group in which questions of power are never, can never be, absent.

Even the narratives that many religions, cults and religious-type groups promulgate – that they are in some sense separate from 'the others' (the Hebrew word for 'holiness', *qadosh*, derives from the word for separation) – are themselves tragically flawed: they are both apart from and firmly within the problems of a wider culture.

Take, for example, the cultural pervasiveness of ideals of female thinness. It is precisely the aspirational desire to be Kate-Moss skinny that allows a Christian diet programme such as Remnant to attract members in the first place (*don't eat too much; it's a sin!*). So too does it allow cults of 'wellness' to take hold: a woman who is already obsessed with cleansing toxins, making her body 'perfect' and 'clean', and 'purifying' herself is more likely to get involved with a cult-like yoga practice and/or be susceptible to sexual abuse by her guru (a not uncommon occurrence).

Likewise, the no less culturally pervasive failure of mainstream institutions – from the healthcare system to mainline Protestant churches – to address the needs of their members gives rise, with equal potency, to individuals susceptible to conspiracy theories, or cultish behaviours: to anything that might provide them with meaningfulness.

The very collapse of wider religious narratives – an established cultural collectivism – seems inevitably to leave space for smaller, more intense, and often more toxic groups to reconfigure those Geertzian symbols as they see fit. Cults don't come out of nowhere; they fill a vacuum, for individuals and, as we've seen, for society at large. Even Christianity itself proliferated most widely as a result of a similar vacuum: the relative decline of state religious observance, and political hegemony, in the Roman Empire.

To talk about religion as a *de facto* abuse-vector of hierarchical power (in other words, a cult writ large) is a meaningless oversimplification. It's less an arrow than a circle: a cycle of power, meaning, identity, and ritual. Every time we repeat a ritual, from the Catholic Mass to a prayer circle on a farm compound to a CrossFit workout, it defines us – and we define the people around us.

Today's cults might be secular, or they might be theistic. But they arise from the same place of need, and from the failure of other, more 'mainstream' cultural institutions to fill it. If God did not exist, as Voltaire said, we would have to invent him. The same is true for cults.

Article 96

It is a matter of debate whether my lack of belief in the existence of an Omnipresent, Omniscient God is due to my arrogant pride and vanity. It never occurred to me that sometime in the future I would be involved in polemics of this kind. As a result of some discussions with my friends, (if my claim to friendship is not uncalled for) I have realised that after having known me for a little time only, some of them have reached a kind of hasty conclusion about me that my atheism is my foolishness and that it is the outcome of my vanity. Even then it is a serious problem. I do not boast of being above these human follies. I am, after all, a human being and nothing more. And no one can claim to be more than that. I have a weakness in my personality, for pride is one of the human traits that I do possess. I am known as a dictator among my friends. Sometimes I am called a boaster. Some have always been complaining that I am bossy and I force others to accept my opinion. Yes, it is true to some extent. I do not deny this charge. We can use the word 'vainglory' for it. As far as the contemptible, obsolete, rotten values of our society are concerned, I am an extreme sceptic. But this question does not concern my person alone. It is being proud of my ideas, my thoughts. It cannot be called empty pride. Pride, or you may use the word, vanity, both mean an exaggerated assessment of one's personality. Is my atheism because of unnecessary pride, or have I ceased believing in God after thinking long and deep on the matter? I wish to put my ideas before you. First of all, let us differentiate between pride and vanity as these are two different things.

I have never been able to understand how unfounded, baseless pride or empty vanity can hinder a person from believing in God. I may refuse to acknowledge the greatness of a really great person only when I have got fame without doing any serious efforts or when I lack the superior mental powers necessary to become great. It is easy to understand but how is it possible that a believer can turn into a non-believer because of his vanity? Only two things are possible: either a man deems himself to be in possession of Godly qualities, or he goes a step further and declares himself to be a god. In both these states of mind he cannot be an atheist in the true sense of the word. In the first case, it is not an outright rejection of God's existence; in the other, he is affirming the existence of some kind of supernatural power responsible for the working of universe. It does not harm our argument whether he claims to be a god or considers God to be a reality in existence above his own being. The real point, however, is that in both cases he is a theist, a believer. He is not an atheist. I want to bring home this point to you. I am not one of these two creeds. I totally reject the existence of an Omnipresent, all powerful, all knowing God. Why so? I will discuss it later in the essay. Here I wish to emphasise that I am not an atheist for the reason that I am arrogant or proud or vain; nor am I a demi-god, nor a prophet; no, nor am I God myself. At least one thing is true that I have not evolved this thought because of vanity or pride. In order to answer this question I relate the truth. My friends say that after Delhi bombing and Lahore Conspiracy Case, I rocketed to fame and that this fact has turned my head. Let us discuss why this allegation is incorrect. I did not give up my belief in God after these incidents. I was an atheist even when I was an unknown figure. At least a college student cannot cherish any sort of

exaggerated notion of himself that may lead him to atheism. It is true that I was a favourite with some college teachers, but others did not like me. I was never a hardworking or studious boy. I never got an opportunity to be proud. I was very careful in my behaviour and somewhat pessimistic about my future career. I was not completely atheistic in my beliefs. I was brought up under the care and protection of my father. He was a staunch AryaSamaji. An AryaSamaji can be anything but never an atheist. After my elementary education, I was sent to D. A. V College, Lahore. I lived in the boarding house for one year. Besides prayers early in the morning and at dusk time, I sat for hours and chanted religious Mantras. At that time, I was a staunch believer. Then I lived with my father. He was a tolerant man in his religious views. It is due to his teachings that I devoted my life for the cause of liberating my country. But he was not an atheist. His God was an all-pervading Entity. He advised me to offer my prayers every day. In this way I was brought up. In the Non-cooperation days, I got admission to the National College. During my stay in this college, I began thinking over all the religious polemics such that I grew sceptical about the existence of God. In spite of this fact I can say that my belief in God was firm and strong. I grew a beard and 'Kais' (long head of hair as a Sikh religious custom). In spite of this I could not convince myself of the efficacy of Sikh religion or *any religion at all, for that matter*. But I had an unswerving, unwavering belief in God.

Then I joined the Revolutionary Party. The first leader I met had not the courage to openly declare himself an atheist. He was unable to reach any conclusion on this point. Whenever I asked him about the existence of God, he gave me this reply: "You may believe in him when you feel like it." The second leader with whom I came in contact was a firm believer. I should mention his name. It was our respected Comrade SachindaraNathSanyal. He was sentenced to life imprisonment in connection with Karachi conspiracy case. Right from the first page of his only book, 'BandiJivan' (Incarnated Life) he sings praises to the Glory of God. See the last page of the second part of this book and you find praises showered upon God in the way of a mystic. It is a clear reflection of his thoughts.

According to the prosecution, the 'Revolutionary Leaflet' which was distributed throughout India was the outcome of SachindaraNathSanyal's intellectual labour. So often it happens that in revolutionary activities a leader expresses his own ideas which may be very dear to him, but in spite of having differences, the other workers have to acquiesce in them.

In that leaflet, one full paragraph was devoted to the praises of God and His doings which we, human beings, cannot understand. This is sheer mysticism. What I want to point out is that the idea of denying the existence of God did not even occur to the Revolutionary Party. The famous Kakory martyrs, all four of them, passed their last day in prayers. Ram ParshadBismal was a staunch AryaSamaji. In spite of his vast studies in Socialism and Communism, RajanLahiri could not suppress his desire to recite hymns from Upanishads and Gita. There was but only one person among them who did not indulge in such activities. He used to say, "Religion is the outcome of human weakness or the limitation of human knowledge." He is also in prison for life. But he also never dared to deny the existence of God.

Till that time I was only a romantic revolutionary, just a follower of our leaders. Then came the time to shoulder the whole responsibility. For some time, a strong opposition put the very existence of the party into danger. Many leaders as well as many enthusiastic comrades began to uphold the party to ridicule. They jeered at us. I had an apprehension that some day I will also consider it a futile and hopeless task. It was a turning point in my revolutionary career. An incessant desire to study filled my heart. 'Study more and more', said I to myself so that I might be able to face the arguments of my opponents. 'Study' to support your point of view with convincing arguments. And I began to study in a serious manner. My previous beliefs and convictions underwent a radical change. The romance of militancy dominated our predecessors; now serious ideas ousted this way of thinking. No more mysticism! No more blind faith! Now realism was our mode of thinking. At times of terrible necessity, we can resort to extreme methods, but violence produces opposite results in mass movements. I have talked much about our methods. The most

important thing was a clear conception of our ideology for which we were waging a long struggle. As there was no election activity going on, I got ample opportunity to study various ideas propounded by various writers. I studied Bakunin, the anarchist leader. I read a few books of Marx, the father of Communism. I also read Lenin and Trotsky and many other writers who successfully carried out revolutions in their countries. All of them were atheists. The ideas contained in Bakunin's 'God and State' seem inconclusive, but it is an interesting book. After that I came across a book 'Common Sense' by Nirlamba Swami. His point of view was a sort of mystical atheism. I developed more interest in this subject. By the end of 1926, I was convinced that the belief in an Almighty, Supreme Being who created, guided and controlled the universe had no sound foundations. I began discussions on this subject with my friends. I had openly declared myself an atheist. What it meant will be discussed in the following lines.

In May 1927, I was arrested in Lahore. This arrest came as a big surprise for me. I had not the least idea that I was wanted by the police. I was passing through a garden and all of a sudden the police surrounded me. To my own surprise, I was very calm at that time. I was in full control of myself. I was taken into police custody. The next day I was taken to the Railway Police lockup where I spent a whole month. After many days' conversation with police personnel, I guessed that they had some information about my connection with the Kakori Party. I felt they had some intelligence of my other activities in the revolutionary movement. They told me that I was in Lucknow during the Kakori Party Trial so that I might devise a scheme to rescue the culprits. They also said that after the plan had been approved, we procured some bombs and by way of test, one of those bombs was thrown into a crowd on the occasion of Dussehra in 1926. They offered to release me on condition that I gave a statement on the activities of the Revolutionary Party. In this way I would be set free and even rewarded and I would not be produced as an approver in the court. I could not help laughing at their proposals. It was all humbug. People who have ideas like ours do not throw bombs at their own innocent people. One day, Mr. Newman, the then senior Superintendent of CID, came to me. After a long talk which was full of sympathetic words, he imparted to me what he considered to be sad news, that if I did not give any statement as demanded by them, they would be forced to send me up for trial for conspiracy to wage war in connection with Kakori Case and also for brutal killings in Dussehra gathering. After that he said that he had sufficient evidence to get me convicted and hanged.

I was completely innocent, but I believed that the police had sufficient power to do it if they desired it to be so. The same day some police officers persuaded me to offer my prayers to God two times regularly. I was an atheist. I thought that I would settle it to myself whether I could brag only in days of peace and happiness that I was an atheist, or in those hard times I could be steadfast in my convictions. After a long debate with myself, I reached the conclusion that I could not even pretend to be a believer nor could I offer my prayers to God. No, I never did it. It was time of trial and I would come out of it successful. These were my thoughts. Never for a moment did I desire to save my life. So I was a true atheist then and I am an atheist now. It was not an easy task to face that ordeal. Beliefs make it easier to go through hardships, even make them pleasant. Man can find a strong support in God and an encouraging consolation in His Name. If you have no belief in Him, then there is no alternative but to depend upon yourself. It is not child's play to stand firm on your feet amid storms and strong winds. In difficult times, vanity, if it remains, evaporates and man cannot find the courage to defy beliefs held in common esteem by the people. If he really revolts against such beliefs, we must conclude that it is not sheer vanity; he has some kind of extraordinary strength. This is exactly the situation now. First of all we all know what the judgement will be. It is to be pronounced in a week or so. I am going to sacrifice my life for a cause. What more consolation can there be! A God-believing Hindu may expect to be reborn a king; a Muslim or a Christian might dream of the luxuries he hopes to enjoy in paradise as a reward for his sufferings and sacrifices. What hope should I entertain? I know that will be the end when the rope is tightened round my neck and the rafters move from under my feet. To use more precise religious terminology, that will be the moment of utter annihilation. My soul will come to nothing. If I take the courage to take the matter in the light of 'Reward', I see that a short

life of struggle with no such magnificent end shall itself be my 'Reward.' That is all. Without any selfish motive of getting any reward here or in the hereafter, quite disinterestedly have I devoted my life to the cause of freedom. I could not act otherwise. The day shall usher in a new era of liberty when a large number of men and women, taking courage from the idea of serving humanity and liberating them from sufferings and distress, decide that there is no alternative before them except devoting their lives for this cause. They will wage a war against their oppressors, tyrants or exploiters, not to become kings, or to gain any reward here or in the next birth or after death in paradise; but to cast off the yoke of slavery, to establish liberty and peace they will tread this perilous, but glorious path. Can the pride they take in their noble cause be called vanity? Who is there rash enough to call it so? To him I say either he is foolish or wicked. Leave such a fellow alone for he cannot realise the depth, the emotions, the sentiment and the noble feelings that surge in that heart. His heart is dead, a mere lump of flesh, devoid of feelings. His convictions are infirm, his emotions feeble. His selfish interests have made him incapable of seeing the truth. The epithet 'vanity' is always hurled at the strength we get from our convictions.

You go against popular feelings; you criticise a hero, a great man who is generally believed to be above criticism. What happens? No one will answer your arguments in a rational way; rather you will be considered vainglorious. Its reason is mental insipidity. Merciless criticism and independent thinking are the two necessary traits of revolutionary thinking. As Mahatmaji is great, he is above criticism; as he has risen above, all that he says in the field of politics, religion, Ethics is right. You agree or not, it is binding upon you to take it as truth. This is not constructive thinking. We do not take a leap forward; we go many steps back.

Our forefathers evolved faith in some kind of Supreme Being, therefore, one who ventures to challenge the validity of that faith or denies the existence of God, shall be called a Kafir (infidel), or a renegade. Even if his arguments are so strong that it is impossible to refute them, if his spirit is so strong that he cannot be bowed down by the threats of misfortune that may befall him through the wrath of the Almighty, he shall be decried as vainglorious. Then why should we waste our time in such discussions? This question has come before the people for the first time, hence the necessity and usefulness of such long discussions.

As far as the first question is concerned, I think I have made it clear that I did not turn atheist because of vanity. Only my readers, not I, can decide whether my arguments carry weight. If I were a believer, I know in the present circumstances my life would have been easier; the burden lighter. My disbelief in God has turned all the circumstances too harsh and this situation can deteriorate further. Being a little mystical can give the circumstances a poetic turn. But I need no opiate to meet my end. I am a realistic man. I want to overpower this tendency in me with the help of Reason. I am not always successful in such attempts. But it is man's duty to try and make efforts. Success depends on chance and circumstances.

Now we come to the second question: if it is not vanity, there ought to be some sound reason for rejection of age-old belief in God. Yes, I come to this question. I think that any man who has some reasoning power always tries to understand the life and people around him with the help of this faculty. Where concrete proofs are lacking, [mystical] philosophy creeps in. As I have indicated, one of my revolutionary friends used to say that "philosophy is the outcome of human weakness." Our ancestors had the leisure to solve the mysteries of the world, its past, its present and its future, its whys and its wherefores, but having been terribly short of direct proofs, every one of them tried to solve the problem in his own way. Hence we find wide differences in the fundamentals of various religious creeds. Sometimes they take very antagonistic and conflicting forms. We find differences in Oriental and Occidental philosophies. There are differences even amongst various schools of thoughts in each hemisphere. In Asian religions, the Muslim religion is completely incompatible with the Hindu faith. In India itself, Buddhism and Jainism are sometimes quite separate from Brahmanism. Then in Brahmanism itself, we find two conflicting sects: AaryaSamaj and SnatanDheram. Charwak is yet another independent thinker of the past ages. He challenged the Authority of

God. All these faiths differ on many fundamental questions, but each of them claims to be the only true religion. This is the root of the evil. Instead of developing the ideas and experiments of ancient thinkers, thus providing ourselves with the ideological weapon for the future struggle, – lethargic, idle, fanatical as we are – we cling to orthodox religion and in this way reduce human awakening to a stagnant pool.

It is necessary for every person who stands for progress to criticise every tenet of old beliefs. Item by item he has to challenge the efficacy of old faith. He has to analyse and understand all the details. If after rigorous reasoning, one is led to believe in any theory of philosophy, his faith is appreciated. His reasoning may be mistaken and even fallacious. But there is chance that he will be corrected because Reason is the guiding principle of his life. But belief, I should say blind belief is disastrous. It deprives a man of his understanding power and makes him reactionary.

Any person who claims to be a realist has to challenge the truth of old beliefs. If faith cannot withstand the onslaught of reason, it collapses. After that his task should be to do the groundwork for new philosophy. This is the negative side. After that comes in the positive work in which some material of the olden times can be used to construct the pillars of new philosophy. As far as I am concerned, I admit that I lack sufficient study in this field. I had a great desire to study the Oriental Philosophy, but I could get ample opportunity or sufficient time to do so. But so far as I reject the old time beliefs, it is not a matter of countering belief with belief, rather I can challenge the efficacy of old beliefs with sound arguments. We believe in nature and that human progress depends on the domination of man over nature. There is no conscious power behind it. This is our philosophy.

Being atheist, I ask a few questions from theists:
1. If, as you believe there is an Almighty, Omnipresent, Omniscient God, who created the earth or universe, please let me know, first of all, as to why he created this world. This world which is full of woe and grief, and countless miseries, where not even one person lives in peace.
2. Pray, don't say it is His law. If He is bound by any law, He is not Omnipotent. Don't say it is His pleasure. Nero burnt one Rome. He killed a very limited number of people. He caused only a few tragedies, all for his morbid enjoyment. But what is his place in history? By what names do we remember him? All the disparaging epithets are hurled at him. Pages are blackened with invective diatribes condemning Nero: the tyrant, the heartless, the wicked.

One Genghis Khan killed a few thousand people to seek pleasure in it and we hate the very name. Now, how will you justify your all powerful, eternal Nero, who every day, every moment continues his pastime of killing people? How can you support his doings which surpass those of Genghis Khan in cruelty and in misery inflicted upon people? I ask why the Almighty created this world which is nothing but a living hell, a place of constant and bitter unrest. Why did he create man when he had the power not to do so? Have you any answer to these questions? You will say that it is to reward the sufferer and punish the evildoer in the hereafter. Well, well, how far will you justify a man who first of all inflicts injuries on your body and then applies soft and soothing ointment on them? How far the supporters and organizers of Gladiator bouts were justified in throwing men before half starved lions, later to be cared for and looked after well if they escaped this horrible death. That is why I ask: Was the creation of man intended to derive this kind of pleasure?

Open your eyes and see millions of people dying of hunger in slums and huts dirtier than the grim dungeons of prisons; just see the labourers patiently or say apathetically while the rich vampires suck their blood; bring to mind the wastage of human energy that will make a man with a little common sense shiver in horror. Just observe rich nations throwing their surplus produce into the sea instead of distributing it among the needy and deprived. There are palaces of kings built upon the foundations laid with human bones. Let

them see all this and say "All is well in God's Kingdom." Why so? This is my question. You are silent. All right. I proceed to my next point.

You, the Hindus, would say: Whosoever undergoes sufferings in this life, must have been a sinner in his previous birth. It is tantamount to saying that those who are oppressors now were Godly people then, in their previous births. For this reason alone they hold power in their hands. Let me say it plainly that your ancestors were shrewd people. They were always in search of petty hoaxes to play upon people and snatch from them the power of Reason. Let us analyse how much this argument carries weight!

Those who are well versed in the philosophy of Jurisprudence relate three of four justifications for the punishment that is to be inflicted upon a wrong-doer. These are: revenge, reform, and deterrence. The Retribution Theory is now condemned by all the thinkers. Deterrent theory is on the anvil for its flaws. Reformative theory is now widely accepted and considered to be necessary for human progress. It aims at reforming the culprit and converting him into a peace-loving citizen. But what in essence is God's Punishment even if it is inflicted on a person who has really done some harm? For the sake of argument we agree for a moment that a person committed some crime in his previous birth and God punished him by changing his shape into a cow, cat, tree, or any other animal. You may enumerate the number of these variations in Godly Punishment to be at least eighty-four lack. Tell me, has this tomfoolery, perpetrated in the name of punishment, any reformative effect on human man? How many of them have you met who were donkeys in their previous births for having committed any sin? Absolutely no one of this sort! The so called theory of 'Puranas' (transmigration) is nothing but a fairy-tale. I do not have any intention to bring this unutterable trash under discussion. Do you really know the most cursed sin in this world is to be poor? Yes, poverty is a sin; it is a punishment! Cursed be the theoretician, jurist or legislator who proposes such measures as push man into the quagmire of more heinous sins. Did it not occur to your All Knowing God or he could learn the truth only after millions had undergone untold sufferings and hardships? What, according to your theory, is the fate of a person who, by no sin of his own, has been born into a family of low caste people? He is poor so he cannot go to a school. It is his fate to be shunned and hated by those who are born into a high caste. His ignorance, his poverty, and the contempt he receives from others will harden his heart towards society. Supposing that he commits a sin, who shall bear the consequences? God, or he, or the learned people of that society? What is your view about those punishments inflicted on the people who were deliberately kept ignorant by selfish and proud Brahmans? If by chance these poor creatures heard a few words of your sacred books, Vedas, these Brahmans poured melted lead into their ears. If they committed any sin, who was to be held responsible? Who was to bear the brunt? My dear friends, these theories have been coined by the privileged classes. They try to justify the power they have usurped and the riches they have robbed with the help of such theories. Perhaps it was the writer Upton Sinclair who wrote (Bhagat Singh is referring to Sinclair's pamphlet 'Profits of Religion' – MIA transcriber) somewhere "only make a man firm believer in the immortality of soul, then rob him of all that he possesses. He will willingly help you in the process." The dirty alliance between religious preachers and possessors of power brought the boon of prisons, gallows, knouts and above all such theories for the mankind.

I ask why your Omnipotent God does not hold a man back when he is about to commit a sin or offence. It is child's play for God. Why did He not kill war lords? Why did He not obliterate the fury of war from their minds? In this way He could have saved humanity of many a great calamity and horror. Why does He not infuse humanistic sentiments into the minds of the Britishers so that they may willingly leave India? I ask why He does not fill the hearts of all capitalist classes with altruistic humanism that prompts them to give up personal possession of the means of production and this will free the whole labouring humanity from the shackles of money. You want to argue the practicability of Socialist theory, I leave it to your Almighty God to enforce it. Common people understand the merits of Socialist theory as far as general welfare is concerned but they oppose it under the pretext that it cannot be implemented. Let the Almighty step in and arrange things in a proper way. No more logic chopping! I tell you that the British rule is not there because

God willed it but for the reason that we lack the will and courage to oppose it. Not that they are keeping us under subjugation with the consent of God, but it is with the force of guns and rifles, bombs and bullets, police and militia, and above all because of our apathy that they are successfully committing the most deplorable sin, that is, the exploitation of one nation by another. Where is God? What is He doing? Is He getting a diseased pleasure out of it? A Nero! A Genghis Khan! Down with Him!

Now another piece of manufactured logic! You ask me how I will explain the origin of this world and origin of man. Charles Darwin has tried to throw some light on this subject. Study his book. Also, have a look at Sohan Swami's "Commonsense." You will get a satisfactory answer. This topic is concerned with Biology and Natural History. This is a phenomenon of nature. The accidental mixture of different substances in the form of Nebulae gave birth to this earth. When? Study history to know this. The same process caused the evolution of animals and in the long run that of man. Read Darwin's 'Origin of Species.' All the later progress is due to man's constant conflict with nature and his efforts to utilise nature for his own benefit. This is the briefest sketch of this phenomenon.

Your next question will be why a child is born blind or lame even if he was not a sinner in his previous birth. This problem has been explained in a satisfactory manner by biologists as a mere biological phenomenon. According to them the whole burden rests upon the shoulders of parents whose conscious or unconscious deeds caused mutilation of the child prior to his birth.

You may thrust yet another question at me, though it is merely childish. The question is: If God does not really exist, why do people come to believe in Him? Brief and concise my answer will be. As they come to believe in ghosts, and evil spirits, so they also evolve a kind of belief in God: the only difference being that God is almost a universal phenomenon and well developed theological philosophy. However, I do disagree with radical philosophy. It attributes His origin to the ingenuity of exploiters who wanted to keep the people under their subjugation by preaching the existence of a Supreme Being; thus claimed an authority and sanction from Him for their privileged position. I do not differ on the essential point that all religions, faiths, theological philosophies, and religious creeds and all other such institutions in the long run become supporters of the tyrannical and exploiting institutions, men and classes. Rebellion against any king has always been a sin in every religion.

As regard the origin of God, my thought is that man created God in his imagination when he realized his weaknesses, limitations and shortcomings. In this way he got the courage to face all the trying circumstances and to meet all dangers that might occur in his life and also to restrain his outbursts in prosperity and affluence. God, with his whimsical laws and parental generosity was painted with variegated colours of imagination. He was used as a deterrent factor when his fury and his laws were repeatedly propagated so that man might not become a danger to society. He was the cry of the distressed soul for he was believed to stand as father and mother, sister and brother, brother and friend when in time of distress a man was left alone and helpless. He was Almighty and could do anything. The idea of God is helpful to a man in distress.

Society must fight against this belief in God as it fought against idol worship and other narrow conceptions of religion. In this way man will try to stand on his feet. Being realistic, he will have to throw his faith aside and face all adversaries with courage and valour. That is exactly my state of mind. My friends, it is not my vanity; it is my mode of thinking that has made me an atheist. I don't think that by strengthening my belief in God and by offering prayers to Him every day, (this I consider to be the most degraded act on the part of man) I can bring improvement in my situation, nor can I further deteriorate it. I have read of many atheists facing all troubles boldly, so I am trying to stand like a man with the head high and erect to the last; even on the gallows.

Let us see how steadfast I am. One of my friends asked me to pray. When informed of my atheism, he said, "When your last days come, you will begin to believe." I said, "No, dear sir, Never shall it happen. I consider it to be an act of degradation and demoralisation. For such petty selfish motives, I shall never pray." Reader and friends, is it vanity? If it is, I stand for it.

Article 97

A biomaterial is any substance that has been engineered to interact with biological systems for a medical purpose - either a therapeutic (treat, augment, repair or replace a tissue function of the body) or a diagnostic one. As a science, biomaterials is about fifty years old. The study of biomaterials is called biomaterials science or biomaterials engineering. It has experienced steady and strong growth over its history, with many companies investing large amounts of money into the development of new products. Biomaterials science encompasses elements of medicine, biology, chemistry, tissue engineering and materials science. Note that a biomaterial is different from a biological material, such as bone, that is produced by a biological system. Additionally, care should be exercised in defining a biomaterial as biocompatible, since it is application-specific. A biomaterial that is biocompatible or suitable for one application may not be biocompatible in another.

Currently, the paramount problem in the field of biomaterials is control over the interface, or surface, between implanted biomaterials and living tissues. The physical properties of most tissues can be matched by careful selection of raw materials: metals, ceramics, or several varieties of polymer materials. Even the requirement that biomaterials processed from these materials be nontoxic to host tissue can be met by techniques derived from studying the reactions of tissue cultures to biomaterials or from short-term implants. But achieving necessary matches in physical properties across interfaces between living and non-living matter requires knowledge of which molecules control the bonding of cells to each other an area that we have not yet explored thoroughly. Although recent research has allowed us to stabilize the tissue-biomaterial interface by controlling either the chemical reactions or the microstructure of the biomaterial, our fundamental understanding of how implant devices adhere to tissues remains woefully incomplete.

Article 98

To MBA or not to MBA? There's no question!
The Masters in Business Administration has been catapulting careers to unprecedented heights since Harvard Business School launched the first ever MBA program in 1908.
Today, the MBA is the world's most sought-after business management degree; the pièce de résistance for many an international b-school.

Michael Bloomberg has one, Google CEO SundarPichai has one, Donald Trump sometimes says he has one. Heck, even Shaquille O'Neal has one. Basically, MBAs are cool.

mbaguru
LEADER IN ADAPTIVE PREPARATION FOR CAT

Business Because (also cool) is in the business of supporting people on their MBA journey all the way from the very beginning.
With this in mind, we spoke to MBA students, grads, professors, admissions staff, bloggers and entrepreneurs — and asked them all the same simple question: Why should I get an MBA?

Here's what they said:

1. Go From MBA To CEO
Who runs the world? MBAs. MBAs grads hold the reigns of some of the world's biggest firms: Apple, Google, JPMorgan and Coca-Cola included.

2. Double Your Earnings
Get rich quick with a **return on your investment** in under four years.

3. Change Industry
Want to switch from finance to fashion? An MBA is the perfect opportunity to start afresh.

4. Get Access To Top Employers
Julia Sanchez, head of global alumni relations at Spain's **IE Business School**, says an MBA will "open your eyes to infinite possibilities".

5. Scholarships
MBAs can be costly. **Prodigy Finance** lets you fund your degree with community-funded student loans.

6. Go From MBA To US President
Harvard MBA grad George Dubya did it.
Go Global

7. Study Abroad
The world's your oyster. Every year, international MBA students flock to Hong Kong's **CUHK Business School**, the gateway to careers in China.

8. Work In The World's Top Cities
Where you choose to study can determine your future career. Choose wisely. Paris, Melbourne, Tokyo and London are ranked among the **top 10 best student cities** in the world!

9. Break A World Record
Students at **London Business School** *(pictured below)* set a new world record for the highest number of different nationalities taking part in a popular singalong. They sang John Lennon's "Imagine" on the school lawn.

10. Cross Cultures
Learn to operate within different cultures. In China, saving face is everything. Oh, and don't be surprised if local people take photos of you in Tiananmen Square!

11. Learn A Language
LBS students are required to learn and be competent in a chosen second language by the time they graduate. Parlez-vous MBA?

12. Live It Up On Campus

Picking a pretty campus can give you that little bit of extra motivation when hitting the books. At **UWA Business School**, students stroll through the picturesque surroundings of Perth's Swan River.

13. International Classrooms
No need to travel! At **Copenhagen Business School**, you get to "meet the world, in one class, in one place", according to MBA student Marius VetaasThomassen.

Entrepreneurship
14. Start Your Own Business
What do Nike, Gap and Victoria's Secret all have in common? They were all started by MBAs. It's simple: If you want to launch your own business venture, an MBA gives you the tools and the support to do so.

15. Jump Into Silicon Valley
Want to join Apple, Google and Facebook in tech heaven? **Stanford**, **Berkeley Haas** and **UCLA Anderson** all have strong ties to the world's number one tech hub.

16. Meet Your Business Partner
Karl Loo and Jason Kang *(pictured below)* met at **Oxford Saïd** before starting up South-East Asia sharing economy venture **ServisHero**, billed as the Uber for local services.

17. Get Some B-School Backing
ESSEC Business School in France cuts out any administrative hassle for its MBA entrepreneurs by providing a rented start-up space, and by organizing meetings with venture capital investors.

18. Launch Your Own Luxury Brand
Bored of big brand designer labels? Puerto Rican fashionista **Mario Alberghini** started up his own luxury menswear brand — La Tigre Uomo — after an MBA at **Bologna Business School** in Italy.

19. Make A Social Impact
Give something back. After an MBA at **George Washington University** b-school (GWSB), **Joshua Pavano** *(pictured below)* set up **Jonas Umbrellas**. Profits from selling limited edition umbrellas fund the building of clean-water wells at schools in Uganda.

Hard Skills, Soft Skills
20. Change The Way You Think
An MBA will get inside your head and mind, and fundamentally change the way you look at the world. Creepy…

21. Be A Leader
MBA programs are training grounds for the world's future business leaders. **Rainmaker Thinking** management guru **Bruce Tulgan** says that basic leadership techniques can be picked up by almost anyone. The next step? "Practice, practice, practice those techniques until they become skills and then habits."

22. Be The Ultimate Team Player
If you can work with a bunch of highly intelligent, highly ambitious, highly strung Type A personalities, then you can work with anyone.

23. Ace Your Analysis

"You'll learn how to analyze any company from many different perspectives and you'll develop the ability to understand the strategy, operations, and performance of that company, quickly and effectively," says former HBS professor-turned-top-business-blogger **Michael Roberto**.

24. Spot The Cheats
Tormented by Toshiba? **John Sakakini** says that, with an MBA, you learn how companies try to get away with massaging numbers to make themselves look better. "Looking at you Groupon!" he says.

25. Master The Dark Arts
Need to secure a big business deal? Pick up the dark arts of seduction and persuasion at b-school and you can make sure things go your way.

26. Be Big On Big Data
An MBA keeps you at the cutting-edge of tech. As big data transforms the business landscape, **McMaster University's DeGroote** b-school in Canada has launched an EMBA on the subject, while IE Business School in Spain offers a **combined MBA and master** in business and data analytics.

27. Stay A Cyber Step Ahead
Online hackers are a threat to any business. GWSB runs a **specialized EMBA**with a cybersecurity specialization.

28. Tap Into 21st Century Marketing
On the Copenhagen Business School MBA, students learn all the best tricks of the trade from top marketing expert **Thomas Ritter**.

29. Sell Yourself
MBAs teach you how to market yourself.

30. Say Goodbye To Stress
Granted, an MBA can be an infinitely stressful experience. But that's partly the point. With an MBA your stress threshold will sky-rocket, preparing you for your high level, high octane business career.

31. Play The Markets
Are stocks, shares, and markets all a mystery? With an MBA, you'll be playing the stock market and partying like the Wolf of Wall Street before you know it.

32. Finally Learn How To Use Excel
Algorithms, equations, tables, spreadsheets, workbooks, bleurgh! Wondering what it all means? You'll be an Excel expert by the time you've finished finance.

33. Up Your Oratory
Pitch, present, represent. An MBA will provide you with the confidence and communication skills to help you conquer your fear of public speaking.

Networking, Parties and Social Life

34. Be A Student Again
As **Lancaster** University Management School MBA student Shaswati Panda says, "The best part of an MBA is that it welcomes us back to student life; the life we always longed for once it was over."

35. Party All Year Round

Diwali, Christmas or the Chinese New Year. In such a multicultural environment, you'll receive more social event invites than you can physically handle.

36. Find A Friend
The **UWA student social club** creates MBA friendships that last.

37. Get Hitched
All those late nights working together.Your eyes meeting over a financial accounting textbook. Where better to meet your high-flying life partner?

38. Free Booze!
MBA events have their perks.

39. Dress For Success
Think you can get away with an un-ironed t-shirt? Think again. B-schools have an unspoken "business casual" dress code. Pack your blazers. And ladies, don't forget that Gucci handbag.

40. More Freebies
B-schools kit out their students with branded gear; umbrellas, calculators, backpacks or, if you're at London's **Imperial College Business School**, a personally engraved iPad.

41. Compete In The MBA Olympics
HEC Paris hosts an annual MBA tournament, which brings sports teams from b-schools around the world together to compete.

42. Go On School Trips
AGSM MBA students started their year by climbing up Australia's Sydney Harbor Bridge.

43. Meet Industry Experts
An MBA opens doors. Get on the career events circuit and network your way to the top.

Me, Myself and I
44. Find Yourself
Already backpacked around South America in search of the inner you? Come up short? An MBA gives you time for self-reflection.

45. Find Your Yoda
"You will find a great mentor among the faculty and alumni of the school you attend," says former HBS prof **Michael Roberto**.
He's not wrong. Ozzie accountant **Chris Yates** was thrilled when he was matched with the former CFO of giant mining corporation ENK on **UWA Business School**'s mentoring program.

46. Spice Up Your Resume
For MBA admissions blogger **Stacy Blackman**, an MBA is a stamp on your resume that no one can take away. You're more than just a name now. You're [insert name here] MBA.

47. Fill In The Gaps

Gaps in your resume? An MBA gives you the time to figure out what you want to do with your life, guilt-free. LBS blogger **Olly Nguyen** calls it a "covered period" allowing you to "experiment and take risks without anyone questioning what you were doing during that time".

48. Take Your Time, Online
Online MBAs are disrupting the traditional b-school model. Take an MBA online and you can work, holiday, and care for your children at the same time. **Arden University** is a leading provider.

49. Test Your Limits
Just how high can you jump? **Michael Czinkota** — an international business blogger and professor at Georgetown University's **McDonough** School of Business — says an MBA will let you "see how and where you fit in among hard charging competitors".

50. Make Your Family Proud
Aww! But seriously, your mom will love it. Get another graduation photograph up on that mantelpiece!

Conclusion
You made it!
There are so many different reasons why you should get an MBA. If we've missed something, let us know in the comments below.

Article 99

A bizarre fish-humanoid creature is subjected to nefarious experiments in film director Guillermo del Toro's new fantasy thriller "The Shape of Water." Strange as it is, this fictional creature could be explained — at least somewhat — from an evolutionary perspective, scientists say.

The Fox Searchlight Pictures film, which opened in theaters Dec. 1, tells the story of Elisa (Sally Hawkins), a deaf woman who develops an unlikely attraction to the fishlike human (CGI-enhanced Doug Jones), which is held captive at a laboratory by researchers with questionable motivations.

The creature fascinates scientists in the film, and with good reason. The movie's setting is largely realistic, centered in a top-secret U.S. government facility against the backdrop of the Cold War. But the peculiar creature, captured in the Amazon, is an evolutionary anomaly. It is semiaquatic, capable of breathing air or water, and though bipedal and humanoid, it is also adapted for swimming, with fins, webbed feet and hands, and specialized skin that needs to be kept moist.

Does such a creature make evolutionary sense, based on what we know of how life on Earth evolved through natural selection? [Rumor or Reality: The Creatures of Cryptozoology]
As it happens, modern humans do have watery origins — if you peer back far enough on the tree of life. Humans in their present form evolved over billions of years, beginning as simple organisms living in water — an origin story shared by all animals on Earth. From those first forms of life, more-complex body plans emerged over time. Diverse features and specializations allowed animals of all sizes to thrive on land and enabled others to inhabit lakes, rivers and oceans.

Nearly all vertebrates, animals with backbones, can trace their ancestry to a tiny, primitive fish named *Metaspriggina* that lived more than 500 million years ago, scientists reported in a study published in 2014 in the journal Nature. Then, around 400 million years ago, some ancient fishes used their muscular fins to propel themselves over mud, with their descendants eventually emerging to live on land, developing lungs and legs.
These were the first tetrapods: air-breathing animals that were fish-like but had the rudimentary beginnings of a four-limbed body plan. This formed the basic blueprint for all land animals to come.

After tetrapods took to land, hundreds of millions of years would pass before a bipedal humanoid form emerged. The earliest fossil evidence of upright walking in a human ancestor dates to about 8 million years ago, in a hominin called *Orrorintugenensis*, according to a study published in 2008 in the journal Science.

A puzzling creature
If the world in "The Shape of Water" followed this same evolutionary timeline, the movie creature — a two-legged, water-dwelling humanoid — would raise puzzling questions about its place on a tree of life. But under the right conditions, evolution by way of natural selection could hypothetically shape such an animal, Jonathan Losos, a professor of organismic and evolutionary biology at Harvard University, told Live Science.
The fish-human creature has gills but also appears capable of breathing air. And some animals in the real world can, in fact, breathe both water and air. Lungfish rely on gills that interact with functional lungs to provide the animals' oxygen, and these creatures will drown if they're submerged for too long. Some species of turtles can extract oxygen from water through their backsides, essentially breathing through their butts. [Extreme Life on Earth: 8 Bizarre Creatures]

Giles (Richard Jenkins), a frustrated artist, rediscovers his creative spark when he meets the aquatic creature, played by Doug Jones.
Over millions of years, environments have posed similar challenges to the diverse creatures that live in those settings. Often, unrelated species evolve the same optimal solution to those challenges, a phenomenon known as convergent evolution, Losos explained.

Convergent evolution explains how animals that are not close relatives can share similar characteristics or traits, such as the streamlined body found in both ancient ichthyosaurs and modern dolphins, or the jaw structures that appear in both whales and pelicans. Hypothetically, convergent evolution could also lead to bipedalism and a human-like appearance in both humans and a creature more closely related to fish.
"Hollywood certainly hasn't violated any rule of evolution to produce a biped that evolved to be convergent with humans and share a lot of features," Losos said.

But, ultimately, the filmmakers' choice of a human-like appearance for their creature probably owes more to perceptions of the human form as a "pinnacle" of evolution, Losos said. This bias is frequently seen in science-fiction portrayals of extraterrestrials that look remarkably like humans, he said.
In reality, the fact that there are no other species alive today that look like modern humans is a good indication that the reason we look the way we do is "just a fluke of evolution," he added.
"While there are many, many cases of convergent evolution of other adaptations, for some reason, the human life-form only evolved once. The way that primates evolved ultimately made something like us possible, but I see no reason to assume that intelligent life forms must look at all like us," Losos told Live Science.

mbaguru
LEADER IN ADAPTIVE PREPARATION FOR CAT

Article 100

In 1915, Albert Einstein published his General Theory of Relativity, arguing that the universe consists of a fundamental fabric: spacetime. Moreover, he said, this fabric is warped by massive objects. The resulting bending and curving explains what we perceive as gravity.

More than one hundred years later, general relativity has proven to be the most successful framework for understanding the universe, guiding scientists to black holes, time dilation, and gravitational waves, as well as countless other discoveries.

Seven years after Einstein formulated general relativity, he also proffered another theory. This one wasn't exactly related to physics – his intellectual wheelhouse – nor was it carefully detailed in a scholarly publication. Rather, the brief musing described his recipe for happiness, and it was penned on a piece of stationery from the Imperial Hotel in Tokyo, Japan. His pockets empty, Einstein apologetically offered the note to a messenger boy in lieu of a tip, saying that it could be worth far more one day.

He was right. The note bearing Einstein's "Theory of Happiness" sold at auction last week for $1.56 million. The seller is rumored to be the messenger boy's nephew.

The highly publicized auction finally revealed Einstein's wisdom on contentment to the public ninety-five years after it was written:
"A calm and modest life brings more happiness than the pursuit of success combined with constant restlessness."

It's interesting that Einstein wrote such as thing, as much of his life was dedicated to arduous, intellectually revolutionary pursuits. Perhaps he was feeling a tad overwhelmed at the time? In October 1922, when Einstein jotted down his thoughts on happiness in that Tokyo hotel, he had just been informed that he had won the Nobel Prize in Physics. No doubt the sudden publicity and fame were physically and mentally exhausting.

So how does Einstein's "Theory of Happiness" stand up after all these years? Happiness is infinitely more relative than general relativity, so it's difficult for science to offer a definitive answer. Some studies show that switching from regular employment to the frenetic life of self-employment and entrepreneurship actually leads to an increase in life satisfaction, countering Einstein's note. Another study suggested that the happiest people live a "balanced" life, working a little over seven hours per day, exercising frequently, enjoying cooked meals five times a week, and seeing their friends once per week, reinforcing Einstein's note.

One of the most in-depth scientific explorations of happiness and success was published in 2005. Researchers reviewed 225 studies and distilled that happiness more often leads to success rather than the other way around. In sum, "happiness [leads] to behaviors that often produce further success in work, relationships and health, and these successes result in part from a person's positive affect."

So perhaps it was Einstein's tranquil and reflective moments that endowed him the happiness to work so diligently and accomplish so much?
As many psychologists have observed, humans run on a "hedonistic treadmill."
"We work very hard to reach a goal, anticipating the happiness it will bring. Unfortunately, after a brief fix we quickly slide back to our baseline, ordinary way-of-being and start chasing the next thing we believe will almost certainly – and finally – make us happy," Frank T. McAndrew, a Professor of Psychology at Knox College, wrote.

That's why people who have supposedly reached the apex of happiness – lottery winners, successful entrepreneurs, and celebrities – often don't seem much happier than everybody else after growing accustomed to their situations.
At the pinnacle of scientific stardom, Einstein may have been looking down from his lofty position and feeling a tad underwhelmed. His humble "Theory of Happiness" could have been the result. So take Einstein's sage advice into account, but don't expect it to be a blueprint for satisfaction like general relativity has been for understanding the universe.

Article 101

Ernest Shackleton's failed quest to reach the South Pole is still a management tutorial in how to face repeated crises. The crew of his ship, the Endurance, was photographed in July 1915 while trapped by an ice floe.CreditFrank Hurley/Scott Polar Research Institute

A HUNDRED years ago this month, the Norwegian explorer Roald Amundsen and four teammates became the first men to reach the South Pole, arriving in triumph five weeks ahead of Robert Falcon Scott. The Amundsen crew would return safely to its base, but, heartbreakingly, Scott and his four British companions died on the return journey.

The race to the pole has long attracted leadership experts, who like to contrast the Amundsen focus on efficiency and innovation with Scott's more deliberate dedication to scientific pursuit.

But another polar explorer — Ernest Shackleton — faced harsh conditions in a way that speaks more directly to our time. The Shackleton expedition, from 1914 to 1916, is a compelling story of leadership when disaster strikes again and again.

Consider just a handful of recent events: the financial crisis of 2008; the gulf oil spill of 2010; and the Japanese nuclear disaster, the debt-ceiling debacle and euro crisis this year. Constant turbulence seems to be the new normal, and effective leadership is crucial in containing it.

Real leaders, wrote the novelist David Foster Wallace, are people who "help us overcome the limitations of our own individual laziness and selfishness and weakness and fear and get us to do better, harder things than we can get ourselves to do on our own."

Shackleton exemplified this kind of leadership for almost two years on the ice. What can we learn from his actions?

As a historian at the Harvard Business School, I wrote a case study about him that has drawn more interest from executives than any other I have taught.

As some talented research assistants and I worked on the study, I was struck by Shackleton's ability to respond to constantly changing circumstances. When his expedition encountered serious trouble, he had to reinvent the team's goals. He had begun the voyage with a mission of exploration, but it quickly became a mission of survival.

This capacity is vital in our own time, when leaders must often change course midstream — jettisoning earlier standards of success and redefining their purposes and plans.

SHACKLETON can serve as a role model even though his expedition,judged by its initial objectives, was a colossal failure. His ship, the Endurance, never reached Antarctica. None of its 28 crew members set foot on the continent. The journey strained Shackleton's finances to the breaking point, and at the end of it, in late 1916, its fame-seeking protagonist found his accomplishments eclipsed by the horrors of World War I.

When the Endurance set sail in August 1914, Shackleton had a bold, potentially history-making goal: he and his team would be the first to walk across the continent, starting from the coast of the Weddell Sea, traversing the South Pole and ending up at the Ross Sea.

But from the beginning, the expedition encountered unfamiliar challenges. In late 1914, the ship arrived at a whaling settlement on South Georgia Island, the last southern port of call before the Antarctic Circle. Local seamen urged Shackleton to postpone his venture because of unusually thick pack ice that could trap the ship if the wind and temperatures shifted suddenly.

Impatient to get moving, Shackleton commanded the ship to continue south, navigating through the icy jigsaw puzzle. In January 1915, the vessel came within sight of the Antarctic mainland. But harsh winds and cold temperatures descended quickly, and the pack ice trapped the ship, just as the South Georgia seamen had warned.

The Endurance was immobilized, held hostage to the drifting ice floes. Shackleton realized that his men would have to wait out the coming winter in the ship's cramped quarters until summer's thaw.

Shackleton feared the potential effects of idleness, ennui and dissidence among his men more than he did the ice and cold. He required that each man maintain his ordinary duties as closely as possible. Sailors swabbed decks; scientists collected specimens from the ice; others were assigned to hunt for seals and penguins when fresh meat, a protection against scurvy, ran low.

He also kept a strict routine for meals and insisted that the men socialize after dinner, as a tonic for declining morale. Still, collective disappointment, and tempers, flared.

Through the routines, order and interaction, Shackleton managed the collective fear that threatened to take hold when the trip didn't go as planned. He knew that in this environment, without traditional benchmarks and supports, his greatest enemies were high levels of anxiety and disengagement, as well as a slow-burning pessimism.

Days became weeks, and weeks became months, and still the ice held the ship. By June 1915 — the thick of winter in the Southern Hemisphere — the ship's timbers were weakening under the pressure created by the ice, and in October water started pouring into the Endurance.

Shackleton ordered the crew to abandon the sinking ship and make camp on a nearby ice floe. The next morning, he announced a new goal: "Ship and stores have gone — so now we'll go home."

A day later, in the privacy of his diary, he was more candid about the gauntlet in front of him. "A man must shape himself to a new mark directly the old one goes to ground," he wrote. "I pray God, I can manage to get the whole party to civilization."

After the Endurance sank, leaving the men stranded on the ice with three small lifeboats, several tents and supplies, Shackleton realized that he himself had to embody the new survival mission — not only in what he said and did, but also in his physical bearing and the energy he exuded.

He knew that each day, his presence had huge impact on the men's mind-sets. He managed his own emotional intelligence — to use a modern term — to keep his own courage and confidence high; when these flagged, he never let his men know.

Andrew Little, group managing director for the Melbourne unit of DDB, the advertising firm, has been strongly influenced by Shackleton in his own work with his team. Mr. Little read the case several years ago in a company-sponsored executive education course. "What I realized from the case is that as a leader, you have to have an unshakable faith in your mission, yourself and your abilities," he said. "The hardest part of leadership is not just feeding your team with ideas and motivation, but feeding yourself. In the face of enormous obstacles, Shackleton found a way to do this."

Just as important, Shackleton kept his men's focus on the future. The ship was gone; previous plans were irrelevant. Now his goal was to bring the team home safely, and he improvised, adapted and used every resource at hand to achieve it.

When a few men expressed skepticism about his plans, he acted quickly to contain their opposition and negativity by trying to win them over and keeping close watch on them. He assigned several potential troublemakers to his own tent on the ice, proving the value of the saying, "Keep your friends close and your enemies closer."

By April 1916, the ice began breaking up, and Shackleton ordered the men to the lifeboats, hoping to reach land along the tip of the Antarctic Peninsula. After a week of stormy seas, they arrived at the deserted Elephant Island. They were exhausted, seasick and dehydrated. But they took "childish joy," one scientist wrote in his diary, "in looking at the black rocks and picking up the stones, for we had stepped on no land since Dec. 5, 1914."

Almost immediately, Shackleton began planning his next move. Along with five other men, he managed to guide a 22-foot lifeboat to South George Island; from there, a smaller party reached a whaling station and help. After a meal, a bath and a change of clothes, Shackleton said, "we had ceased to be savages and had become civilized men again."

Then he began looking for a vessel capable of rescuing the rest of his crew. During the next several months, he set sail in three different ships, but none could cut through the pack ice surrounding Elephant Island. Finally, on Aug. 30, 1916, aboard the Yelcho, a Chilean steamer, Shackleton sailed within sight of the island and rescued the 22 remaining men. "I have done it," he wrote his wife, Emily. "Not a life lost, and we have been through hell."

Certainly, Shackleton was far from perfect, as executives and M.B.A. students often point out to me. He ordered the ship to sail south even in the face of whalers' warnings about the pack ice. And the expedition might have fared better had he given more than sporadic attention to training his men how to manage and drive the 60-odd sled dogs on board.

Then there is the question of responsibility for the Aurora, whose crew had been charged with setting out supply depots for the Endurance party as it crossed the continent. After unloading men and supplies in early 1915, the Aurora was also trapped by pack ice and carried into open waters, stranding 10 men. Three of them perished before Shackleton and others arrived in January 1917 to rescue them.

Would the outcome have been different had Shackleton devoted more time, energy and money to preparing the Aurora and its crew? The historical record offers no definitive answers. Nonetheless, I have taught this case more than 60 times, and most participants give Shackleton low or mixed marks for planning.

SET against these mistakes is Shackleton'sbehavior after the Endurance was trapped. Once he relinquished his first mission, to walk across Antarctica, and embraced the second, to bring all 28 men home safely, his leadership became much more effective.

Shackleton assumed ultimate responsibility for his team. Perhaps he recognized that he was partly to blame for the crisis that befell the Endurance. Perhaps his naval training instilled in him a deep sense of loyalty and obligation to his fellow crew members. The men themselves understood this, and most, in turn, offered him their commitment.
Shackleton devoted himself to a worthy goal. "As soon as I first read about Shackleton, I was struck by how critical a leader's personal commitment to his or her mission is," said Lynne Greene, global president of the beauty brands Clinique, Origins and Ojon, part of the Estée Lauder Companies. (Ms. Greene encountered the case when I spoke at a company executive leadership session.)

"Shackleton's team knew that whatever came before them on the ice, their leader would give his all to bring them home alive," she said. This knowledge, she added, "was crucial to achieving the mission, and this commitment is key today when so much is changing so fast."

Shackleton's sense of responsibility and commitment came with a great suppleness of means. To get his men home safely, he led them across ice, sea and land with all the tools he could muster. This combination — credible commitment to a larger purpose and flexible, imaginative methods to achieve a goal — is increasingly important in our tumultuous times.

Article 102

Adrienne Mayor's years of research challenge the widely held view that natural historians in classical Greece and Rome lacked the knowledge to interpret large vertebrate fossils as organic remains of the past. That conceptual breakthrough, representing the start of the modern science of paleontology, was supposedly made by the French naturalist Georges Cuvier in 1806. Yet, much like today's fossil hunters, Ms. Mayor found, ancient Greeks and Romans collected and measured the petrified bones they encountered and displayed them in temples and museums. They, too, recognized fossils as evidence of past life, now extinct, anticipating Cuvier by more than 2,000 years.

Still, the ancients often let their culture-bound imaginations run in unscientific directions. In her book, "The First Fossil Hunters: Paleontology in Greek and Roman Times," published in May by Princeton University Press, Ms. Mayor draws on a close study of classical texts to show that some of the more impressive and mysterious fossils were used as evidence supporting existing myths or creating new ones.

The Homeric legend of Heracles rescuing Hesione by slaying the Monster of Troy, for example, may have a paleontological origin. Ms. Mayor pointed out that in the earliest known illustration of the Heracles legend, painted on a Corinthian vase, the monster's skull closely matched that of an extinct giraffe. Such fossils are plentiful on the Greek islands and western coast of Turkey and are mentioned in classical literature. The

vase painting from the sixth century B.C., Ms. Mayor concluded, is most likely "the earliest artistic record of a vertebrate fossil discovery."

Fossils found and displayed in antiquity on the island of Samos probably inspired the story of savage monsters called Neades, whose reverberating bellows were said to tear the earth apart. The Greeks thus had a neat explanation for two perplexing phenomena, the gigantic bones and the earthquakes that frequently devastated their land. Other discoveries of huge mammal bones were viewed as confirmation of the ancient Greek belief in ancestral heroes as 15-foot giants. Mastodon fossils on Samos were hailed as the remains of the war elephants Dionysus is supposed to have deployed in his mythic battle with the Amazons.

And where did the idea of the griffin come from? Aristeas, a seventh-century B.C. traveler, wrote of the gold-seeking Scythians who fought creatures in the Gobi Desert that resembled "lions but with the beak and wings of an eagle." These fierce creatures presumably nested on the ground and guarded deposits of gold. In reality, Ms. Mayor concluded, the griffin "was based on illiterate nomads' observations of dinosaur skeletons in the deserts of Central Asia."

Ms. Mayor's success in piecing together the griffin legend encouraged her to examine other Greek and Roman texts for "the world's oldest written descriptions of fossil finds," which had been overlooked by most classics scholars and historians of science. On a visit to Samos, she studied a rich collection of prehistoric bones and skulls with which the ancients must have been familiar. She began to put texts and fossils together and saw the ancients in a new light. "Just as a fossil is 'petrified time,' so is an ancient artifact or text," she wrote. "The tasks of paleontologists and classical historians and archaeologists are remarkably similar -- to excavate, decipher and bring to life the tantalizing remnants of a time we will never see."

Although Ms. Mayor's interpretations may draw fire from some scholars, the response to her book has so far been favorable. John R. Horner, a dinosaur paleontologist at the Museum of the Rockies in Bozeman, Mont., has called it "the best account ever concerning the real meaning of mythical creatures."

Article 103

We are living in a new age of monopoly power. Mega-mergers are dominating headlines. This week, CVS Health announced that it intends to buy the health insurer Aetna. Meanwhile, AT&T, the telecom behemoth, continues to battle the Justice Department in its $85 billion bid to take over the media giant Time Warner.

Small wonder that fighting monopolies has become a centerpiece of the Democratic Party's economic agenda. On Wednesday, Sen. Elizabeth Warren (D-Mass.) gave a powerful speech warning that anti-competitive market power "also translates into concentrated political power — the kind of power that can capture our government." The Economist — not exactly known as a bastion of socialism — catalogues dangerous levels of concentration in major industries such as airlines, banking, health care and telecommunications — a recipe that yields high profits for corporations but bad service for consumers.

Americans could be forgiven for feeling indifferent about the rise of market power. Many big companies seem benign, even beneficial. Though it might seem odd that Echo speakers are now selling in the produce aisle of Whole Foods since Amazon bought the food retailer, the price of kale, salmon and avocados has dropped. So what, exactly, is the problem?

Despite the superficial benefits of these mega-mergers, it is, in fact, our democracy that is paying the true price. Today, unchecked corporate power is the biggest threat to the American public. Our new age of untrammeled monopoly power brings many economic disadvantages: We see increasing evidence of lower wages, insecure jobs and layoffs. But the real issue is the symbiotic link between overwhelming economic power and overwhelming political power. This makes for a brutally strong chain, locking in its own dominance.

Consider the fact that corporate America spends almost $6.5 billion every political cycle lobbying federal elected officials on behalf of business interests. This is more than double the amount spent on elections, and the most concentrated industries — health care, telecom and finance — dominate. Thousands of lobbyists swarm Capitol Hill daily, writing (and rewriting) everything from financial regulations to the tax code in their own blatant self-interest.

The most egregious example of concentrated monied interests overwhelming public opinion is, of course, the Republican tax bill, rushed through Congress without public hearings. Adam Davidson compared the bill to a teaser rate on a new credit card: a few enticements for the poor and middle class early on, but with the benefits increasingly, year by year, going to the wealthy, until ultimately the poor pay more, and the greatest cuts continue only for those making more than a million dollars a year.

And all of this is to pay for a drastic cut in corporate rates, from 35 percent to 20 percent — just what the donors ordered. Sen. Lindsey O. Graham (R-S.C.) is one of many who have said that "financial contributions will stop" if Republicans don't cut corporate taxes. Let's be clear: The tax bill is historically unpopular, approved by fewer than a third of all voters. Its likely passage is the very definition of undemocratic. The true cost of monopoly is the hijacking of our politics by the hugely powerful few.

We must remember that this situation is not an inevitable result of natural forces. A century ago, the taming of corporate power was central not only to our organization of the economy, but to our politics. Presidents from the Republican Teddy Roosevelt to his Democratic cousin Franklin battled "the curse of bigness" in the name of political freedom. The Supreme Court leveraged the Sherman Antitrust Act to break up Standard Oil, which controlled more than 90 percent of all refined petroleum in the United States. As Nobel laureate Joseph Stiglitz notes, early 20th-century antitrust policy "was not based on a finely honed economic analysis. It was really about the nature of our society and democracy."

But in the 1970s, our thinking about corporations shifted from a focus on democracy to a narrow focus on pricing alone, making antitrust claims very difficult to win. Since then, the number of mergers and acquisitions has skyrocketed, increasing from fewer than 2,000 in 1980 to more than 14,000 in 2000, a level that has been sustained since.

Those concerned about the end of our democracy in the age of Trump must care about the power of giant corporations. And don't be deceived — even those selectively better deals at Whole Foods seem to have been a marketing ploy, since overall prices at the Amazon-owned stores are basically unchanged. (Jeffrey P. Bezos, founder and chief executive of Amazon, owns The Washington Post.) But the bigger reason to fight corporate power is political. No matter your political party, those who believe in basic American liberalism — the free exchange of ideas, goods and services within the context of the common good — must gather the political will and clarity to take our democracy back.

Article 104

Vice President Pence went to the Queens Museum in New York yesterday to commemorate the site of the old United Nations, which 70 years ago today voted for partition to divide the land and establish Arab and Jewish states.

The question 70 years later is, is West Bank partition still feasible? Analysts wonder if the various players such as President Trump, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and Palestinian Authority President Mahmoud Abbas have the will to successfully launch such an effort — or if the best-laid plans will run aground for lack of political resolve.

Aside from the issue of political will, there are those on both the right and left who say there is no way to reconcile the territorial issue and point to the growing West Bank settlements. Critics on the right want Israel to annex much of the West Bank but fail to take into account the international reaction to such a unilateral move. On the left, critics evenwant Israel to be replaced in its entirety and become a bi-national Israeli-Palestine state.

Both approaches are delusional. Israel is not about to commit national suicide.
Given the paucity of options, partition is still feasible. Indeed, newest data suggests that territorial dimension is solvable. A new website launched by the Washington Institute for Near East Policy called Settlements and Solutions seeks to use civilian satellite imagery to provide a better understanding of settler trends.

The interplay of geography and demography in the West Bank matters — for it helps to address whether it is too late for Israelis and Palestinians to reach a compromise on the territorial issues, as well as on matters of security, refugees and the fate of Jerusalem.

If we want to parse out territorial solutions, we need to delineate between two groups of settlers, for they have vastly different implications for resolving the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. Both groups live beyond the Green Line, the boundaries before the 1967 war; one group lives west of (within) the Israeli security barrier (constructed by the Israeli government during the Second Intifada of 2000-2005 to stymie the flow of Palestinian suicide bombers from the West Bank). The second group lives beyond or east of the security barrier. According to the Israel Central Bureau of Statistics, approximately 85 percent of Israelis living east of the Green Line but within the security barrier's delineated area live in approximately 8 percent of the West Bank, in areas largely adjacent to Israeli urban areas. This translates to just under 556,000 Israelis living inside, or west, of the security barrier and more than 97,000 living outside of the barrier.

The above does not suggest that there are not demographic threats that could end a two-state option. While the ratio of 85 percent in 8 percent of the land has remained largely steady, the number of settlers has grown. In 2009 there were 70,000 settlers living beyond the barrier — as of June 2017, that number has increased by 27,000. If, in a two-state solution, there were an agreement between Israelis and Palestinians regarding the relocation of these settlers, the prospect of relocation would become increasingly difficult. Case in point: In contrast, approximately 8,000 settlers were relocated during the 2005 Gaza withdrawal. Of course, parties could agree in negotiations for the settlers to stay for a period of time.

The numbers also highlight the changing nature of the settlement movement. Two settlements out of 139 now account for almost 30 percent of all West Bank settlers and 46 percent of the growth over the last year. The two locations are ultra-Orthodox settlements, denoting a shift since the settlement movement was launched in the late 1960s, largely by religious Zionists who saw the West Bank as biblical patrimony and viewed themselves as political warriors in the struggle to retain the West Bank as part of the State of Israel.

In contrast, the ultra-Orthodox are largely motivated by socioeconomic concerns, especially affordable housing. This is a major demand for an ultra-Orthodox community in which birth-rate averages are an astounding 6.9 per family.
Israel needs to align its settlement policy with a two-state approach that enables Israeli-Palestinian compromise. This would be a strong signal to counter the belief, reflected in Palestinian polls, that Israel wants the entire West Bank. None of this suggests that the barrier would necessarily be the border in a final-status agreement. That border would remain to be negotiated by the parties.

It is not too late. Those on both the right and the left that rush to proclaim the death of the two-state solution due to settlement population growth are too fatalistic. One cannot be certain about the political will to make it happen, but 70 years later, there is — at least for now — a way.

Article 105

Over the last decade, the global economy has seen an increasing move towards digital technologies being a key drive for economic change. The ubiquity of high-speed connectivity, the democratisation of technology via cloud computing and the increasing analysis being performed upon the huge amount of data being created every day, have all created a new economy – one which is disrupting traditional industry without the previous requirements for fixed assets and capital investment.

This convergence of an increasing number of connected devices, ubiquitous broadband, data analytics, artificial intelligence and the cloud has expanded the scope of the digital economy. The measures of the impacts of these changes, however, have not kept pace and many people suggest that measuring the impacts of digital economy should include not only the value that firms derive from digital technology assets, including their consumption of digital services but also the so-called "digital spillover". Digital spillover is a term used to describe the knock-on benefits that follow on from the initial digital investment. These gains come from increased productivity, the unlocking of new business models and sector gained due to the diffusion of digital approaches across different organisations within a sector.

Huawei, in conjunction with Oxford Economics, published the Digital Spillover report which attempted to quantify the true size of the digital economy and determined that its value, when digital spillover is included, is far larger than most people assess. The findings indicated that $11.5 trillion – equating to some 15.5 percent of global GDP – comes from the diffuse digital economy. Further, the study found that the digital economy has been growing at 2.5 times the rate of GDP growth, indicating the digital economy is much larger and more widely spread than previously thought and this casts a new light on how to make plans for the future. Given the growing rate of the digital economy, as Stanford University's Timothy Chou says "Every corporation will become an information-driven company."

One of the side-effects of this change is a shift in the total share of the digital economy that different countries will enjoy. In particular, the report predicts a huge rise in the market share of the digital economy that China and India enjoy, with corresponding falls for some western economies. As for developing countries, Raul Katz, director of business strategy research at Columbia Institute for Tele-Information, states that: "For some developing countries, providing ubiquitous high-speed internet is not going to materialise in one or two years, it's going to take 10 years."

The report recommends that governments focus on incentivising digital investment, and do all that they can to multiply and amplify the channels for digital spillovers. An associated piece of research, Huawei's Global Industry Vision, takes a look at the future and predicts some of the bigger macro trends that will occur by 2025 – a 470% increase in the number of intelligent devices, 70% global coverage by gigabit mobile networks and widespread adoption of artificial intelligence technologies, for example.

Given this context, the report provides six suggestions for governments to increase the total impact of digital technologies:

1. Developing an active digital strategy
2. Bridging the digital divides
3. Providing digital infrastructure
4. Investing in new competitive resources
5. Encouraging a vibrant technology sector
6. Prioritising entrepreneurship and innovation

Running some analysis over different scenarios, the report determined that a high level of focus on digital technology, along with investment in programs to aid its creation, dissemination and uptake, could boost 2025 global GDP by $1.7 trillion - equivalent to $500 extra in the pocket of every working-age adult in the world. But this initial work needs to be done. As Randeep Sudan, an adviser on digital strategy with the World Bank says: "Governments need a whole-of-government approach to ICT."

Both individual organisations, and entire economies, need to recognise that digital technology is evolving from playing a mere support role in the economic process into a core enabler of economies. This evolution will become a key factor for both organisations and economies striving for growth and prosperity. By recognising the spillover impacts of the digital economy, and putting in place policy and investment to maximise those impacts, economies can enjoy exponential benefits.

Article 106

It was almost exactly five years ago that I realised something was changing. A video landed on my phone – I was living in Ghana then – raising awareness of "this time of need for Norway". This "need" was winter, and the video was hilarious. Amid scenes of blizzards, vehicles overturned in snow, and children battling

through subzero conditions, glamorous (and warm) African pop stars encouraged donations of radiators for Norway. "People don't ignore starving people, so why should they ignore cold people?" they sang.

The song, Radi-Aid, was a clear riff on Band Aid, the Feed the World charity set up in response to the 1984 Ethiopian famine. In the ensuing years, Band Aid has come to epitomise the genre that "radiators for Norway" so mocks: poverty porn.

The colonial perspective has such a strong hold that we regard their very identities as in need of being saved Poverty porn, wrote Jorgen Lissner, who first popularised the term in 1981 as an appropriate label for the aid campaigns targeting developing countries, "exposes something in human life that is as delicate and deeply personal as sexuality, that is, suffering ... It puts people's bodies, their misery, their grief and their fear on display with all the details and all the indiscretion that a telescopic lens will allow."

Over three decades later, it seems little has changed. This year, three aid campaigns in particular have attracted attention for the wrong reasons: the singer Ed Sheeran, in a Comic Relief appeal to alleviate poverty in Liberia; the actor Tom Hardy, calling for donations to the Disasters Emergencies Committee for the crisis in Yemen; and the actor Eddie Redmayne, in a DEC advert on the famine in East Africa.

SAIH, the Norwegian group that conceived Radi-Aid, has awarded all three campaigns its "rusty radiator award". Its verdicts are damning. The campaign featuring Sheeran – who is so moved by the plight of two boys sleeping rough in a filthy canoe during his visit to Liberia that he personally commits to placing them in a hotel until they can be "sorted out" – is found guilty of a particularly narcissistic white saviour offence, with an aggravated charge of "poverty tourism".
The DEC campaign starring Hardy, who is also clearly touched by the plight of starving children, receives a similar appraisal. "It is surprising to see the 'white spokesperson trope' in a development video published in 2017," SAIH says. "The video offers no political context … How is the long-term issue addressed? Awful."

These may seem like harsh verdicts. No one is questioning the celebrities' motive – which seem to me a desire to do good – and Hardy, in particular, attempts to humanise his subjects: "These children live in a far-off country many of us are not familiar with. But they are children nonetheless, children just like yours and mine."

It's the right sentiment, but well-intentioned remarks fail to arouse viewers' empathy when the video has the opposite effect. By showing starving and sick children at their most vulnerable and exposed, it goes against the idea that their dignity is worth as much as his children's, and creates an artificial distinction between "us" and "them". Here *we* are, the resourceful and benevolent agents of change; and *they* are the passive others in need of our charity.

There's a simple reason aid agencies use such explicit images: they shock people into giving. And that does, undoubtedly, help alleviate problems in the short term. The East African Emergency campaign between 1980 and 1984, of which Band Aid was a part, brought in £17m for famine relief in Ethiopia. In Yemen, the subject of Hardy's video, 10,000 children have died of preventable diseases. This is a heartbreaking reality, one we should all commit to trying to change.

But what will really effect change is not charity but activism. The problem with adverts of this kind is that, by denying viewers any context as to who "the victims" are, or the structural factors that have contributed to their situation, they give the impression that the suffering is inevitable. It is not. Yemen's humanitarian crisis, which the UN has called the worst in the world, is being exacerbated by the continuing blockade by Saudi Arabia, one of Britain's closest allies. Lobbying the government to stop selling arms to the Saudis would have a far greater impact than charity.

In 2015, the financial assistance received by the 54 countries on the African continent was far outstripped by the $203bn (£150bn) taken out of itby multinationals repatriating profits and moving money into tax havens, or by costs imposed by other countries – many of the same nations whose citizens are being fed the idea that only their generosity can save Africa's impoverished children.

These narratives do not exist in a vacuum. The colonial perspective – in which we regard the developing world as a place to plunder, while simultaneously congratulating ourselves on our humanitarian concern for its people – has us in an enduring psychosis. This skews our judgment, allowing us to commit these extreme acts of othering, even when – as is clearly the case with these well-intentioned celebrities – we are trying to help.

It's not that the content of these videos is false. As the Nigerian writer ChimamandaNgoziAdichie – who has spoken powerfully of the problems of a "single narrative" of the African continent – has put it, the problem with stereotypes is not that they are untrue. The problem is that they are stereotypes. And in the long run they are powerful enough, in denying people their agency and caricaturing them as beggars lacking dignity, to create more problems than they solve.

Article 107

Political ideology became a more pronounced factor in the numerous guerrilla campaigns of World War II. In most of the countries invaded by Germany, Italy, and Japan, local communists either formed their own guerrilla bands or joined other bands—such as the French and Belgian maquis. While consolidating their hold on the country, some of these groups spent as much time eliminating indigenous opposition as they did fighting the enemy, but most of them contributed sufficiently to the Allied war effort to be sent shipments of arms, equipment, and gold, which helped them to challenge existing governments after the war. In the following decades the Soviet Union and United States supported a series of widespread guerrilla insurgencies and counterinsurgencies in dangerous and often unproductive—but always costly—proxy wars.

In Yugoslavia and Albania the communist takeover of government was simple and immediate; in China it was complicated and delayed; in South Vietnam it succeeded after nearly three decades; in Greece, Malaya, and the Philippines it was foiled—but only after prolonged and costly fighting. Noncommunist insurgents simultaneously used guerrilla warfare, with heavy emphasis on terrorist tactics, to help end British rule in Palestine in 1948 and Dutch rule in Indonesia in 1949.

Mao's victory in China in 1949 established him as the prophet of "revolutionary warfare" who had transferred Marxism-Leninism from the industrial areas to the countryside and in doing so heartened contemporary insurgents and encouraged new ones. In Indochina, Ho Chi Minh's Viet Minh guerrillas, ably commanded by Vo Nguyen Giap, had been fighting the French overlords since 1945. The struggle ended in 1954 with the Battle of Dien Bien Phu, when a strongly fortified French garrison surrendered after a two-month-long quasi-conventional ground attack by Giap's army. A civil war followed between Ho's North Vietnam and South Vietnam, the former supported by the Soviet Union and China and the latter by the United States and its allies. U.S. involvement in the Vietnam War steadily increased, resulting in the first

commitment of U.S. troops in 1961 and ending only with the North Vietnamese conquest of the entire country in 1975.

Meanwhile, a spate of new insurgencies, both communist and noncommunist, followed to end French rule in Algeria and British rule in Kenya, Cyprus, and Rhodesia. Fidel Castro's overthrow of the tottering and corrupt regime of Fulgencio Batista in Cuba in 1959 provoked other rural insurgencies throughout Latin America (*see also* Che Guevara), Asia, the Middle East, and Africa. Old and new insurgencies flourished in Peru, Colombia, El Salvador, Nicaragua, the Philippines, Thailand, Sri Lanka, India, Kashmir, Lebanon, Syria, Morocco, Angola, Mozambique, Northern Ireland, and Spain.

Such was the media-heightened impact of urban guerrilla warfare, and such its potential danger to civilized society, that some observers believed "urban terrorism" should be classified as a new genre of warfare. But terrorist tactics, urban or rural, even the most extreme, have always been integral to guerrilla and counterguerrilla warfare—indeed to all warfare. "Kill one, frighten 10,000," wrote the Chinese general Sunzi (Sun Tzu) in 350 BC.

Initially, urban guerrilla warfare alone appeared to be a losing proposition, in that its promiscuous collective destruction—particularly mass murder—tended to alienate a formerly passive and even sympathetic citizenry. Its Achilles' heel was threefold: a lack of a viable political goal based on the repair of social, economic, and political failures, a lack of an organization designed to reach that goal and capable of providing operational bases and sanctuary areas, and a failure to recruit and train new activists. The lack of organization in depth helps to explain the eventual demise of fringe advocates and practitioners of urban and international terrorism, groups far removed from guerrilla insurgencies. Examples of such groups in the 1970s and '80s are the Black Panther Party, the Weathermen, and the Symbionese Liberation Army in the United States; the Japanese Red Army; the Red Army Faction in West Germany; the Angry Brigade in the United Kingdom; the Red Brigades of Italy; Direct Action in France; and Middle Eastern groups such as the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine–General Command and the AbūNiḍāl Group.

However, urban warfare, once properly organized and combined with rural guerrilla warfare and with the increased employment of bomb attacks, played an important role in bringing cease-fires and even peace (however tentative) to such places as Northern Ireland, Sri Lanka, and Israel-Palestine (though not to Colombia, Spain, Indonesia, Nepal, the Philippines, or Chechnya). Not without reason did some experts conclude that guerrilla warfare and terrorism, rural or urban, internal or international, had become the primary form of conflict for that time.

Article 108

Bill Gates really cut loose during the question and answer portion of his lecture at the University of Washington's Paul G. Allen Center. Asked about economic disparity, how money is influencing politics and the challenge voters face making informed decisions, Gates said "the world at large is less inequitable today than at any time in history." The number of people around the world in abject poverty has gone down, as has the mortality rate for young children, he said. But there is clearly concentration of wealth, said the man who was the world's richest for many years. "You're absolutely right. There's some big fortunes and society can't - it's not good to have a society where you don't have mobility in between different income levels. That is, if you're born in the bottom quartile, education ought to be good enough that you have a reasonable chance of getting into the first or second quartile." Education is the key, he said. "So if you really look at

where we're letting people down in terms of the American dream, I wouldn't say - you can take this as self-serving - I wouldn't say it's because of a few people are very rich. I'd say it's because we haven't been doing a good job on education to give them an opportunity to move up into the top few percent." As for the ultrarich, Gates noted that he and Warren Buffett have encouraged other billionaires to share more of their wealth. "The rich should give away more of their wealth than they currently do, and we've certainly been willing to speak out about that. Warren's the only person who's ever had a tax named after him -- the Buffett tax." Gates said he was just in Washington, D.C., trying to explain to members of Congress that it won't help the country to cut spending on science projects. "You can be very frustrated with the political system -- I certainly am." Gates said he doesn't know why politics are so fractured today. "Maybe the system will realize the problems that it has there, but I don't think that just by getting rid of the wealthiest in the country that will solve all these problems," he said. Then he reiterated that better education is key - and education costs should come down - to make society more equitable. Gates said that "money politics" and political districts that enable extreme politicians to hold their seats are factors. The media's also partly to blame, he said. "Certainly, the media -- people do wonder if this polarization comes from the Fox News phenomenon, that you're just listening to the people who agree with you," he said. "I don't really know." Another challenge is the complexity of topics such as taxes and healthcare reform. "The U.S. tax code is so complex that you don't know where to be outraged and you don't have time to read it," he said. Another student told Gates that growing up, she wanted to be the richest person in the world, and she wanted advice. Gates gave a long and thoughtful response. "I didn't start out with a dream of being superrich," he said, noting that after the Intel founders became billionaires, "I thought, wow, that must be strange ... It is.' Here's his advice: "Most people who have done well have just found something they're nuts about doing. Then they figure out a system to hire their friends to do it with them. If it's an area of great impact then sometimes you get financial independence." Gates said crazy money isn't all that it's cracked up to be. "Wealth above a certain level ... really it's a responsibility," he said, explaining that you're either going to have to leave it to your children or "be smart about giving it away." "I can understand about having millions of dollars," he said. "There's meaningful freedom that comes with that, but once you get much beyond that I have to tell you, it's the same hamburger. Dick's has not raised their prices enough." "But being ambitious is good. You just have to pick what you enjoy doing."

SET-5

Article 109

Textbooks are an important aspect of inclusive education in how they incorporate inclusive language, diverse identities, and human rights, particularly as they reflect issues of culture, gender, and religion. The defense of cultural diversity, as understood by UNESCO, is an ethical imperative, inseparable from children's universal right to education. It implies a commitment to the fundamental rights of persons belonging to minorities and to the cultural rights that are an integral part of human rights. Culture is also central to contemporary debates on citizenship and identity, social cohesion, and the growth of knowledge-based economies. Education has a major part to play in shaping such dialogues as cultural exchanges and economic cooperation become increasingly more common. Schools are often the first place in which a climate of trust and mutual understanding among diverse individuals and communities can be built. Textbooks can either help or hinder this development.

Schools naturally expect textbooks to be a valuable source of cultural information for students. Textbooks can be used to promote cultural diversity and, in particular, nurture culture in its broadest sense understood as the "whole complex of distinctive spiritual, material, intellectual and emotional features that characterize a society or social group. A recent research suggests, however, that textbooks, like most other human constructs, are biased on controversial topics. In cases of history, science, current events, and politics textbooks, "the writer might be biased towards one way or another. Topics such as actions of a country, presidential actions, and scientific theories are common potential biases." The research cites as an example textbooks that address the place of Native Americans within the history of the United States. These textbooks distort history to suit a particular cultural value system. In some textbooks, for example, settlers are pictured as more humane, complex, skillful, and wise than Native American. In essence, textbooks stereotype and deprecate the numerous Native American cultures while reinforcing the attitude that the European conquest of the New World denotes the superiority of European cultures. Although textbooks evaluate Native American architecture, political systems, and homemaking, the report contends that they do it from an ethnocentric, European perspective without recognizing that other perspectives are possible.

One argument against the contention asserts that, by nature, textbooks are culturally biased and that one might be simply underestimating children's ability to see through these biases. Some researchers even claim that by the time students are in high school, they know they cannot take textbooks literally. Yet substantial evidence exists to the contrary. Two researchers, for example, have conducted studies that suggest that children's attitudes about particular culture are strongly influenced by the textbooks used in schools. Given this, an ongoing, careful review of how school textbooks depict certain cultures is certainly warranted.

Article 110

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT TO BE HAPPY? Well, for one thing, by definition, you will feel better. But there is more to it than that. Happiness does not just make you enjoy life more; it actually affects how successful you are in both your personal life and your professional life.

A few years ago Sonja Lyubomirsky at the University of California and her colleagues set about the mammoth task of reviewing hundreds of studies in which experimenters cheered up selected people and then monitored the effects of their subjects' newfound joy. All sorts of procedures were employed to make participants feel happy, including having them smell fresh-cut flowers, read out positive affirmations ("I really am a good person"), eat chocolate cake, dance, or watch a funny film. Sometimes the experimenters resorted to trickery, telling participants that they had performed especially well on an IQ test or ensuring that they "accidentally" found some money in the street. Regardless of the method used, the overall result was clear—happiness doesn't just flow from success; it actually causes it.

After trawling the data from hundreds of studies involving more than a quarter of a million participants, Lyubomirsky discovered impressive benefits to being happy. Happiness makes people more sociable and altruistic, it increases how much they like themselves and others, it improves their ability to resolve conflict, and it strengthens their immune systems. The cumulative effect means that people have more satisfying and successful relationships, find more fulfilling careers, and live longer, healthier lives.

Given the emotional and tangible benefits of happiness, it is not surprising that everyone wants a slice of the pie. But what is the most effective way of putting a permanent smile on your face? Ask most people the question, and you are likely to receive a two-word answer: more money. In survey after survey, the need for a fatter wallet consistently tops the "must have" list for happiness. But is it really possible to buy happiness, or do financial aspirations set you on the road to despair?

Part of the answer comes from a remarkable study conducted in the 1970s by Philip Brickman from Northwestern University and his colleagues. Brickman wanted to discover what happens to people's happiness when their financial dreams come true. Does a huge windfall really create a long-term smile, or does the initial thrill quickly fade away as newfound fortune becomes commonplace? Brickman contacted a group of people who had won a major prize in the Illinois State Lottery, including several who had hit the million-dollar jackpot. For a control group, he randomly selected people from the Illinois telephone directory. Everyone was asked to rate how happy they were at that moment and how happy they expected to be in the future. In addition, they were asked to say how much pleasure they derived from everyday activities in life, such as chatting with friends, hearing a funny joke, or receiving a compliment. The results provide a striking insight into the relationship between happiness and money.

Contrary to popular belief, those who had won the lottery were no more or less happy than those in the control group. There was also no significant difference between the groups when it came to how happy they expected to be in the future. In fact, there was only one difference—compared to those who had won the lottery, the people in the control group derived significantly more pleasure from the simple things in life. Clearly, winning the lottery is a rather unusual way of obtaining financial security, but psychologists have also examined the relationship between income and happiness among those who have worked for their wealth.

Some of this work has involved carrying out large-scale international surveys by having people rate how happy they are (usually using standard ten-point scales that run from "very unhappy" to "very happy") and then plotting countries' average happiness ratings against their gross national product (GNP). The results suggest that although people in very poor nations are not as happy as those in wealthier countries, this

disparity vanishes once a country has achieved a relatively modest GNP. Research examining the possible link between salary and happiness found the same type of pattern. One study, conducted by Ed Diener from the University of Illinois and his colleagues, revealed that even those on the Forbes 100 list of the wealthiest people are only slightly happier than the average American. All of this adds up to one simple message: when people can afford the necessities in life, an increase in income does not result in a significantly happier life.

So why should this be the case? Part of the reason is that we all get used to what we have very quickly. Buying a new car or a bigger house provides a short-term feelgood boost, but we quickly become accustomed to it and sink back to our prepurchase level of joy. As psychologist David Myers once phrased it, "Thanks to our capacity to adapt to ever greater fame and fortune, yesterday's luxuries can soon become today's necessities and tomorrow's relics." If money can't buy happiness, what is the best way of putting a long-term smile on your face?

The bad news is that research shows that about 50 percent of your overall sense of happiness is genetically determined, and so cannot be altered. The better news is that another 10 percent is attributable to general circumstances (educational level, income, whether you are married or single, etc.) that are difficult to change. However, the best news is that the remaining 40 percent is derived from your day-to-day behavior and the way you think about yourself and others. With a little knowledge, you can become substantially happier in just a few seconds.

The problem is that the advice offered in some self-help books and courses is at odds with the results of scientific research. Take, for example, the power of positive thinking. Does the road to happiness really depend on people's being able to simply push negative thoughts out of their mind? Actually, research suggests that such thought suppression may be far more likely to increase, rather than decrease, misery. In the mid-1980s Harvard psychologist Daniel Wegner chanced upon an obscure but intriguing quote from Dostoyevsky's Winter Notes on Summer Impressions: "Try to pose for yourself this task: not to think of a polar bear, and you will see that the cursed thing will come to mind every minute." Wegner decided to carry out a simple experiment to discover if this was true. Each person from a group of willing volunteers was made to sit alone in a room and told to think about anything, but NOT to imagine Dostoyevsky's white bear. Everyone was then asked to ring a bell each time the banned bear sprang to mind. Within moments a cacophony of bells indicated that Dostoyevsky was right—attempting to suppress certain thoughts makes people obsess on the very topic that they are trying to avoid.

Other work has shown how this effect operates in real life, with one study, conducted by Jennifer Borton and Elizabeth Casey at Hamilton College in New York State, providing a dramatic demonstration of how it influences people's moods and selfesteem. Borton and Casey asked a group of people to describe their most upsetting thought about themselves. The researchers then had half of the group spend the next eleven days trying to push this thought out of their minds, while the remaining participants were asked to carry on with life as usual. At the end of each day, everyone indicated the degree to which they had dwelled upon their upsetting thought, and rated their mood, anxiety level, and self-esteem. The results were conceptually similar to those obtained by Wegner's "white bear" experiment. The group attempting to actively suppress their negative thoughts actually thought more about them. Compared to those going about their business as usual, the suppression group also rated themselves as more anxious, more depressed, and having lower self-esteem. More than twenty years of research have demonstrated that this paradoxical phenomenon occurs in many different aspects of everyday life, showing, for example, that asking dieters not to think about chocolate causes them to consume more of it and asking the public not to elect fools to positions in government encourages them to vote for George Bush.

So, if thought suppression is not the answer, what can you do? One possibility is to distract yourself. Perhaps spend time with your family, go to a party, get more involved in your work, or take up a new hobby. Although this technique can often provide an effective short-term boost, it will probably not lead to a long-term sense of contentment. For that, research suggests, you need to know how to use a pencil, how to keep the perfect diary

Article 111

We've all been told we could be better listeners and that listening is important. But what does that really mean and how do we do it? Let's round up the research...

Why it's important

Nobody likes a conversational narcissist but we've all been one:

Conversational narcissists always seek to turn the attention of others to themselves. Your first reaction to this statement is likely, "Oh, I don't do that, but I know someone who does!" But not so fast. Conversational narcissism typically does not manifest itself in obviously boorish plays for attention; most people give at least some deference to social norms and etiquette. Instead, it takes much more subtle forms, and**we're all guilty of it from time to time. Everyone has felt that itch where we couldn't wait for someone to stop talking so we could jump in; we pretended to be listening intently, but we were really focusing on what we were about to say once we found an opening.**

What makes teams at the office smart isn't combined IQ, it's social skills, with the ability to listen being paramount:

What do you hear about great groups? Not that the members are all really smart but that they listen to each other. They share criticism constructively. They have open minds. They're not autocratic. And in our study we saw pretty clearly that groups that had smart people dominating the conversation were not very intelligent groups.

What two qualities make great salespeople? One of them is the ability to listen:

...successful salesmen must have two qualities, empathy and ego drive: enough empathy to listen and understand what is in the customer's head, and enough ego to close the sale.

What made subjects in a research study be rated instantly more likable? Just listening to the other person *and saying "tell me more."*

Not listening ends relationships. And from a more strategic point of view, if people don't think you're listening to them it's almost impossible to change their mind.

Active Listening

So what do you have to do?

Keep in mind that good listening is "non-evaluative." Don't judge or analyze what the person is saying at first. Just focus on trying to understand their perspective.

What's the first thing you have to do? Shut your mouth. Should be obvious but if it were, you might not be reading this.

Here's the important part: *just shutting up is not enough.*

Listening isn't just listening. It's letting the other person know you're listening.

This is "active listening." It has three components: paraphrasing, inquiry and acknowledgment:
• **Paraphrase:** "It sounds as if you're satisfied with our component overall. But if I understand correctly, you need me to assure you that we can increase production if large orders come in. You're also concerned about our proposed per-unit price and our willingness to work with you to create an acceptable arrangement. Have I captured your main points?"
• **Inquire:** "You mentioned that you found our proposed price to be unacceptable. Help me understand how you came to this conclusion. Let's also talk about how we might set up a pricing structure that you find more reasonable."
• **Acknowledge:** "It sounds as if you're quite disappointed with various elements of our proposal, so much so that you have serious concerns about whether we'll be able to work together over the long haul."

does this really work?
It works in relationships. Active listening is sexy:
The technology developed by Sandy Pentland and his colleagues at MIT Media Lab counts the number of times people say "uh-huh," "yeah," "yup," "aha," "okay," and "I see" when they're listening to someone speak. In Pentland's study, **the more short interjections a man made, the more attractive he was to the woman who was talking.**
Our happiest moments are made better when 1) we share them with others and 2) they respond supportively. A response should be both active and constructive.

Guess what the top ranked telemarketers all had in common?
Better telemarketers consistently "spoke at an appropriate rate; emphasized important points with changes in pitch and volume;**acknowledged or paraphrased what the customer said; used short, affirmative words and sounds to indicate that he/she listened to the customer**; and used language the customer could understand."
Active listening is the first thing FBI hostage negotiators use to de-escalate incidents and save lives.

BCSM consists of five stages: active listening, empathy, rapport, influence, and behavioral change. Progression through these stages occurs sequentially and cumulatively. Specifically, the negotiator proceeds in sequence from Stage 1 (active listening) to Stage 5 (behavioral change). However, **in order to establish rapport (Stage 3) with the subject, active listening skills (Stage 1) and empathy (Stage 2) must first be demonstrated (and maintained throughout) by the negotiator.** As this process continues, influence (Stage 4) and behavioral change (Stage 5) follow. The latter stage refers to **the successful resolution of the crisis that can only occur when, and only when, the previous stages have been carried out successfully.**
Gary Noesner, former chief negotiator with the FBI's Critical Incident Response Group and author of Stalling for Time: My Life as an FBI Hostage Negotiator has discussed the use of active listening techniques:

1) Minimal Encouragements
During negotiations with a subject, **negotiators must demonstrate that they are listening attentively and are focused on the subject's words. Negotiators can convey these qualities either through body language or brief verbal replies that relate interest and concern.** The responses need not be lengthy. By giving occasional, brief, and well-timed vocal replies, negotiators demonstrate that they are following what the subject says. **Even relatively simple phrases, such as "yes," "O.K.," or "I see," effectively convey that a negotiator is paying attention to the subject. These responses will encourage the subject to continue talking and gradually relinquish more control of the situation to the negotiator.**

2) Paraphrasing

Paraphrasing consists of negotiators' repeating in their own words the meaning of subjects' messages back to them. This shows that negotiators are not only listening but also understanding what the subject is conveying...

Short Takeaway

Summing up: what do you need to do to be a great listener? **What steps should you follow in your next conversation?**

1. **Listen to what they say.** ***Don't interrupt, disagree or "evaluate."***
2. **Nod your head, and make brief acknowledging comments like "yes" and "uh-huh."**
3. **Without being awkward, repeat back the gist of what they just said, from their frame of reference.**
4. **Inquire. Ask questions that show you've been paying attention and that move the discussion forward.**

They will feel like you really understand them and you probably will -- because while they were speaking you weren't trying to figure out why they're wrong or misguided. You were trying to understand their perspective and communicated that to them with your behavior.

Article 112

When Serge Gainsbourg died in 1991, France's then-president François Mitterrand mourned the loss of "our Baudelaire, our Apollinaire," the man who had "elevated song to the level of art." In a career spanning five decades, Gainsbourg embraced everything from chanson, mambo and yéyé to rock, reggae and electronica, incorporating lyrics that were in turn profound, witty or provocative and at times utterly obscene. Frequently employing ingenious wordplay that would give the lyrics two, if not three different meanings his compositions remain wholly original and uniquely out of time.

Although he has had a growing cult following since the 1990s, the fact that he is not more widely appreciated amongst Anglophone audiences is perhaps because there has been no-one to do for Gainsbourg what Mort Shuman and Scott Walker did for Jacques Brel, offering an entry point to his work with exceptional translations and performances that created stunning versions in their own right.

Former Nick Cave collaborator Mick Harvey's ongoing projectis clearly born of admiration and respect but his insistence on providing literal translations to carbon copy musical arrangements offers nothing but bland imitations and only serves to emphasise the uniqueness of the originals.Even in his own country, where he has been covered by numerous artists, no-one has managed to make Gainsbourg's songs their own.

The only person who has come close is Jane Birkin, Gainsbourg's muse and lover, whose unique connection has given her the confidence to reinterpret the songs in a wholly original way, first with luscious Arabic-infused versions of his songs on the 2002 album Arabesque and now on the record Le Symphonique where, inspired by Gainsbourg's classical influences, she performs his songs with the backing of a symphony orchestra.

mbaguru
LEADER IN ADAPTIVE PREPARATION FOR CAT

Article 113

Iguacu Falls, which sit on the border between Argentina and Brazil, are said to make Niagara look like a leaky faucet. The great cataracts stretch for two and a half miles across lushly foliaged rocky outcroppings before plunging a staggering two hundred and thirty feet into the river below.

The falls region is densely forested, and is home to a wide variety of plants and animals, including a number of endangered ones. It is a paradise where parrots dive and swoop through the spray,butterflies cavort among the tropical plants and coatis, and giant otters and anteaters amble through the trees. The foliage itself varies between tropical and deciduous with orchids blushing in the shade of pines and ferns nodding gracefully in the shadow of fruit trees.

Depending on rainfall and water flow, between 100 and 300 individual falls tumble over the cliffs creating a stunning panoply of churning water. Small wonder that this natural powerhouse attracted the attention of developers. At the top of the falls on the Parana River sits Itaipu Dam, the world's largest operational hydroelectric power plant. The dam is often numbered among the wonders of the modern world.

The falls' superlatives don't stop with technology. Many consider the cataract system itself one of the natural wonders of the world. In 1986, UNESCO (United Nations Educational, Scientific, and Cultural Organization) concurred when it declared the falls a World Heritage site in order to ensure its preservation in the face of continuing technological development.

Article 114

Softhearted people always advocate spending more on kids. But according to a new and authoritative synthesis of available evidence, there's a hardheaded case for investing more in young kids over older ones.

In the United States, we've spent trillions of dollars over decades on K-12 schooling in the hopes of making young people more productive, or at least less criminally delinquent. The results have been mixed. About 20 percent of the American workforce is essentially illiterate (compared with 5 to 10 percent in Sweden or Germany), creating a major drag on our international competitiveness. And an astronomical 5.6 million adults in the United States have served time in state or federal prison, with 1.3 million there currently. Their incarceration, along with other costs of crime, costs us around $1.3 trillion a year.

Why doesn't all our spending on education buy better results? Nobel Prize winner James Heckman of the University of Chicago and DimitriyMasterov of the University of Michigan argue that by waiting until kindergarten, we throw money at kids when it's too late. Their evidence urges shifting educational spending to younger children.

The early investment is needed, the authors argue, to supplement the role of the family. Recent developments in neuroscience have shown that the early years are vital to cognitive development, which in turn is important to subsequent success and productivity in school, life, and work. Early-childhood nurturing has traditionally been the province of families. But families are deteriorating. Roughly one in six kids was born into poverty or single parenthood or both in 1970. In 2000, the rate was about one in four. What's more, almost 10 percent of children were born to unmarried teenage mothers in 1999; these kids tend to receive especially low levels of emotional and intellectual support and cognitive stimulation. They

arrive at kindergarten cognitively disadvantaged, and the gap widens as they get older, eventually leading to early babies, lousy jobs, and elevated crime.

Heckman and Masterov look at a number of pilot programs in early-childhood education that have targeted high-risk kids in disadvantaged families, and studied them into adulthood. These programs are like Head Start, only more intensive. For example, between 1962 and 1967, the Perry Project in Ypsilanti, Mich., provided two years of intensive preschool to a group of disadvantaged 3-year-old black children, chosen from an eligible pool by a coin flip. The program consisted of a daily session of two and a half hours and a weekly 90-minute teacher home visit. In today's dollars, it would cost $10,000 per child per year.

Perry participants have been followed through age 40, and the program has shown substantial benefits in educational achievement and other social outcomes. Participants achieved greater literacy and higher grades, and they were more likely to graduate high school. Later in life, they were more likely to be employed—and to earn more—and less likely to be on welfare. They also committed less crime and had lower rates of teen pregnancy.

The authors estimate the rate of return for programs like the Perry Project to be a substantial 16 percent. While some of this payback accrues directly to the kids, in the form of higher earnings when they're grown up, about three-quarters of it goes to the rest of us in the form of lower crime and savings on prison spending. Heckman and Masterov compare the return from investing in preschool kids with the returns from lower class size in high school (smaller than the return to preschool) and to GED programs (smaller still). They propose that the return on investment declines with age, although they don't offer a ton of quantitative evidence on this point.

The big economic return for intensive preschool for disadvantaged kids has two implications. First, while many people advocate spending on these kids for reasons of fairness or justice, Heckman and Masterov make a different case. They're saying this preschool spending is a sound economic investment. Each dollar we spend on targeted, intensive preschool returns more than a dollar invested in, say, a pretty good mutual fund.

Many families already make this investment on their own, either by spending time with their kids or by purchasing high-quality child care. Why involve governments? Well, Heckman and Masterov show that if *your* kid goes to one of these programs, *the rest of us*get most of the benefit. Economists assume that even if parents of disadvantaged kids are rational and forward-looking—as if they didn't have enough to worry about—they will invest in preschool only to boost their kids' earnings and not to reduce crime and prison costs, which are borne by the rest of us. As a result, even conscientious parents will under-invest. So, Economics 101 tells you—granted, in an end-of-semester lecture that you probably skipped—that clearly this is a job for government.

The hardheaded case for Perry-like preschool extends beyond higher pay and reduced crime. Unlike many efforts to boost productivity—think trickle-down—this one would reduce inequality as well, by raising the incomes of the disadvantaged. Investing in preschools can also enhance international competitiveness. Much of the growth in American standards of living over the past half-century has flowed from our population's ever-increasing educational attainment. But for the generations born since 1950, the growth has stopped. The problem is not that a college education costs too much, but rather that many disadvantaged kids aren't academically ready for college when they finish high school. And Heckman and Masterov argue that it stems from the academic deficits they bring to kindergarten. If preschool whips them into shape, they'll be better prepared for all the other steps along the way.

A sales problem remains: These programs invade the traditional province of the family, and in Heckman and Masterov's conception, they would target disadvantaged populations that are disproportionately minority. Wanted: a credible and sympathetic pitchman.Paging Barack Obama.

Article 115

I was the last child of a small-time government servant, in a family of five brothers. My earliest memory of my Father is as that of a District Employment Officer in Koraput, Orissa. It was and remains as back of beyond as you can imagine. There was no electricity; no primary school nearby and water did not flow out of a tap. As a result, I did not go to school until the age of eight; I was home-schooled.

My Father used to get transferred every year. The family belongings fit into the back of a jeep—so the family moved from place to place and, without any trouble, my Mother would set up an establishment and get us going. Raised by a widow who had come as a refugee from the then East Bengal, she was a matriculate when she married my Father. My parents set the foundation of my life and the value system which makes me what I am today and largely defines what success means to me today. As District Employment Officer, my Father was given a jeep by the government. There was no garage in the office, so the jeep was parked in our house. My Father refused to use it to commute to the office. He told us that the jeep is an expensive resource given by the government—he reiterated to us that it was not ''his jeep'' but the government's jeep. Insisting that he would use it only to tour the interiors, he would walk to his office on normal days. He also made sure that we never sat in the government jeep—we could sit in it only when it was stationary. That was our early childhood lesson in governance—a lesson that corporate managers learn the hard way, some never do.

The driver of the jeep was treated with respect due to any other member of my Father's office. As small children, we were taught not to call him by his name. We had to use the suffix ''dada'' whenever we were to refer to him in public or private. When I grew up to own a car and a driver by the name of Raju was appointed, I repeated the lesson to my two small daughters. They have, as a result, grown up to call Raju ''Raju Uncle''—very different from many of their friends who refer to their family drivers as ''my driver''. When I hear that term from a school or college-going person, I cringe. To me, the lesson was significant—**'you treat small people with more respect than how you treat big people. It is more important to respect your subordinates than your superiors'.**

Our day used to start with the family huddling around my Mother's *chulha*—an earthen fireplace she would build at each place of posting where she would cook for the family. There was no gas, nor electrical stoves. The morning routine started with tea. As the brew was served, Father would ask us to read aloud the editorial page of *The Statesman's muffasil* edition—delivered one day late.

We did not understand much of what we were reading. But the ritual was meant for us to know that the world was larger than Koraput district and the English I speak today, despite having studied in an Oriya-medium school, has to do with that routine. After reading the newspaper aloud, we were told to fold it neatly. Father taught us a simple lesson. He used to say, ''You should leave your newspaper and your toilet the way you expect to find it.'' That lesson was about **'showing consideration to others. Business begins and ends with that simple precept'.**

Being small children, we were always enamored with advertisements in the newspaper for transistor radios—we did not have one. We saw other people who had radios in their homes and each time there was an advertisement for Philips, Murphy or Bush radios, we would ask Father when we could get one. Each time, Father would reply that we did not need one because he already had five radios—alluding to his five sons. We also did not have a house of our own and would occasonally ask Father as to when, like others, we would live in our own house. He would give a similar reply, ''We do not need a house of our own. I already own five houses.'' His replies did not gladden our hearts in that instant. Nonetheless, we learnt that **'it is important not to measure personal success and sense of wellbeing through material possessions'.**

Government houses seldom came with fences. Mother and I collected twigs and built a small fence. After lunch, Mother would never sleep. She would take her kitchen utensils and with those, she and I would dig the rocky, white ant-infested surrounding. We planted flowering bushes. The white ants destroyed them. My Mother brought ash from her *chulha* and mixed it in the earth and we planted the seedlings all over again. This time, they bloomed. At that time, my Father's transfer order came. A few neighbours asked my Mother why she was taking so much pain to beautify a government house, why she was planting seeds that would only benefit the next occupant. My Mother replied that it did not matter to her that she would not see the flowers in full bloom. She said: **''I have to create a bloom in a desert and whenever I am given a new place, I must leave it more beautiful than what I had inherited.''** That was my first lesson in success. **'It is not about what you create for yourself, it is what you leave behind that defines success'.**

My Mother began developing cataract in her eyes when I was very small. At that time, the eldest among my brothers got a teaching job at a university in Bhubaneswar and had to prepare for the civil services examination. So, it was decided that my Mother would move to cook for him and, as her appendage, I had to move too. For the first time in my life, I saw electricity in homes and water coming out of a tap. It was around 1965 and the country was going to war with Pakistan. My Mother was having problems reading and in any case, being Bengali, she did not know the Oriya script. So, in addition to my daily chores, my job was to read her the local newspaper—end to end. That created in me a sense of connectedness with a larger world. I began taking interest in many different things. While reading out news about the war, I felt that I was fighting the war myself. She and I discussed the daily news and built a bond with the larger universe. In it, we became part of a larger reality. Till date, I measure my success in terms of that sense of **'larger connectedness'.**

Meanwhile, the war raged and India was fighting on both fronts. LalBahadurShastri, the then prime minister, coined the term 'Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan' and galvanised the nation into patriotic fervour. Other than reading out the newspaper to my Mother, I had no clue about how I could be part of the action. So, after reading her the newspaper, everyday I would land up near the university's water tank, which served the community. I would spend hours under it, imagining that there could be spies who would come to poison the water and I had to watch for them. I would daydream about catching one and how the next day, I would be featured in the newspaper. Unfortunately for me, the spies at war ignored the sleepy town of Bhubaneswar and I never got a chance to catch one in action. Yet, that act unlocked my imagination.**'Imagination is everything. If we can imagine a future, we can create it, if we can create that future, others will live in it. That is the essence of success'.**

Over the next few years, my Mother's eyesight dimmed but in me, she created a larger vision, a vision with which I continue to see the world and, I sense, through my eyes, she was seeing too. As the next few years unfolded, her vision deteriorated and she was operated for cataract. I remember, when she returned after her operation and she saw my face clearly for the first time, she was astonished. She said: ''Oh my God, I did not know you were so fair.'' I remain mighty pleased with that adulation even till date.

Within weeks of gettin her sight back, she developed corneal ulcer and, overnight, became blind in both eyes. That was 1969. She died in 2002. In all those 32 years of living with blindness, she never complained about her fate even once. Curious to know what she saw with blind eyes, I asked her once if she sees darkness. She replied: ''No, I do not see darkness. I only see light, even with my eyes closed.'' Until she was 80 years of age, she did her morning yoga everyday, swept her own room and washed her own clothes. To me,**'success is about the sense of independence; it is about not seeing the world but seeing the light'.**

Over the many intervening years, I grew up, studied, joined the industry and began to carve my life's own journey. I began my life as a clerk in a government office, went on to become a management trainee with the DCM group and eventually found my life's calling with the IT industry when fourth-generation computers came to India in 1981. Life took me places—I worked with outstanding people, challenging assignments and travelled all over the world.

In 1992, while I was posted in the US, I learnt that my father, living a retired life with my eldest brother, had suffered third-degree burns and was admitted in Safdarjung Hospital in Delhi. I flew back to attend to him—he remained for a few days in a critical stage, bandaged from neck to toe. The Safdarjung Hospital is a cockroach-infested, dirty, inhuman place. The overworked, under-resourced sisters in the burn ward are both victims and perpetrators of dehumanised life at its worst.

One morning, while attending to my Father, I realised that the blood bottle was empty and fearing that air would enter his veins, I asked the attending nurse to change it. She bluntly told me to do it myself. In that horrible theatre of death, I was in pain and frustration and anger. Finally, when she relented and came, my Father opened his eyes and murmured to her: ''Why have you not gone home yet?'' Here was a man on his deathbed but more concerned about the overworked nurse than his own state. I was stunned at his stoic self. There I learnt that **'there is no limit to how concerned you can be for another human being and what is the limit of inclusion you can create'.** My Father died the next day.

He was a man whose success was defined by his principles, his frugality, his universalism and his sense of inclusion. Above all, he taught me that **'success is your ability to rise above your discomfort, whatever may be your current state. You can, if you want, raise your consciousness above your immediate surroundings'.** Success is not about building material comforts—the transistor that he never could buy or the house that he never owned. His success was about the**'legacy he left, the memetic continuity of his ideals that grew beyond the smallness'** of an ill-paid, unrecognised government servant's world.

My Father was a fervent believer in the British Raj. He sincerely doubted the capability of post-Independence Indian political parties to govern the country. To him, the lowering of the Union Jack was a sad event. My Mother was the exact opposite. When Subhash Chandra Bose quit the Indian National Congress and came to Dacca, my Mother, then a schoolgirl, garlanded him. She learnt to spin khadi and joined an underground movement that trained her in using daggers and swords. Consequently, our household saw diversity in the political outlook of the two. On major issues concerning the world, the Old Man and the Old Lady had differing opinions. In them, we learnt the **'power of disagreements, of dialogue and the essence of living with diversity in thinking. Success is not about the ability to create a definitive dogmatic end-state; it is about the unfolding of thought processes, of dialogue and continuum'.**

Two years back, at the age of 82, Mother had a paralytic stroke and was lying in a government hospital in Bhubaneswar. I flew down from the US, where I was serving my second stint, to see her. I spent two weeks with her in the hospital as she remained in a paralytic state. She was neither getting better nor moving on. Eventually I had to return to work. While leaving her behind, I kissed her face. In that paralytic state and a

garbled voice, she said: ''Why are you kissing me, go kiss the world.'' Her river was nearing its journey, at the confluence of life and death, this woman who came to India as a refugee, raised by a widowed mother, no more educated than high school, married to an anonymous government servant whose last salary was Rs 300, robbed of her eyesight by fate and crowned by adversity—was telling me to go and kiss the world!

"Success to me is about vision. It is the ability to rise above the immediacy of pain. It is about imagination. It is about sensitivity to small people. It is about building inclusion. It is about connectedness to a larger world existence. It is about personal tenacity. It is about giving back more to life than you take out of it. It is about creating extraordinary success with ordinary lives".
Thank you very much. I wish you good luck and Godspeed. **Go, kiss the world**

Article 116

I've been feeling freshly conscious of an aspect of being human that's so constant and fundamental it seems weird to me that it isn't a subject of everyday conversation. It's simply this: that at the background of all my activities and interactions, behind all the containers I pour myself into from moment to moment, is my awareness of the boundless ocean of awareness itself.

They huddle in the back room, waiting to seep through some hidden cat-door and flood the room I live in.
I feel it as an amoeba-like latency, an unruly sea of infinite possibility, lurking in the back room — exciting, ominous, darkly beckoning. It conjures up the image Jonathan Franzen uses in his novel "The Corrections" of an impending thunderstorm: "big spiders in a little jar." Only the jar in this case is infinitely vast, the spiders correspondingly enormous. They huddle in the back room, waiting for the lid to come off. Waiting to leak or seep or sneak through some hidden cat-door and flood the room I live in.

With it is the chronic background anxiety that if I don't pour myself into this or that (read my book, clean the house, or at the very least think a bunch of thoughts), I'll fall into this ocean of shapelessness and lose all sense of definition. I'll be ejected from the safe confines of my predictable foreground world, where all the familiar experiences live: the sensations and tastes and textures that confirm my sense of who I am.

I live in this foreground world. I depend on it for my orientation, my ability to navigate through a day. It supports my belief that I am a separate, cohesive individual.

But I'm haunted by the knowledge that foreground can't exist without background, any more than weather can exist without sky. The existence of the one necessarily implies the existence of the other. Despite this, I restrict my attention to the foreground. I keep my settings on "busy."

Still, I'm haunted by implications. Something whispers that I'm only living half a life. And the half I'm living is coming way too fast. I'm on the down escalator trying to run up, but no matter how fast I run, I stay in the same spot — always a little agitated, a little lost, a little hungry.

What to do? The logical solution would be to check out the background. Be adventurous, explore this vastness that breathes so continually down my neck.

Easily said. Unhappily, when I do stray, accidentally or intentionally, into this formless background, I recall all too quickly what the foreground commotion is doing for me.

It's protecting me from the intolerable experience of being a personality: a rabid consumer of ego-supplies with a curiously cruel capacity for self-awareness. A capacity that leads perversely to the realization that despite my hard-won knowledge that all my yearnings are ultimately doomed, still there will never be an end to yearning.

It's protecting me from my meanness, my ugliness, my judgments about my looks and my smarts, my uncertainty about my lovability and my capability.

It's protecting me from tasting the certain knowledge that I'm not built to last, that no matter what intimations I may have of after-states, I still face an irrevocable loss when I die. Everything as I know it, gone.

It's protecting me from the secrets I keep even from myself.

It's protecting me from the unbearable taste of my separateness, my chronic disconnection from life, within and without. It's creating the wall of white noise that distracts me from my deep sense of meaninglessness, my feeling of being locked in and locked out at the same time — trapped on the surface of my life, nose against the glass, dimly aware that somewhere a feast is going on. Somewhere I'm not.

Extreme irony, given that this foreground commotion is also the cause of my disconnection.

What could be crazier? My mind incessantly constructing a wall of white noise to distract me from the dreariness of its incessant constructions. Stale solutions continually reproducing the same stale problems, locking me in to a life in the shallows. A life that had one school of existentialists believing that suicide was the logical "cure" for the human condition.

I look in vain for a consolation prize. What do I get for taking these pains, for subjecting myself to a glimpse of the background?

Most of the time, a convincing argument for staying in the foreground. The whispered suggestion that it's probably best to just keep up the clatter. And the implicit judgment that I'm worse than pathetic if I can't take the heat. After all, everyone else (mostly) seems to be staying alive.

I circle my jar of spiders…

At some point it occurs to me that circling my jar is quite possibly the worst of it. It's so neither here nor there. I give up. Out of sheer exhaustion, I take off the lid and slide in. What else is there to do? I tell them to go ahead, eat me alive.

They're only too happy to oblige. The white noise gradually subsides and they set to work, sucking the sweet, juicy marrow of hope from the bones of all my constructions.

(Somewhere a feast is going on…)

One after another the buildings collapse, until all hope is gone and I'm alone in the rubble.

I know this place. It's flat and empty and dead. There's nowhere left to run and nothing left to hide. After a long while, I notice the quiet: bleak, but oddly relaxing. No straining, nothing to hold up. There seems to be something left of me as well, though I'd be hard pressed to give it a name.

It finally dawns on me that I've made it through the switcheroo. Background has become foreground. I'm now the thing I was running from — the formless ocean of awareness itself.
My sense of an impending thunderstorm has dissolved. It was apparently a feature of life on the run. Now the spiders are all over there, where the foreground used to be. They look small and hectic from here, more like ants. Noisily milling about.

Me, I'm the emptiness inside the jar, though the jar itself has vanished. I'm spacious and peaceful and vast.

I like this place. As always, I resolve to remember what a relief this is.

I vow to bring myself to the feast more often.

As usual, I forget and get trapped outside again. Circling the jar.

Article 117

Once upon a time, in a dirty, problem-filled but happy forest, there lived a parrot. Animals, birds and insects who had problems with others of their kind, would go to the lion king or queen, who would in turn ask the parrot to fly to the accused's house and resolve the matter.

Every 5 years, the ruling set of lions would be decided by the inhabitants of the forest. One day, something weird happened. One of the animals had a complaint against the ruling lion himself. The lion was caught unawares. The lions in the rival camp began to roar and demand that the ruling lion step down. This continued for days together. The ruling lion never expected that one day, he himself would have to be questioned by the parrot. The night before he was to be questioned, without anyone's knowledge, he grabbed the parrot, clamped its beak, took him to his cave and threatened to eat him right there, if the parrot didn't declare him innocent.

Out of fear, the next day, the parrot went to a waste-paper yard a little outside the forest and picked up a clean, white piece of paper. In the real world, clean white meant surrender, but in the forest, it meant that the person who is being questioned is innocent. This incident empowered the ruling lion all the more – the parrot was no more free, he was caged in the lion's cave. The lion would set him free according to his whims and fancies.

Soon, the occasions became calculated. Anyone among the ruling lion's supporters who wouldn't heed his order, would have the parrot sent to his house. The lion would tell the parrot, "You are corrupt, you are guilty!" and get the parrot to repeat it. Should the parrot get it wrong, there was a young lion cub who corrected him. Parrots are known for repeating what they hear. This one was no different. He would go to the targets' houses and gleefully repeat what the lion had told him. Fed up, the targets would promise to follow the lion's orders, if the parrot returned. And thus would the parrot return to its cage.

This had instilled such fear in the minds of the animals. They were scared even to make love. They didn't want the parrot to swoop in and start leveling accusations on them while they were busy caressing each

other. One day, from within his cage, the parrot saw the lion couple making love. The lion moved his head, gently stroking the lioness. His mane made her feel all tingly. He started licking her face all over. All of a sudden, he was interrupted by a commotion outside his cave. He walked outside to check it out and was stunned to find the whole forest gathered in protest, demanding that one of the lions in his group be sacked.

Under pressure, the lion said that the parrot would investigate the matter and dispersed the crowd. The animals, however had other plans. They appealed to the almighty God to look into the matter. The almighty God descended, analyzed the state of affairs and lambasted the ruling lion for keeping the parrot caged. God said, "Will you free the parrot or do you want me to do it myself?" The parrot was finally happy. A smile came on his face. He was finally going to be free, after years and years of confinement.

The ruling lion bowed down to the almighty God and told him that he would ensure it as soon as possible. However, instead of freeing the parrot, he set up a committee called GoAi.e a Group of Animals, who would look into freeing the parrot. The parrot's happiness was short-lived, as the group of animals consisted of a wily fox, a sly jackal and a harsh owl. A pall of gloom descended on the forest. They now had to wait for God himself to come and free the parrot. "God sees the truth but waits," they thought.

Article 118

Our propensity to look out for regularities, and to impose laws upon nature, leads to the psychological phenomenon of dogmatic thinking or, more generally, dogmatic behaviour: we expect regularities everywhere and attempt to find them even where there are none; events which do not yield to these attempts we are inclined to treat as a kind of 'background noise'; and we stick to our expectations even when they are inadequate and we ought to accept defeat. This dogmatism is to some extent necessary. It is demanded by a situation which can only be dealt with by forcing our conjectures upon the world. Moreover, this dogmatism allows us to approach a good theory in stages, by way of approximations: if we accept defeat too easily, we may prevent ourselves from finding that we were very nearly right. It is clear that this dogmatic attitude, which makes us stick to our first impressions, is indicative of a strong belief; while a critical attitude, which is ready to modify its tenets, which admits doubt and demands tests, is indicative of a weaker belief. Now according to Hume's theory, and to the popular theory, the strength of a belief should be a product of repetition; thus it should always grow with experience, and always be greater in less primitive persons. But dogmatic thinking, an uncontrolled wish to impose regularities, a manifest pleasure in rites and in repetition as such, is characteristic of primitives and children; and increasing experience and maturity sometimes create an attitude of caution and criticism rather than of dogmatism.

My logical criticism of Hume's psychological theory, and the considerations connected with it, may seem a little removed from the field of the philosophy of science. But the distinction between dogmatic and critical thinking, or the dogmatic and the critical attitude, brings us right back to our central problem. For the dogmatic attitude is clearly related to the tendency to verify our laws and schemata by seeking to apply them and to confirm them, even to the point of neglecting refutations, whereas the critical attitude is one of readiness to change them - to test them; to refute them; to falsify them, if possible. This suggests that we may identify the critical attitude with the scientific attitude, and the dogmatic attitude with the one which we have described as pseudo-scientific. It further suggests that genetically speaking the pseudo-scientific attitude is more primitive than, and prior to, the scientific attitude: that it is a pre-scientific attitude. And this primitivity or priority also has its logical aspect. For the critical attitude is not so much opposed to the dogmatic attitude as super-imposed upon it: criticism must be directed against existing and influential

beliefs in need of critical revision oe in other words, dogmatic beliefs. A critical attitude needs for its raw material, as it were, theories or beliefs which are held more or less dogmatically. Thus, science must begin with myths, and with the criticism of myths; neither with the collection of observations, nor with the invention of experiments, but with the critical discussion of myths, and of magical techniques and practices. The scientific tradition is distinguished from the pre-scientific tradition in having two layers. Like the latter, it passes on its theories; but it also passes on a critical attitude towards them. The theories are passed on, not as dogmas, but rather with the challenge to discuss them and improve upon them. The critical attitude, the tradition of free discussion of theories with the aim of discovering their weak spots so that they may be improved upon, is the attitude of reasonableness, of rationality. From the point of view here developed, all laws, all theories, remain essentially tentative, or conjectural, or hypothetical, even when we feel unable to doubt them any longer. Before a theory has been refuted we can never know in what way it may have to be modified.

Article 119

LOS ANGELES — Every climate event these days, it seems, breaks a historic pattern: the warmest temperatures on record; the fastest shrinking glaciers and ice caps; the most intense storms and unprecedented flooding; ever more ravaging wildfires. I write this from Southern California, enveloped this week by smoke and flames, fanned by epic winds. Sooner or later, all these fragmentary incidents add up to a new narrative, which itself breaks from the past.

In his recent book, "The Climate Swerve," social scientist Robert Jay Lifton argues that the realization of a huge shift underway has now dawned on civilization as a whole. Lifton borrows the term "swerve" from the ancient poet Lucretius' meditation on physics to confer the departure from a previous trajectory. "I consider the climate swerve a movement toward the recognition of climate danger and what I call species awareness — awareness of ourselves as a single species in deep trouble," Liftonsays. "The swerve is toward that recognition, that consciousness."

Nearly 30 years ago, California Governor Jerry Brown and I visited with era-of-limits philosopher Ivan Illich at his rustic retreat near Cuernavaca, Mexico. In those early days of ecology, Illich was among the first to grasp that industrial modernization, which sought to deliver society from necessity through the conquest of nature, might instead end up provoking doom.

"Our common sense has begun searching for a language to speak about the shadow our future throws," Illich intoned in his clipped Austrian-Croatian accent. "The warming atmosphere is making it intolerable to think of industrial growth as progress; now it appears to us as aggression against the human condition. Perhaps for the first time, we can now imagine that, as Samuel Beckett once put it, 'This earth could be uninhabited.'"

Illich's radical views seem less far-fetched as the future gets closer.
The fact that all other nations but the United States are committed to implementing the Paris climate accord aimed at decarbonizing the planet is at least an incipient move toward the species consciousness of which Lifton speaks. Acting on that new awareness, however, is a race with the interconnected cascade of consequences that are accelerating climate change. Alarmed scientists warn "we are now on a collision course with tipping points in the Earth system" that are irreversible.

What stands between a changed mind and changing ways is the systemic inertia of the past. U.S. President Donald Trump may be the political face of that inertia, but it also resides in the ingrained habits of consumer societies that have industrialized their desires. Mitigating ourselves is the hardest task of all.

This week The WorldPost looks at the ongoing consequences of climate change in some of the more remote zones across the planet and how some local communities are acting on their global awareness.

In a video report from Inner Mongolia, China, Lu Liu shows how the spread of desertification due to overgrazing, industrialization and drought has severely degraded the region's prairies and disrupted the herding culture that has existed there for millennia.

In the Congo Basin, Melanie Gouby joined British and Congolese scientists investigating how the largest tropical peatland on the planet — larger than the size of England — acts as a gigantic sink absorbing carbon from the atmosphere. She also documents the advancing deforestation taking place in Congo that reduces the natural capacity to absorb carbon. As usual, the culprit is corruption and the invasion of outsider commercial avarice.

"In recent years," she writes, "studieshave shown that forests are better protected by indigenous people whose ownership of their ancestral land has been recognized. Those rights have been successfully legislated in some Latin American countries, for example, but African indigenous communities have been mostly ignored by their governments."

But the fight is on. "It is important for us to protect the intact forest, not a degraded forest," Gouby quotes a local indigenous leader as saying. "We do not want companies to come exploit here; they will exploit us too. They'll give us a little something [while they] earn a lot selling our trees. We keep our forest for our children and yours."

In a way, some of the least modern places on the planet are most readily able to cope with climate change. As anthropologist Jorge Recharte reports from the Peruvian mountains, indigenous communities are models of how to adapt to climate change. He explains how mountain villagers have devised a "back-to-the-future" solution, based on the practices of pre-Inca civilization, to counter the melting glaciers, whose waters once sustained them.

"The water management systems developed in ancient Peru involved a set of technologies designed to slow or retain water in high alpine territories," Recharte writes. "The purpose was to keep water available for use as long as possible in the dry season. These ancient systems included dams and reservoirs of different sizes, irrigation canals and large silt traps that kept soil from being eroded in years of intense rain. They also encouraged wetlands to develop."

Many mountain communities affected by disappearing glaciers can learn from this experience, he maintains. "We should pay close attention; mountains near the equator are our canary in the coal mine. They are the Earth's thermometer — an early indicator of a planetary fever."

Article 120

When I started out in journalism in the 1970s, attitudes toward sexual harassment among the token women sprinkled about in newsrooms were nearly antithetical to those we've heard from the women who have come forth in recent weeks with a flood of anguished revelations.

My first job was at the London bureau of a prominent international wire service. When I walked in the newsroom, the all-male staff gaped at me as if I were an oasis in a desert. They were soon disappointed. I responded with such aloofness, they called me the Ice Princess. I felt lonely, in need of a friend. I suppose this is why I responded when one reporter began to engage me in conversation. My hopes rose — until I felt the hand slowly sneaking up my thigh. I dispatched him with an elbow in the torso. And the guy who grabbed my butt the next day got a swift back kick into the kneecap and a couple of four-letter words.

My generation of women came of age amid the exhilaration of second-wave feminism: We saw ourselves as strong, fierce self-defenders. Inappropriate sexual advances, we told ourselves, were simply an opportunity to prove our superiority over the weaker sex. Few of us believed we sustained any serious damage, and most of us thought that with enough grit, we could defy the odds and find our way.

One night after work, a group of reporters invited me to the local Irish pub. In the space of an hour, we downed several big glasses of Guinness, with Paddy Whiskey chasers. I was terrified, but I knew how crucial this test was. I would absolutely deny them the pleasure of seeing me fall off my stool. I kept up with them drink for drink and didn't pass out until I put the key to my apartment inside the door. But I collapsed with a warm feeling, giddy at the thought of their respect. It's not that I wanted to be one of the guys — I just wanted to be a good journalist, with perhaps a place in the bigger club that ran the world.

I soon found myself in Northern Ireland, in the middle of a ferocious attack on Catholics by club-wielding Protestants. I sustained a superficial scalp wound and, excitedly bloody, I found a pay phone. I began dictating a first-person story when the London bureau chief came on the line. He was an irascible eccentric known for flinging Remington typewriters at offending reporters, and he wasn't happy to hear from me. "Damn you, get your tail back here. Women aren't allowed in war zones!" he shouted. At the time, he was too apoplectic to see that a good story would be over by the time he found a man to replace me, but he gradually, grudgingly let me stay.

Once I returned, I saw him darkly flipping through my copy. I ducked. "Franks," he finally pronounced with congratulatory gravity, "I don't think of you as a woman anymore. You write like a man."

I still can't help thinking of this as the ultimate compliment. I was already brainwashed.
When the sluice opened a few months ago and men across all industries began to take sudden and precipitous falls, at first, I was slightly skeptical. I was puzzled by the stories some women told about freezing up, unable to repel a boss or sometimes even a co-worker. A few maintained that when they did resist, they felt guilty and fearful, and wrote emails the next day apologizing and asking for another chance. I felt bad for them, and yet my honest reaction was confusion: What feminist, I wondered, would be so desperate as to trade her self-respect for a job?

As the stories about what these women experienced became more perverted and even downright weird, I wondered whether male hubris had finally gone berserk. Had the sexualization of American popular culture in the 1990s and 2000s taken the restraints off the male id, freeing men to pursue their most absurd fantasies — holding professional interviews at their homes, parading around naked under open bathrobes in front of job applicants? Had feminism, with its promotion of sexual freedom, combined with these cultural changes,

paradoxically poured gas on the fires of these workplace assaults? Or had this stomach-turning type of aggression simply evaded the rumor mill but been happening all along?

As I thought about this, more of my own memories came back. Had our pioneering generation deceived ourselves?

Of course, back then we were fully aware of the quid pro quo of the casting couch, where men in power could use that power to make or break a young woman's career. We warned our sisters, but we spoke in whispers, never aloud. Maybe we were more afraid than we admitted.

Even if most of us may not have suffered serious sexual harassment, how many of us sustained more hidden damage inflicted by insecure men — especially if we had the audacity to be successful?

Two years after I joined the news service, I won the Pulitzer Prize. I suffered for it mightily. That I was the first woman to win for national reporting — I had been brought to New York to do a five-part series on the violent antiwar Weatherman group — made it only worse. I could see it in their bowed heads: We've been striving for years to win that coveted prize and a 24-year-old walks away with it! The entire bureau of men refused to speak to me that day and the days after.

I was haunted by the creeping conviction that I didn't deserve the prize — I should give it back. For at least the next 10 years, I was too ashamed to tell people I'd won.

Subtler moments of discrimination in my younger days have been coming back over the past few weeks: the stories killed before I'd even finished them; the time I came back to work after visiting my ailing mother and a man my age, hired for much higher wages, had been awarded my promised transfer to Paris.

When you get older, gender discrimination gets easier, somewhat predictable and sometimes even funny. But it doesn't stop — even if you've published four books and had a long journalism career. When my last book came out, I was interviewed by a certain talk show host, before he was stripped of his job because of gross sexual misconduct charges. I had hardly opened my mouth before he fell asleep. During the rest of the interview, he kept nodding off while the camera judiciously avoided him. When I left the studio, he had popped awake for his new guests. I saw him waving his hands enthusiastically while speaking with two high-powered male journalists.

I herald this latest female generation for their courage in revealing their humiliations for the chance to change society. We, the earliest female newswomen, were tough, ambitious, even cocky about our talent, but over the years, our self-confidence was often irreparably harmed. Our generation might have been smart, but there was much we just didn't get. Grateful to win a place in the hierarchy of power, we didn't understand the ways that gender degradation still shaped our work lives.

A few years ago, I met a fellow who had won a Pulitzer for foreign reporting the year before. When he finally discovered what we had in common, he said in a scolding voice: "You're the shyest Pulitzer winner I've ever met. Do you understand you won the highest award in journalism? When I got it, I shouted it to the skies."
And the skies clearly listened.
Lucinda Franks is a journalist and the author, most recently, of "Timeless: Love, Morgenthau, and Me."

Article 121

If one were to rank a list of civilization's greatest and most elusive intellectual challenges, the problem of "decoding" ourselves -- understanding the inner workings of our minds and our brains, and how the architecture of these elements is encoded in our genome -- would surely be at the top. Yet the diverse fields that took on this challenge, from philosophy and psychology to computer science and neuroscience, have been fraught with disagreement about the right approach.

In 1956, the computer scientist John McCarthy coined the term "Artificial Intelligence" (AI) to describe the study of intelligence by implementing its essential features on a computer. Instantiating an intelligent system using man-made hardware, rather than our own "biological hardware" of cells and tissues, would show ultimate understanding, and have obvious practical applications in the creation of intelligent devices or even robots.

Some of McCarthy's colleagues in neighboring departments, however, were more interested in how intelligence is implemented in humans (and other animals) first. Noam Chomsky and others worked on what became cognitive science, a field aimed at uncovering the mental representations and rules that underlie our perceptual and cognitive abilities. Chomsky and his colleagues had to overthrow the then-dominant paradigm of behaviorism, championed by Harvard psychologist B.F. Skinner, where animal behavior was reduced to a simple set of associations between an action and its subsequent reward or punishment. The undoing of Skinner's grip on psychology is commonly marked by Chomsky's 1959 critical review of Skinner's book *Verbal Behavior*, a book in which Skinner attempted to explain linguistic ability using behaviorist principles.

Skinner's approach stressed the historical associations between a stimulus and the animal's response -- an approach easily framed as a kind of empirical statistical analysis, predicting the future as a function of the past. Chomsky's conception of language, on the other hand, stressed the complexity of internal representations, encoded in the genome, and their maturation in light of the right data into a sophisticated computational system, one that cannot be usefully broken down into a set of associations. Behaviorist principles of associations could not explain the richness of linguistic knowledge, our endlessly creative use of it, or how quickly children acquire it with only minimal and imperfect exposure to language presented by their environment. The "language faculty," as Chomsky referred to it, was part of the organism's genetic endowment, much like the visual system, the immune system and the circulatory system, and we ought to approach it just as we approach these other more down-to-earth biological systems.

As written today, the history of cognitive science is a story of the unequivocal triumph of an essentially Chomskyian approach over Skinner's behaviorist paradigm -- an achievement commonly referred to as the "cognitive revolution," though Chomsky himself rejects this term. While this may be a relatively accurate depiction in cognitive science and psychology, behaviorist thinking is far from dead in related disciplines. Behaviorist experimental paradigms and associationist explanations for animal behavior are used routinely by neuroscientists who aim to study the neurobiology of behavior in laboratory animals such as rodents.

Noam Chomsky, speaking in a symposium on AI, organized at MIT, critiqued the field of AI for adopting an approach reminiscent of behaviorism, except in more modern, computationally sophisticated form. Chomsky acknowledged that the statistical approach might have practical value, just as in the example of a useful search engine, and is enabled by the advent of fast computers capable of processing massive data. But as far as a science goes, Chomsky would argue it is inadequate, or more harshly, kind of shallow. We wouldn't have taught the computer much about what the phrase "physicist Sir Isaac Newton" really means, even if we can build a search engine that returns sensible hits to users who type the phrase in.

mbaguru
LEADER IN ADAPTIVE PREPARATION FOR CAT

Article 122

The awful news that all but two penguin chicks have starved to death out of a colony of almost 40,000 birds is a grim illustration of the enormous pressure Antarctic wildlife is under. The causes of this devastating event are complex, from a changing climate to local sea-ice factors, but one thing penguins, whales and other marine life don't need is additional strain on food supplies.

Over the next year we have the opportunity to create an Antarctic Ocean Sanctuary – the largest protected area on Earth – which would put the waters off-limits to the industrial fishing vessels currently sucking up the tiny shrimp-like krill, on which all Antarctic life relies.

In 1990, the Voyager 1 space probe looked back at Earth from six billion kilometres away and took a historic selfie of our solar system. What it saw, according to renowned astrophysicist Carl Sagan, was a "pale blue dot".
"Our planet is a blue planet," echoed David Attenborough, in his opening words to the BBC's landmark Blue Planet series. With over 70% of our world covered by water, this is no exaggeration. Our oceans can be seen from across the solar system.

The majority of this water falls outside of national borders. In fact, almost half of our planet is a marine natural wonder outside the boundaries of flags, languages and national divisions. These vast areas cover 230 million square kilometres, and they belong to us all. To give a sense of scale, that's the size of every single continent combined, with another Asia, Europe and Africa thrown in for good measure. The size of our oceans may seem overwhelming. Our collective responsibility to protect them, however, should not.

It wasn't long ago that the oceans were thought to be too vast to be irrevocably impacted by human actions, but the effects of overfishing, oil drilling, deep sea mining, pollution and climate change have shown that humans are more than up to the task of imperilling the sea and the animals that live there.

Article 123

I scowl with frustration at myself in the mirror. Damn my hair – it just won't behave, and damn Katherine Kavanagh for being ill and subjecting me to this ordeal. I should be studying for my final exams, which are next week, yet here I am trying to brush my hair into submission. I must not sleep with it wet. I must not sleep with it wet. Reciting this mantra several times, I attempt, once more, to bring it under control with the brush. I roll my eyes in exasperation and gaze at the pale, brown-haired girl with blue eyes too big for her face staring back at me, and give up. My only option is to restrain my wayward hair in a ponytail and hope that I look semi presentable.

Kate is my roommate, and she has chosen today of all days to succumb to the flu. Therefore, she cannot attend the interview she'd arranged to do, with some mega-industrialist tycoon I've never heard of, for the student newspaper. So I have been volunteered. I have final exams to cram for, one essay to finish, and I'm supposed to be working this afternoon, but no – today I have to drive a hundred and sixty-five miles to downtown Seattle in order to meet the enigmatic CEO of Grey Enterprises Holdings Inc. As an exceptional entrepreneur and major benefactor of our University, his time is extraordinarily precious – much more

precious than mine – but he has granted Kate an interview. A real coup, she tells me. Damn her extra-curricular activities.

Kate is huddled on the couch in the living room. "Ana, I'm sorry. It took me nine months to get this interview. It will take another six to reschedule, and we'll both have graduated by then. As the editor, I can't blow this off. Please," Kate begs me in her rasping, sore throat voice. How does she do it? Even ill she looks gamine and gorgeous, strawberry blonde hair in place and green eyes bright, although now red-rimmed and runny. I ignore my pang of unwelcome sympathy. "Of course I'll go Kate. You should get back to bed. Would you like some Nyquil or Tylenol?" "Nyquil, please. Here are the questions and my mini-disc recorder. Just press record here. Make notes, I'll transcribe it all." "I know nothing about him," I murmur, trying and failing to suppress my rising panic. "The questions will see you through. Go. It's a long drive. I don't want you to be late." "Okay, I'm going. Get back to bed. I made you some soup to heat up later." I stare at her fondly. Only for you, Kate, would I do this. "I will. Good luck. And thanks Ana – as usual, you're my lifesaver."

Gathering my satchel, I smile wryly at her, then head out the door to the car. I cannot believe I have let Kate talk me into this. But then Kate can talk anyone into anything. She'll make an exceptional journalist. She's articulate, strong, persuasive, argumentative, beautiful – and she's my dearest, dearest friend. The roads are clear as I set off from Vancouver, WA toward Portland and the I-5. It's early, and I don't have to be in Seattle until two this afternoon. Fortunately, Kate's lent me her sporty Mercedes CLK. I'm not sure Wanda, my old VW Beetle, would make the journey in time. Oh, the Merc is a fun drive, and the miles slip away as I floor the pedal to the metal.

My destination is the headquarters of Mr. Grey's global enterprise. It's a huge twentystory office building, all curved glass and steel, an architect's utilitarian fantasy, with Grey House written discreetly in steel over the glass front doors. It's a quarter to two when I arrive, greatly relieved that I'm not late as I walk into the enormous – and frankly intimidating – glass, steel, and white sandstone lobby. Behind the solid sandstone desk, a very attractive, groomed, blonde young woman smiles pleasantly at me. She's wearing the sharpest charcoal suit jacket and white shirt I have ever seen. She looks immaculate. "I'm here to see Mr. Grey. Anastasia Steele for Katherine Kavanagh." "Excuse me one moment, Miss Steele." She arches her eyebrow slightly as I stand selfconsciously before her. I am beginning to wish I'd borrowed one of Kate's formal blazers rather than wear my navy blue jacket. I have made an effort and worn my one and only skirt, my sensible brown knee-length boots and a blue sweater. For me, this is smart. I tuck one of the escaped tendrils of my hair behind my ear as I pretend she doesn't intimidate me. "Miss Kavanagh is expected. Please sign in here, Miss Steele. You'll want the last elevator on the right, press for the twentieth floor." She smiles kindly at me, amused no doubt, as I sign in. She hands me a security pass that has VISITOR very firmly stamped on the front. I can't help my smirk. Surely it's obvious that I'm just visiting. I don't fit in here at all. Nothing changes, I inwardly sigh. Thanking her, I walk over to the bank of elevators past the two security men who are both far more smartly dressed than I am in their well-cut black suits. The elevator whisks me with terminal velocity to the twentieth floor. The doors slide open, and I'm in another large lobby – again all glass, steel, and white sandstone.

I'm confronted by another desk of sandstone and another young blonde woman dressed impeccably in black and white who rises to greet me. "Miss Steele, could you wait here, please?" She points to a seated area of white leather chairs. Behind the leather chairs is a spacious glass-walled meeting room with an equally spacious dark wood table and at least twenty matching chairs around it. Beyond that, there is a floor-to-ceiling window with a view of the Seattle skyline that looks out through the city toward the Sound. It's a stunning vista, and I'm momentarily paralyzed by the view. Wow. I sit down, fish the questions from my satchel, and go through them, inwardly cursing Kate for not providing me with a brief biography. I know nothing about this man I'm about to interview. He could be ninety or he could be thirty. The uncertainty is

galling, and my nerves resurface, making me fidget. I've never been comfortable with one-on-one interviews, preferring the anonymity of a group discussion where I can sit inconspicuously at the back of the room. To be honest, I prefer my own company, reading a classic British novel, curled up in a chair in the campus library. Not sitting twitching nervously in a colossal glass and stone edifice. I roll my eyes at myself. Get a grip, Steele. Judging from the building, which is too clinical and modern, I guess Grey is in his forties: fit, tanned, and fair-haired to match the rest of the personnel.

Another elegant, flawlessly dressed blonde comes out of a large door to the right. What is it with all the immaculate blondes? It's like Stepford here. Taking a deep breath, I stand up. "Miss Steele?" the latest blonde asks. "Yes," I croak, and clear my throat. "Yes." There, that sounded more confident. "Mr. Grey will see you in a moment. May I take your jacket?" "Oh please." I struggle out of the jacket. "Have you been offered any refreshment?" "Um – no." Oh dear, is Blonde Number One in trouble? Blonde Number Two frowns and eyes the young woman at the desk. "Would you like tea, coffee, water?" she asks, turning her attention back to me. "A glass of water. Thank you," I murmur. "Olivia, please fetch Miss Steele a glass of water." Her voice is stern. Olivia scoots up immediately and scurries to a door on the other side of the foyer. "My apologies, Miss Steele, Olivia is our new intern. Please be seated. Mr. Grey will be another five minutes." Olivia returns with a glass of iced water. "Here you go, Miss Steele." "Thank you." Blonde Number Two marches over to the large desk, her heels clicking and echoing on the sandstone floor. She sits down, and they both continue their work.

Perhaps Mr. Grey insists on all his employees being blonde. I'm wondering idly if that's legal, when the office door opens and a tall, elegantly dressed, attractive African-American man with short dreads exits. I have definitely worn the wrong clothes. He turns and says through the door. "Golf, this week, Grey." I don't hear the reply. He turns, sees me, and smiles, his dark eyes crinkling at the corners. Olivia has jumped up and called the elevator. She seems to excel at jumping from her seat. She's more nervous than me! "Good afternoon ladies," he says as he departs through the sliding door. "Mr. Grey will see you now, Miss Steele. Do go through," Blonde Number Two says. I stand rather shakily trying to suppress my nerves. Gathering up my satchel, I abandon my glass of water and make my way to the partially open door. "You don't need to knock – just go in." She smiles kindly. I push open the door and stumble through, tripping over my own feet, and falling head first into the office. Double crap – me and my two left feet! I am on my hands and knees in the doorway to Mr. Grey's office, and gentle hands are around me helping me to stand. I am so embarrassed, damn my clumsiness. I have to steel myself to glance up. Holy cow – he's so young. "Miss Kavanagh." He extends a long-fingered hand to me once I'm upright. "I'm Christian Grey. Are you all right? Would you like to sit?" So young – and attractive, very attractive. He's tall, dressed in a fine gray suit, white shirt, and black tie with unruly dark copper colored hair and intense, bright gray eyes that regard me shrewdly. It takes a moment for me to find my voice. "Um. Actually–" I mutter. If this guy is over thirty then I'm a monkey's uncle. In a daze, I place my hand in his and we shake. As our fingers touch, I feel an odd exhilarating shiver run through me. I withdraw my hand hastily, embarrassed. Must be static. I blink rapidly, my eyelids matching my heart rate. "Miss Kavanagh is indisposed, so she sent me. I hope you don't mind, Mr. Grey." "And you are?" His voice is warm, possibly amused, but it's difficult to tell from his impassive expression. He looks mildly interested, but above all, polite.

Article 124

To determine climatic conditions that existed in the past, paleoclimatologists must use material that fulfills some principal criteria. The source of the material-rocks, lakes, vegetation, etc.- must be widespread enough to provide plenty of information for correlation. Besides, in the process of formation, the material of interest must have received an environmental signal that reflects a change in climate and at least some of the material must have retained the signal unaffected by subsequent changes in the environment. Owing to these limitations, the methods used by paleoclimatologists have been useful only to an extent.

A traditional method used by the Paleoclimatologists in the investigation of past climatic conditions involves the measurement of water levels in ancient lakes. Though the method has been much helpful, it is not without its own setbacks. In temperate regions, for instance, there is a sufficient number of lakes for correlations, thus allowing for a reliable picture. In arid and semiarid regions, however, the small number of lakes separated by great distances between them reduces the possibilities for correlation. Moreover, since lake levels are controlled by rates of evaporation as well as by precipitation, the interpretation of such levels is dubious. After all, the fact that lake levels in the semiarid southwestern United States were apparently higher during the last ice age than they are now was at one time attributed to increased precipitation. On the basis of recent studies, however, it has been concluded that the climate then was not necessarily wetter than it is now, but rather that both summers and winters were cooler, resulting in reduced evaporation.

Article 125

While shaming was weaponized long ago as a means of punishment, social media has transformed it into a weapon of reversed mass destruction. Rather than a single weapon destroying masses, it is the social media masses that are destroying one person at a time. Perhaps the best known example of this is the destruction of Justine Sacco, the woman who tweeted "Going to Africa. Hope I don't get AIDS. Just kidding. I'm white!" While Sacco is currently the best known victim of such shaming, the practice has become a common one and the list of casualties increases each day.

While it is tempting to issue a blanket condemnation of shaming, this would be a mistake. While shaming is abused, it can be a morally acceptable form of punishment. However, this requires that it be used properly and justly.

As with any form of punishment, shaming should only be used when the target has done wrong. Unlike with actual civil and criminal laws, there is not a codified set of rules specifying what actions are wrong in a way that warrant shaming. As with most social interactions, people are guided by vague norms, intuitions, traditions and feelings. As such, the practice of shaming can be rather chaotic. That said, it is certainly possible to consider situations rationally and assess whether they are shame worthy or not—though disputes are inevitable. Working out such guideless would be analogous to developing a hybrid between laws and etiquette and would presumably require at least a small book, which is far beyond the scope of this short essay. However, I do have some recommendations.

In the United States criminal justice system, there is a presumption of innocence on the part of the defendant. This is based on the ideal that it is better to allow the guilty to go free than to punish the innocent. The same sort of presumption should be extended to those who are accused of engaging in shame

worthy actions. I would even suggest a specific sort of presumption, namely a presumption of error. This is to begin the consideration by assuming the accused acted from error rather than malice.

One common type of error that leads to excessive shaming is when a person attempts to be funny, but fails to do so because of a lack of skill. Sacco's infamous tweet seems to be an example of this sort of error. A skilled comedian could have created a piece of satire using the same basic idea and directed attention to the issue of race in the context of AIDS. Because of a lack of comedic skill, Sacco's tweet came across as racist—although all the evidence seems to clearly show that this is not what she intended. Another type of error is that of ignorance—a person has no malicious intent, but errs by not knowing something rather important. For example, a person trying to be funny might appear racist because they are unaware of the social norms governing who has the right to use which terms of race. The obvious example, is a white person imitating a black comedian's use of the n-word without realizing that the word is essentially off limit to white comedians.

If a person is reasonably judged worthy of shaming, the next concern is how and to what extent the person should be shamed and the objective of the shaming. Since shaming is a punishment, the usual moral considerations about punishment apply.

One reason to punish by shaming is deterrence—so the shamed will not engage in shameful activity again and that others will be less inclined to behave in similar ways. Another reason is retribution—to "balance the books" by harming the shamed in return for the harm they did. While retribution strikes me as morally problematic (at best), both deterrence and retribution should be limited by the principle of proportionality. That is, the punishment should be comparable in severity to the harm done. If the punishment is excessive, then it creates a new harm that would require punishment and this punishment would need to be proportional or there would need to be another punishment and so on to infinity. As such, even if retribution is embraced, it can only be justified when it matches the harm inflicted.

Unfortunately, in social media shaming the punishment tends to be excessive. In fact, the punishments for such offenses can exceed those imposed for serious civil or criminal violations of the law. For example, Sacco's failed attempt at humor cost her job and wrecked her life. One reason that the punishment can be excessive is that people are often insulated from consequences of their acts of punishment, and hence they are freed to be harsher than they would be in person. That said, shamers are sometimes themselves shamed for shaming, thus creating a vicious circle. Another reason for the excesses of punishment is the scope of social media. A person's shame can be broadcast to the entire world and the entire world can get in on punishing the person, thus inflicting excessive harm. This also helps explain why people who are shamed are often fired—their employers fear the wrath of the social media mob and will fire a person to protect themselves.

Another, and what I think is the best, reason to punish is redemption. Such punishment aims to inform the person that their action is unacceptable, to give them a chance to atone for their misdeed and to allow them a chance to be accepted back into the social fold. This approach does have some limits. The person must be subject to feeling shame or vulnerable to the consequences of being shamed. A person who is shameless (or at least without shame in the matter at hand) will be rather resistant to attempts to appeal to their sense of shame. A person who can suffer little or no ill-consequences from being shamed will also not be corrected by shaming. Donald Trump is often presented as an example of a person who is either shameless or able to effectively avoid the negative consequences of being shamed (or both).

Punishing for the purpose of redemption does put a limit on the punishment that should be inflicted. After all, excessive punishment is unlikely to teach a person a moral lesson about how they should act (but it can teach a practical lesson). Also, excessive punishment can do so much damage that a person cannot

effectively make it back into the social fold. Such redemptive shaming should be severe enough to send the intended message, but moderate enough that the person can achieve redemption. What is often forgotten about redemptive punishment is the important role of society—redemption is not merely about the wrongdoer redeeming themselves, but other people accepting this redemption. Those who engage in social media shaming all too often rush to punish and then move on to the next transgressor. In doing so, they fail in their obligations to those they have punished, which includes offering an opportunity for redemption.

Article 126

In their study of slavery in the United States, Time on the Cross: The Economics of American Negro Slavery, Fogel and Engerman rightly stressed the slaves' achievements. But, contrary to what they suggest, plantation owners deserve little credit for these achievements. Rather, one must look to the Black family and the slaves' extended kinship system to understand how crucial achievements, such as the maintenance of a cultural heritage and the development of a communal consciousness, were possible.

Thomas Haskell, who spent years of research recreating the slaves' family and extended kinship structure, effectively proves them wrong. He achieves this mainly through an ingenious use of what any historian should draw upon, quantifiable data, derived in this case mostly from plantation birth registers. These sources indicate, Haskell argues, that two-parent household predominated in slave quarters just as it did among freed slaves. Although Haskell admits that forced separation by sale was frequent, he shows that the slaves' preference, revealed most clearly on plantations where sale was infrequent, was very much for stable monogamy. In less conclusive fashion Fogel, Engerman, and Genovese had already indicated the predominance of two-parent households; however, only Haskell emphasizes the preference for stable monogamy and points out what stable monogamy meant for the slaves' cultural heritage. Haskell argues convincingly that the stability of the Black family encouraged the transmission of—and so was crucial in sustaining—the Black heritage of folklore, music, and religious expression from one generation to another, a heritage that slaves were continually fashioning out of their African and American experiences.

Haskell's examination of other facets of kinship also produces important findings. Haskell discovers that cousins rarely married, an exogamous tendency that contrasted sharply with the endogamy practiced by the plantation owners. This preference for exogamy, Haskell suggests, may have derived from West African rules governing marriage, which, though they differed from one tribal group to another, all involved some kind of prohibition against unions with close kin. This taboo against cousins' marrying is important, argues Haskell, because it is one of many indications of a strong awareness among slaves of an extended kinship network. The fact that distantly related kin would care for children separated from their families also suggests this awareness. When blood relationships were few, as in newly created plantations in the Southwest, "fictive" kinship arrangements took their place until a new pattern of consanguinity developed. Haskell presents convincing evidence that this extended kinship structure—which he believes developed by the mid-to-late eighteenth century—provided the foundations for the strong communal consciousness that existed among slaves.

In sum, Haskell's study is significant because it offers a closely reasoned and original explanation of some of the slaves' achievements, one that correctly emphasizes the resources that slaves themselves possessed.

Article 127

Language is not a cultural artifact that we learn the way we learn to tell time or how the federal government works. Instead, it is a distinct piece of the biological makeup of our brains. Language is a complex, specialized skill, which develops in the child spontaneously, without conscious effort or formal instruction, is deployed without awareness of its underlying logic, is qualitatively the same in every individual, and is distinct from more general abilities to process information or behave intelligently. For these reasons some cognitive scientists have described language as a psychological faculty, a mental organ, a neural system, and a computational module. But I prefer the admittedly quaint term "instinct". It conveys the idea that people know how to talk in more or less the sense that spiders know how to spin webs. Web-spinning was not invented by some unsung spider genius and does not depend on having had the right education or on having an aptitude for architecture or the construction trades. Rather, spiders spin spider webs because they have spider brains, which give them the urge to spin and the competence to succeed. Although there are differences between webs and words, I will encourage you to see language in this way, for it helps to make sense of the phenomena we will explore.

Thinking of language as an instinct inverts the popular wisdom, especially as it has been passed down in the canon of the humanities and social sciences. Language is no more a cultural invention than is upright posture. It is not a manifestation of a general capacity to use symbols: a three-year-old, we shall see, is a grammatical genius, but is quite incompetent at the visual arts, religious iconography, traffic signs, and the other staples of the semiotics curriculum. Though language is a magnificent ability unique to Homo sapiens among living species, it does not call for sequestering the study of humans from the domain of biology, for a magnificent ability unique to a particular living species is far from unique in the animal kingdom. Some kinds of bats home in on flying insects using Doppler sonar. Some kinds of migratory birds navigate thousands of miles by calibrating the positions of the constellations against the time of day and year. In nature's talent show, we are simply a species of primate with our own act, a knack for communicating information about who did what to whom by modulating the sounds we make when we exhale. Once you begin to look at language not as the ineffable essence of human uniqueness hut as a biological adaptation to communicate information, it is no longer as tempting to see language as an insidious shaper of thought, and, we shall see, it is not.

Moreover, seeing language as one of nature's engineering marvels— an organ with "that perfection of structure and co-adaptation which justly excites our admiration," in Darwin's words – gives us a new respect for your ordinary Joe and the much-maligned English language (or any language). The complexity of language, from the scientist's point of view, is part of our biological birthright; it is not something that parents teach their children or something that must be elaborated in school — as Oscar Wilde said, "Education is an admirable thing, but it is well to remember from time to time that nothing that is worth knowing can be taught." A preschooler's tacit knowledge of grammar is more sophisticated than the thickest style manual or the most state-of-the-art computer language system, and the same applies to all healthy human beings, even the notorious syntax fracturing professional athlete and the, you know, like, inarticulate teenage skateboarder. Finally, since language is the product of a well-engineered biological instinct, we shall see that it is not the nutty barrel of monkeys that entertainer columnists make it out to be.

Article 128

Over 100 CEOs of artificial intelligence and robotics firms recently signed an open letter warning that their work could be repurposed to build lethal autonomous weapons — "killer robots." They argued that to build such weapons would be to open a "Pandora's Box." This could forever alter war.

Over 30 countries have or are developing armed drones, and with each successive generation, drones have more autonomy. Automation has long been used in weapons to help identify targets and maneuver missiles. But to date, humans have remained in control of deciding whether to use lethal force. Militaries have only used automated engagements in limited settings to defend against high-speed rockets and missiles. Advances in autonomous technology could change that. The same intelligence that allows self-driving cars to avoid pedestrians could allow future weapons that hunt and attack targets on their own.

For the past three years, countries have met through the United Nations to discuss lethal autonomous weapons. Over 60 non-governmental organizations have called for a treaty banning autonomous weapons. Yet most countries are hedging their bets. No major military powers have said they plan to build autonomous weapons, but few have taken them off the table.

There's a certain irony in the CEOs of robotics and AI companies warning of the dangers of the very same technologies they themselves are building. They implore countries to "double their efforts" in international negotiations and warn that "we do not have long to act." But if the situation is truly dire, couldn't these companies slow their research to buy diplomats more time?

In reality, even if all of these companies stopped research, the field of AI would continue marching forward. The intelligence behind autonomous robots isn't like stealth technology, which was created in secret defense labs and tightly controlled by the military. Autonomous technology is everywhere. Hobbyist drones that retail for a few hundred dollars can takeoff, land, follow moving objects and avoid obstacles all on their own. Elementary school students build robots in competitions. Even the Islamic State is getting in on the game, strapping bombs to small drones. There is no stopping AI. Robotics companies can't easily band together to stop progress, because it only takes one company to break the agreement and advance the technology. Besides, to ask companies to stop research would be to ask them to forgo innovations that could generate profits and save lives.

These same dynamics make constraining autonomous weapons internationally very difficult. Asking countries to sign a treaty banning a weapon that doesn't yet exists means asking them to forgo a potentially useful tool to defend against threats and save lives. Moreover, the same problem of cheaters applies in the international arena, but the stakes are higher. Instead of lost profits, a nation might lose a war. History suggests that even when the international community widely condemns a weapon as inhumane — like chemical weapons — some despots will use them anyway. Treaties alone won't prevent rogue regimes and terrorists from building autonomous weapons. If autonomous weapons led to a decisive advantage in war, a treaty that disarmed only those who care for the rule of law would be the worst of all possible worlds. The letter's signers likely understand this, which may be why the letter doesn't call for a ban, a notable departure from a similar letter two years ago. Instead, the signatories ask countries at the United Nations to "find a way to protect us from all these dangers." Banning or regulating emerging weapons technologies is easier said than done, though. Nations have tried to ban crossbows, firearms, surprise attacks by submarines, aerial attacks on cities and, in World War I, poison gas. All have failed.

And yet: Nations held back from using poison gas on the battlefields of World War II. The Cold War saw treaties banning chemical and biological weapons, using the environment as a weapon and placing nuclear weapons in space or on the seabed. The United States and Soviet Union pulled back from neutron bombs

and anti-satellite weapons even without formal treaties. Nuclear weapons have proliferated, but not as widely as many predicted. In more recent years, nations have passed bans on blinding lasers, land mines and cluster munitions.

Weapons are easier to ban when few countries have access to them, when they are widely seen as horrifying and when they provide little military benefits. It is extremely difficult to ban weapons that are seen as giving a decisive advantage, as nuclear weapons are. A major factor in what will happen with autonomous weapons, therefore, is how nations come to see the benefits and risks they pose.

Autonomous weapons pose a classic security dilemma for countries. All countries may be better off without them, but mutual restraint requires cooperation. Last year, nations agreed to create a more formal Group of Governmental Experts to study the issue. The group will convene in November and, once again, nations will attempt to halt a potentially dangerous technology before it is used in war.